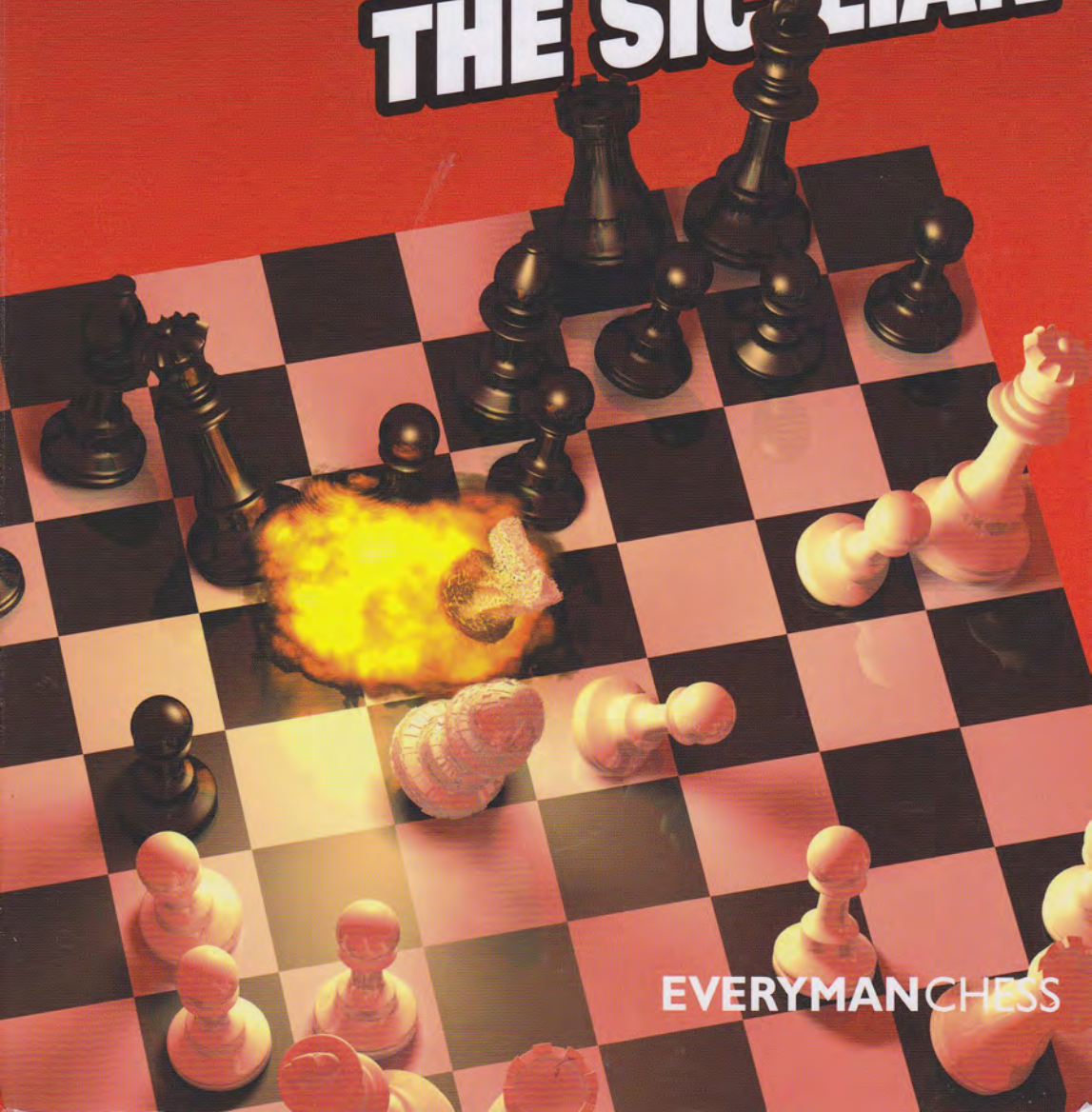
YURY LAPSHUN
NICK CONTICELLO

7 WAYS TO SMASH THE SICILIAN



EVERYMANCHESS

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Introduction

Stop me if you've heard this before...

One evening at the Marshall Chess Club in early 2008 while Yury Lapshun and I, Nick Conticello, were awaiting publication of our first book, *Play 1 b4!*, Yury came up to me and said: 'I have an idea for another book. It's all about piece sacrifices for White in the Open Sicilian. Want to write it with me?'

I gave the matter due deliberation, but this time I replied: 'You know, there's a pretty good old Batsford book called *Sacrifices in the Sicilian* by David Levy that had a similar idea. I don't want to do a rehash of that book.' I described Levy's book for Yury and he assured me that what we would do would be quite different. So I agreed...again.

Later, after the contracts were signed and the work well under way, someone told me about a book by GM Jacob Aagaard on combinations, and that every one was a Sicilian! I got hold of a copy of that book, and was relieved to discover that what we were doing was also far removed from Aagaard's approach. I'm sure, after reading this introductory essay or perusing this book, our readers will agree.

Our aim

First, let me clear up any possible misconceptions right at the start. This is not a repertoire book or a theoretical opening guide, although readers seeking guidance in those areas may well find useful items herein. It is certainly not an endgame book either, although a few thematic endings will be analysed. Moreover it is not intended to be encyclopaedic, nor is it a quiz or puzzle book. So what is it then?

This book is a collection of well-analysed games featuring thematic, active piece sacrifices by White in the Open Sicilian. Yury and I are firm believers in annotating complete games as thoroughly as possible. We under-

stand that most of our readers will be ambitious amateurs, who will not be aware of certain ideas and technical matters that professionals take for granted. Therefore we have spelled things out to an extent that might annoy strong players. We are sorry about that, but we ask those folks to remember that they are not our primary audience. (Of course, we believe strong players will find some useful information here, and we hope that coaches too will find this book helpful.)

We have analysed each game independently, aided by engines such as *Fritz* and *Rybka*. Of course, when our lines are identical with published commentary, we have credited the published sources as much as possible. Any lapses in this regard are chiefly my responsibility and are inadvertent. I apologize in advance for any such omissions.

Active Piece Sacrifices

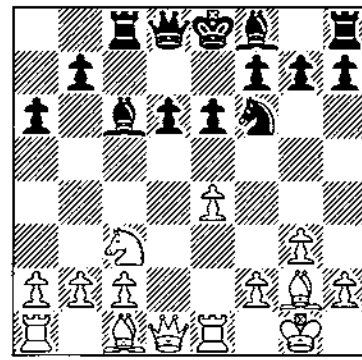
What exactly do I mean by 'active piece sacrifices'? I hope the following two examples will make this term clear.

Game 1
W.Browne-J.Kaplan
San Antonio 1972

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘c6 5 ♘c3 e6

Black's move order is designed to avoid the Keres Attack against the Scheveningen.

6 g3 a6 7 ♗g2 ♗d7 8 0-0 ♖c8 9 ♖e1 ♘f6 10 ♘xc6 ♗xc6



11 ♘d5!

Here is a perfect illustration of an active sacrifice. It need not be accepted at once, but sooner or later this pesky knight must be dealt with, as its presence is intolerable. As Browne points out in his notes, the attempt to keep developing calmly with 11...♗e7 allows 12 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 13 b3 threatening 14 ♗a3 with a nice advantage.

11...♗xd5 12 exd5 e5 13 f4 ♕c7 14 ♕e2! ♘d7

The attack keeps rolling after 14...♕xc2 15 ♗d2! ♕xb2 16 ♖ab1 (Browne).

15 ♗h3 f6 16 ♗e3 g6 17 ♗e6 ♗g7 18 ♖ac1

Threatening to roll the queenside pawns.

18...♕c4 19 ♕g4 ♖c7 20 b3! ♕c3?

After 20...♕b5 Browne analyses a long variation: 21 ♗f7+! ♔d8 22 ♕e6 ♖f8 23 ♕xd6! ♖xf7 24 c4 ♕a5 25 b4! (the point of this combination is that Black's queen cannot stem the pawn advance with a dark-square blockade) 25...♗f8

26 ♕e6 ♘c5 27 bxc5 ♗xc5 28 d6 ♖cd7 29 fxe5 ♗xe3+ 30 ♖xe3 ♕c5 31 exf6, which he considers to be winning.

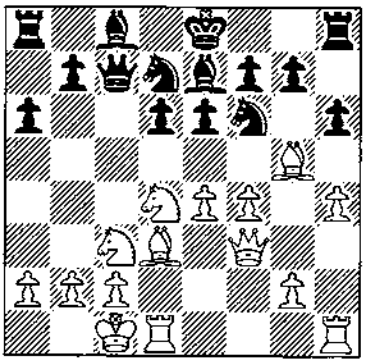
21 ♗xd7+ ♖xd7 22 ♕e6+ ♔d8

22...♖e7 simply hangs the d-pawn.

23 ♗b6+ ♔c8 24 ♖e4 1-0

On the other hand, consider this bizarre idea in a standard Najdorf:

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9. 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♗d3 h6 11 h4!?



An idea first played by Velimirovic, I believe. I would categorize this as a passive sacrifice, as Black need not take the bishop, but can improve his position with, say, 11...♘c5! and then decide what to do. (Please also examine Minic-Fischer in the introduction to Chapter 4 for a similar example.)

Which Sacrifices are Covered?

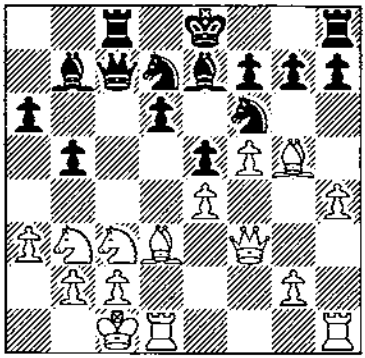
The sacrifices we will examine in separate chapters are those involving ♘d5, ♘xe6, ♗xe6, ♘f5, ♘(x)b5, and ♗(x)b5. The seventh chapter will consider ♗d5, ♖xf6 and other miscellaneous sacrifices, including queen ones. We did not, however, think it necessary to include any examples of a ♖xh5 sacrifice, as this idea is now common in all sorts of openings, not just the Sicilian. (If you really want to see some examples of ♖xh5, just curl up with a copy of Fischer's *My 60 Memorable Games* and study his victories over Larsen and Gligoric.)

Why devote an entire book to piece sacrifices in the Open Sicilian, you may ask. The reason is quite simple: *without a full understanding of these ideas you cannot win with White in this opening!* The Open Sicilian is virtually unique among responses to 1 e4 in that Black acquires with no effort an extra centre pawn and a half-open file for his rooks. Therefore Black has a ready-made counterattack available on the queenside and/or in the centre. On the other hand, White has more space, a lead in development and the initiative. According to the teachings of Steinitz, White must use these advantages to attack or suffer unpleasant consequences. A complicating factor is that Black need not always castle quickly, thanks to his extra central pawn. Witness the following game, cited by Daniel King in his book *Winning with the Najdorf*. No comments are needed – just watch the master at work:

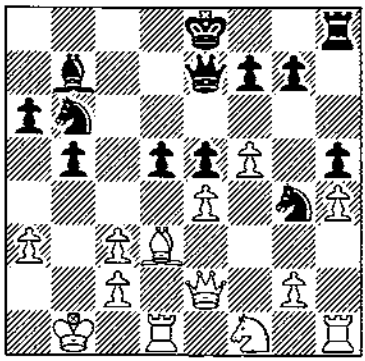
Game 2
W.Ader-R.Fischer
Santiago 1959

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6

5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 f5?! e5! 11 ♘b3?! b5 12 a3 ♗b7 13 h4 ♖c8! 14 ♗d3



14...h5! 15 ♔b1 ♘b6 16 ♘d2 ♘g4 17 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 18 ♘f1 ♖xc3! 19 bxc3 d5 20 ♕e2



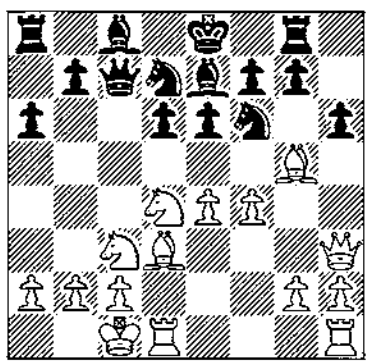
20...0-0! 21 ♗xb5 axb5 22 ♕xb5 ♘c4 23 ♕b4 ♕xb4 24 cxb4 ♘f2 25 ♘g3 ♘xa3+ 26 ♔b2 ♘c4+ 27 ♔b3 ♘e3 28 ♖d2 ♘xh1 29 ♖xh1 dxe4 30 ♘g3 ♗d5+ 31 ♔a4 ♖a8+ 32 ♔b5 ♖b8+ 33 ♔c5 ♖c8+ 34 ♔d6 ♘c4+ 35 ♔d7 ♘xd2 36 ♔xc8 ♗c4 0-1

See what I mean? Ader did nothing outrageously bad, but he got crushed. Fischer's structure let him keep central lines closed while he prepared his counterattack. Notably too his 14...h5! stonewalled White's kingside play and once everything was rolling, he could safely castle on move 20 so his last rook could join the party. A model win for Black against uninspired White play.

Contrast that with what could have happened to Black in the following extract from a recent game at the Marshall Chess Club between two masters. (I'll not give their names for reasons which will soon become obvious.)

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♗d3 h6 11 ♕h3 ♖g8?

Practice has established 11...♘b6! as the best move.



White played 12 ♗xf6? ♘xf6 13 f5 e5 and suffered a similar fate to Mr. Ader. However, after working through this book a reader unfamiliar with this line might spot 12 e5! dxe5 13 ♘xe6! with a strong attack, which I saw while kibitzing and later found in John Nunn's 1988 *The Najdorf for the Tournament Player*.

It's hard to play the Open Sicilian, and many players choose quieter approaches such as 2 ♘c3 or 2 c3, but Yury and I feel that the Open is the way to go, and we have written this book to encourage people to take the plunge.

A Note on Sources

When a published source is cited in this text we will generally do so by the name of the writer and not the work. More specifically, 'Nunn' will refer to the book cited above unless otherwise stated, and 'Levy' will refer to *Sacrifices in the Sicilian* unless otherwise noted.

We wish to single out a book here which we found particularly useful: *The Najdorf Variation* by Geller, Gligoric, Kavalek and Spassky is the beau ideal of an opening book. It offers theory and game analysis by four top grandmasters, and a number of lines from this work are still quoted in opening books over thirty years later, often, sad to relate, without attribution. Here when one of those four names is cited in relation to the Najdorf, it is from this work. (The only exception is Gligoric-Bobotsov in Chapter 7.)

Division of Labour

Yury Lapshun selected all the games and is chiefly responsible for the analysis in Chapters 1-6. I wrote all the chapter introductions and am primarily responsible for the selection of games and commentary in Chapter 7.

Acknowledgements

The authors wish to express gratitude to the following for their invaluable aid in the production of this book:

FM Jon Jacobs, for the loan of a copy of David Levy's *Sacrifices in the Sicilian*.

The Marshall Chess Club, for the use of its library and facilities.

The Chess Forum and the Newton eCafe in New York City, from which the present writer has produced most of his scribbling.

Finally, the good people at Everyman Chess, especially our editor for both of our books, grandmaster John Emms.

On behalf of Yury and myself, we wish the reader gains as much pleasure and profit from reading this work as the authors have experienced in writing it.

Nick Conticello,
New York
March 2009

Chapter One

The Knight Sacrifice on d5

This opening chapter is concerned with the move ♘c3-d5, and it will be the longest chapter in the book. The reason is simply that many Open Sicilians, even sometimes the Dragon nowadays, feature a black pawn on e6. Despite this fact, White is often able to start a violent attack on the enemy king by the dramatic centralization of his queen's knight.

We will not concern ourselves here with positions in which White regains at once this material after the sacrifice. We will deal mostly with examples in which ♘d5 is a real, positional sacrifice, as Rudolf Speelman put it. White's ideas vary upon the placement of the enemy king, so we must divide the material accordingly.

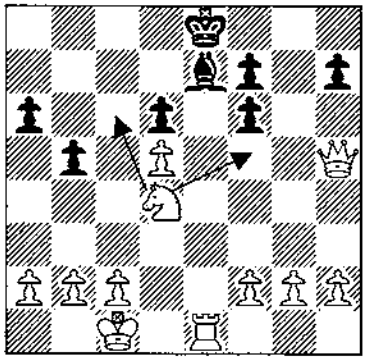
1. The Uncastled King

When Black's king is in the centre, the purpose of the ♘d5 sacrifice is to keep it there. Note that the attack generally fails if the monarch can flee to one flank or the other.

The sacrifice on d5 sets off a chain of events: White recaptures with a pawn, opening the e-file for the heavy pieces; the pawn on d5 creates a possible anchor for a knight on d4 to occupy c6; and the absence of a pawn from e6 clears the f5-square for that same knight, from which the squares e7 and g7 can be pressed. Moreover, when White has a bishop on g5, he can capture a knight on f6, perhaps rupturing the black pawns, but always making h5 a fore-post for the white queen.

(see following diagram)

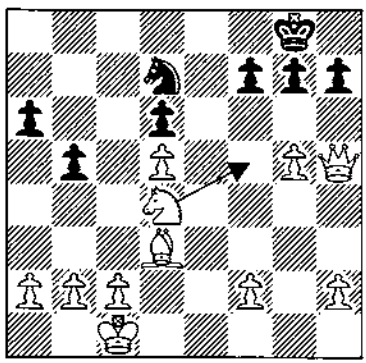
The sacrifice will work if all or almost all of the effects listed above occur, and will fail if two or more are absent. Crucially all the white forces must gain in scope.



2. The Castled King

Here we will be dealing almost exclusively with Black's king castled short. A successful ♘d5 sacrifice with the king already on the queenside is very rare, and when it does work White recoups his investment almost at once.

Usually White will have driven away Black's knight by the advance g4-g5 as a preliminary, and often the white queen will already stand on h5 aiming at h7. So when White plays ♘d5 in this situation he opens the b1-h7 diagonal for his king's bishop and clears the f5-square for his knight on d4.



Occasionally White will have a bishop on d4 instead. Now the sacrifice deflects the enemy e-pawn from the square e5, from where it would inhibit both White clerics. A few times White will have his king's bishop on b3 or c4; in these cases White might well recapture on d5 with that bishop, often with gain of time, and dominate the diagonal leading to f7, which in turn will make possible a timely advance g5-g6.

In virtually all successful ♘d5 attacks on a castled king, White must have spent some time earlier massing his forces on the kingside. Once the sacrifice is made, the momentum must be kept driving forward. Any hesitation will most likely be fatal. (The one notable exception to this is the famous game Tal-Larsen, 10th matchgame, Bled 1965. That said, after much research and analysis we think that Black was winning, but I would not be surprised to see later analysis refuting ours.)

Herewith are examples of both possible king positions.

Game 3
N.Conticello-M.Paolozzi
New York City 1978

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♗d3

The most popular here, then and now. Note that 10 ♗e2 will be discussed in Chapter Seven.

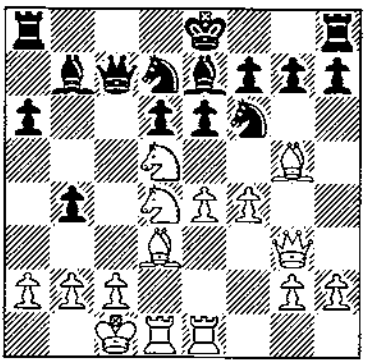
10...b5 11 ♖he1 ♗b7 12 ♕g3

The trappy 12 ♘d5!? will be discussed in the games Zaitsev-Anetbaev and Fluvia Poyatos-Gual Pascual later in this chapter.

12...b4

Most likely the best. 12...0-0-0 13 ♗xb5! was D.Velimirovic-R.Al Kazzaz, Nice Olympiad 1974, which will be annotated in the introduction to Chapter Six.

13 ♘d5



Nothing else merits any serious consideration.

13...exd5 14 e5!?

This is the 'other' method of attack, as opposed to the traditional approach of 14 exd5. The text was fashionable in those days, since it was analysed by Geller in the R.H.M. Najdorf book which had just come out. The attraction for me was that White could apparently keep a small plus with no great risk.

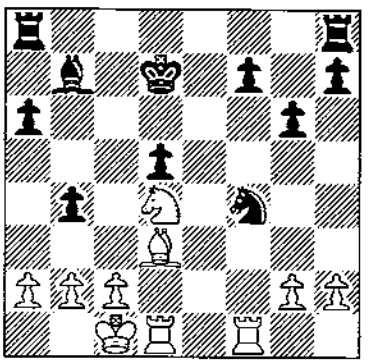
14...dxe5 15 f xe5 ♘h5 16 ♕h4?

Both players were following Geller's analysis. It is known today that 16 e6! is necessary. Nunn's main line continues 16...♘xg3 17 exf7+ ♔xf7 18 ♖xe7+ ♔g8 19 hxg3 ♕xg3 20 ♘e6 ♕e5 21 ♖f1 ♘f8 22 ♗f5 ♗c8 23 ♖e8 ♔f7 24 ♖e7+ ♔g8 25 ♖e8 with a draw by repetition.

16...♗xg5+ 17 ♕xg5 g6 18 e6 ♕f4+?

Winning is the simple 18...♘df6!, as later pointed out by Nunn. Both players are still in lockstep with Geller, and are playing at lightning speed to boot!

19 ♕xf4 ♘xf4 20 exd7+ ♔xd7 21 ♖f1



21...♘xd3+

Only now did the future Brazilian grandmaster pause for reflection for an entire hour (!) before acquiescing to march with Geller towards a draw with a very lucky booked-up fish, namely yours truly.

22 ♖xd3 f5 23 g4! ♖af8 24 ♖df3 ♖hg8 25 gxf5 gxf5 26 ♖h3 ♖g7

Hereabouts I took a 45-minute catnap under the guise of trying to find a win. I have no idea what I could have been thinking about thirty years later.

27 ♖xf5 ♖xf5 28 ♘xf5 ♖f7 29 ♘d4 ♔d6 30 ♔d2 a5 ½-½

Nowadays I would keep playing, but I'm sure he would also. I decided not to push my luck.

Game 4
A.Ostapenko-Yartsev
correspondence 1969

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 ♗e7 8 ♕e2 0-0 9 ♗b3 ♕c7 10 0-0-0 a6 11 ♖hg1

Necessary preparation since 11 g4 ♘xd4! forces the clumsy 12 ♖xd4, so that 12...e5 can be met by 13 ♖c4.

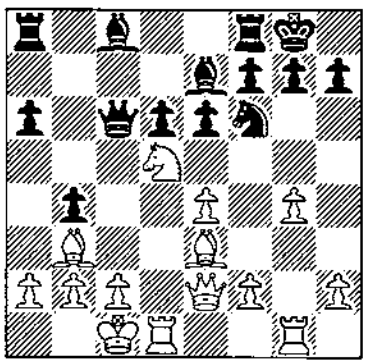
11...b5 12 g4 b4

Nowadays 12...♘a5 is often preferred.

13 ♘xc6 ♕xc6

Instead 13...bxc3 14 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 15 ♗d4 ♗b7 16 f3 is given as good for White by Nunn in *ECO*.

14 ♘d5!



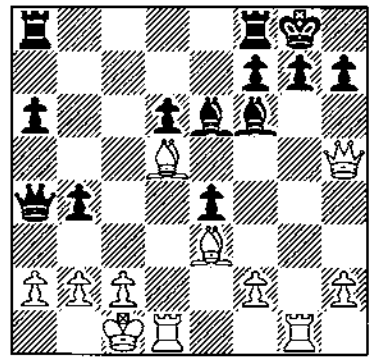
White has not had time to play g4-g5, so he sacrifices the knight first. Even though he never gets to capture the rook on a8, the possibility of doing so makes this attack work.

14...exd5 15 g5 dxe4?

As far as I know, the losing move. A much tougher defence is 15...♘xe4! 16 ♗xd5 ♕a4 17 ♗xe4 (17 ♗xa8 ♘c3! 18 bxc3 ♗e6! gives Black good counterplay) 17...♗e6 18 ♗d4 g6, holding White to a small edge.

16 gxf6 ♗xf6 17 ♗xd5 ♕a4 18 ♕h5! ♗e6

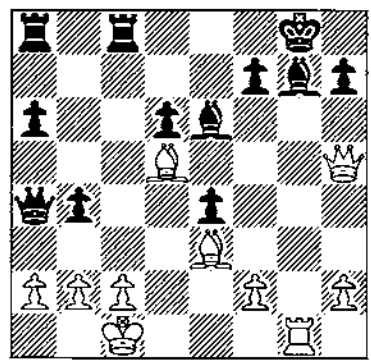
18...♔h8 is met in the same way.



19 ♖xg7+!! ♗xg7

And not 19...♔xg7? 20 ♕h6+.

20 ♖g1 ♖fc8

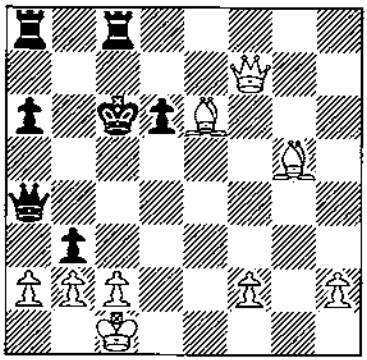


Perhaps hoping to answer 21 ♗xe4 with 21...♔f8! as suggested by Boleslavsky.

21 ♖xg7+! ♔xg7 22 ♕h6+ ♔g8 23 ♗xe4 b3

Ostapenko in *Informator 8* prefers 23...♖c5!, but then he continues 24 ♗d4 ♖e5 25 ♗xh7+ ♔h8 26 ♗f5+ ♔g8 27 ♗xe5 dxe5 28 ♕h7+ ♔f8 29 ♗xe6 fxe6 30 ♕h8+, picking off the a8-rook at last.

24 ♗xh7+ ♔h8 25 ♗f5+ ♔g8 26 ♕h7+ ♔f8 27 ♗h6+ ♔e8 28 ♕g8+ ♔e7 29 ♗g5+ ♔d7 30 ♕xf7+ ♔c8 31 ♗xe6



31...♔b6

Boleslavsky thought that 31...♕e4 might hold, but White wins after 32 ♕d7+ ♔b6 33 ♕xd6+ ♖c6 34 ♗d8+.

32 ♗e3+ ♔a5 33 ♗xc8 ♖xc8 34 ♕f5+ ♖c5 35 ♗xc5 ♕b5 36 ♗b4+ ♔xb4 37 a3+ ♔c4 38 ♕xb5+ axb5 39 cxb3+ ♔d3 40 ♔d1 1-0

An important game for the theory of this opening.

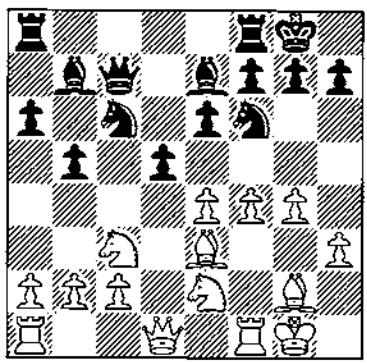
Now it's time to hand over to Yury:

We begin our more detailed coverage with an important theoretical game between two legends. In this game Leonid Stein, three times USSR champion, demonstrated many interesting ideas which follow an 11 ♘d5 sacrifice. Semen Furman, Karpov's coach and a noted theoretician, defended like a lion, but he couldn't do anything against Stein's various threats.

Game 5
L.Stein-S.Furman
USSR Championship, Moscow 1969

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 a6 5 ♘c3 ♕c7 6 g3 b5

This risky move, neglecting development of the king's wing, has been all but abandoned at higher levels in favour of the disruptive 6...♗b4: for example, 7 ♘de2 ♘f6 8 ♗g2 ♗e7! (the bishop drops back to e7 to answer a later ♗f4 with ...d6, thereby keeping the said bishop out of harm's way) 9 0-0 0-0 10 h3 ♘c6 11 f4 b5 12 ♗e3 ♗b7 13 g4 d5!



gave Black good counterplay in the oft-quoted game J.Tarjan-F.Gheorghiu, Los Angeles 1974.

7 ♗g2 ♗b7 8 0-0 ♘f6

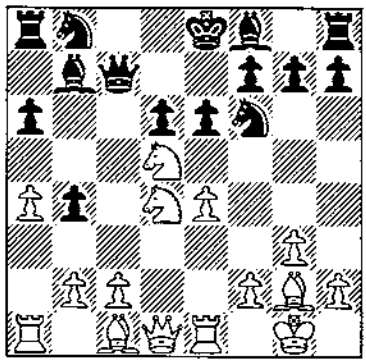
It is already hard for Black to wriggle out of the net he has made for himself. After 8...d6, Davies cites J.Nunn-

G.Sigurjonsson, London 1975, which went 9 ♖e1 ♗e7 10 a4 bxa4 11 ♕h5! g6 12 ♕e2 ♘c6 13 ♖xa4 with a strong initiative. Also if 8...♘c6 9 ♖e1 d6? (Quinteros later played the stronger 9...♘e5) 10 a4 b4 11 ♘d5! ♕a5 then White has a pleasant choice between Hulak's 12 ♘xc6 and Almasi's 12 ♕h5. Finally, Taimanov's 8...♗c5 9 ♘b3 ♗e7 can be met with Davies' suggestion of 10 ♖e1 d6 11 a4 b4 12 ♘a2.

9 ♖e1 d6 10 a4

10 a3 is passive and not in the spirit of the Open Sicilian. White must be prepared to offer his knight when the signs are favourable.

10...b4 11 ♘d5



11 ♘a2 is another good possibility which leads after 11...♕c4 (or 11...e5 12 ♘f5 g6 13 ♘h6 ♘c6 14 ♗g5 ♗e7 15 ♖c1 ♕a5 16 c3 bxc3 17 ♕b3 ♘d8 18 ♘xc3 and White got some advantage, A.Berelovich-K.Van der Weide, Solingen 2005) 12 ♘b3 a5 13 c3 to a slight advantage.

11...exd5 12 exd5+ ♔d8

Many computers will tell us that Black is better, but White's threats are coming. Instead 12...♗e7 is bad due to 13 ♘f5 ♘g8 14 ♗g5 f6 15 ♘xg7+ ♔f7 16 ♘e6 ♕b6 17 ♕h5 mate.

13 ♗g5

A common idea which generally leads to the capture of Black's knight and the consequent spoiling of his structure.

13...♘bd7

Our computer likes 13...♗c8, but praxis proves otherwise. The game O.Quinones-K.Higashi, Siegen Olympiad 1970, continued 14 ♗xf6+ gxf6 15 ♕h5 ♖a7 16 ♖e4 ♗g7 17 ♖ae1 ♕c5 18 ♕e2 ♗d7 19 ♘b3 ♕b6 20 a5 ♕b5 21 ♕e3 ♖c7 22 ♕f4 ♖e8 23 ♕xd6 ♖xe4 24 ♖xe4 ♔c8 25 ♗f1 ♕a4 26 ♖xb4 ♕a2 27 ♘c5 ♕a1 28 ♖xb8+ ♔xb8 29 ♘xa6+ 1-0. We find it curious that Levy cites this game and not Stein's antecedent.

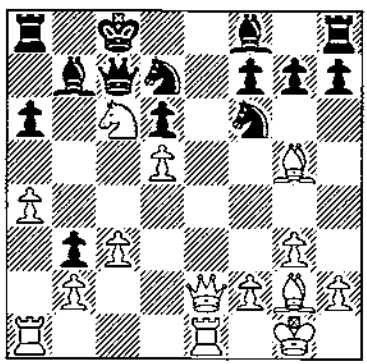
14 ♕e2 ♔c8

The king tries to scurry away, but Stein is not deterred. His next move aims to open the c-file for his rook.

15 c3 b3

Black keeps the c-file closed, but White has more tricks up his sleeve.

16 ♘c6



16...♗xc6 17 dxc6

A natural move, but White missed a simple win. After 17 ♕e8+ ♘xe8 18 ♖xe8+ ♔b7 19 dxc6+ ♔b6 20 a5+ ♔b5 21 c4+ ♔b4 22 cxd7 ♗e7 23 ♗d2+ ♔c5 24 ♗e3+ ♔b4 25 ♗xa8 ♕xd7 26 ♖xh8 Black is lost.

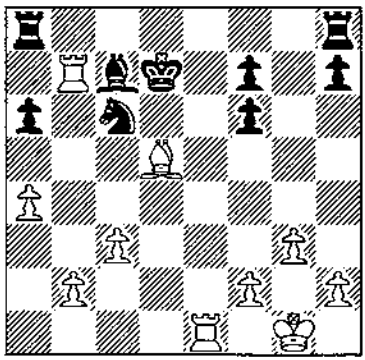
17...♘e5 18 ♖a3

An original idea! The manoeuvre ♖a3-b3-b7 will cause Black extra problems.

18...d5 19 ♖xb3 ♗d6 20 ♗xf6 gxf6 21 ♗xd5 ♘xc6

It took some doing, but now we have the typical aftermath of a ♘d5 sacrifice. Black's disorganized pieces and bad pawn structure give White a serious advantage.

22 ♕g4+ ♕d7 23 ♕xd7+ ♔xd7 24 ♖b7+ ♗c7



25 ♗g2

The best move. White wins material.

25...♖ad8 26 ♗h3+ ♔d6 27 ♖d1+ ♔c5 28 b4+ ♔c4 29 ♗f1+ ♔b3 30 ♖xc7

30 ♖b1+ ♔a2 31 ♖xc7 ♘e5 32 f4 ♔xb1 33 fxe5 fxe5 34 ♗xa6 ♔c2 35 ♔f2 ♖d2+ 36 ♗e2 is another way to win.

30...♖xd1 31 ♖xc6 ♔xa4 32 ♔g2 a5 33 bxa5 ♖hd8 34 ♖xf6 ♖8d7 35 a6

An extra passed pawn and two weak black pawns decide this game.

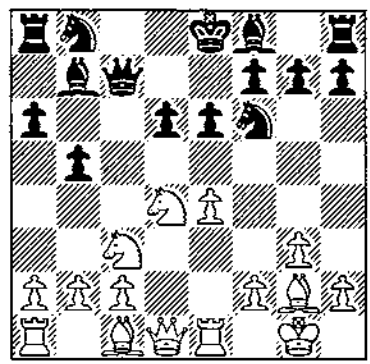
35...♖c1 36 ♗d3 ♖xc3 37 ♗xh7 ♔b5 38 ♗e4 ♖a3 39 ♗b7 ♔c5 40 h4 ♔d4 41 ♖f5 ♖e7 42 h5 ♖e5 43 ♖f4+ ♔c5 44 h6 1-0

Black can't stop all White's passed pawns.

Stein's approach in this game is a model. Decades later, his plan is still scoring points. Witness the following game:

Game 6
E.Hagara-M.Manik
Pardubice 2000

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 a6 5 ♘c3 b5 6 g3 ♗b7 7 ♗g2 ♕c7 8 0-0 d6 9 ♖e1 ♘f6



10 a4

Dangerous but less incisive is 10 ♘d5!? exd5 11 exd5+ ♔d8 12 ♗g5 ♘bd7 13 a4 (the wild 13 c4!? h6 14

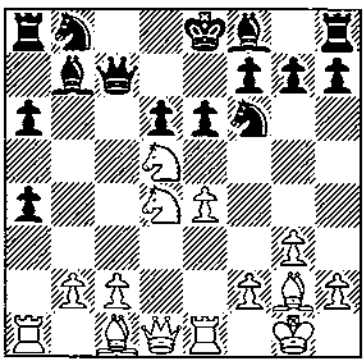
♗xf6+ ♘xf6 15 cxb5 axb5 16 ♕b3 ♕c4 as in B.Horberg-A.Kotov, Telegraph Game 1959, looks unpleasant for Black after 17 ♕e3 ♘xd5 18 ♕e8+ ♔c7 19 ♕xf7+) 13...h6 14 ♗xf6+ ♘xf6 15 axb5 axb5 16 ♖xa8+ ♗xa8 17 ♕a1 ♗b7 18 ♘c6+ ♗xc6 19 dxc6 d5! 20 ♕a8+ ♕c8 21 ♕a5+ ♕c7 and the opponents decided on a draw in W.Browne-L.Evans, U.S. Championship, Chicago 1974.

10...bxa4

Deviating from Furman's 10...b4. It doesn't look right for Black to create a weak pawn on a6, but the open b- and c-files may give him counterchances.

11 ♘d5!

After 11 ♖xa4 ♗e7 12 ♕e2 0-0 White has a comfortable position. The text is more ambitious.



11...exd5 12 exd5+ ♔d8 13 ♗g5 ♘bd7

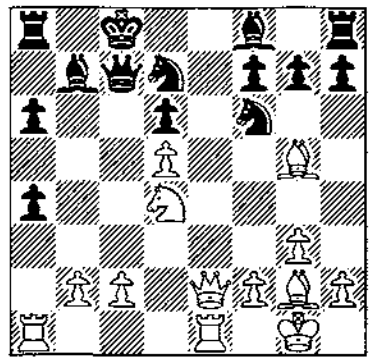
Probably 13...♗c8 14 ♖xa4 ♗e7 15 ♗d2 a5 creates an unclear mess with chances for both sides.

14 ♕e2

White is copying Stein's moves, but the extra ♖a1-a4-c4 threat gives him even better chances.

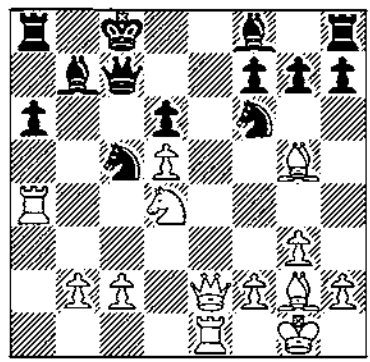
14...♔c8

Instead 14...♕b6 15 ♖xa4 ♕xb2 16 ♕e8+ ♔c7 17 ♕xf7 ♖c8 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♗h3 is winning for White.



15 ♖xa4 ♘c5

Losing, but 15...♘e5 16 ♗xf6 (another way is 16 f4! ♕d7 17 ♖b4 ♗xd5 18 ♗xf6 a5 19 ♗xd5 axb4 20 ♗xa8) 16...gxf6 17 f4 ♕b6 18 fxe5 dxe5 19 ♔h1 is but a temporary stay of execution.



16 ♗xf6 gxf6 17 ♕e8+ ♕d8 18 ♗h3+ f5 19 ♗xf5+ ♔c7 20 ♕xf7+ ♔b8 1-0

Black can't argue with 21 ♖b4 and 22 ♘c6 or 21 ♖e8. In this excellent example of White's mating attack after a ♘d5 sacrifice, all of White's pieces enjoyed enhanced mobility.

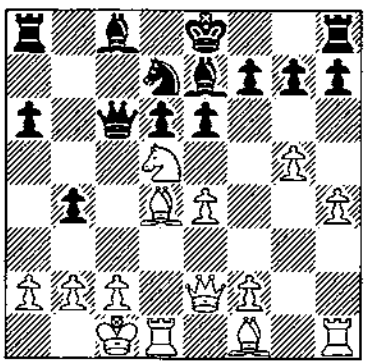
Now we will see how Anatoly Karpov sacrificed his knight on d5 against a great player and coach, GM Dorfman. Even though this sacrifice in the Scheveningen Variation was perfect and effective, Black almost drew a lost position.

Game 7
A.Karpov-J.Dorfman
USSR Championship, Moscow 1976

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e6 6 g4 ♗e7 7 g5 ♘fd7 8 h4 ♘c6 9 ♗e3 a6 10 ♕e2

This is not Karpov's natural style. However, he is happy to block his king's bishop with his queen in order to castle queenside and open the e-file by sacrificing his knight on f5 or d5.

10...♕c7 11 0-0-0 b5 12 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 13 ♗d4 b4 14 ♘d5!?



After this rather unclear positional sacrifice, White will get at least two pawns for the piece, while Black will have four pawn islands and a king in the centre. All these factors give White plenty of compensation.

14...exd5 15 ♗xg7

According to Speelman, 15 exd5 ♕xd5 16 ♗xg7 ♕xh1 17 ♖e1 ♘e5 18 ♗xe5 dxe5 19 ♕xe5 0-0 wins for Black.

15...♖g8 16 exd5 ♕c7 17 ♗f6 ♘e5

Black defends as well as he can, trying to trade as many of White's active pieces as possible, but White's attack still leads to the gain of a third pawn for the knight.

18 ♗xe5

18 f4 ♗xf6 19 gxf6 ♗g4 20 ♕e4 ♗xd1 21 ♔xd1 ♖g4 22 ♗e2 ♔d8 23 ♗xg4 ♘xg4 was good for Black.

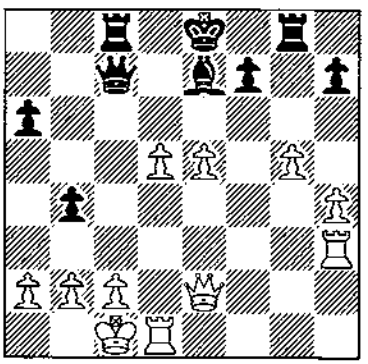
18...dxe5 19 f4

The best move which wins a third pawn due to the pin on the e-file.

19...♗f5 20 ♗h3

20 fxe5 was another good choice.

20...♗xh3 21 ♖xh3 ♖c8 22 fxe5



22...♕c4

Dorfman's brilliant defensive skill has forced Karpov to trade almost all the pieces, but White must keep on the queens to retain his attack.

23 ♖dd3! ♕f4+

23...♕xa2 24 d6 ♖c5 25 ♕e3 ♕a5 26 e6 ♖e5 27 exf7+ ♔xf7 28 ♕f2+ ♔g7 29 dxe7 ♖e8 30 ♕f6+ ♔g8 31 ♖he3 gives White a winning position.

24 ♔b1 ♖c4 25 d6 ♖e4 26 ♖he3 ♖xe3 27 ♖xe3 ♕xh4

The best chance to hold. After 27...♗d8 28 ♖f3 ♕xh4 29 e6 f5 30 e7 ♕e4 31 d7+ ♔xd7 32 ♕xe4 fxe4 33 ♖f8 White is winning.

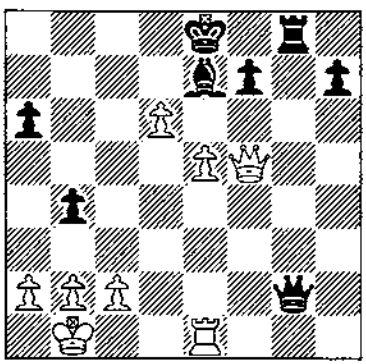
28 ♕f3 ♕xg5

Possibly better was 28...♗d8 since the long line 29 d7+ ♔e7 30 ♕f6+ ♔xd7 31 ♕xf7+ ♔c6 32 ♕e6+ ♔b7 33 ♕d5+ ♔b8 34 a3 ♕xg5 35 ♕d6+ ♗c7 36 ♕xb4+ ♔c8 37 ♕e4 is only slightly better for White.

29 ♖e1 ♕g2

Otherwise 29...♗d8 30 ♖f1 ♕g6 31 ♕c6+ ♔f8 32 ♕d7 ♔g7 33 e6 ♗f6 34 e7 ♕e4 35 ♖g1+ ♔h6 36 ♕h3+ ♗h4 37 ♖h1 ♔h5 38 ♕xh4+ ♕xh4 39 ♖xh4+ ♔xh4 40 b3 and the white pawns are unstoppable.

30 ♕f5



30...♖g6

After 30...♕g4 31 ♕xh7 ♖g7 32 ♕d3 ♗h4 33 ♖f1 ♕c8 34 ♖d1 ♔f8 35 d7 ♕d8 36 ♕f5 ♔g8 37 e6 ♗f6 38 ♕d5 ♔f8 39 ♖f1 a5 40 c4 Black position is tied up and hopeless.

31 ♖f1 ♕d5 32 dxe7 ♔xe7

Instead 32...a5 33 ♕h5 h6 34 e6 is given a '!!' by Speelman, but after 34...♕xe6 35 ♕xa5 ♕xe7 36 ♕a8+ ♔d7 37 ♕b7+ ♔d8 we don't see a win.

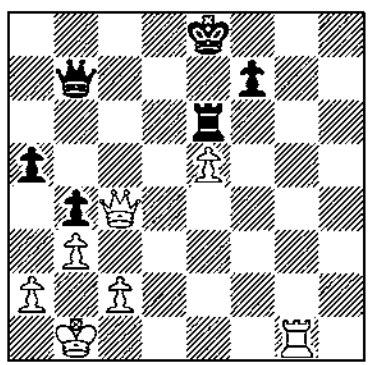
33 ♕f4

Black's three pawn islands and centralized king give Karpov enough targets and advantage to win this endgame.

33...a5 34 ♕h4+ ♔e8 35 ♕xh7 ♕f3 36 ♕h8+ ♔e7 37 ♕h4+ ♔e8 38 ♕c4 ♕b7 39 b3

At long last White makes some luft!

39...♖e6 40 ♖g1



Karpov's temporary pawn sacrifice further opens up Black's king.

40...♖xe5 41 ♖g8+ ♔e7 42 ♕h4+ ♔d7 43 ♕f6 ♖e7 44 ♕f5+ ♔d6 45 ♕xa5 ♖e5 46 ♕d8+ ♔e6 47 ♔b2 f6 48 ♖f8 ♕g7 49 ♕c8+ ♔d5 50 ♕c4+ 1-0

Black gave up as 50...♔d6 51 ♖d8+ ♔e7 52 ♕c7+ wins the queen.

We now come to a very complicated

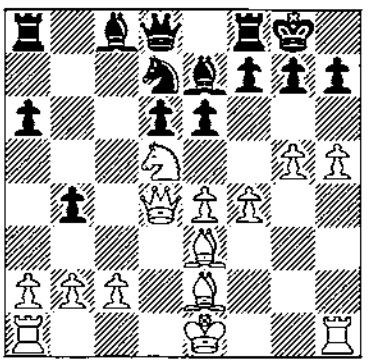
game with hundreds of variations which are very difficult to calculate even for a computer. After Iordachescu sacrificed his knight on d5 in the Scheveningen, I had to prove to the computer in a lot of variations that White is better, not worse. I believe that if you too analyse this game with a computer, your tactical ability will improve and maybe you can find improvements for both sides.

Game 8
V.Iordachescu-F.Guido
Jesolo 1999

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 g4 ♘c6 7 g5 ♘d7 8 h4 ♗e7 9 ♗e3 a6 10 f4 0-0 11 ♗e2 ♘xd4 12 ♕xd4 b5 13 h5

White is ready to castle queenside and to create a deadly attack on the black king. Black, for his part, is forced to play aggressively too.

13...b4 14 ♘d5!



With the idea of diverting the e-pawn from blocking the long diagonal. Instead 14 ♕xb4 ♖b8 15 ♕a4 ♖xb2 gives Black counterchances, while 14 h6 e5 15 ♕xb4 ♖b8 16 ♕a4 g6 17 ♘d5 ♖xb2 is good for Black.

14...exd5 15 h6 gxh6 16 0-0-0 b3

Instead after 16...hxg5 (which looks good because 17 ♖xh7? fails to 17...♗f6) 17 ♕xd5 ♘b6 18 ♕d3! f5 19 ♖h6 fxe4 20 ♕b3+ ♖f7 21 ♗h5 ♕f8 22 fxg5 ♗b7 23 g6 hxg6 24 ♗xg6 ♗d5 25 ♗xf7+ ♔xf7 26 ♖xd5, White wins.

17 axb3 ♕a5 18 ♔b1 hxg5 19 b4 ♕c7 20 exd5 ♖e8

Black might have raced on, but after 20...a5 21 ♖xh7 ♘f6 (21...♗f6 22 ♕e4 axb4 23 ♖dh1 ♖d8 24 ♖xf7 ♔xf7 25 ♗h5+ ♔f8 26 ♕e6 ♖a1+ 27 ♔xa1 ♗xb2+ 28 ♔xb2 ♕c3+ 29 ♔b1 ♕f6 30 f5 ♔g7 31 ♗xg5 wins material) 22 ♖h6 axb4 23 ♕d3 ♗d8 24 ♖dh1 ♖e8 25 ♖h8+ ♔g7 26 ♖1h7+ ♘xh7 27 ♕xh7+ ♔f6 28 ♕h6+ White wins.

21 ♕d3

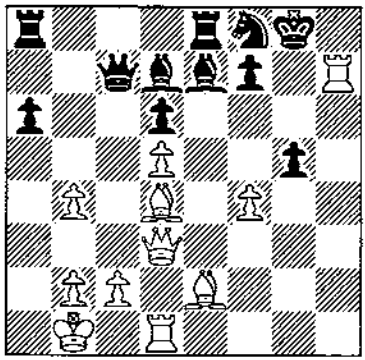
And not 21 ♖xh7? ♗f6 22 ♕d3 ♖xe3 23 ♕xe3 ♔xh7.

21...♘f8 22 ♗d4 ♗d7?

Closing the b1-h7 diagonal by 22...f5 doesn't save Black: 23 ♗h5 ♖d8 24 ♗c3 ♕a7 25 ♖de1 h6 26 ♖e6 ♘xe6 27 ♕xf5 ♗f6 28 ♕xf6 ♕g7 29 ♗f7+ ♔f8 30 dxe6 ♕xf6 31 ♗xf6 ♗xe6 32 ♗xe6 ♖e8 33 ♗d5 and wins. However, the superior defence 22...♕d7 23 fxg5 ♕f5 24 ♕c3 ♗f6 25 gxf6 ♖xe2 26 ♖d2 ♖xd2 27 ♕xd2 ♕g6 28 ♖h6 ♕f5 29 ♖h1 ♕g6 30 ♖h6 ♕f5 31 ♖h1 leads only to a draw as I discovered.

23 ♖xh7!

A rook sacrifice which heralds the final, decisive wave of the attack.



23...♘xh7 24 ♖h1 ♘f6 25 fxg5 ♖ac8 26 gxf6 ♕xc2+ 27 ♕xc2 ♖xc2 28 fxe7 1-0

Black can't save his rook and avoid checkmate.

Game 9
A.Sulypa-B.Andonov
Sautron 2004

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗e3 ♗e7 7 g4 a6 8 g5 ♘fd7 9 h4 ♕c7

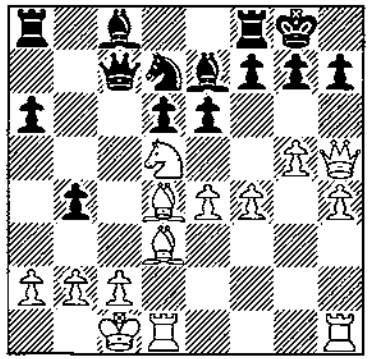
A superior handling of the black pieces was 9...♘c6 10 ♕h5 0-0 11 0-0-0 ♘de5 12 ♗d3 ♘xd3+ 13 ♖xd3 ♘e5 14 ♖dd1 b5 15 f4 ♘c4 16 ♘c6 ♕d7 17 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 18 ♗d4 b4 19 ♘e2 e5, which gave Black a good position in S.Movsesian-L.Van Wely, Panormo (blitz) 2002.

10 ♕h5 0-0 11 f4 ♘c6 12 0-0-0

White's dangerous attack forces Black to play actively. Moreover, Black has to be ready for all of ♘d5, ♘f5 and f4-f5 hits.

12...♘xd4 13 ♗xd4 b5 14 ♗d3 b4 15 ♘d5

Fritz likes 15 ♗xg7! as White mates after either 15...♔xg7 16 ♕h6+ ♔g8 17 e5 or 15...bxc3 16 e5. We will analyse similar variations in the next game.



15...exd5 16 e5

Throwing another pawn on to the fire. Two centralized bishops, an active queen and a potent pawn-storm gives White more than enough compensation for the knight. Alternatively, 16 ♗xg7 most likely leads to another win: for example, 16...♘c5 17 ♕h6 b3 18 axb3 ♖e8 19 b4 ♗f8 20 ♗xf8 ♘xd3+ 21 ♖xd3 ♖xf8 22 f5 f6 23 gxf6 ♖f7 24 ♖g1+ ♔h8 25 ♖dg3 ♗xf5 26 exf5 ♕d7 27 ♖g7 ♖xg7 28 fxg7+ ♔g8 29 f6 and wins. However, the typical 16 exd5 is probably not so good in view of the resource 16...f5 17 ♖he1 ♘c5 18 ♔b1 ♘xd3 19 ♖xd3 ♗b7 20 ♖de3 ♖ac8.

16...g6

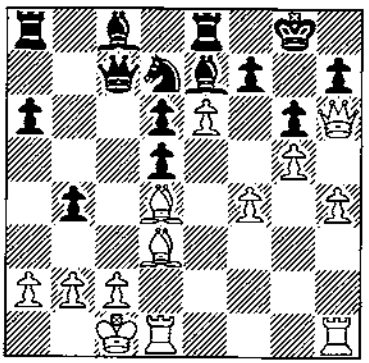
According to the computer the best move, but in any case it won't save the black king.

17 ♕h6 ♖e8

Otherwise, 17...dxe5 18 h5 exd4 19 hxg6 ♕xf4+ 20 ♔b1 ♘f6 21 g7 ♗f5 22 gxf8♕+ ♗xf8 23 ♕xf6 wins material,

and 17...♘xe5 18 fxe5 dxe5 19 h5 ♗f5 20 ♗xf5 gxf5 21 g6 fxg6 22 hxg6 ♗f6 23 g7 ♕xg7 24 ♖dg1 is hopeless for Black.

18 e6



The final nail in the coffin. White's mating threats decide the game.

18...f6

18...♘e5 doesn't help, since 19 exf7+ ♔xf7 20 ♕xh7+ ♔e6 21 ♗xe5 dxe5 22 ♕xg6+ wins for White.

19 ♗xg6 1-0

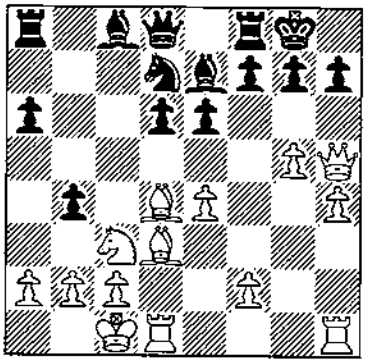
Game 10
E.Szalanczy-V.Gavrikov
Debrecen 1988

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e6 6 ♗e3 a6 7 g4 ♘c6 8 g5 ♘d7 9 h4 ♗e7 10 ♕h5 0-0 11 0-0-0 ♘xd4 12 ♗xd4 b5 13 ♗d3

Aiming at the h7-pawn.

13...b4

Losing immediately. According to the computer, 13...♘e5 was the best choice for Black, neutralizing the white bishops. However, after 14 f4 ♘xd3+ 15 ♖xd3 b4 16 ♘e2 ♕a5 17 ♔b1 e5 18 ♗e3 ♗e6 19 b3 ♖fc8 20 ♖d2 ♖c3 21 ♘xc3 bxc3 22 ♖f2 exf4 23 ♖xf4 ♖c8 24 ♖hf1 g6 25 ♕f3 ♕e5 26 ♖xf7 ♗f8 27 ♖xf8+ White is winning, T.Luther-M.Brod, Oberwart 2005.



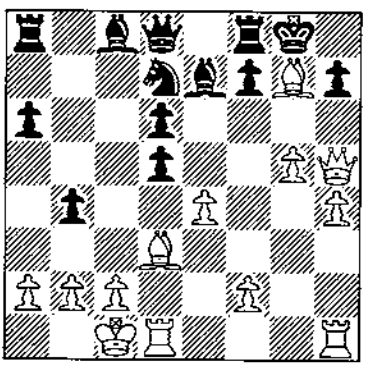
14 ♘d5!?

Amazingly enough 14 ♗xg7! wins after 14...bxc3 (14...♔xg7 15 ♕h6+ ♔h8 16 e5 f5 17 g6 ♖f7 18 gxf7 ♕f8 19 ♕xf8+ ♗xf8 20 ♖hg1 costs Black material) 15 e5 cxb2+ 16 ♔b1 f5 17 gxf6 with a mating attack.

14...exd5

14...♘e5 could give Black counterchances after 15 ♘xb4 ♕c7 16 a3 ♗b7.

15 ♗xg7

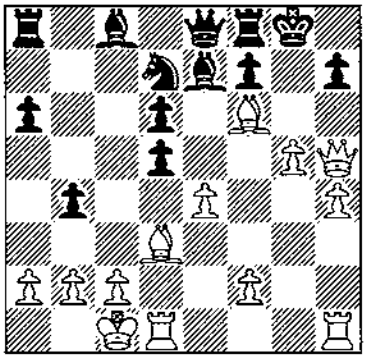


This unexpected sacrifice finishes the game.

15...♕e8

Alternatively, 15...♔xg7 16 ♕h6+ ♔g8 (16...♔h8 is perhaps more stubborn, but 17 e5 f5 18 g6 ♖f7 19 gxf7 ♕f8 20 ♕xf8+ ♘xf8 21 ♖dg1 looks good for White) 17 exd5 f5 18 gxf6 ♖f7 19 ♖hg1+ ♔h8 20 ♖g7 ♘xf6 21 ♖xf7 wins for White.

16 ♗f6 1-0



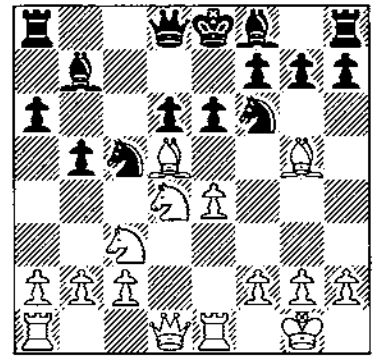
Following 16...♘xf6 17 gxf6 ♗xf6 18 e5 h6 19 ♖hg1+ Black will be mated in a couple of moves. Note that Gavrikov is a strong tactician who participated in the legendary USSR Championship. Indeed, it's amazing how he couldn't survive more than three moves after the ♘d5 sacrifice.

Game 11
M.Tal-M.Mukhin
USSR Championship, Baku 1972

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4

Fischer's favourite weapon against the Najdorf.

6...e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 0-0 ♗b7 9 ♖e1 ♘bd7 10 ♗g5 ♘c5 11 ♗d5!

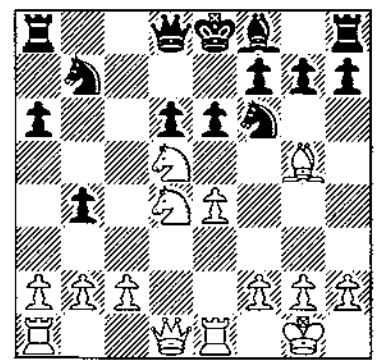


Sacrificing a bishop and preparing the next trick after 11...b4.

11...b4

After 11...exd5 12 exd5+ ♔d7 13 b4 ♘a4 14 ♘xa4 bxa4 15 c4 ♔c8 16 ♕xa4 ♕d7 17 ♘c6 White's great activity gives him good winning chances.

12 ♗xb7 ♘xb7 13 ♘d5



After this sacrifice Black is losing in all variations.

13...exd5

Entertaining is the line 13...a5 14

♗xf6 gxf6 15 ♘c6 ♕c8 16 ♘xf6 mate.

14 exd5+

Levy's 14 e5 dxe5 15 ♖xe5+ ♔d7 16 c4 also looks good for White.

14...♔d7 15 c3

15 ♘c6 ♕b6 16 ♗xf6 gxf6 17 ♕h5 ♘d8 18 ♕f5+ ♔c7 19 ♘xd8 ♖xd8 20 ♕xf6 is another way to win material.

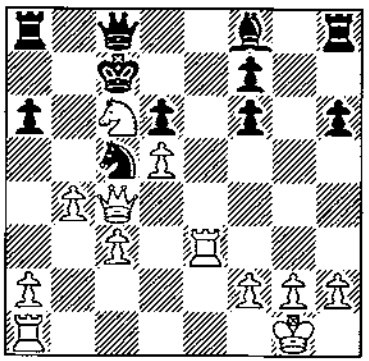
15...b3

Many years later after 15...♕a5 16 ♗xf6 gxf6 17 cxb4 ♕xd5 18 ♕a4+ ♔c7 19 ♖ac1+ ♘c5 20 bxc5 dxc5 21 ♖ed1 ♖g8 22 g3 ♔b6 23 ♘b3 ♕h5 24 ♖d7 ♖c8 25 ♕a5+ ♔c6 26 ♖cd1 ♕e2 27 ♘d4+! Black resigned in the game A.Areshchenko-S.Akbarinia, Kuala Lumpur 2002.

16 ♕xb3 ♘c5 17 ♕c4 ♕c8 18 ♘c6 h6 19 ♗xf6 gxf6 20 ♖e3

White follows the typical plan after sacrificing a knight on d5: place the remaining knight on c6, spoil Black's pawn structure on the kingside, double rooks on the open file, and wait for the resignation.

20...♔c7 21 b4



Winning a piece.

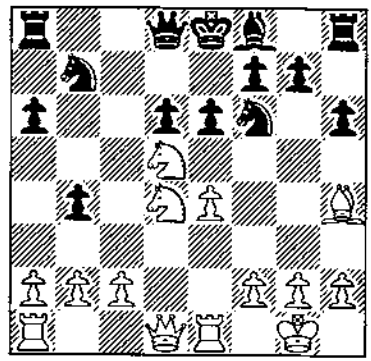
21...♖g8 1-0

Game 12
O.Kozlitin-R.Nechepurenko
Samara 2004

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 0-0 ♗b7 9 ♖e1 ♘bd7 10 ♗g5 h6 11 ♗h4 ♘c5 12 ♗d5 b4

If 12...exd5 13 exd5+ ♔d7 14 b4 ♘a4 15 ♘xa4, then 15...g5 could give Black some counterchances after 16 ♗g3 bxa4 17 c4, although it seems to me that White's initiative is more than enough for the bishop. Here a weaker defence is 15...bxa4, as we'll see in Chapter Seven.

13 ♗xb7 ♘xb7 14 ♘d5



Black's idea of ...g5 reduces White's threats after the knight sacrifice, but it is not enough to solve all his problems.

14...exd5 15 exd5+ ♔d7 16 c3

Promising too is 16 ♘c6 ♕c8 17 ♕f3 ♔c7 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♕xf6 ♖h7 20 a3 due to Black's open king, disorganized pieces and many pawn islands.

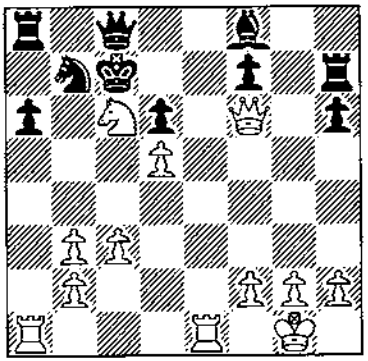
16...b3

Sacrificing a pawn, but closing the c-file.

17 ♘c6 ♕c8 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♕d4

19 ♕f3 and 19 ♕h5 were two other strong possibilities to attack Black's king and pawns.

19...♔c7 20 ♕xf6 ♖h7 21 axb3



White can consider his sacrifice a success. He has won three pawns for his bishop and all his pieces are very active, whereas Black can only dream about finding good squares for or exchanging his pieces.

21...♕d7 22 ♕d4

Among many ways to win this tricky position is 22 ♖a4 ♘c5 23 ♖c4 ♖e8 24 ♖xe8 ♕xe8 25 ♔f1 ♖g7 26 b4 ♘d7 27 ♕d4 which wins material.

22...♖g7 23 ♕c4 ♕g4 24 ♘d4+ ♘c5 25 g3 ♔d8 26 b4 ♘b7 27 ♖e4

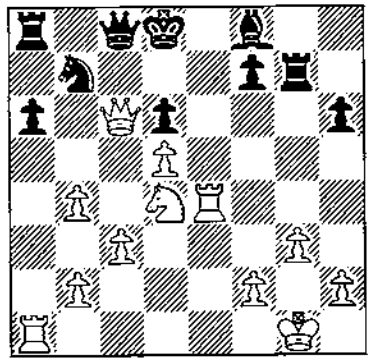
The superior 27 ♖xa6 wins immediately in view of the line 27...♖xa6 28 ♕xa6 ♕c8 29 ♘c6+ ♔c7 30 ♘a7 ♕d7 31 ♘b5+.

27...♕c8

27...♕xe4 28 ♘c6+ wins the queen.

28 ♕c6

Now White regains his piece, leaving him a couple of pawns ahead. Black's position is hopeless.



28...♕xc6 29 dxc6 ♘c5 30 bxc5 ♔c7 31 cxd6+ ♗xd6 32 ♘f5 ♖g6 33 ♘xd6 ♖xd6 34 ♖e7+ ♔xc6 35 ♖xf7 ♖d2 36 ♖f6+ ♔b5 37 c4+ ♔xc4 38 ♖axa6 ♖e8 39 ♖ac6+ ♔b3 40 ♖b6+ ♔a4 41 ♖xh6 ♖f8 42 ♖hf6 1-0

Game 13
L.Dominguez-J.Corral Blanco
Spanish Team Championship 2002

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 ♗e7 8 ♕e2 0-0 9 0-0-0 a6 10 ♗b3 ♕e8

Preparing ...b5 and moving the queen away from the range of the rook on d1. More recently, 10...♕c7 11 ♖hg1 b5 12 g4 b4 13 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 14 ♘d5 exd5 15 g5 ♘xe4 16 ♗xd5 ♕a4 17 ♗d4 ♗f5 18 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 19 ♕xe4 ♕xa2!? 20 ♕xe7 ♖ae8 21 ♕c7 ♖e4 22 ♗e3 ♖c4 23 ♕xd6 b3 24 ♔d2 was rather unclear in K.Movsziszian-K.Spraggett, Tarragona 2006, although White went on to win.

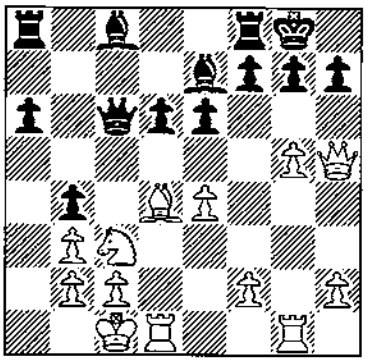
11 ♖hg1

Preparing a kingside attack.

11...♘d7 12 g4 ♘c5 13 g5 b5 14 ♘xc6 ♘xb3+ 15 axb3 ♕xc6 16 ♕h5

According to the computer, Black's threats make his position very dangerous, but White's future sacrifices will destroy the black king's fortress.

16...b4 17 ♗d4!

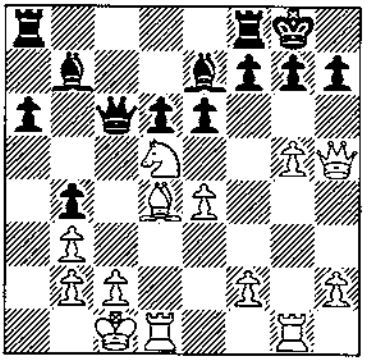


17...♗b7

It's hard to believe, but the best try here is most likely 17...bxc3 18 ♕h6 cxb2+ 19 ♔xb2 e5 20 ♗xe5 ♕xc2+ 21 ♔xc2 dxe5 22 ♕h5 ♗e6 23 ♖d3 ♖fc8+ 24 ♔b2 a5 25 ♖a1 ♖c5 when White has a queen for a pair of bishops, but his attack is spent while Black has plenty of potential. 'Unclear' is perhaps a copout, but this is as close to the truth as I can determine.

18 ♘d5

The computer believes that White is absolutely lost, but after the two players follow its recommendations for seven moves, White lands up winning! This reminds us that sometimes a human's intuitive sense can still be better than the computer's calculations.



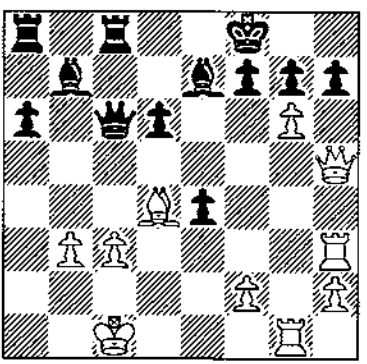
18...exd5 19 ♖d3

The typical queen sacrifice, 19 ♕h6, loses after 19...♕xc2+ 20 ♔xc2 ♖fc8+ 21 ♔b1 gxh6 22 gxh6+ ♔f8 23 exd5, leaving White down a piece.

19...♖fc8

Alternatively, 19...♖ac8 20 c3 bxc3 21 bxc3 f6 22 ♖h3 fxg5 23 ♗xg7 wins, while after 19...f6 20 ♖h3 ♖ac8 21 ♕xh7+ ♔f7 22 exd5 ♕xc2+ 23 ♕xc2 ♖xc2+ 24 ♔xc2 ♖c8+ 25 ♔d3 fxg5 26 ♖f3+ ♔g6 27 ♖e3 White wins material.

20 c3 bxc3 21 bxc3 dxe4 22 ♖h3 ♔f8 23 g6!



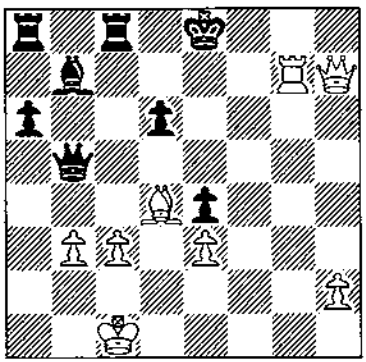
The natural 23 ♕xh7? actually loses for White after 23...♔e8 24 g6 ♕d5 25

gxf7+ ♔d7.

23...fxg6?

This loses in couple of moves. Instead 23...h6 was the best move which leads to a very unclear position after 24 ♗xg7+ ♔e8 25 gxf7+ ♔d7 26 ♕f5+ ♔c7 27 c4 a5 28 ♖xh6 a4 29 ♖e6 ♕d7 30 b4. Even though computers like Black here, I believe that White has enough counterchances to survive this mess.

24 ♕xh7 ♔e8 25 ♖xg6 ♕b5 26 ♖xg7 ♗g5+ 27 ♖e3! ♗xe3+ 28 fxe3



Black's extra rook is nothing compared to White's mating attack. Indeed, only a couple of checks can postpone Black's fate.

28...♕f1+ 29 ♔b2 1-0

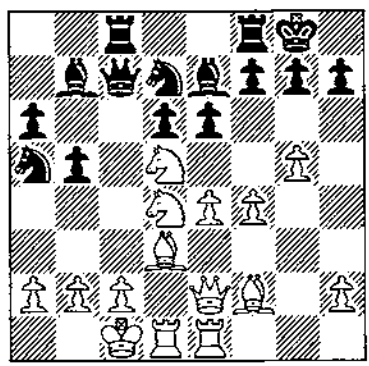
The line 29...♕f2+ 30 ♔a3 ♕f8 31 ♕g6+ ♔d8 32 ♗b6+ ♖c7 33 ♗xc7+ ♔c8 34 ♕e6 mate finishes the game.

Game 14
A.Lukashok-V.Smirnov
Belarus Championship, Minsk 2003

1 ♘f3 c5 2 e4 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 a6 8 ♕e2 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘a5 10 ♗d3 b5 11 f4 ♗b7 12 ♗f2

White moves his bishop twice in the opening to defend the e4-pawn and prepare ♘d5, as well as to introduce the dangerous ideas of e4-e5, f4-f5 and ♗h4. Instead after 12 ♔b1 ♗e7 13 f5 e5 14 ♘b3 ♘c4 15 ♗c1 h5 16 ♖he1 ♖c8 17 ♗xc4 ♕xc4 18 ♕xc4 bxc4 19 ♘d2 ♗d8 20 ♘f3 ♔e7 White eventually managed to win this even endgame in V.Kupreichik-S.Voitsekhovsky, Tula 2002.

12...♖c8 13 ♖he1 ♗e7 14 g4 0-0 15 g5 ♘d7 16 ♘d5!



The computer doesn't believe that after Black played all the natural moves one crazy sacrifice can win the game. However, we shall soon prove otherwise...

16...exd5 17 ♘f5 ♖fe8

Interesting is 17...♗d8 18 exd5 g6 (this weakening appears forced) 19 ♘h6+ ♔g7 20 ♗d4+ f6 21 ♕e6 ♘c4 22 ♗xc4 bxc4 23 ♖g1 ♖b8 24 f5 ♘c5 25 ♕e3 ♔h8 26 fxg6 hxg6 27 gxf6 ♗xf6 28 ♖xg6 ♗xd4 29 ♕xd4+ ♔h7 30 ♖dg1 and

White has a mating attack. Another possible line runs 17...♘c5 18 exd5 ♘xd3+ 19 ♖xd3 ♗d8 20 ♗d4 ♕d7 21 ♕e4 ♖c4 22 ♖h3 f6 23 ♘e7+ ♗xe7 24 ♕xh7+ ♔f7 25 ♕h5+ g6 26 ♕h7+ ♔e8 27 ♕xg6+ ♔d8 28 gxf6 ♗xf6 29 ♗xf6+ ♔c8 30 ♖h7, trapping Black's queen.

18 exd5 ♗f8

Alternatively, 18...♘e5 19 fxe5 ♗xg5+ 20 ♔b1 ♖xe5 21 ♕g4 h6 22 ♖xe5 dxe5 23 ♗e3 ♕d8 24 h4 ♗f6 25 ♗xh6 g6 26 h5 leaves Black's king with no chances to survive.

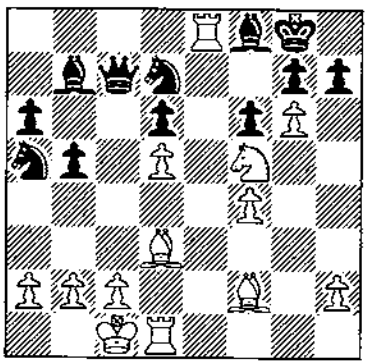
19 ♕xe8 ♖xe8 20 ♖xe8

White threatens 21 ♘e7+ ♔h8 22 ♗f5.

20...f6

Even after the best response 20...g6 White still wins: 21 ♘h6+ ♔g7 22 ♗d4+ f6 23 gxf6+ ♔xh6 24 ♖e3 ♘xf6 25 ♗xf6 ♗c8 26 f5 gxf5 27 ♖g1 f4 28 ♗g5+ ♔h5 29 ♗e2+ ♗g4 30 ♗xg4+ ♔xg5 31 ♗e2+ ♔f5 32 ♖e6 f3 33 ♗d3+ ♔f4 34 ♖e4+ ♔f5 35 ♖c4+ wins the queen.

21 g6



After this move Black's king is in huge trouble.

21...hxg6 22 ♘e7+ ♔h7 23 ♗xg6+ ♔h6 24 ♖g1 1-0

Black can't escape checkmate.

Game 15
B.Spassky-G.Zaichik
Moscow 1972

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 ♗d3

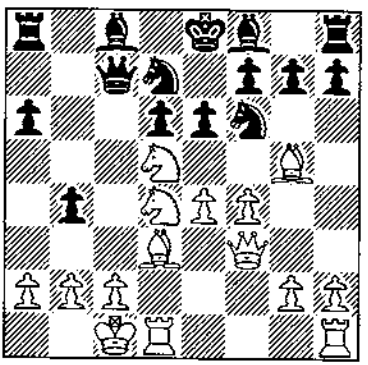
A popular variation which leads to lots of very complicated continuations with many sacrificial possibilities for both sides.

10...b4

As hinted elsewhere in this chapter, 10...♗b7 is a decent alternative here.

11 ♘d5

Otherwise 11 ♘ce2 is safe but unpromising.



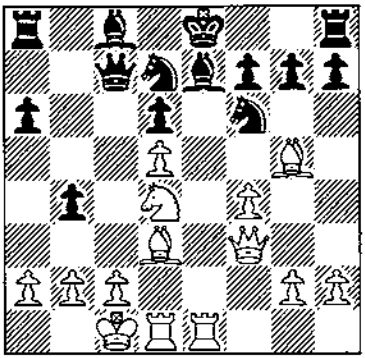
11...exd5 12 ♖he1 ♗e7

The alternative 12...♗b7 will be discussed in the next game.

13 exd5

The promising, extremely complicated 13 ♘f5! actually appears to be winning after 13...b3 14 axb3 ♘c5 15

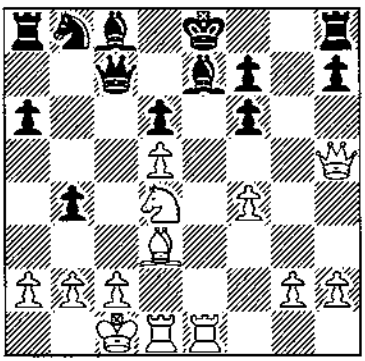
♘xg7+ ♔f8 16 ♗h6 ♕a5 17 exd5 ♕a1+ 18 ♔d2 ♕a5+ 19 c3 ♘g8 20 ♕e3 ♘xd3 21 ♘f5+ ♔e8 22 ♘xe7 ♗e6 23 ♕xd3 ♘xh6 24 ♘c6 ♕c5 25 ♕e4.



13...♘b8

Trying to cover the c6- and f5-squares, but Black is helping White to organize a dangerous attack. Better is 13...♔f8 14 ♘f5 ♗d8 15 ♘xg7 h6 16 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 17 ♘f5 with chances for both sides.

14 ♗xf6 gxf6 15 ♕h5



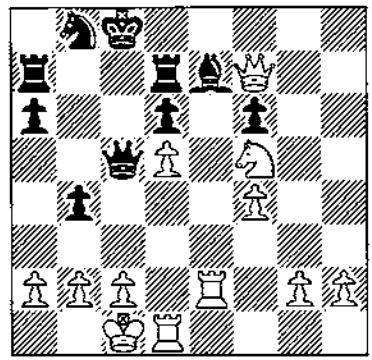
White's activity is more than enough compensation for the bishop. Note that Black's pieces are very passive and his pawns are weak, while White is trying to double his rooks on e-file and trade the light-squared bishops, thereby capturing the f5-square with serious pressure.

15...♖a7 16 ♖e2 ♖f8

16...♕a5 17 ♔b1 ♖c7 18 ♗f5 is very unpleasant for Black.

17 ♗f5 ♔d8 18 ♕xh7 ♕c5 19 ♗xc8 ♔xc8 20 ♕g7 ♖d8 21 ♕xf7 ♖dd7 22 ♘f5

White successfully follows his positional plan. He has easily traded the light-squared bishops, placed the knight on f5 and prepared to double his rooks on the open file.



22...♗d8 23 ♕e6 ♖ac7 24 h4

White's passed h-pawn and activity decides this game, as Spassky follows a famous rule: if you have a passed pawn, just push it.

24...♔b7 25 ♕e4 a5 26 h5 a4 27 ♔b1 a3 28 g4 ♔a8 29 ♕d4

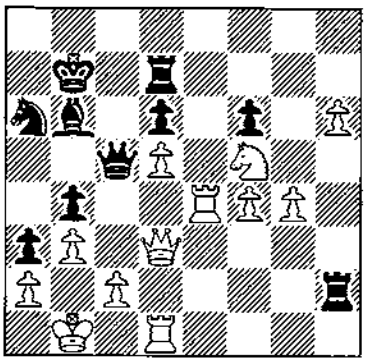
Promising too is 29 ♘d4 ♕a5 30 ♘e6 ♖a7 31 b3, which helps White to get two connected passed pawns.

29...♕b5 30 ♕d3 ♕a5 31 b3 ♖c3 32 ♕d4 ♖h3 33 ♖e6

While Black is trying to stop

White's passed pawns, White has put more pressure on the weak b4-, d6- and f6-pawns.

33...♗b6 34 ♕d2 ♕c5 35 ♖e4 ♖h2 36 ♕d3 ♔b7 37 h6 ♘a6



38 ♖e6?

Spassky drifts around here, perhaps due to a shortage of time. Instead after 38 g5 fxg5 39 fxg5 ♕f2 40 ♖f1 ♕g2 41 ♕c4 White is better due to his two passed pawns and continuing attack.

38...♔a7?

Better was 38...♘c7 39 ♖c4 ♘xd5 40 ♖c4 ♘c3+ 41 ♔a1 ♕f2 42 ♘xd6+ ♖xd6 43 ♕xd6 ♘xd1 44 ♕d7+ ♔a6 45 ♕c8+ when it's perpetual check.

39 ♖xf6?

Another mistake; 39 ♖e4 ♔b7 40 ♖c4 ♕a5 41 g5 would have been winning for White.

39...♖c7?

And another! 39...♘c7 40 ♘g3 ♘xd5 41 ♘e4 ♕c6 leaves White in big trouble due to Black's activity.

40 ♖c1

After this defensive move Black can't stop the three passed pawns.

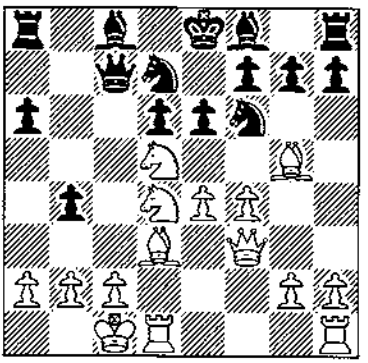
40...♕f2 41 ♘xd6 1-0

White wins another pawn.

We will next see another important idea behind the ♘d5 sacrifice; White trades his knight on c6 and the resulting passed c-pawn becomes an extra threat.

Game 16
U.Atakisi-L.Mazi
European Championship, Antalya 2004

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 ♗d3 b4 11 ♘d5



In the previous game we saw how Spassky successfully used this sacrifice against Zaichik. In this game Atakisi uses Spassky's ideas, but adds his own flavour.

11...exd5 12 exd5 ♗b7

For 12...♗e7 13 ♖he1, see the previous game.

13 ♖he1+ ♔d8 14 ♘c6+ ♗xc6

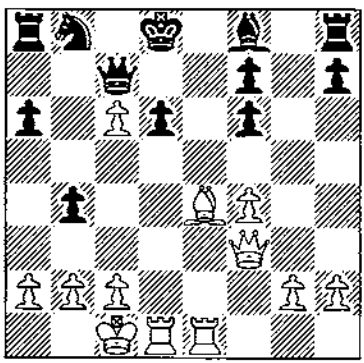
14...♔c8 is losing after 15 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 16 ♗f5+ ♘d7 17 ♖e8+.

15 dxc6 ♘b8

Another alternative is 15...♘b6, but after 16 ♗xf6+ (16 ♗h4!? ♖c8 17 ♗xa6 ♖a8 18 ♗b7 ♖xa2 19 ♔b1 ♖a5 20 ♖e5 ♘a4 21 ♕e4 ♖xe5 22 fxe5 ♕b6 23 ♖d4 ♘c5 24 ♕d5 b3 25 exd6 bxc2+ 26 ♔xc2 ♘xb7 27 ♗xf6+ forced Black to resign in E.Berg-Li Chao, Beijing 2006) 16...gxf6 17 ♗f5 ♗e7 18 ♕e3 ♘c8 19 ♖e2 ♖b8 20 ♖de1 Black's uncoordinated pieces are in big trouble.

Practice has seen too 15...♘c5 when 16 ♗xf6+ gxf6 17 ♗c4 ♖a7 18 ♕d5 ♕b6 19 ♕f5 ♗e7 20 ♗d5 a5 21 ♕g4 a4 22 ♕g7 ♖e8 23 ♗xf7 b3 24 ♖xd6+ ♔c8 25 a3 gave White more than enough initiative for the piece in P.Thipsay-L.Ravi, Mumbai 2003.

16 ♗xf6+ gxf6 17 ♗e4



This position reminds us of Spassky-Zaichik. For the knight White has a pawn, active pieces, a dangerous c-pawn which paralyses Black's queenside, an open e-file, weak black pawns to target and a mating attack. However, even though Black's pieces are badly placed, an extra piece can give him good drawing or even winning chances if he can just trade a couple of active white pieces. Indeed, objectively the position is unclear with chances for both sides.

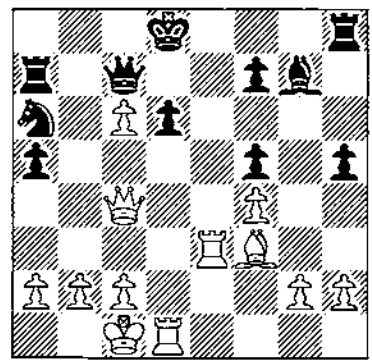
17...h5

Black's best chance was to free his pieces on the queenside by 17...a5 18 ♕e3 ♗e7 19 ♗d5 ♖a6 20 ♖d2 ♘xc6 21 ♖de2 ♖e8 22 ♗xf7 ♖f8 23 ♗d5 ♖e8, which would have remained rather unclear.

18 ♗d5 ♖a7 19 ♕e4 ♗g7 20 ♕xb4

The collection of the pawn harvest begins.

20...a5 21 ♕c4 f5 22 ♖e3 ♘a6 23 ♗f3



Preventing ...♘c5 and aiming at Black's weak pawns.

23...♔c8 24 ♖de1 ♖d8 25 ♕d5 ♘c5 26 ♕xf5+?

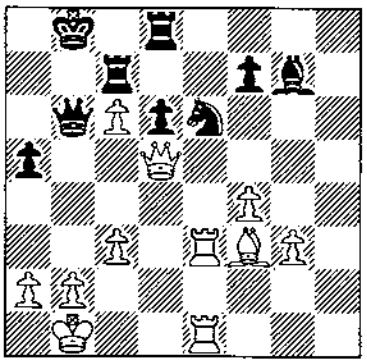
The f5-pawn was not going anywhere. Better is 26 ♗xh5 ♕b6 27 c3 ♖c7 28 ♕xf5+ and the extra material gives White excellent winning chances.

26...♔b8 27 ♕d5 ♕b6 28 c3 ♘e6 29 g3 h4 30 ♔b1

I believe this prophylactic move was a small mistake. The active 30 ♗h5 ♕c5 31 ♖d3 hxg3 32 hxg3 ♖c7 33 ♗xf7

♕xd5 34 ♖xd5 ♘xf4 35 ♖b5+ ♔c8 36 ♗b3 ♘d3+ 37 ♔d2 ♘c5 38 ♖xa5 ♖xc6 leads to an unclear position, although this probably should end as a draw.

30...hxg3 31 hxg3 ♖c7

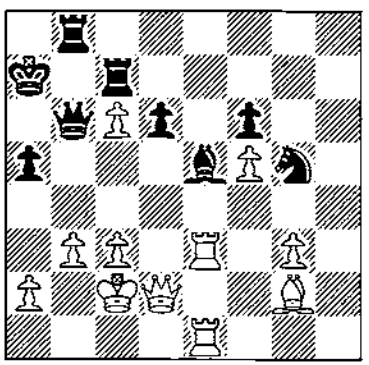


Black has activated all his pieces, while White has equalized the material count. It looks like Black should survive this messy position, but White's positional pressure proves too much for Mazi.

32 ♔c2 ♔a7 33 f5?!

33 ♗h5! ♖xc6 34 ♗xf7 ♘d4+ 35 ♔d1 ♖c5 36 ♕g2 was a better try.

33...♘g5 34 ♗g2 ♖b8 35 b3 ♗e5 36 ♕d2 f6



Suddenly Black has activated his pieces, defended his weak pawns and is ready to seize the initiative. Probably it was wrong to give up the e5- and g5-squares by pushing White's f-pawn.

37 ♖d3 ♕c5?

After the manoeuvre 37...♘f7 38 g4 ♘d8 39 ♗d5 ♘xc6 White could only dream about survival.

38 ♖d5 ♕a3 39 ♔b1 ♖b6 40 c4

The sacrifice 40 ♖exe5! gives White an extra pawn and good winning chances after 40...dxe5 41 ♖d7 ♖xb3+ 42 axb3 ♕xb3+ 43 ♕b2 ♕xb2+ 44 ♔xb2 ♔b6 45 ♖d6.

40...♖a6?

A better try was the wild 40...♖xb3+ 41 axb3 ♕xb3+ 42 ♔c1 ♕xc4+ 43 ♔d1 ♕g4+ 44 ♖e2 ♕a4+ 45 ♔e1 ♗xg3+ 46 ♔f1 ♕a1+ 47 ♕d1 ♕xd1+ 48 ♖xd1 ♗e5 49 ♖b1, although this still is lost for Black.

41 ♖b5 a4 42 ♖e3 axb3 43 ♖exb3 ♕a4 44 ♕e3+ 1-0

Checkmate follows.

Game 17
D.Bronstein-F.Gheorghiu
Petropolis Interzonal 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕e2

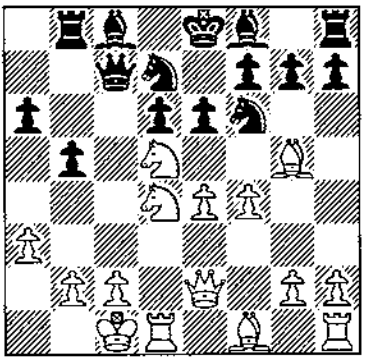
Innovative. In order to castle as quickly as possible, White blocks his light-squared bishop. In addition, e4-e5 and ♘c3-d5 can become serious threats in the future.

8...♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 a3 ♖b8

Threatening 11...b4. A respectable

alternative is 10...♗e7, while after 10...♗b7 11 g4 ♗e7 12 ♗g2 0-0 13 ♗h4 g6 14 ♖hf1 ♘b6 15 ♖d3 ♘c4 16 ♖h3 ♖ac8 17 f5 e5 18 ♘b3 d5 19 exd5 e4 20 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 21 ♗xe7 ♘xc3 22 ♖xc3 ♖fe8 23 f6 ♗xd5 White achieved an advantage, but the game was later drawn, in T.Radjabov-S.Karjakin, European Team Championship, Crete 2007.

11 ♘d5



After the sacrifice is accepted, Black's rook on b8 will become a target for White's remaining knight.

11...exd5 12 exd5+ ♗e7 13 ♘c6 ♘b6 14 ♗xf6 gxf6 15 g3

After 15 ♘xb8 ♕xb8 both sides have their chances.

15...♗b7

15...♖b7 16 ♕h5 ♗d7 17 ♗g2 ♗xc6 18 dxc6 ♖b8 19 ♖he1 gives White enough initiative for the piece.

16 ♘xb8 ♕xb8 17 ♗g2 ♕d8 18 ♖he1

Material is equal, but by attacking Black's weak structure and centralized king, White can continue to pose his opponent serious problems.

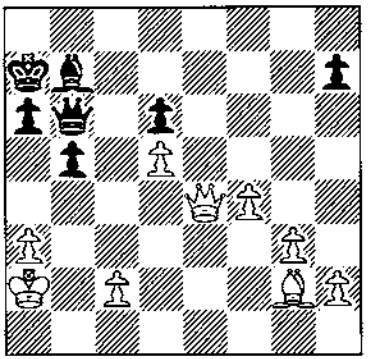
18...f5 19 ♖d3 ♔d7 20 ♕h5 ♔c8 21 ♕xf5+ ♔b8 22 ♕xf7

So the Black king has escaped, but White's two extra pawns and open e-file give him a winning advantage.

22...♗f6 23 ♖de3 ♗xb2+

The last chance to complicate the game.

24 ♔xb2 ♘c4+ 25 ♔a2 ♘xe3 26 ♖xe3 ♕b6 27 ♖e8+ ♖xe8 28 ♕xe8+ ♔a7 29 ♕e4



White has defended his king and is now ready to roll his passed f-pawn.

29...♕f2 30 ♔b2 a5 31 f5 ♔b6 32 g4 h6 33 ♗f3 ♕xh2 34 f6 ♕h4 35 ♕d4+ ♔c7 36 f7 1-0

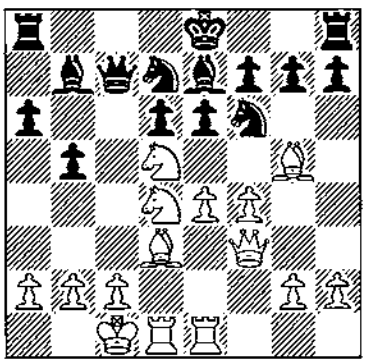
36...♕e7 37 ♕g7 will make a second queen.

Game 18
I.Zaitsev-B.Anetbaev
Odessa 1972

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♗d3 b5 11 ♖he1 ♗b7 12 ♘d5

Kasparov doesn't trust this sacrifice, although GM Alex Stripunsky believes

it is enough for a draw. Maybe it's not so good, but it has baffled many strong players. Certainly, though, it's a memorable sacrifice for me, as a while ago I was teaching one of my students this crazy variation. In the beginning it made her lose a couple of important games, but later she easily checkmated a master and so qualified for a World Girl's Championship.



12...exd5

My student's game continued 12...♘xd5 13 exd5 ♗xd5? (critical is 13...♗xg5 14 ♖xe6+) 14 ♕xd5 exd5 15 ♖xe7+ ♔f8 16 ♗f5 h6 (16...♖d8 17 ♗e6 wins) 17 ♗g6 (better was 17 ♖xd7) 17...hxg5? (the amazing 17...♖h7 creates an unclear position) 18 ♖xf7+ ♔e8 19 ♘e6 ♕c4 20 ♖xg7 and mate.

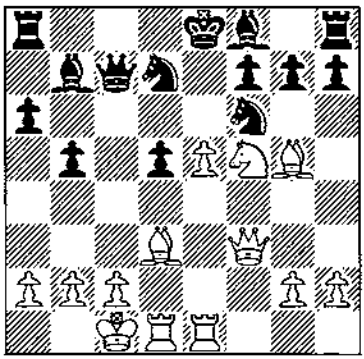
13 ♘f5 ♗f8

This should lose! Better is 13...dxe4 14 ♗xe4 ♘xe4 (14...♘e5 15 fxe5 ♘xe4 16 ♗xe7 ♖c8 17 ♘xg7+ forced Black to give up in M.Brodsky-V.Mudrov, Novgorod 1995) 15 ♖xe4 with chances for both sides.

14 e5!

Superior here to 14 exd5+, as my student once tried without success.

14...dxe5 15 fxe5



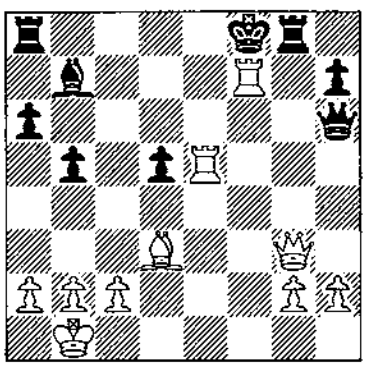
15...♘xe5

According to the computer Black is better after 15...♘e4, but in fact he should lose after the fascinating line 16 ♗xe4 dxe4 17 ♖xe4 ♗xe4 18 ♕xe4 ♕b8 19 e6 ♘e5 20 exf7+ ♔xf7 21 ♖d7+ ♘xd7 22 ♕d5+ ♔g6 23 ♘h4+ ♔h5 24 ♕f5 ♘e5 25 ♗f4+ ♔xh4 26 ♕g5 mate.

16 ♘xg7+

This wins back the material and soon the game.

16...♗xg7 17 ♗xf6 ♔f8 18 ♗xg7+ ♔xg7 19 ♕g3+ ♔f8 20 ♖xe5 ♕b6 21 ♖f1 ♕h6+ 22 ♔b1 ♖g8 23 ♖xf7+!



A beautiful sacrifice, which immediately concludes the game.

23...♔xf7 24 ♖f5+ 1-0

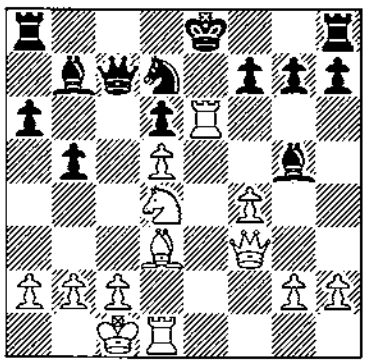
It's mate after 24...♔e6 25 ♕e5+ ♔d7 26 ♖f7+ ♔d8 27 ♕e7+ ♔c8 28 ♕c7.

Game 19
J.Fluvia Poyatos-A.Gual Pascual
Badalona 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 ♘f6 4 ♘c3 cxd4 5 ♘xd4 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 ♗d3 ♗b7 11 ♖he1 ♗e7 12 ♘d5!?

White chose to give this complicated idea a try even though theory hasn't always trusted it.

12...♘xd5 13 exd5 ♗xg5 14 ♖xe6+



A theoretical rook sacrifice which makes life very difficult for Black.

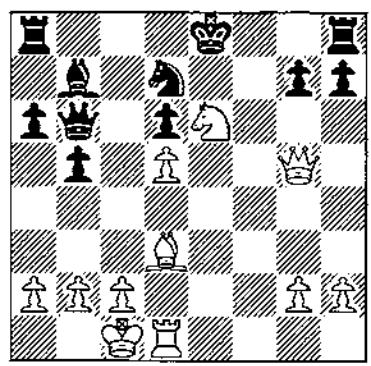
14...fxe6 15 ♘xe6

After 15 ♕h5+ g6 16 ♗xg6+ hxg6 (and not 16...♔e7? 17 ♕xg5+ ♘f6 18 ♘f5+ ♔d7 19 dxe6+ ♔c6 20 ♖xd6+ ♕xd6 21 ♘xd6 ♔xd6 22 ♗f7 ♘d5 23 e7 ♘c7 24 ♕e5+ ♔d7 25 f5 ♖he8 26 ♗e6+ ♘xe6 27 ♕xe6+ ♔c7 28 f6, which forced Black to resign in Djikic-B.Damljanovic, Yugoslavia 1980) 17 ♕xg6+ ♔d8 18 ♘xe6+ ♔c8 19 ♕xg5, despite being down two pieces White can still pose a number of problems: for example, 19...♕c4 20 ♕g7 ♖d8 21 ♕e7 ♖g8 22 ♕f7 ♘f6 23 ♖d4 ♕f1+ 24 ♖d1 ♕c4 25 ♖d4 with a repetition.

15...♗xf4+?

Natural, but bad. Better is 15...♕b6 16 ♕h5+ g6 17 ♗xg6+ ♔e7 18 ♕xg5+ ♘f6 19 ♗h5 ♖ag8 20 ♘g7 ♕e3+ 21 ♔b1 ♗c8 22 ♕h4 ♖xg7 23 ♖e1 ♕xe1+ 24 ♕xe1+ ♔d8 when material is equal, but the position very unclear.

16 ♕xf4 ♕b6 17 ♕g5



Black is helpless.

17...♘f8 18 ♖e1 ♘xe6 19 ♖xe6+ ♔f8 20 ♕f5+ 1-0

After 20...♔g8 21 ♖e7 ♕g1+ 22 ♗f1 ♕xf1+ 23 ♕xf1 ♗xd5 24 ♕f5 ♗c4 25 ♕d7 White will force mate.

We now turn to a famous game in which the American master Sidney Bernstein sacrificed his knight on d5, but Fischer easily won by placing his pieces on the right squares.

Game 20
S.Bernstein-R.Fischer
U.S. Championship, New York 1957

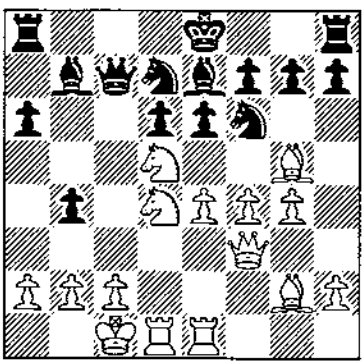
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♘bd7 9 0-0-0 ♕c7 10 g4 b5 11 ♗g2

This natural move wastes a vital tempo and probably misplaces the bishop. Instead 11 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 12 g5 ♘d7 13 f5 is a well-known theoretical variation. However, if White wants to sacrifice his knight he should prefer the central strategy 10 ♗d3 followed by 11 ♖he1, as we've just seen in action.

11...♗b7 12 ♖he1 b4

After 12...♘b6 13 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 14 g5 ♗e7 15 h4 b4 16 ♘ce2 g6 17 ♔b1 d5 18 e5 ♘a4 19 h5 ♕b6 20 ♖h1 0-0-0 21 hxg6 hxg6 22 ♖h6 ♔b8 23 ♖dh1 ♖hf8 24 ♖h7 a5 25 ♖g7 ♗a6 26 ♖hh7 ♗c5 the position was unclear in Y.Sakharov-V.Korchnoi, Leningrad 1960.

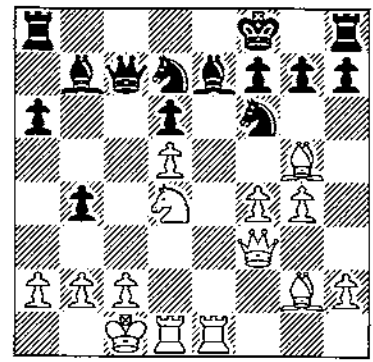
13 ♘d5?



This certainly looks good, as all White's pieces are ready to smash the black king. However, Black's king can sidestep the threats. Thus 13 ♘a4 looks like the best try.

13...exd5 14 exd5 ♔f8!

14...♔d8?! 15 ♕e2 ♘b6 16 ♘f5 ♘c8 17 ♘xg7 ♘e8 18 ♘f5 ♗xg5 19 fxg5 is too dangerous for Black.



15 ♘f5 ♖e8

White hopes to double his rooks on the e-file, improve the position of his queen and push his kingside pawns, but Black can position his pieces in the right places much more quickly.

16 ♕e3 ♗d8

Larsen against Tal forgot to place his Bishop on d8, as we will see shortly, but Fischer understood how this seemingly passive bishop can spring into action from b6.

17 ♕d4 ♗c8

Alternatively, the line 17...a5 18 ♖xe8+ ♘xe8 19 ♗xd8 ♕xd8 20 ♖e1 ♘c5 21 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 22 ♕xg7 ♔d7 23 ♕xf7+ ♔c8 should win too for Black.

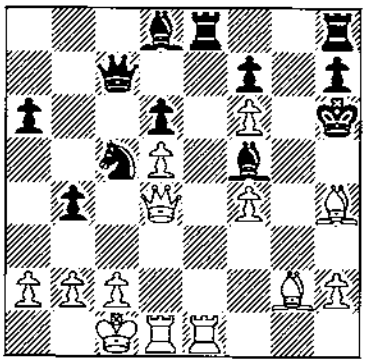
18 ♗h4

18 ♕xb4 gives White chances to survive.

18...♘c5 19 ♘xg7

Better fighting chances were offered by 19 ♗xf6 gxf6 20 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 21 ♕xb4 ♗xf5 22 gxf5 ♖g8.

19...♔xg7 20 g5 ♗f5 21 gxf6+ ♔h6



The black king is actually quite safe, whereas White king's is in danger.

22 ♕c4 ♘d7 23 ♕xc7 ♗xc7 24 ♗f3 ♗d8 25 ♗g5+ ♔g6 26 ♖g1 ♗xf6 27 ♗h4+ ♔h6

Sid continues to fight, but down a piece he could have packed it in for the day.

28 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 29 ♖g5 ♗e4 30 ♖f1 ♗g6 31 ♖fg1 ♖e3 32 ♗d1 ♘e4 33 ♖5g2 f5 34 ♗e2 a5 35 h4 ♖h3 36 h5 ♗xh5 37 ♗d3 ♗g6 38 ♖f1 ♖f8 39 ♔d1 ♘f6 40 ♖e1 ♘xd5 41 ♖f2 ♖e3 42 ♖g1 ♖e7 43 ♔d2 ♔g7 44 ♖f3 0-1

Game 21
D.Lima-I.Morovic Fernandez
Sao Paulo 2002

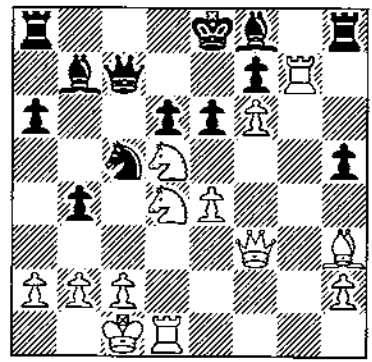
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♗e7 10 g4 b5 11 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 12 g5 ♘d7 13 f5 ♘c5

13...♗xg5+ is another theoretical move, but the text will allow White to demonstrate two amazing sacrifices.

14 f6 gxf6 15 gxf6 ♗f8 16 ♖g1 h5 17 ♖g7 ♗b7

After 17...♗xg7 18 fxg7 ♖g8 19 ♘dxb5 axb5 20 ♘xb5 ♕e7 21 ♘xd6+ Whites wins the queen and the game. Thus the most popular option is 17...b4!?, after which, for example, 18 ♘d5 exd5 19 exd5 ♘d7 20 ♘c6 ♗b7 21 ♖e1+ ♘e5 22 ♘xe5 dxe5 23 ♗h3 ♕d6 24 ♕g3 ♕xf6 25 ♕xe5+ ♕xe5 26 ♖xe5+ ♔d8 27 ♖xf7 ♗c8 28 ♖xh5 ♖xh5 29 ♖xf8+ ♔c7 30 d6+ ♔xd6 31 ♖xc8 ♖a7 32 ♖d8+ saw Black manage to draw in R.Hall-A.Kiss, correspondence 2002.

18 ♗h3 b4 19 ♘d5



19...exd5 20 exd5 ♘d7?

This logical move loses immediately. The superior 20...♔d8 21 ♘c6+ ♗xc6 22 dxc6 ♗xg7 23 fxg7 ♖g8 24 ♕xh5 ♘e6 25 ♖f1 ♘xg7 26 ♕g5+ ♔e8 27 ♗d7+ ♔f8 28 ♕g6 ♘f5 29 ♕xf5 ♖g7 30 h4 would only have given White a slight advantage.

21 ♗xd7+ ♕xd7 22 ♘c6 ♗xc6 23 ♖e1+

♔d8 24 dxc6 ♕c7 25 ♕e4 ♗xg7 26 fxg7 1-0

We now come to a famous game, the finale of Tal's 1965 Candidates match against Larsen. Tal's knight sacrifice has long graced the pages of many chess books and magazines. Indeed, for about 40 years now many chess coaches have demonstrated this game as an example of Tal's tactical genius. That it may well be. But was it correct? Let us see...

Game 22
M.Tal-B.Larsen
10th matchgame, Bled 1965

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 e6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗e3 ♘f6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 0-0 9 0-0-0 ♕c7 10 ♘db5 ♕b8 11 g4 a6 12 ♘d4 ♘xd4 13 ♗xd4 b5

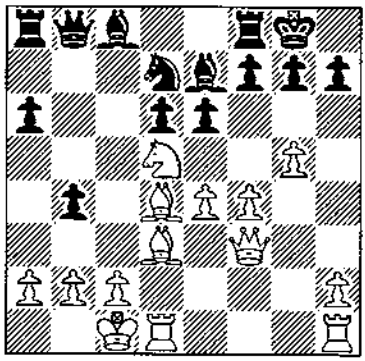
The aggressive 13...e5 14 g5 ♗g4 15 ♕g3 exd4 (15...♗xd1? 16 gxf6 ♗xf6 17 ♘d5 ♔h8 18 ♘xf6 gxf6 19 ♗c3 looks like a win for White) 16 ♖xd4 ♗e6 17 gxf6 ♗xf6 18 ♖d3 is unclear, but we would rather be White.

14 g5 ♘d7 15 ♗d3 b4

The seemingly natural 15...♗b7 forced Black to resign after 16 ♕h3 ♖d8 17 ♖hg1 e5 18 ♘d5 ♗xd5 19 exd5 g6 20 f5 exd4 21 fxg6 hxg6 22 ♗xg6 ♘f8 23 ♗xf7+ ♔xf7 24 g6+ ♔g7 25 ♖df1 ♗f6 26 ♖xf6 in A.Suetin-E.Jimenez Zerquera, Havana 1969.

16 ♘d5?!

In almost every book before you will have seen '!!' attached to this move, perhaps because the great Tal won this game. However, we believe 16 ♘e2 was safer and stronger.



16...exd5!

16...♗d8? 17 ♘f6+ is winning for White: 17...gxf6 18 gxf6 ♗xf6 19 ♖hg1+ ♔h8 20 e5 ♖g8 21 exf6 ♘f8 22 ♕h5 d5 23 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 24 ♕h6 mates.

17 exd5 f5 18 ♖de1 ♖f7?!

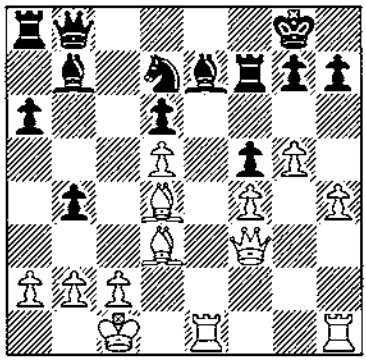
Much better was 18...♗d8! à la Fischer. It is important to keep this bishop for now, watching e7 and preparing a well-timed ...♗b6! to kill off a white attacker. Then 19 h4 ♘c5! (19...♗b6? 20 ♗xg7! ♔xg7 21 ♕h5 ♖f7 22 ♕h6+ ♔g8 23 ♖e8+ ♘f8 24 h5 ♗d4 25 g6 ♕c7 26 gxh7+ ♔h8 27 ♖g1 ♗xg1 28 ♕g6 leads to mate) 20 ♗c4 ♘e4 21 g6 h6 easily stops White's attack, leaving Black with an extra piece.

19 h4

19 ♗xf5 ♘f8 20 ♗e6 ♘xe6 21 dxe6 ♖f5 is good for Black.

19...♗b7

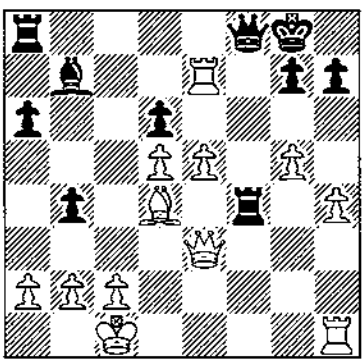
The alternative 19...♘c5 is not good enough, e.g. 20 h5 ♘xd3+ 21 ♕xd3 ♗f8 22 g6 ♖b7 23 h6 gxh6 24 ♕g3 ♕c7 25 ♖e8 with a win.



20 ♗xf5 ♖xf5

The best was 20...♘f8, but even so 21 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 22 h5 ♗xg5 23 ♕e4+ ♔g8 24 fxg5 ♕d8 25 g6 ♖c7 26 ♖hg1 ♖ac8 27 h6 gxh6 28 ♕f4 ♖xc2+ 29 ♔b1 should crush the black king.

21 ♖xe7 ♘e5 22 ♕e4 ♕f8 23 fxe5 ♖f4 24 ♕e3



24...♖f3

24...♗xd5 25 exd6 ♖xd4 26 ♕xd4 ♗xh1 27 b3! leaves Black with an extra bishop, but a bad position where White's dangerous d-pawn, active pieces and attack should prove decisive.

25 ♕e2 ♕xe7 26 ♕xf3 dxe5 27 ♖e1 ♖d8 28 ♖xe5 ♕d6 29 ♕f4 ♖f8 30 ♕e4

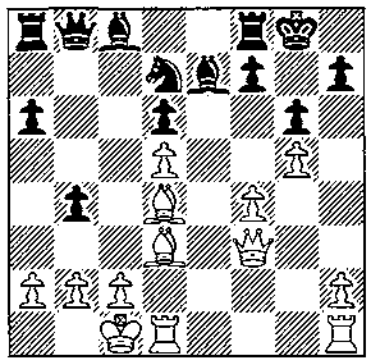
With two extra pawns, White can even allow some checks.

30...b3 31 axb3 ♖f1+ 32 ♔d2 ♕b4+ 33 c3 ♕d6 34 ♗c5 ♕xc5 35 ♖e8+ ♖f8 36 ♕e6+ ♔h8 37 ♕f7 1-0

Larsen defended like a lion, but Tal's amazing tactical ability overwhelmed his resistance.

Let us now return to the position after 17 exd5 and check out Black's main alternative defence:

17...g6



For many years this was considered a better try than 17...f5, but...

18 ♖he1!! ♗d8

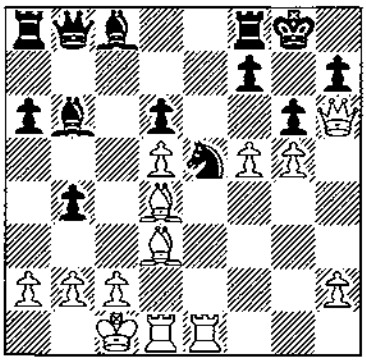
After 18...♖e8 19 ♗f6 ♘xf6 20 gxf6 h5 21 ♕g3 ♗g4 22 fxe7 ♗xd1 23 ♗xg6 fxg6 24 ♕xg6+ ♔h8 25 ♕h6+ ♔g8 26 ♕g5+ ♔h8 27 f5 Black can't protect his king.

19 ♕h3 ♘e5

19...♘c5? doesn't stop the mating attack after 20 ♕h6 ♘xd3+ 21 ♖xd3 f6 22 gxf6 ♕c7 23 ♖e7 ♕xe7 24 fxe7. Neither would 19...h5 have helped: 20 gxh6 ♗f6 21 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 22 ♕h4 ♘h7 23 ♕g3 ♕c7

24 f5 g5 25 f6 g4 26 ♖e7 ♕c5 27 ♕f4 b3 28 axb3 ♕a5 29 ♔b1 ♕d8 30 ♗xh7+ ♔xh7 31 ♕g5 ♖g8 32 ♖xf7+ ♔h8 33 ♖g7 ♖a7 34 ♖e1 ♗f5 35 ♕xf5 and Black's position is hopeless.

20 ♕h6 ♗b6 21 f5!!



We analysed many moves, but only this generates a strong enough attack to keep White in the game.

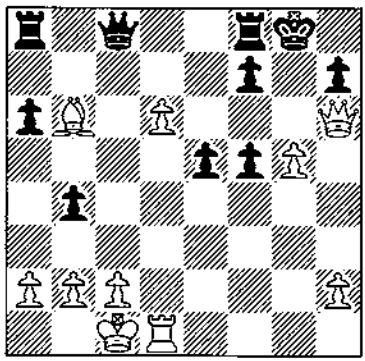
21...♗xf5

Here 21...gxf5 22 ♗xb6!! ♘g4 23 ♗d4!! is an amazing queen sacrifice which took us many hours to find and then work out: 23...♘xh6 24 gxh6 ♖d8 (the superior 24...f6 25 ♖e7 ♖f7! 26 ♖e8+ ♖f8 27 ♖e7 ♖f7 forces a repetition) 25 ♖d2 ♗e6 26 dxe6 fxe6 27 ♖xe6 ♔f8 28 ♖g2 ♖e8 29 ♖f6+ ♔e7 30 ♗xf5 ♔d8 31 ♖f7 ♖a7 32 ♖xa7 ♕xa7 33 ♗xa7 wins.

22 ♗xf5 gxf5 23 ♖xe5 dxe5 24 ♗xb6 ♕c8

Another eventually level line runs 24...♖c8 25 ♖d3 e4 26 ♖d1 ♕f4+ 27 ♔b1 ♕g4 28 ♖g1 ♕e2 29 g6 ♕xc2+ 30 ♔a1 fxg6 31 ♖xg6+ hxg6 32 ♕xg6+ ♔f8 33 ♕f6+ ♔e8 34 ♕e6+ ♔f8 35 ♕f6+ ♔g8 36 ♕g6+ ♔f8 37 ♕f6+ with perpetual check.

25 d6



25...♕d7

Better than 25...♕c6? 26 d7 ♕xh6 27 gxh6 ♖fd8 28 ♖g1+ ♔h8 29 ♗c7 ♖f8 30 ♖d1 ♖ad8 31 ♗d6 ♔g8 32 ♖g1+ ♔h8 33 ♗e7 f6 34 ♗xd8 ♖xd8 35 ♖g7 e4 36 ♖e7 ♔g8 37 ♖e8+ ♔f7 38 ♖xd8 and wins.

26 ♖d3 f4 27 ♖h3 ♕f5 28 d7 ♖fd8 29 ♖d3 f3 30 ♕f6 ♕xf6 31 gxf6 f2 32 ♗xf2 ♖ab8 33 ♗c5 ♖b7 34 ♖g3+ ♔h8 35 ♗e7 ♖dxd7 36 ♗f8 h5 37 ♖g5 ♔h7 38 ♖g7+ ♔h8 39 ♖g5

Again the game should finish in a draw by repetition.

Chapter Two

The Knight Sacrifice on e6

The sacrifice ♘(x)e6 is one of the less common sacrificial ideas in the Sicilian, as it tends to be a true sacrifice; White generally obtains only two pawns for his piece. However, from a strategic viewpoint, White gains complete domination of the vital central squares d5 and f5, whilst ripping away the pawn cover of the black king. The light-squared bishop which settles on e6 can play a leading role in the attack, especially if the g6-square has been weakened by an advance of Black's h-pawn. The weakness of g6 is in fact a green light for ♘xe6, as in the following classic contest.

Game 23
M.Stean-W.Browne
Nice Olympiad 1974

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 ♘bd7 7 ♗c4 e6

At that time 7...♕a5 had been getting hammered, as in Spassky-Petrosian, 19th matchgame 1969, which will be discussed in more detail in Chapter Seven.

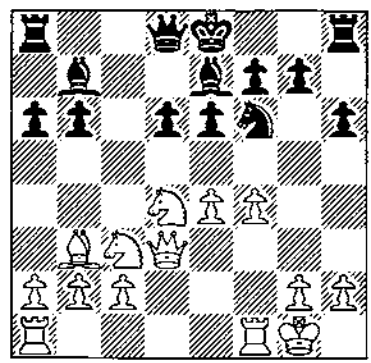
8 0-0

Threatening a timely ♗xe6!.

8...h6 9 ♗xf6!

White plays à la Spassky.

9...♘xf6 10 ♗b3 b6 11 f4 ♗b7 12 ♕d3 ♗e7



Now White must decide whether to

play fairly calmly with the standard thrust f4-f5, or to sacrifice something on e6. Since the American chess patron I.S.Turover had offered a prize of $1000 for the most brilliant game at Nice, the young English IM went for the sacrifice with gusto.

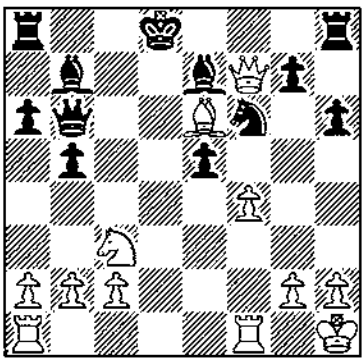
13 ♘xe6! fxe6 14 ♗xe6

Now Black's king is stuck in the centre, and there is the nasty if obvious threat of e4-e5 followed by ♕d3-g6+. Note that White had to sacrifice this way round: 13 ♗xe6? fxe6 14 ♘xe6 ♕d7 15 ♘xg7+ ♔f8! 16 ♘f5 ♗xe4! wins for Black.

14...b5

In the tournament book, Stean noted that he would have answered 14...♘d7 with 15 ♖ad1 ♘c5 16 ♕h3 ♘xe6 17 ♕xe6. If instead 14....♗c8, the bishop drops back to b3 and Black is no closer to escaping from the centre.

15 e5 ♕b6+ 16 ♔h1 dxe5 17 ♕g6+ ♔d8 18 ♕f7!



Now the plan is ♖ad1+ and/or fxe5.

18...♕c5 19 fxe5 ♗xg2+

Hoping for a miracle on the g-file. Gligoric gives 19...♖f8 20 ♕xg7 ♘d7 21 ♖fd1 as winning, while 19...♘e8 20 ♖ad1+ ♔c7 21 Rd7+ is futile.

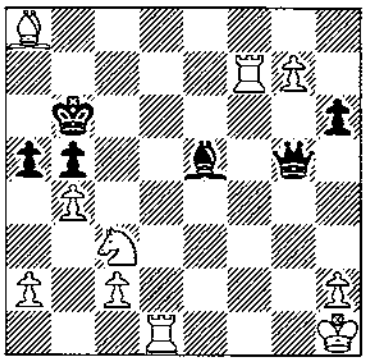
20 ♔xg2 ♖f8 21 ♖ad1+ ♔c7 22 ♕xg7 ♖g8 23 exf6!

Keeping the bishop around to support the resulting passed pawn proves to be the cleanest way to win.

23...♖xg7+ 24 fxg7 ♗d6

The point of White's 23rd is apparent after 24...♕g5+ 25 ♔h1 ♕xg7 26 ♖f7 ♕g5 27 ♖xe7+ ♕xe7 28 ♘d5+.

25 ♖f7+ ♔c6 26 ♗d5+ ♔b6 27 ♗xa8 ♕g5+ 28 ♔h1 ♗e5 29 b4 a5



30 ♖b7+

White has mate in 8 with 30 ♘d5+ but the text is good enough.

30...♔c6

It's mate after 30...♔a6 31 ♖xb5 ♕xg7 32 ♖xa5+ ♔b6 33 ♘d5, as Gligoric pointed out.

31 g8/♕ ♕xg8 32 ♖b8+ 1-0

Browne was undoubtedly short of time and could not pause to resign sooner. By the way, Stean got his $1000!

It's harder to make ♘xe6 work if you pick up less than two pawns or if

the black king has castled. Thus when Black has castled, the sacrifice tends to be of the sham variety. White may be able to use the d5-square to recoup his investment, as in the following extract.

Game 24
O.Nikolenko-Z.Nagy
Budapest 1990

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 0-0 b5 8 ♗b3 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♕b6

This eccentric manoeuvre stems from Kavalek, I believe. These days 9...♕c7 is sometimes preferred.

10 ♗e3 ♕b7 11 ♕g3 ♘bd7 12 f3 0-0 13 ♘d5! ♗d8

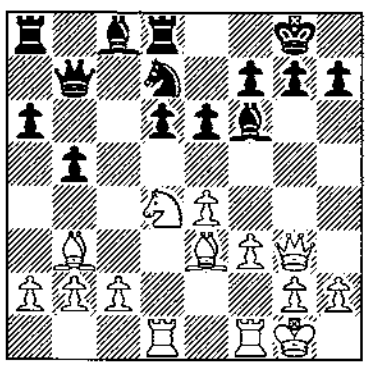
Of course, 13...exd5? 14 ♘f5 is decisive.

14 ♘xf6+ ♗xf6 15 ♖ad1

A computer would snatch the d6-pawn at once.

15...♖d8?

More obstinate was 15...♗e5.



16 ♘xe6!

This transaction will leave White comfortably ahead in material.

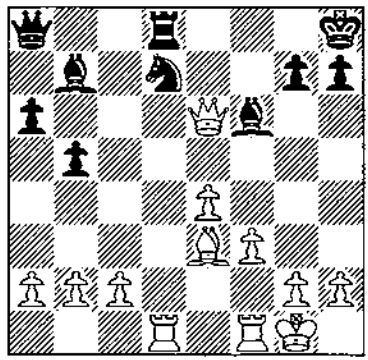
16...fxe6 17 ♗xe6+ ♔h8 18 ♗d5

There's that square again!

18...♕b8 19 ♗xa8 ♕xa8 20 ♕xd6

Only now! At this point 20...♘f8 21 ♕xd8! is strong, so Black played...

20...♗b7 21 ♕e6



and White duly converted his material plus and won in 38 moves.

Nonetheless, we have included a few examples of ♘xe6 sacrifices against a castled king. It's hard, though, to find many examples at high levels nowadays, as defensive technique has improved considerably thanks to the proliferation of silicon. (Also, consult Minic-Fischer in the introduction to Chapter Four for an example of ♘xe6 working against a king castled short.)

Over to Yury...

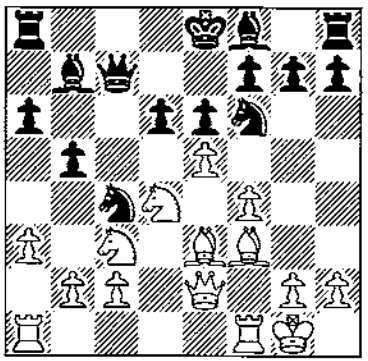
Game 25
B.Spassky-K.Darga
Varna Olympiad 1962

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 e6

5 ♘c3 ♕c7 6 ♗e3 a6 7 a3 b5 8 ♗e2 ♗b7 9 f4 ♘f6 10 ♗f3 d6 11 0-0 ♘a5

It must be wrong to play actively before developing your pieces. More logical is 11...♗e7 12 ♕e1 ♘xd4 13 ♗xd4 e5 14 ♗e3 0-0 15 ♖d1 ♖fe8 16 ♕g3, as in R.Nezhmetdinov-B.Vladimirov, Baku 1961, and now the most direct seems to be 16...♕c4 with good play.

12 ♕e2 ♘c4 13 e5



13...♘xe3

After 13...dxe5? 14 ♘dxb5 axb5 15 ♘xb5 ♕d7 16 ♕xc4 ♖c8 17 ♕b3 an extra pawn, three passed pawns and decent activity should give White a winning position.

14 ♕xe3 dxe5 15 fxe5 ♘d7 16 ♗xb7 ♕xb7 17 ♕f4 ♘b6 18 ♖ad1 ♘a4??

After 18...♖d8! 19 ♘e4 we have:

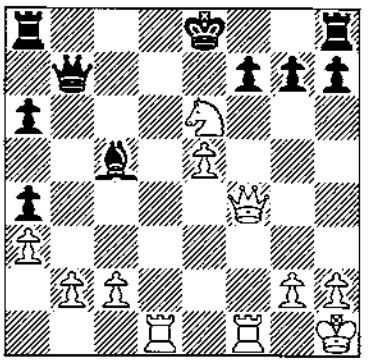
a) The attempt to win a pawn can cause Black a lot of problems: 19...♘c4?! 20 b3 ♘xa3 21 ♔h1 ♖d7 22 ♘g5 ♗c5 23 ♘dxe6!! fxe6 24 ♘xe6 ♗b6 25 ♖xd7 ♕xd7 (25...♔xd7 leaves Black's king in a mating net after 26 ♕g4 ♔e8 27 ♘xg7+) 26 ♘f8! ♕b7 (26...♕e7 27 ♕f3 ♖xf8 28 ♕c6+ wins) 27 ♕g4 ♕d5 (27...♖xf8 28 ♕e6+ ♕c7 29 ♕c6+) 28 ♕h5+ g6 29 ♘xg6 ♖g8 30 ♘h4+, protecting the g2-pawn and winning material after 30...♔d8 31 ♖d1 ♗d4 32 c3.

b) 19...♖d5! 20 ♔h1 ♘c4 21 ♘g5 ♗c5 22 b3 ♗xd4 23 ♖xd4 ♘xe5 24 ♕e4 gave Black a defensible position in S.Korolev-H.Palm, correspondence 1982, but after couple of bad moves he lost.

19 ♘xa4 bxa4 20 ♔h1 ♗c5

The best try was 20...♖c8, although 21 ♘f3 leaves White with an advantage sufficient to win.

21 ♘xe6!



After this sacrifice the black king will be stuck in the centre forever. Now White's queen will tease him from both flanks until his resignation.

21...fxe6 22 ♕xa4+ ♕b5 23 ♕g4

Black can't defend both pawns.

23...♕c6 24 ♕xg7 ♖f8 25 ♖xf8+ ♗xf8 26 ♕xh7

Black's king is surrounded and nothing can help him.

26...♖c8 27 ♕g6+ 1-0

White wins with 27...♔e7 28 ♖d6 ♕c4 29 ♕h7+.

Game 26
G.Kasparov-L.Van Wely
Wijk aan Zee 2000

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 f3 b5 8 g4 h6 9 ♕d2 ♘bd7 10 0-0-0 ♗b7 11 h4 b4 12 ♘a4

A typical position for the English Attack where White is planning to assault Black's kingside.

12...d5

12...♕a5 is another choice which after the popular 13 b3 ♘c5 14 a3 ♘xa4 15 axb4 ♕c7 16 bxa4 leads to a very complicated position with chances for both sides.

13 ♗h3 g5

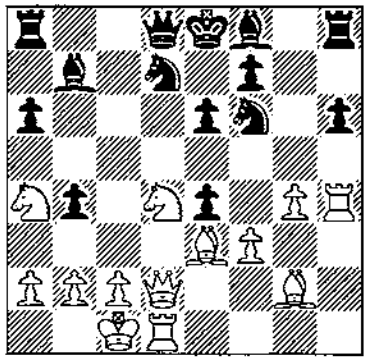
Alternatively, 13...♕a5 14 b3 dxe4 15 g5 hxg5 16 hxg5 exf3 17 ♘xe6 fxe6 18 ♗xe6 ♖xh1 19 ♗xd7+ ♔f7 20 ♖xh1 ♘e4 21 ♕d4 ♕d5 led to a very unclear position in the game B.Lugo-I.Novikov, San Diego 2004. We believe this game should finish as a draw, but after couple of mistakes White lost the endgame.

14 ♗g2 gxh4

Kasparov suggests 14...♖g8!? with a playable game.

15 ♖xh4 dxe4

Our computer's choice 15...♘xe4?! left Black in a completely lost position after the further 16 fxe4 ♕xh4 17 exd5 e5 18 d6 e4 19 ♘c5 ♘xc5 20 ♘f5 ♘d3+ 21 cxd3 ♕d8 22 dxe4 ♕d7 23 ♕d4 of A.Copar-P.Clement, correspondence 2003. Instead 15...♕a5 was analysed by Kasparov, who gave 16 b3 dxe4 17 g5 ♘d5 18 ♘xe6! fxe6 19 fxe4 as winning.



16 g5 ♘d5 17 ♖xe4 hxg5

The computer believes that after 17...♕a5 Black is better, but according to our analysis after 18 ♘xe6! fxe6 19 ♗h3 ♕xa4 20 ♗xe6 0-0-0 21 ♖c4+! (21 ♗xd5? is losing after 21...♘c5 22 ♖xb4 ♖xd5 23 ♕xd5 ♗xd5 24 ♖xa4 ♘xa4 25 ♖xd5 hxg5 26 ♗xg5 ♖h1+ 27 ♔d2 ♖h2+ 28 ♔e3 ♗c5+ 29 ♔e4 ♖xc2 and Black will enjoy an extra knight) 21...♔b8 22 ♗xd5 ♘b6 23 ♕d4 ♕xa2 24 ♖c8+ ♘xc8 25 ♗f4+ ♔a8 26 ♗xb7+ ♔xb7 27 ♕e4+ ♔b6 28 ♖xd8 hxg5 29 ♖xc8 ♖h1+ 30 ♔d2 gxf4 31 ♕c6+ ♔a5 32 ♖a8 Black will be mated in a few moves.

18 ♗xg5 ♕a5?

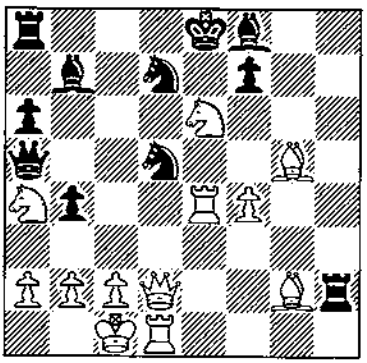
Better is 18...♕xg5! 19 ♕xg5 ♗h6, although White is still better according to Kasparov.

19 f4 ♖h2

The attempt to slow White down by playing 19...e5 proves fruitless after 20 ♘f5 (Kasparov gives 20 ♘b3! as winning) 20...f6 21 ♘e3 fxg5 22 ♘xd5 gxf4 23 ♘ab6 ♗xd5 24 ♘xd5 ♖d8 25 ♗f3 ♗g7 26 ♕xf4. Meanwhile the defensive

try 19...♘7f6 leads to trouble after 20 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 21 ♘xe6! ♗xe4 22 ♗xe4 ♖c8 23 ♘xf8 ♕c7 (23...♕xa4 24 ♕d6 ♘xe4 25 ♕e5+ ♔xf8 26 ♕xh8+ ♔e7 27 ♕xc8 wins material and mates shortly) 24 ♗f5 ♖d8 25 ♘d7 ♘xd7 26 ♖e1+ ♔f8 27 ♕xb4+ ♔g7 28 ♕d4+ ♘f6 29 ♖g1+ and Black will lose material.

20 ♘xe6!



This concludes the game in style.

20...fxe6 21 ♖xe6+ ♔f7 22 ♕d3 ♗g7 23 ♕f5+ ♔g8 24 ♖xd5 ♕xa4 25 ♖e7 1-0

Black can't escape the mating threats. A crushing attack from the 13th World Champion which left neither the computer nor Van Wely able to figure out what was going on.

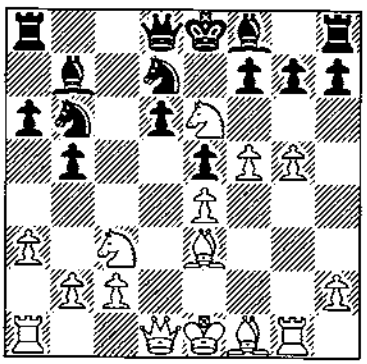
Game 27
L.Shamkovich-P.Benko
U.S. Championship, Pasadena 1978

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 g4 a6 7 g5 ♘fd7 8 ♗e3 b5 9 a3 ♘b6 10 ♖g1 ♘8d7 11 f4 ♗b7 12 f5

After the less direct 12 ♕f3 ♖c8 13 ♗f2 ♕c7 14 0-0-0 e5 15 ♘f5 ♘a4 16 ♗e1 ♘dc5 17 ♗d3 g6 18 ♘e3 ♘xd3+ 19 ♖xd3 exf4 20 ♕xf4 we see a very unclear position which White managed to win in P.Enders-L.Espig, German League 1999.

12...e5 13 ♘e6?

This looks like a good sacrifice where all White's pieces are ready to pounce on an open black king, but in reality Black has enough resources to protect his Majesty. Instead 13 ♘b3 ♖c8 14 ♗d3 ♘c4 15 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 16 ♕d3 ♕a8 17 ♘d2 ♖c8 18 0-0-0 ♘c5 19 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 left White with a slight advantage in Y.Balashov-B.Malich, Leipzig 1973.



13...fxe6!

If Black refuses this kind offer, White can get a better position: for example, after 13...♕b8 14 ♘xf8 ♔xf8 15 ♕d2 ♘c5 16 ♖g4 Black has to solve many problems.

14 ♕h5+

The alternative 14 fxe6!? doesn't give White enough initiative for a piece after 14...♘c5: for instance, 15 ♗xc5 dxc5 16 ♕f3 ♕e7 17 ♘d5 ♘xd5 18 exd5 ♖d8 19 0-0-0 ♖d6 20 ♗h3 g6 21 ♕f6

♗g7 22 ♕xe7+ ♔xe7 23 ♖gf1 ♖f8 and White's position is hopeless.

14...g6?

We believe the fearless 14...♔e7!! was winning in all variations: 15 fxe6 (fruitless is 15 g6 ♘f6 16 ♗g5 ♔d7 17 fxe6+ ♔c7 18 ♗xf6 ♕xf6 19 gxh7 ♕xe6 and White is losing) 15...♔xe6 16 ♗h3+ ♔e7 17 ♖f1 ♕e8 18 ♕h4 ♔d8 and Black will finish castling by hand while keeping an extra piece.

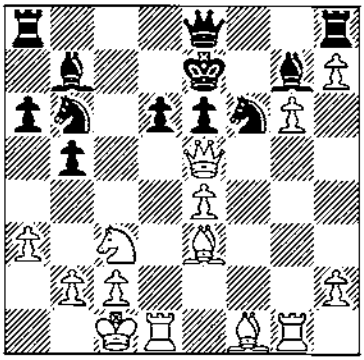
15 fxg6 ♔e7 16 gxh7

Black has simply handed his opponent two passed pawns for no reason.

16...♗g7 17 0-0-0 ♕e8 18 g6 ♘f6

A rule says: 'If you are up material, trade pieces.' Thus after 18...♘a4 White would play 19 ♘xa4 bxa4 20 ♕g5+ ♘f6 21 ♕xe5! ♖d8 22 ♗c4 ♗c8; this slows down White's attack a bit, but most likely Black is doomed in the long run.

19 ♕xe5!



This neat tactic equalizes the material count.

19...♕c6

It's mate after 19...dxe5 20 ♗c5. Meanwhile the passive 19...♘c8 allows White to mobilize all his forces in amusing fashion as follows: 20 ♗c5 ♕d7 21 ♗h3 ♘e8 22 ♕g5+ ♗f6 23 ♕e3 ♔d8 24 ♗d4 ♗g7 25 ♘d5 and the white army will tear Black's fortress to shreds.

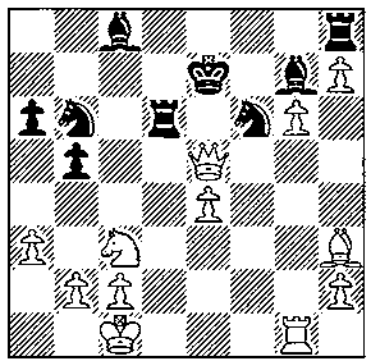
20 ♖xd6!

A further blow. Now nothing can save Black.

20...♕xd6 21 ♗c5 ♖ad8 22 ♗h3 ♗c8 23 ♗xd6+ ♖xd6 24 ♕g5 e5

The only way to save the piece.

25 ♕xe5+



In this endgame Black is down the equivalent of three pawns. In order to win White will trade as many pieces as possible and then his queen and passed pawns will decide matters.

25...♗e6 26 ♗xe6 ♖xe6 27 ♕c5+ ♔e8 28 ♕f5 ♖e7 29 ♖d1 ♘fd7 30 ♘d5 ♘xd5 31 ♕xd5 ♗e5 32 ♕c6 ♔d8 33 ♖d5 ♖f8 34 ♕a8+ 1-0

Game 28
E.Vasiukov-B.Modr
Prague 1980

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 ♘c3 d6 4 d4 cxd4 5

♘xd4 ♘f6 6 g4 a6

Two more popular answers against the Keres Attack are 6...♘c6 and 6...h6.

7 g5 ♘fd7 8 ♗e3 b5 9 a3 ♘b6 10 ♖g1 ♗b7 11 ♕g4 ♘8d7

11...♘c6!? 12 ♘xc6 ♗xc6 gives Black a playable position.

12 0-0-0 ♖c8?!

This looks like the reason for Black's defeat. After 12...g6!? 13 f4 ♖c8 14 f5 exf5 15 exf5 ♘e5 16 ♕g3 ♖xc3 17 bxc3 ♕c7 18 ♗f4 ♕c5 Black had just about enough initiative for the pawn, which led to a draw in M.Matulovic-B.Malich, Siegen Olympiad 1970.

13 g6! hxg6 14 ♘xe6! fxe6

After 14...♕e7 15 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 16 ♗g5 ♘f6 17 ♕g3 Black's open king and isolated pawn give White the advantage.

15 ♕xg6+

White plays the rest in best silicon fashion.

15...♔e7 16 ♗g5+ ♘f6 17 e5

Winning back material with interest and keeping the attack. The battle is decided.

17...♔d7 18 exf6 gxf6 19 ♗xf6 ♗e7 20 ♗xh8 ♕xh8 21 ♖g3 1-0

Should Black have been inclined to continue, there might have occurred 21...♕xh2 22 ♗h3 ♖e8 23 ♗xe6+ with an extra exchange.

Game 29
L.Schneider-M.Cebalo
Eksjo 1982

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e6 6 f4 ♗e7 7 ♗b5+!?

The American IM Mark Ginsburg wrote about this tricky idea in the early 1980s.

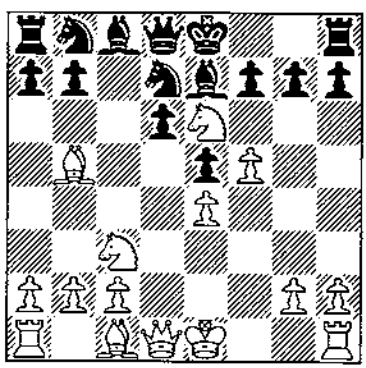
7...♘fd7

Another line runs 7...♗d7!? 8 e5 dxe5 9 fxe5 ♘d5 10 ♘xd5 cxd5 11 ♗xd7+ (11 e6?! fxe6 12 ♘xe6 ♗b4+! 13 c3 ♕h4+ doesn't help White) 11...♕xd7 12 0-0 ♗c5 13 ♗e3 ♘c6 14 ♘f5 ♗xe3+ 15 ♘xe3 0-0 16 ♕xd5 ♕xd5 17 ♘xd5 ♖ad8 18 ♖ad1, and this ended up as a draw in J.Timman-V.Salov, Madrid 1995.

8 f5 e5

8...0-0 is another interesting idea to sacrifice a pawn for an activity, but after 9 fxe6 ♘e5 10 exf7+ ♖xf7 11 ♖f1 ♗h4+ 12 g3 ♗f6 13 ♘f5 ♘bc6 14 ♗e3 ♕a5 15 ♘xd6 Black didn't get enough compensation and later lost in the game J.Van der Wiel-I.Sokolov, Rotterdam 1999.

9 ♘e6!



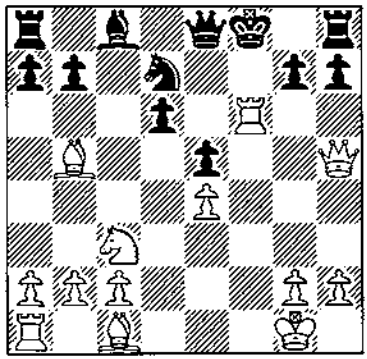
9...fxe6 10 ♕h5+ ♔f8

The inferior 10...g6? allows 11 fxg6 ♔f8 12 g7+ ♔xg7 13 ♗h6+ ♔g8 14 ♕g4+ ♔f7 15 ♕g7+ followed by mate in a couple of moves.

11 fxe6 ♕e8 12 0-0+ ♗f6 13 exd7 ♘xd7

White also won after the alternative 13...♗xd7 14 ♖xf6+ gxf6 15 ♕h6+ ♔f7 16 ♘d5 ♕d8 17 ♗c4 ♗e6 18 ♕h5+ ♔g8 19 ♗h6 in M.Geenen-T.Penson, Ghent 1989.

14 ♖xf6+!



A winning sacrifice.

14...gxf6

Yet another disaster for Black was 14...♘xf6 15 ♗xe8 ♘xh5 16 ♗xh5 which gave him no hope of survival in the game R.Lau-H.Schuh, Bad Neuenahr 1982.

15 ♕h6+ ♔e7 16 ♘d5+ ♔d8 17 ♗xd7 ♕g6

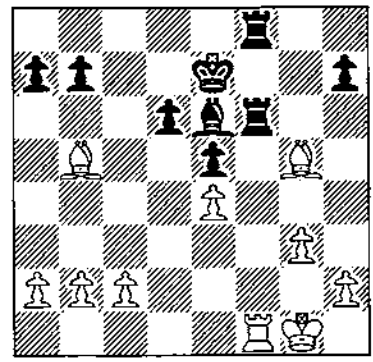
Or 17...♗xd7 18 ♕xf6+ ♔c8 19 ♕xd6 and wins.

18 ♗b5 ♖g8 19 g3 ♗e6 20 ♘xf6

20 ♕d2 ♗xd5 21 ♕xd5 ♔c7 22 ♗e3 was another way to win.

20...♕xh6 21 ♗xh6 ♖g6 22 ♗e3 ♖xf6 23 ♗g5 ♔e7 24 ♖f1 ♖af8

Black's rook is pinned forever and for the rest of the game White will optimize the placement of his pieces before liquidating to an easily winning ending.



25 b3 h6 26 ♗h4 b6 27 ♗c6 ♗c8 28 ♗d5 a5 29 a3 ♗d7 30 ♔g2 ♗c8 31 ♖f2 ♗a6 32 c4 ♗c8 33 ♔f1

White's king is running for his dessert on b6.

33...♗g4 34 ♔e1 ♗h3 35 ♔d2 ♗g4 36 ♔c3 ♗h3 37 b4 ♗d7 38 bxa5 bxa5 39 c5!

White opens a square for his king, while Black's mobility is decreasing...

39...dxc5 40 ♔c4 ♗a4 41 ♖xf6

White prudently avoids the painful trap 41 ♔xc5?? ♖c8+ 42 ♗c6 ♖cxc6+.

41...♖xf6 42 ♔xc5 ♗d1 43 ♔b5 a4 44 ♔b4 ♗c2 45 ♗c4 ♗xe4 46 ♔xa4 ♗f5 47 ♔b4 e4 48 ♔c3 e3 49 a4 1-0

Game 30
V.Tseshkovsky-W.Browne
Manila Interzonal 1976

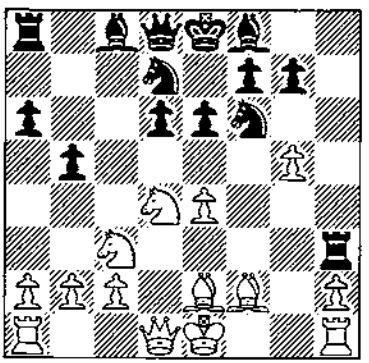
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 ♗e2 ♘bd7 8 g4 h6 9 f4 b5 10 g5 hxg5 11 fxg5 ♖h3?!

This sharp position has seen too 11...b4!? 12 gxf6 (12 ♘c6 might be more promising: for example, 12...♕c7 13

♘xb4 ♘xe4 14 ♘xe4 d5 15 ♘xd5 exd5 16 ♘c3 ♖xh2 17 ♖xh2 ♕xh2 18 ♕xd5 ♖b8 19 0-0-0 ♕c7 20 g6 ♘e5 21 gxf7+ ♘xf7 22 ♗h5 and 1-0 in L.Kaufman-R.Bauer, Connecticut 2002) 12...bxc3 13 ♘xe6 ♕xf6 14 ♕d5 cxb2 15 ♖d1 ♖b8 16 ♘c7+ ♔d8 17 ♕a5 b1♕ 18 ♘d5+ ♔e8 19 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 20 ♖xb1 ♖xb1+ 21 ♗d1 ♗g4 22 ♕a4+ ♘d7 23 ♔d2 ♗xd1 24 e5 ♗xc2 25 ♕xc2 ♖xh1, which should be winning for Black, but White managed to win despite his material deficit in the game P.Smirnov-N.Ibraev, Tomsk 2006.

12 ♗f2!

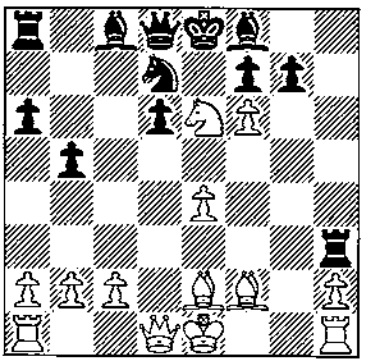
Tseshkovsky had done his homework and prepared this move, improving over Browne's published analysis. Our computer likes Black, but it will become evident that Tseshkovsky was right, decades before the advent of the analysis engine. Previously, 12 ♗f4 b4 13 ♘d5 exd5 14 gxf6 ♘xf6 15 ♘c6 ♕b6 16 exd5 ♘e4 17 ♕d4 ♕xd4 18 ♘xd4 g5 19 ♗c1 ♗g7 20 ♘c6 ♘g3 had left Black with the advantage in R.Byrne-W.Browne, Oberlin 1975.



12...♖xc3 13 gxf6 ♖h3

The probably superior 13...♖c5! 14 ♘xe6! ♕a5+ 15 c3 fxe6 16 b4 ♕a3 17 bxc5 ♕xc3+ 18 ♔f1 created a very unclear position which White happened to win in V.Isupov-K.Akhmedzhanov, Prokojevsk 1998.

14 ♘xe6!



14...♕a5+

Of course, 14...fxe6?? 15 ♗h5+ wins.

15 c3 fxe6 16 fxg7 ♗xg7 17 ♕xd6 ♖h6

Or 17...♔f7 18 0-0 ♘f6 19 ♗b6 ♕a4 20 ♕c6 ♖b8 21 b3 ♕a3 22 ♕c7+ ♔g6 23 ♕xb8 and White wins material.

18 ♖g1 ♗f8

18...♗xc3+ wins a pawn, but after 19 ♔f1 ♗b4 20 ♖g8+ ♔f7 21 ♕g3 ♗f8 22 ♗h5+ ♖xh5 23 ♕g6+ ♔e7 24 ♕xh5 ♕b4 25 ♖d1 ♔d8 26 ♗b6+ ♔e7 27 ♕g5+ ♔e8 28 ♕g6+ ♔e7 29 ♖h8 ♕c4+ 30 ♔g1 Black's king is in a mating net.

19 ♖g8 ♕d8

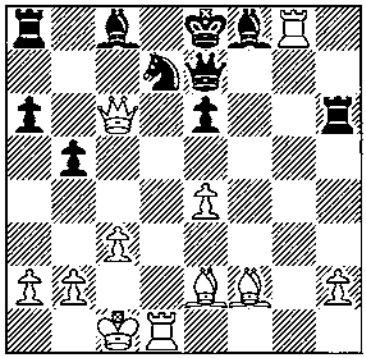
After 19...♔f7 20 ♖xf8+! ♘xf8 21 ♕f4+ ♖f6 22 ♗h5+ ♘g6 23 ♕h6 ♔g8 24 ♕g5 ♕d8 25 ♗xg6 ♕f8 26 e5 ♖xf2 27 ♗e4+ ♕g7 28 ♕xg7+ ♔xg7 29 ♔xf2 White is up two pawns.

20 0-0-0 ♕e7

Our computer thinks that 20...♔f7 is

the best try, but we believe that after 21 ♕g3 ♕f6 22 e5! ♘xe5 23 ♖xf8+! ♔xf8 24 ♗c5+ ♔f7 25 ♖f1 ♕xf1+ 26 ♗xf1 ♘d7 27 ♕g5 ♖f6 28 ♗e2 ♘xc5 29 ♗h5+ ♔e7 30 ♕g7+ ♔d6 31 ♕xf6 White wins.

21 ♕c6



White now recoups his investment with a tidy profit.

21...♖b8 22 ♗a7 ♔f7 23 ♖g2 ♖b7

Alternatively, 23...♗b7 24 ♕c7 ♖d8 25 ♕xb7 and White is winning.

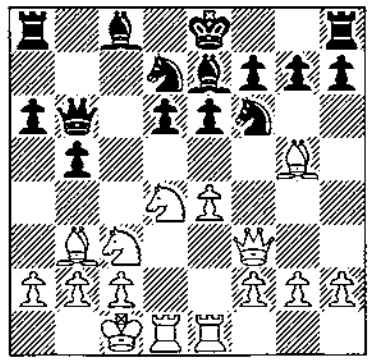
24 ♕xc8 ♖xa7 25 ♖f1+ ♘f6 26 e5 ♕d7 27 ♖xf6+ ♖xf6 28 ♗h5+ ♖g6 29 ♗xg6+ ♔e7 30 ♕c5+ 1-0

White wins a piece.

I had the privilege of observing the following game firsthand while playing in the 2003 U.S. Championship. It is equally a privilege to annotate it.

Game 31
M.Ashley-H.Nakamura
U.S. Championship, Seattle 2003

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 ♗g5 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♕b6 10 0-0-0 ♘bd7 11 ♖he1



11...h6

This looks like a new move to us. Previously Black had tried 11...0-0 and after 12 ♕g3 ♘c5 13 ♗h6 ♘e8 14 ♘f5!? (an interesting but doubtful sacrifice; 14 f4 ♔h8 15 ♗g5 is better) 14...exf5 (14...♘xb3+! 15 axb3 exf5 16 exf5 d5 17 ♗xg7 ♘xg7 18 ♖xe7 ♗xf5 19 ♘xd5 ♕h6+ 20 ♔b1 ♖fd8 was quite good for Black in A.Fernandez-Y.Quezada, Quemado 2005) 15 exf5 ♕d8 16 ♖xe7 ♕xe7 17 ♘d5 ♕d8 18 ♖e1 ♘e6 19 fxe6 fxe6 20 ♗g5 ♕a5 21 ♗d2?! (*Fritz* suggests 21 ♘e7+ ♔h8 22 ♖e3 as a likely win) 21...♕d8 22 ♗g5 ♕a5 23 ♗d2 ♕d8 24 ♗g5 the game finished as a draw in W.Hendriks-L.Van Wely, Dutch League 1998.

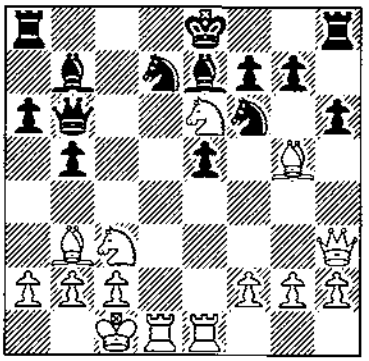
Also Black has tried 11...♘c5, but practice has shown that after 12 ♘f5!? White gets the advantage: for example, 12...exf5 13 ♗xf6 gxf6 14 ♘d5 ♕d8 15 exf5 ♖a7 16 ♕g4 ♔f8 17 ♖e3 h5 18 ♕f4 a5 19 a3 ♘xb3+ 20 cxb3 ♖c7+ 21 ♔b1 ♔g7 22 ♖g3+ ♔f8 23 ♖c3 ♔g7 24 ♖de1 ♗f8 25 ♖g3+ ♔h7 26 ♖e8 and Black

gave up in the game A.Tukhaev-R.Wojtaszek, Belfort 2005

12 e5 ♗b7 13 ♕h3 dxe5

Another important line runs 13...♘xe5 14 ♗xe6! fxe6 15 ♕xe6 ♕d8 16 ♗xf6 gxf6 17 f4 ♗c8 18 ♕d5 ♗g4 19 fxe5 dxe5 20 ♕c6+ ♗d7 21 ♕f3 ♕b8 (21...exd4 22 ♘d5 ♗c6 23 ♕h5+ ♔f8 24 ♘f4 ♕d6 25 ♘e6+ wins) 22 ♘d5 ♖f8 23 ♘c7+ ♕xc7 24 ♕xa8+ and White wins material.

14 ♘xe6!

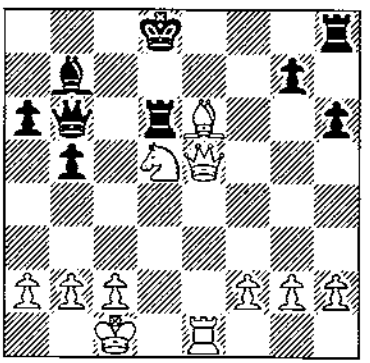


14...fxe6 15 ♗xe6 ♖d8?

A natural but losing move. Instead we believe that 15...♘f8! was a good way to force White to achieve a draw by finding 'only' moves: 16 ♖xe5 ♘xe6 17 ♖xe6 ♕c5 18 ♗e3! (after 18 ♗xf6?! gxf6 19 ♖de1 ♖h7 20 ♔b1 ♔f8 21 ♕g3 ♖g7 22 ♕xg7+ ♔xg7 23 ♖xe7+ ♔h8 24 ♖xb7 ♕xf2 25 ♖be7 it looks like White has only a small chance to draw this position) 18...♕c8 (18...♕c7 19 ♗b6 ♕f4+ 20 ♗e3 ♕c7 is a draw) 19 ♗d4 ♔f7 20 ♖de1 ♖e8 21 ♕f5 ♗xg2 22 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 23 ♖xf6+ gxf6 24 ♕h7+ ♔f8 25 ♕h8+ with a draw. Another option was 15...♘c5, but 16 ♗xf6 ♘xe6 17 ♕h5+ ♔f8 18 ♗xe7+ ♔xe7 19 ♕xe5 ♖hg8 20 f4 g6 21 g4 is very good for White.

16 ♖xd7 ♖xd7 17 ♗xf6 ♖d6 18 ♕h5+ ♔d8 19 ♗xe7+ ♔xe7 20 ♕xe5 ♔d8 21 ♘d5?!

This gives Black a great chance to survive. Instead 21 ♗d5! would have been an easy win after 21...♖f6 (21...♗xd5 22 ♘xd5 ♕c5 23 ♕xg7 ♖xd5 24 ♕xh8+ wins) 22 ♕e7+ ♔c8 23 ♕xg7 ♖hf8 24 ♖e7 ♗c6 25 ♘e4 ♗xd5 26 ♘xf6 ♕xf6 27 ♖e8+.



21...♗xd5 22 ♗xd5 ♕c7 23 f4 ♖d7 24 ♕f5?!

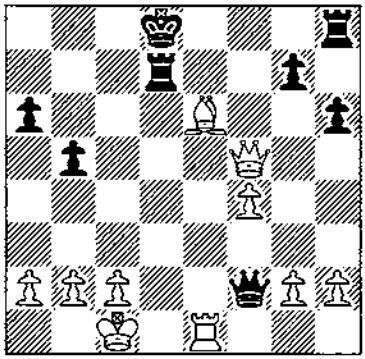
This further error helps Black to take over the initiative. The preferable 24 g3 ♕xe5 25 ♖xe5 looks about equal.

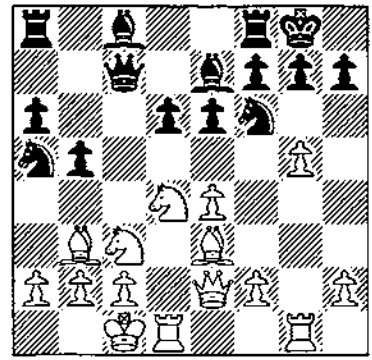
24...♕c5 25 ♗e6??

Instead 25 ♖d1 ♖e8 26 g3 ♕e3+ 27 ♔b1 ♕f2 would give chances for both sides, but not here 27...♕d2? since 28 ♕xd7+! ♔xd7 29 ♗e6+ ♔xe6 30 ♖xd2 wins.

25...♕f2! 0-1

Nothing can save White. Indeed, it's mate after both 26 ♖d1 ♕e3+ 27 ♔b1 ♖xd1 and 26 ♖h1 ♕d2+ 27 ♔b1 ♕d1+ 28 ♖xd1 ♖xd1.





Game 32
G.Ligterink-R.Dieks
Wijk aan Zee 1975

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘c6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗e3 ♘f6 7 ♗c4 a6 8 ♕e2 ♗e7 9 0-0-0 ♕c7 10 ♗b3 0-0 11 ♖hg1 ♘a5

Velimirovic theory also includes the sharp line 11...b5 12 g4 b4 13 ♘d5 exd5 14 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 15 g5. Play might continue 15...♘xe4 16 ♗xd5 ♕a4 17 ♗xe4 (the possibly superior 17 ♗d4!? ♗f5 18 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 19 ♕xe4 ♖fe8 20 ♔b1 ♗f8 21 ♕d3 ♕c6 22 h4 ♕e4 23 h5 ♖ac8 24 ♗e3 ♖e6 25 ♕xe4 ♖xe4 26 ♖d5 ♖ec4 27 ♖c1 ♗e7 28 b3 ♖e4 29 ♖cd1 gave White a positional edge which he used masterfully to win in A.Fedorov-I.Lutsko, Minsk 2005, but there's also 19...♕xa2 – see page 28) 17...♗e6 18 ♖d4 ♖ac8 19 a3 a5 20 ♗d3 g6 21 h4 ♕b3 22 axb4 ♕a2, which left White helpless against Black's attack in V.Ivanchuk-A.Grischuk, Odessa (rapid) 2007.

12 g4 b5 13 g5

13...♘d7

Allowing White to sacrifice on e6, whereas 13...♘xb3+!? would stop all such ideas.

14 ♗d5

White couldn't sacrifice immediately because 14 ♘xe6? ♘xb3+ 15 axb3 fxe6 wins for Black.

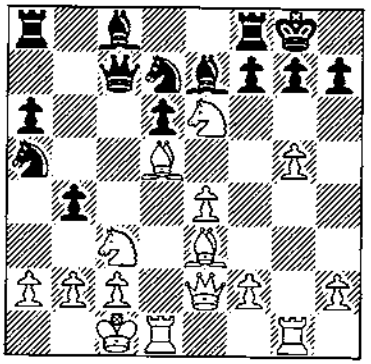
14...b4?

The most natural is 14...♗b7 when 15 ♗xe6 fxe6 16 ♘xe6 ♕c4 17 ♘xf8 ♗xf8 18 ♖ge1 ♕xe2 19 ♖xe2 ♘c4 20 f4 ♘xe3 21 ♖xe3 ♖e8 22 a3 ♘b6 23 ♖e2 ♗c6 24 h4 a5 25 ♖de1 b4 26 axb4 axb4 27 ♘d1 g6 28 ♘f2 ♗b5 29 ♖d2 ♗g7 gave Black a slight edge in J.Fumero Sanchez-R.Hernandez, Spain 1996.

However, accepting the sacrifice with 14...exd5? is inadvisable because after 15 ♘xd5 ♕d8 16 ♗d2 b4 17 ♗xb4 ♗xg5+ 18 ♔b1 ♗f6 19 ♘f5 ♘b7 20 ♖xg7+ ♗xg7 21 ♕g4 White wins.

15 ♘xe6!

Much better than 15 ♗xa8? bxc3 16 b4 ♕b8 17 a3 ♘e5 18 f4 ♘ec4 19 ♖d3 ♕xa8 20 bxa5 ♕xe4 21 ♖xc3 d5, which gives Black a tremendous attack and one which should be enough to win.



15...fxe6 16 ♗xe6+ ♔h8 17 ♘d5 ♕d8 18 g6!

Decisive.

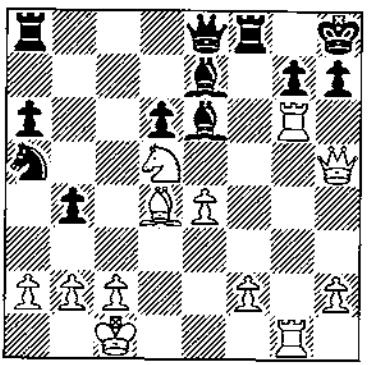
18...♘e5

After 18...h6 19 ♕h5 ♘f6 20 ♘xf6 ♖xf6 21 ♗d5 ♗f8 22 ♗xa8 White wins material.

19 ♕h5 ♘xg6 20 ♖xg6 ♕e8 21 ♖dg1

21 ♘xe7 ♗xe6 22 ♕g5 ♖f7 23 ♖xe6 was another way to win.

21...♗xe6 22 ♗d4



Black is completely lost. Every single white piece says 'hello' to the black king. Indeed, with so many 'hellos' about, soon one of White's pieces will say a final 'goodbye'.

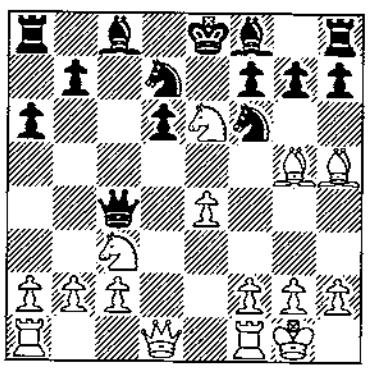
22...♗f6 23 ♘xf6 ♖xf6 24 ♗xf6 gxf6 25 ♕h6 ♕f8 26 ♖g7 ♘b3+ 27 axb3 ♗xb3 28 ♕xh7 mate (1-0)

Game 33
P.Keres-A.Kotov
Budapest Candidates 1950

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e2 ♕c7 7 ♗g5 ♘bd7 8 0-0 e6 9 ♗h5 ♕c4?

Better is 9...g6 hitting the bishop, after which, for example, 10 ♗e2 b5 11 ♖e1 ♗b7 12 a4 b4 13 ♘d5 exd5 14 exd5 ♗e7 15 ♘c6 ♗xc6 16 dxc6 ♘c5 17 ♗xa6 0-0 18 ♗b5 ♘e6 19 ♗h4 d5 which gave Black a slight advantage in the game L.Yurtaev-A.Wojtkiewicz, Manila Olympiad 1992.

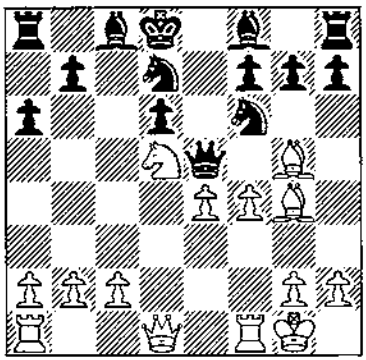
10 ♘xe6!



10...♕xe6 11 ♘d5 ♔d8

11...♘xd5 12 exd5 ♕f5 13 ♕e1+ ♘e5 14 f4 g6 15 fxe5 ♕xg5 16 exd6+ ♗e6 17 dxe6 gxh5 18 ♕b4 ♕b5 19 ♕c3 leaves Black with no chances whatsoever for survival.

12 ♗g4 ♕e5 13 f4



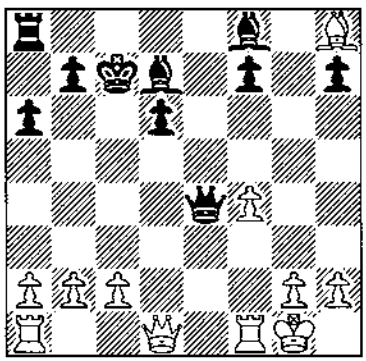
13...♕xe4

After the best try 13...♕xb2 White continues 14 ♗xd7 ♗xd7 15 ♖b1 ♕a3 16 ♕d4 ♕c5 17 ♕xc5 dxc5 18 ♖fd1! when Black can't save the piece: 18...c4 19 ♗xf6+ gxf6 20 ♘xf6 ♔c7 21 ♘xd7 b5 22 ♘b6 and White's extra pawn should be enough for a win.

14 ♗xd7 ♗xd7 15 ♘xf6 gxf6

After 15...♕c6, 16 ♘d5+ ♔c8 17 ♕d4 ♖b8 18 ♖f3 wins material. Another try was 15...♕f5, but White wins after 16 ♘d5+ f6 17 ♕d4 ♗c6 18 ♕b6+ ♔d7 19 ♕c7+ ♔e6 20 ♖fe1+ ♔xd5 21 ♕a5+ ♗b5 22 c4+ ♔xc4 23 ♕c3+ ♔d5 24 ♖ad1+.

16 ♗xf6+ ♔c7 17 ♗xh8



Black tries to resist, but Keres snuffs out any remaining hopes.

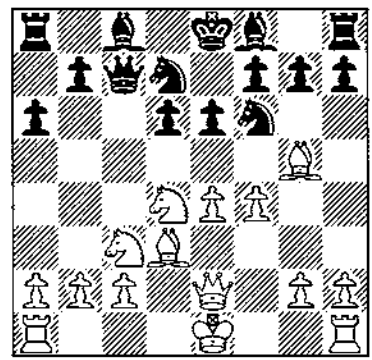
17...♗c6 18 ♕d2 ♗h6 19 ♖ae1 ♕g6 20 ♖e7+ ♔d8 21 ♖fe1 a5 22 ♗d4 ♖a6 23 ♕f2 ♗f8 24 ♗b6+ ♔c8 25 ♖e8+ ♗xe8 26 ♖xe8+ ♔d7 27 ♖xf8 1-0

Game 34
B.Spassky-N.Rashkovsky
USSR Championship, Moscow 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♕c7 8 ♗d3 ♘bd7

More recently Black has favoured 8...b5, perhaps because after 9 ♕e2 b4 the sacrifice 10 ♘d5? no longer works in view of 10...exd5 11 exd5+ ♕e7! – compare the note to Black's 10th move, below. Instead here White should play 10 ♘d1; for example, 10...♘bd7 11 ♘f2 ♗b7 12 0-0-0 ♗e7 with equality, L.Nisipeanu-A.Istratescu, Mamaia 1991.

9 ♕e2



This prepares many nasty sacrifices,

although 9 ♕f3 is the most popular move in this position.

9...b5

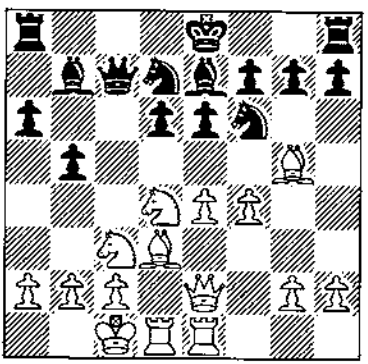
Many years later 9...♗e7 10 0-0-0 h6 11 ♗h4 b5 12 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 13 e5 dxe5 14 fxe5 ♘d7 15 ♗e4 ♖b8 16 ♘c6 b4 17 ♘xb8 ♗g5+ 18 ♔b1 ♕xb8 19 ♘a4 ♕b5 20 ♕xb5 axb5 21 ♖xd7 ♔xd7 22 ♘c5+ ♔c7 gave Black an equal endgame in O.Perez Mitjans-O.Zambrana, Havana 2006.

10 0-0-0 ♗b7

10...b4 11 ♘d5! exd5 12 exd5+ ♗e7 13 ♖he1 ♘b8 14 ♗f5 should give White more than enough compensation for a piece.

11 ♖he1 ♗e7

11...0-0-0 12 ♗xb5 axb5 13 ♘dxb5 was suggested by Spassky with no further analysis or evaluation, but *Fritz* thinks this is promising.



12 e5 dxe5 13 fxe5 ♘d5 14 ♗xe7

14 ♘xe6!? gives White some winning chances:

a) 14...fxe6 was mentioned by Spassky. His analysis ran 15 ♕h5+ ♔d8 16 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 17 ♗xe7+ ♔xe7 18 ♕g5+ ♔f8 19 ♖f1+ ♔e8! 20 ♕xg7, but here Black can improve on his 20...♖f8 with 20...♕xe5!. Instead 20 ♗xh7! as per *Fritz* is the right way.

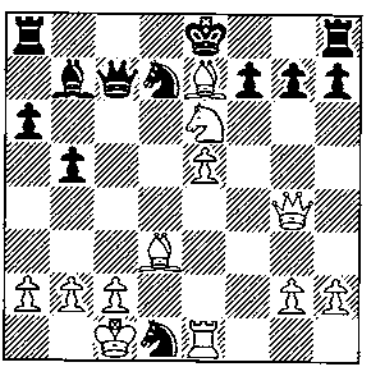
b) 14...♗xg5+ 15 ♘xg5 ♘xc3 16 bxc3 ♕xc3 17 e6 (17 ♕g4, Keres' suggestion, quoted by Spassky, also looks good after 17...♘c5 18 ♔b1 h6 19 ♖e3 ♔e7 20 ♘xf7 ♘a4 21 ♔c1 ♗c8 22 ♕xg7; here 18...♘xd3 19 ♖xd3 ♕xe1+ 20 ♖d1 ♗c8 21 e6 ♕xd1+ 22 ♕xd1 ♗xe6 23 ♕d6 is perhaps an improvement but White still has chances) 17...♕a3+ 18 ♔d2 favoured White in S.Ter Sahakyan-G.Popilsky, Kemer 2007.

14...♘xc3 15 ♕g4 ♘xd1

After 15...♔xe7 White has 16 ♘xe6! ♘xa2+ 17 ♔b1 ♘c3+ 18 bxc3 ♕xc3 19 ♕g5+ ♔e8 20 ♘xg7+ ♔f8 21 e6 ♕b4+ 22 ♔c1 f6 23 ♕h6 ♕a3+ 24 ♔d2 ♕a5+ 25 ♔e2 which left Black in a completely lost position in V.Gurevich-B.Katalymov, Moscow 1975.

16 ♘xe6!

Much better than 16 ♗d6 ♘xe5! (Spassky) 17 ♗xe5 ♘f2, which looks good for Black.

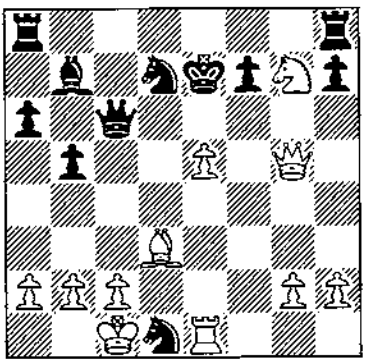


16...♕c6

This is a fairly good move, but it

won't save Black. However, of the many possible variations, none of them really help Black. For example, 16...fxe6 17 ♗d6 ♕a5 (or 17...♕b6 18 ♕xe6+ ♔d8 19 ♗f5 ♗c6 20 ♕e7+! ♔c8 21 ♕xg7 ♖d8 22 ♖xd1 with good winning chances) 18 ♕xe6+ ♔d8 19 ♗f5 ♗c6 20 ♖xd1 ♔c8 21 ♗b4 ♕xb4 22 ♕xc6+ ♔b8 23 ♗xd7 ♖a7 24 e6 ♕e7 25 ♕b6+ ♖b7 26 ♕xa6 and White should win.

17 ♘xg7+! ♔xe7 18 ♕g5+



18...f6

After 18...♔f8 19 ♘f5 ♕g6 20 ♕e7+ ♔g8 21 e6 White enjoys crushing threats: for instance, 21...♗d5 22 exd7 h6 23 d8♕+ ♖xd8 24 ♕xd8+ ♔h7 25 ♕xd5 and wins.

19 exf6+ ♔d8 20 f7+ ♔c7 21 ♕f4+ 1-0

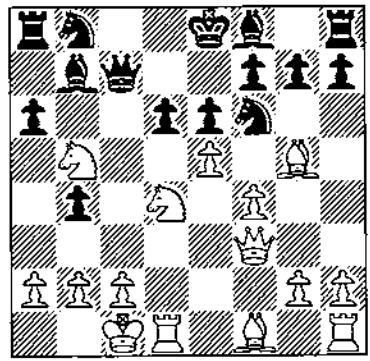
Black loses material after 21...♔b6 22 ♖e6 ♘xb2 23 ♔xb2 ♘c5 24 ♕e3 ♖ac8 25 ♖xc6+ ♖xc6 26 ♗f5 ♖f8 27 ♕e7.

Game 35
K.Georgiev-G.Kasparov
La Valetta Olympiad 1980

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♕c7 8 ♕f3 b5 9 0-0-0 b4

The most popular move in this sharp position.

10 e5 ♗b7 11 ♘cb5!?



A theoretical sacrifice that leads to an unclear game with chances for both sides.

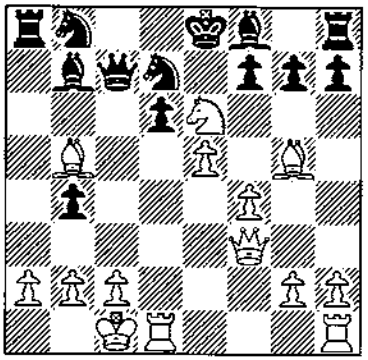
11...axb5 12 ♗xb5+ ♘fd7?

After the correct 12...♘bd7! one example saw 13 ♕h3 b3 14 ♕xb3 ♗d5 15 c4 ♘e4 16 ♕c2 ♗b7 17 ♖he1 ♘xg5 18 fxg5 0-0-0 19 ♗xd7+ ♖xd7 20 ♘b5 ♕b6 21 ♔b1 ♗e7 (Brunner gives 21...dxe5! 22 ♖xd7 ♔xd7 23 ♖d1+ ♔c8 24 ♕d2 ♗c5 as winning in *Informator*) 22 ♕b3 dxe5 23 ♖xd7 ♔xd7 24 ♖d1+ ♔c8 25 ♘d6+ ♕xd6 26 ♖xd6 ♗xd6 27 c5 ♗e4+ 28 ♔a1 ♗e7 and Black was better, but couldn't win due to his exposed king in J.Van der Wiel-L.Brunner, Baden-Baden 1992.

A more recent example ran 16 ♖he1!? (instead of 16 ♕c2) ♘xg5 17 fxg5 ♗xc4 18 exd6 ♗xb3+ 19 dxc7 ♗xd1 20 ♖xd1 ♗d6 21 ♘xe6 ♔e7 22 ♘d4 ♗f4+ 23 ♔b1 ♘b6 24 ♘c6+ ♔e6 25 ♘d8+ ♔e7 26 ♘c6+ ♔e6 27 ♘d8+ ♔e5

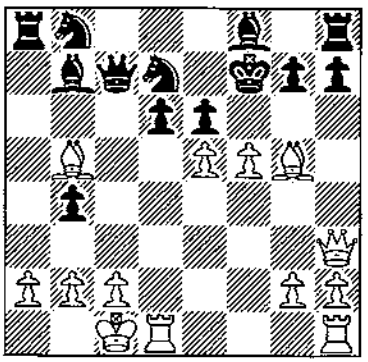
and a draw was agreed in K.Miton-M.Vachier Lagrave, Dresden Olympiad 2008. However, both *Fritz* and *Rybka* rather like White after 28 g3. The variations are numerous and complex, so we think it is best for the reader to analyse this with a good engine and come to a decision.

13 ♘xe6!



We believe that any computer program will, at least initially, consider this position as completely lost for White, but our analysis shows that really it is Black who is in trouble.

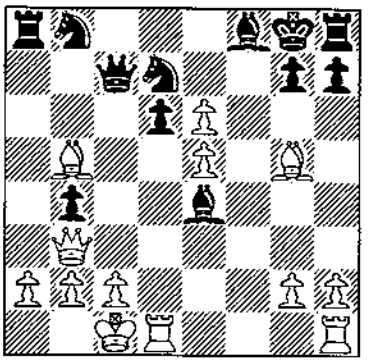
13...fxe6 14 ♕h3 ♔f7 15 f5



15...♗e4

Black's attempt to follow *Fritz*'s recommendation led to a total catastrophe after 15...♘xe5 16 fxe6+ ♔g8 17 e7 ♗xc7 18 ♕e6+ ♘f7 19 ♗xe7 ♗c8 20 ♕d5 (20 ♕c4! is even better, says *Fritz*) 20...♕b7 (20....♗b7 21 ♗xd6 ♗xd5 22 ♗xc7 ♗c6 23 ♗c4 ♘d7 24 ♖he1 ♘f6 25 ♖e7 ♗e8 26 ♗d6 should leave White with a winning endgame) 21 ♗c4 ♕xd5 22 ♗xd5 ♗b7 23 ♗e6 ♗e4 24 ♖hf1 ♗g6 25 ♖xd6 ♘a6 26 ♗d5 ♘c7 27 ♗xa8 ♘xa8 28 ♖d8+ and 1-0 in M.Yeo-M.Rose, British League 1997.

16 fxe6+ ♔g8 17 ♕b3



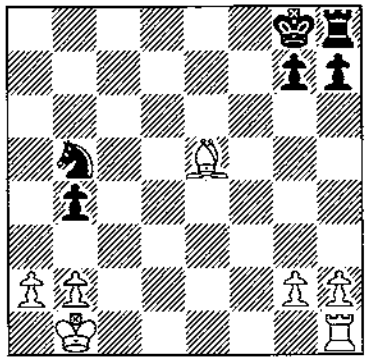
17...♗xc2

After 17...♘c5 *Fritz* indicates 18 ♕c4 d5 19 ♖xd5 ♘xe6 20 ♖c5! as best (20 ♕xe4 ♘xg5 21 ♕c4 is not bad), after which 20...♕f7 (or 20...♗xc5 21 ♕xe6+ ♕f7 22 ♕c8+ ♗f8 23 ♗c4 ♗d5 24 e6) 21 ♖f1 ♗f5 22 ♖c8 ♕g6 23 h4 supplies crushing threats like g2-g4 or ♗e8.

18 ♕xc2 ♕xc2+ 19 ♔xc2 ♘xe5 20 e7 ♗xe7 21 ♗xe7 ♘bc6 22 ♗xd6 ♖a5 23 ♖d5 ♖xb5 24 ♖xb5 ♘d4+ 25 ♔b1 ♘xb5

The young Kasparov has lost his extra material and now in desperation seeks salvation in the ending.

26 ♗xe5



26...♔f7 27 ♖c1 ♔e6 28 ♖c5 ♘d6 29 ♔c2 ♖f8 30 ♗d4 ♖f1 31 ♖e5+ ♔d7 32 ♗c5 ♔c6 33 ♗xb4 ♖f2+ 34 ♔c1 ♘b7 35 ♖g5

Down two pawns, even Kasparov cannot resist.

35...g6 36 a3 ♖e2 37 ♔b1 ♖f2 38 ♔a2 ♘d8 39 ♖c5+ ♔b7 40 ♖d5 ♘c6 41 ♗c3 ♖xg2 42 ♖d7+ ♔b6 43 ♖xh7 ♔b5 44 ♔b3 ♖g4 45 ♖d7 ♖h4 46 ♖d2 ♖h3 47 ♖g2 ♘d4+ 48 ♔a2 ♘f5 49 ♗e5 ♖e3 50 ♗b8 ♖e6 51 ♖g4 ♘e7 52 ♗g3 ♘c6 53 a4+ ♔c5 54 ♔a3 ♖f6 55 b3 ♔d5 56 ♖g5+ ♔e4 57 ♖c5 ♖e6 58 a5 ♔d3 59 b4 ♘d4 60 ♗e5 ♘f3 61 ♗b2 ♘d2 62 ♖c3+ ♔e2 63 ♔a4 1-0

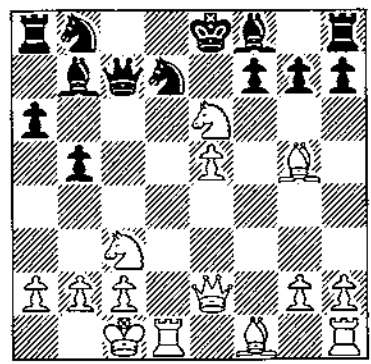
Game 36
Y.Grünfeld-F.Van der Vliet
Amsterdam 1982

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 b5 8 e5 dxe5 9 fxe5 ♕c7 10 ♕e2

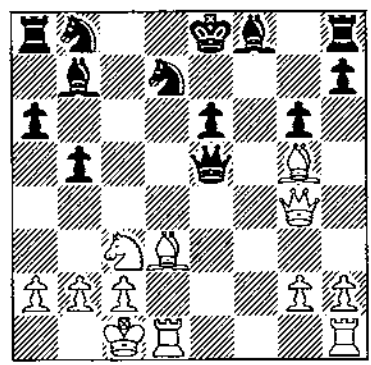
Instead 10 exf6 ♕e5+ is the main line of this, the Polugaevsky Variation.

10...♘fd7 11 0-0-0 ♗b7 12 ♘xe6?!

We don't trust this sacrifice. As I always tell my students: 'Before you do something active, develop your pieces.' According to De Firmian, 12 ♕g4 ♕xe5 13 ♗d3 should be a better line: for example, 13...h6 14 ♗h4 g5 15 ♘xe6 h5 16 ♕h3 ♗h6 17 ♔b1 g4 18 ♘c7+ ♕xc7 19 ♖hc1+ ♔f8 20 ♗e7+ ♔g8 21 ♕xh5 ♗g7 22 ♕g5 ♘c6 23 ♗f5 ♘ce5 24 ♗d6 was good for White in the game W.Sauermann-H.Lassen, correspondence 1983.



12...fxe6 13 ♕h5+ g6 14 ♕g4 ♕xe5 15 ♗d3

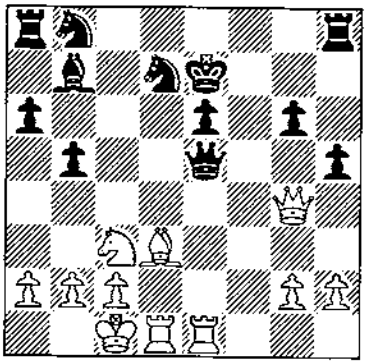


15...♗e7

This was popular at the time, but we prefer 15...♘c5! because it's important for Black to defend the e6-pawn and trade as many pieces as possible. Indeed, after 16 ♖he1 ♘xd3+ 17 cxd3 ♕f5 18 ♕g3 ♘d7 19 ♖f1 ♗d6 20 ♕h4 ♕c5 21 ♖fe1 ♗d5 the extra bishop soon proved to be decisive in the game J.Aliqogin-I.Siuniakov, Novokuznetsk 2007.

16 ♗xe7 ♔xe7 17 ♖he1 h5

Black wants to sacrifice a pawn to gain a tempo for the defence.



18 ♕xg6 ♕f4+

Another good try is 18...♕f6, after which 19 ♕g3 ♔d8 20 ♗e4 ♔c8 21 ♗xb7+ ♔xb7 22 ♘e4 ♕h6+ 23 ♔b1 ♖f8 24 a4 ♖a7 25 ♘d6+ ♔a8 26 axb5 is unclear, although later White achieved a decisive initiative in the game D.Jabot-J.Bennborn, correspondence 1999.

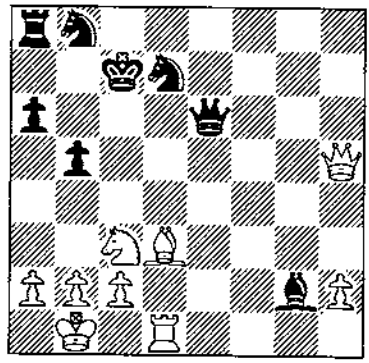
19 ♔b1 ♕g4

It looks like Black will trade queens, but White has one more trick up his sleeve.

20 ♖xe6+!

Winning a pawn and maintaining the attack.

20...♕xe6 21 ♕g7+ ♔d8 22 ♕xh8+ ♔c7 23 ♕xh5 ♗xg2



Who is winning in this mess? Black's idea is easy: to develop his pieces and win with the extra piece. White, on the other hand, is hoping to paralyse Black's undeveloped pieces and at the same time to push his passed pawn. Then when Black's pieces run to stop the h-pawn, White will attack Black's king. As coaches say: attack two weaknesses!

24 ♗f5 ♕e5 25 ♕h7 ♗c6 26 h4

Are you ready for some football? Four more squares to a touchdown!

26...♔b6 27 ♕g6 ♕f6

Alternatively, 27...♘c5!? 28 h5 ♔c7 29 h6 ♘bd7 30 a3 ♖h8 31 h7 and in this unclear position Black has developed all his pieces, but faces a passed-pawn problem.

28 ♕g4 ♕e5 29 ♘e4 ♖a7 30 ♘d6 ♖c7 31 h5?!

Three squares left for a touchdown, but Black is almost untangled. Instead 31 ♕g1+ ♕c5 32 ♖d4 would have kept up the pressure.

31...♔a7?!

It was more important for Black to improve the other pieces. Indeed, 31...♗d5 32 ♘e4 ♖c4 33 ♕g6+ ♖c6 34 ♕g1+ ♔b7 looks good for Black.

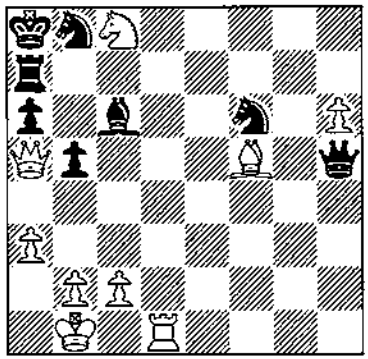
32 h6

Two more squares for a touchdown!

32...♘f6 33 ♕b4 ♔a8 34 a3?!

White stumbles just before the goal line: 34 ♕a5! ♖e7 35 ♘c8 ♕c7 36 ♕c3 ♖f7 37 ♕d4 ♘bd7 38 ♘d6 ♖e7 39 ♕c3 and White's activity will cause Black too many problems.

34...♕h2 35 ♕a5 ♖a7 36 ♘c8 ♕h5??



This allows checkmate in six moves. The correct 36...♖f7 37 ♘b6+ ♔a7 (but not 37...♔b7? 38 ♗c8+ ♔a7 39 ♗xa6 ♘xa6 40 ♘c8+ ♔b8 41 ♕b6+ ♖b7 42 ♕xc6 ♕e2 43 ♖d8 and White wins) 38 ♘c8+ ♔a8 39 ♘b6+ would have been a draw.

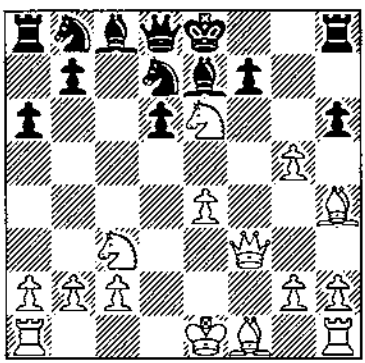
37 ♘b6+ ♔b7 38 ♗c8+ ♔c7 39 ♘a8+ ♔xc8 40 ♖d8+ ♔b7 41 ♕b6+ 1-0

It's funny how Black couldn't develop his knight. The moral of the story: checkmate is better than a touchdown!

We now turn to a famous game with a funny story. According to various sources, three Argentineans, Najdorf, Panno and Pilnik, had prepared a new idea against the 6 ♗g5 Najdorf and all three got to use it in the same round of the Gothenburg Interzonal against no lesser players than Keres, Geller and Spassky. However, led by Geller, the Soviets found a refutation over the board!

Game 37
B.Spassky-H.Pilnik
Gothenburg Interzonal 1955

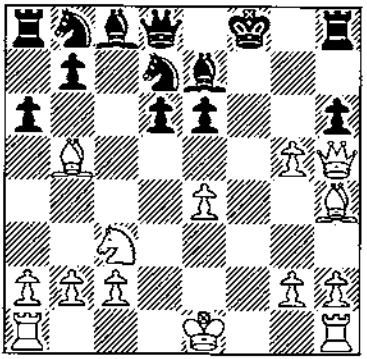
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 h6 9 ♗h4 g5 10 fxg5 ♘fd7 11 ♘xe6!



11...fxe6 12 ♕h5+ ♔f8 13 ♗b5!

The Argentineans were ready only for 13 ♗c4 which they had analysed together before the round. The idea of White's 13th, first played by Geller, is to control the d7- and c6-squares so as to remove the important defender from b8. Instead after 13 ♗c4? ♘e5 (this knight holds Black's position together) 14 ♗g3 ♘bc6 (now Black gets to keep a

knight on e5) 15 gxh6 ♖h7 16 0-0+ ♔g8 17 ♗b3 ♔h8 18 ♕h3 ♗g5 19 ♗f4 ♖xh6 20 ♕e3 ♖g6 21 ♖ad1 ♗e7 22 ♘e2 ♕g8 23 ♗g3 ♕g7 24 ♘f4 ♖h6 25 ♖d2 b5 26 c3 ♖b8 27 ♕e2 ♗d7 28 ♘d3 ♖g8 I easily won with the extra piece in D.Pruess-Y.Lapshun, U.S. Championship, Seattle 2003.



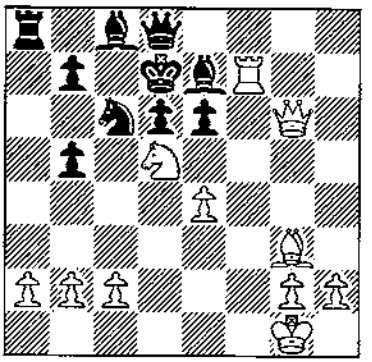
13...♔g7?

White won too after 13...♘e5 14 ♗g3! in the encounter between Geller and Panno. However, better is 13...♖h7!, Fischer's improvement, which he introduced against Gligoric. Now:

a) 14 0-0+ is the most famous continuation: 14...♔g8 15 g6 ♖g7 16 ♖f7 ♗xh4 17 ♕xh6 ♖xf7 (a queen sacrifice which we don't trust is 17...♕f6: after 18 ♖xf6 ♗xf6 19 e5 ♗xe5 20 ♗d3 ♘c5 21 ♖f1 ♗d7 22 h4 ♘c6 23 h5 ♘xd3 24 cxd3 ♖f8 25 ♖xf8+ ♔xf8 26 ♘e4 ♘e7 27 g4 White's passed pawns were a headache for Black in A.Shabalov-D.Sadvakasov, Los Angeles 2000) 18 gxf7+ ♔xf7 19 ♕h7+ ♔f8 20 ♖f1+ ♗f6 21 ♗e2 ♕b6+ 22 ♔h1 ♔e8 23 ♕g8+ ♔e7 24 ♗h5 d5 25 exd5 ♗xc3 26 bxc3 e5 27 ♕xc8 ♔d6 28 ♗g4 was better for White in V.Jansa-J.Fichtl, Jablonec 1962.

b) 14 ♕g6 is not popular, but contains its dangers too, although 14...♖f7 15 ♕xh6+ ♔g8 16 ♕g6+ ♖g7 17 ♕xe6+ ♔h8 18 ♗xd7 ♘xd7 19 0-0-0 ♘e5 20 ♕d5 ♗g4 21 ♖df1 ♗xg5+ 22 ♗xg5 ♕xg5+ 23 ♔b1 ♕e7 24 ♕d2 was roughly equal in the game S.Gligoric-R.Fischer, Portoroz Interzonal 1958.

14 0-0 ♘e5 15 ♗g3 ♘g6 16 gxh6+ ♖xh6 17 ♖f7+ ♔xf7 18 ♕xh6 axb5 19 ♖f1+ ♔e8 20 ♕xg6+ ♔d7 21 ♖f7 ♘c6 22 ♘d5!!



A final blow which puts more pressure on Black's bishop.

22...♖xa2

Alternatively, 22...exd5 23 ♕xd6+ ♔e8 24 ♕g6 ♔d7 25 exd5 ♖a6 26 ♖h7 ♕f8 27 d6 ♖xa2 28 ♕g4+ ♔d8 29 dxe7+ ♘xe7 30 ♕d1+ ♗d7 31 ♗h4 wins.

23 h3

Keres and Najdorf also reached this position (!) and in that game White won with 23 h4.

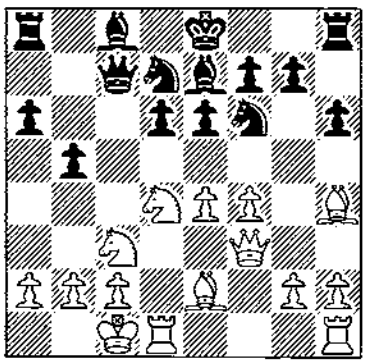
23...♕h8

Or 23...♖xb2 24 ♘xe7 ♘xe7 25 ♔h2 ♔c6 26 ♕f6 ♖xc2 27 ♖xe7 e5 28 ♗xe5 and wins.

24 ♘xe7 ♘xe7 25 ♕g5 ♖a1+ 26 ♔h2 ♕d8 27 ♕xb5+ ♔c7 28 ♕c5+ ♔b8 29 ♗xd6+ ♔a8 30 ♗xe7 ♖a5 31 ♕b4 1-0

Game 38
A.Zwaig-J.Bednarski
Tel Aviv Olympiad 1964

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 h6 9 ♗h4 ♘bd7 10 0-0-0 ♕c7 11 ♗e2 b5

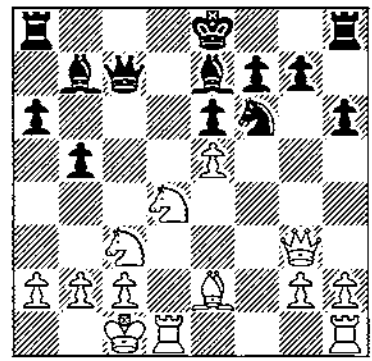


11...♖b8 is a safer move: for example, 12 ♗g3 b5 13 e5 ♗b7 14 ♕f2 dxe5 15 fxe5 ♘e4 16 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 17 ♗f3 ♘c5 18 ♖he1 ♗xf3 19 gxf3 ♘a4 20 f4 ♘xb2! 21 ♘xe6 fxe6 22 ♔xb2 0-0 and White had avoided mate, but his weak king position rendered his cause hopeless in A.Stripunsky-J.Ehlvest, Connecticut 2007.

12 ♗xf6

The queen sacrifice 12 e5 ♗b7 13 exf6 ♗xf3 14 ♗xf3 ♗xf6 15 ♗xf6 ♖c8 16 ♗h4 d5 was praised highly by Geller, but later Nunn was not convinced.

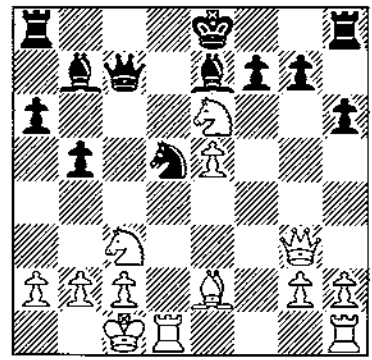
12...♘xf6 13 e5 ♗b7 14 ♕g3 dxe5 15 fxe5



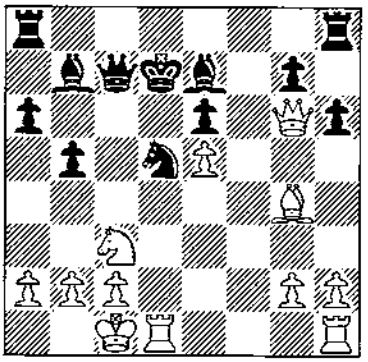
15...♘d5

Practice has seen too 15...♘d7, after which 16 ♘xe6 fxe6 17 ♗h5+ ♔d8 18 ♕xg7 ♖f8 19 ♗g4 ♗xg2 (or 19...♕c5 20 ♗xe6 ♗c6 21 ♗xd7 ♗xd7 22 ♕g4 ♗d6 23 ♕e4 ♗c6 24 ♕g6 ♔c7 25 ♖xd6 and White won in R.Vasquez-H.Contreras Rodriguez, Minneapolis 2005) 20 ♖hg1 ♗f3 21 ♗xf3 ♖xf3 22 ♕g2 ♗g5+ 23 ♔b1 ♖xc3 24 ♕xa8+ ♕c8 25 ♕a7 ♖c7 26 ♕b6 ♕b7 27 ♕xe6 ♖c6 28 ♕g8+ ♔c7 29 ♕f7 ♔c8 30 e6 ♘c5 31 ♖xg5 forced Black to resign in M.Molner-F.Corrales Jimenez, Yerevan 2007.

16 ♘xe6



16...fxe6 17 ♕g6+ ♔d7 18 ♗g4



The pair of pins ensures that White will regain his material.

18...♕xe5 19 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 20 ♖xd5+ ♕xd5 21 ♖d1 ♗g5+ 22 ♔b1 ♕xd1+ 23 ♗xd1 ♗f6

Whatever the correct assessment of this position, there is no doubt that it is more pleasant to play for White.

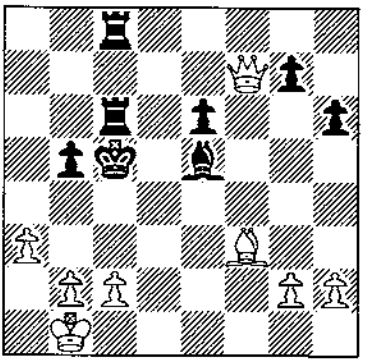
24 ♕f7+ ♔d6 25 ♗f3 ♖ab8 26 ♕a7

There seems to have been no way to prevent this unpleasant incursion of the white queen. White's advantage is now clear.

26...♖hd8 27 a3 ♗e5 28 ♗g4 ♖dc8 29 ♕xa6+ ♖c6 30 ♕a7 ♖bc8

Or 30...♖f8 31 h3 ♖c7 32 ♕b6+ and White continues to collect pawns. The weakness of the light squares is fatal.

31 ♕f7 ♔c5 32 ♗f3



32...♖b6

After 32...♖8c7 33 ♕g6 ♖d6 34 b4+ ♔b6 35 ♕e8 the mating threats mean that White will gain even more material.

33 ♕d7 ♖bc6 34 ♕a7+ ♔d6 35 ♗xc6 ♖xc6 36 ♕b8+ ♖c7 37 ♕xb5 ♗xh2 38 c4 ♗g1 39 b4 ♖f7 40 c5+ ♔e5 41 ♕b8+ ♔d4 42 ♕d6+ ♔c3 43 ♕d1 ♗e3 44 ♕c2+ ♔d4 45 c6 ♗f4 46 ♕f2+ ♔e4 47 ♕f3+ ♔f5 48 g3 g5 1-0

Chapter Three

The Bishop Sacrifice on e6

The sacrificial possibility ♗xe6 is one of the most common themes in the Sicilian, if not one that is commonly realized. In some circles it is referred to as the 'Capablanca sacrifice', because of a couple of games the Cuban played in the 1920s. Consider the following:

Game 39
J.Capablanca-K.Havasi
Budapest 1928

1 d4 d5 2 c4 e6 3 ♘f3 dxc4 4 e4 c5 5 ♗xc4 cxd4 6 ♘xd4 ♘f6 7 ♘c3 a6?

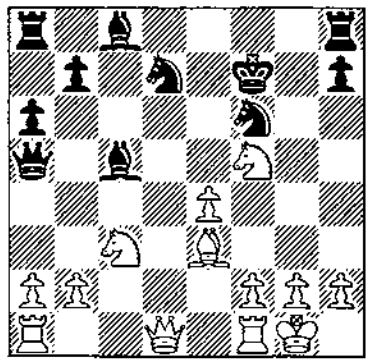
At Moscow 1925 Bogoljubow played 7...♗c5 8 ♗e3 ♘bd7 which allowed 9 ♗xe6, but at least White had not castled there.

8 0-0 ♗c5 9 ♗e3 ♘bd7?

He really had to castle. Leaving the king in the centre is asking for it.

10 ♗xe6! fxe6 11 ♘xe6 ♕a5 12 ♘xg7+ ♔f7 13 ♘f5

Three pawns and an attack for the piece. So far, so caveman, but the rest is a bit more subtle...



13...♘e5 14 ♕b3+ ♔g6 15 ♖ac1 ♗f8 16 ♘e2 h5 17 ♖fd1 ♖g8 18 ♘f4+ ♔h7 19 ♗b6 ♕b5 20 ♖c7+ ♔h8 21 ♕xb5

Trading queens in the midst of a violent attack is so typically Capablanca.

21...axb5 22 ♖d8 ♖xa2 23 ♖dxc8 ♘c4 24 h3 ♘xb6 25 ♖xf8! ♘fd7 26 ♖f7 ♖xb2 27 ♘d5 1-0

Yes, I know it was a QGA, but if you like you can think of it as a funky Maroczy Bind. And, yes, I know that Black played the opening like a zombie, but a lot of people played like that back then. However, this is as clear and simple an example of the mechanics of the ♗xe6 sacrifice as we could find. Virtually every game in this chapter has some complication which makes life difficult. (Don't ask about Fedorov-Kobalija, which could fit into four different chapters! I'm still not wholly sure why we put it in this one.)

We will consider differing placements of the black king, as per custom.

1. The Uncastled King

The aim here is naturally to keep His Majesty in the centre and expose him to attack. If you can get three pawns and an attack, then go ahead and sacrifice! If you get only two pawns, though, you need to start with a big lead in development to support that knight on e6 to make things fly. At least, once the e6-pawn leaves the premises, you get to use d5. You may also be able to push f4-f5 and nail down exclusive use of e6. Another positive indicator is a weakening move like ...h6.

Of course, if the black king can run to the queenside as in Cervenka-Schneider, below, then look for a better opportunity to sacrifice.

2. The Castled King

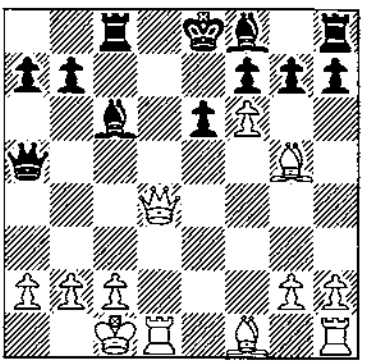
It's hard to give specifics here. Look for a weakness in the castled position and/or a massive concentration of your forces near the king's address. And, while you're at it, look for other sacrifices as well!

Now it's time to get down to some specific examples with Yury.

Game 40
V.Tseshkovsky-G.Zaitshik
USSR Championship, Telavi 1982

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 ♘c6 6 ♗g5 ♗d7 7 ♕d2 ♖c8 8 f4 ♘xd4 9 ♕xd4 ♕a5 10 e5 dxe5 11 fxe5 e6 12 0-0-0 ♗c6 13 ♘b5 ♗xb5 14 exf6 ♗c6?!

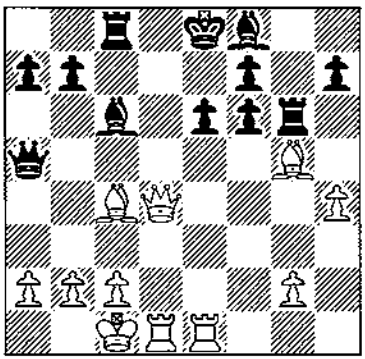
Much more recently 14...g6 15 ♕e5 a6 16 ♗xb5+ axb5 17 ♖d3 ♗c5 18 ♔b1 0-0 19 ♗e3 gave White a slight advantage in the game F.Caruana-Bui Vinh, Budapest 2007.



15 h4 ♖g8 16 ♗c4 gxf6 17 ♖he1 ♖g6

Worse is 17...fxg5? on account of 18 ♗xe6! fxe6 19 ♕f6 and after 19...♕xe1 20 ♖xe1 ♖c7 21 ♕xe6+ ♖e7 22 ♕c8+ ♔f7

23 ♖f1+ ♔g7 24 ♕d8 ♖e6 25 ♕d4+ ♔g6 26 ♕c4 ♗d7 27 ♕d3+ ♔h5 28 ♕xh7+ Black had to resign in K.Lahno-E.Andreev, Kramatorsk 2003.



18 ♗xe6?!

This obvious sacrifice is enough only for a draw. Tseshkovsky gives the stronger 18 ♗xf6 which prepares a ♗xe6 blow. He analyses, for example, 18...♖xg2 19 ♔b1! ♕b6 20 ♕d3 ♖g6 21 ♗xe6 fxe6 22 ♖xe6+ ♔f7 23 ♕f5 ♔g8 24 ♗d4 ♕c7? (here, though, *Fritz* prefers 24...♗d7 25 ♗xb6 ♗xe6 26 ♕f3 axb6 27 ♕xb7 ♔h8 with an edge for Black!) 25 ♖xg6+ hxg6 26 ♕xg6+ ♗g7 27 ♕e6+ ♔h7 28 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 29 ♖g1+ ♔h7 30 ♕g6+ ♔h8 31 ♕h6+ and mates.

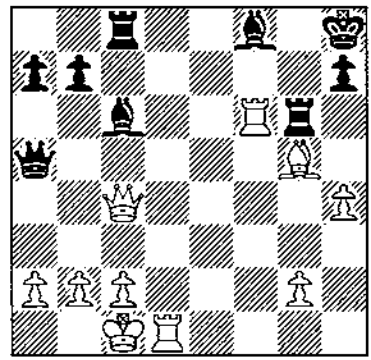
18...fxe6 19 ♖xe6+

19 ♕c4?? is not good, because after 19...♗d7 20 ♖xe6+ ♗e7 21 ♖xd7 ♔xd7 22 ♕g4 ♖xg5 23 hxg5 f5 24 ♕e2 ♗xg5+ Black is up a bishop.

19...♔f7 20 ♖xf6+

After 20 ♕c4 ♔g7 21 ♗xf6+ ♖xf6 22 ♖xf6 ♕c5 23 ♕g4+ ♔xf6 24 ♕xc8 ♗xg2 25 ♕g4 it seems to us that any result might occur.

20...♔g8 21 ♕c4+ ♔h8



22 ♖xg6

The more aggressive 22 ♕e6 ♕c7 23 ♖xg6 hxg6 24 ♕xg6 ♗g7 25 ♗h6 ♖g8 26 ♗xg7+ ♕xg7 27 ♕h5+ ♕h7 28 ♕e5+ leads to a draw.

22...hxg6 23 ♗f6+ ♗g7 24 ♕f7 ♗xf6 25 ♕xf6+ ♔h7 26 ♕e7+ ♔h8 ½-½

26...♔h6 leads to a draw too, says Tseshkovsky: 27 ♕e3+ ♔h5 28 g4+ ♔xh4 29 ♕h6+ ♔g3 30 ♕e3+ ♔h4 (30...♔xg4?? allows White to push the black king into a mating net with 31 ♖d4+ ♔h5 32 ♕h3+ ♔g5 33 ♕h4+ ♔f5 34 ♕f4+ ♔e6 35 ♖d6+ ♔e7 36 ♕f6+ ♔e8 37 ♖e6+ ♔d7 38 ♕c7 and mate) 31 ♕h6+ and White must repeat.

Game 41
P.Svidler-R.Sherbakov
Russian Championship, Krasnoyarsk 2003

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗g5 ♗d7 7 ♕d2 ♖c8 8 f4 ♘xd4 9 ♕xd4 ♕a5 10 e5 dxe5 11 fxe5 e6 12 0-0-0 ♗c6 13 ♘b5 ♗xb5 14 exf6 ♗c6 15 h4 g6 16 ♗c4 ♕c5?

Taking away the c5-square from Black's bishop and creating a traffic jam in his camp. Better is 16...♗c5 17 ♕g4 h5 18 ♕e2 0-0 19 ♖hf1 ♗b4 with chances for both sides, V.Sukula-T.Abergel, Meurthe et Moselle 2007.

17 ♕d3

Instead 17 ♗xe6 ♕xd4 18 ♗xc8 ♕d6 19 ♖he1+ ♔d8 20 ♖xd6+ ♗xd6 21 ♗h3 wins a pawn, but in the ending the f6-pawn will remain a target, so a win is not certain.

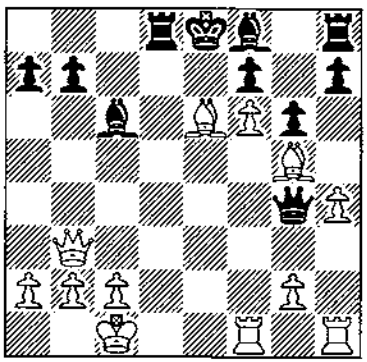
17...♕f5

Other continuations don't help: 17...b5 18 ♗b3 ♕f5 19 ♗xe6 fxe6 20 f7+ ♔xf7 21 ♖hf1 and White wins material; or 17...♗a4 18 ♗b3 ♗b5 19 ♕d2 h5 20 ♖he1 ♕f5 21 ♖f1 ♕xf1 22 ♖xf1 ♗xf1 23 ♗xe6 fxe6 24 f7+ ♔xf7 25 ♕d7+ and wins.

18 ♕b3! ♖d8

White wins immediately after 18...♗xg2?? 19 ♖hf1 ♗xf1 20 ♕xb7.

19 ♖df1 ♕g4 20 ♗xe6!



This is a dynamic way to destroy the blockade of the f-pawn.

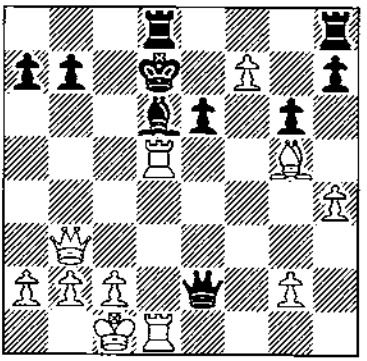
20...fxe6

Neither is Black saved by 20...♕xe6 21 ♖e1 ♗e4 22 ♕a4+ b5 23 ♕xb5+ ♖d7 24 ♕a4 and it's game over.

21 ♖f4 ♕e2 22 f7+ ♔d7 23 ♖d4+ ♗d6 24 ♖hd1 ♗d5

24...♔c7 25 ♗xd8+ ♖xd8 26 ♖xd6 ♖xd6 27 ♖xd6 ♕f1+ 28 ♖d1 ♕xf7 29 ♕e3 is just as bad, according to Svidler.

25 ♖xd5!



The final nail in the coffin.

25...exd5 26 ♕xb7+ 1-0

Svidler indicates 26...♗c7 27 ♖xd5+ ♔e6 28 ♕c6+ ♗d6 29 ♖xd6+ ♖xd6 30 ♕e8+ and wins.

Game 42
R.Kasimdzhanov-P.Van der Sterren
German League 2001

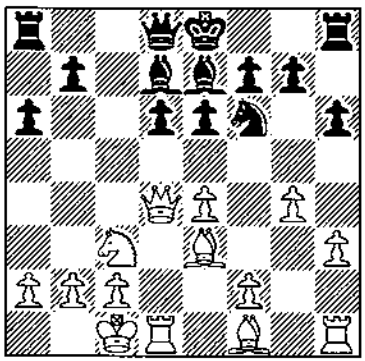
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘c6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 g4 h6 7 ♗e3 ♘f6 8 h3

The more aggressive 8 ♖g1 ♗e7 9 h4 d5 10 ♗b5 ♗d7 11 exd5 ♘xd5 12 ♘xd5 exd5 13 g5 hxg5 14 hxg5 was slightly better for White in S.Movsesian-A.Maksimenko, Chalkidiki 2002.

8...♗e7 9 ♕d2 a6 10 0-0-0 ♘xd4 11

♕xd4 ♗d7

Black might do better with 11...e5: for example, 12 ♕d2 ♗e6 13 f4 ♕a5 14 a3 exf4 15 ♗xf4 ♖d8 16 ♗g2 ♘d7 17 ♔b1 ♘e5 18 ♘d5 ♕xd2 19 ♗xd2 ♗xd5 20 exd5 and the strong central knight maintained equality in A.Rogic-Z.Kozul. Austrian League 2005.



12 f4 ♗c6 13 ♖g1

Kasimdzhanov doesn't like 13 g5? hxg5 14 fxg5 e5 15 ♕d3 ♘g4. We continue his line as follows: 16 ♖g1 ♘xe3 17 ♕xe3 ♖h5 18 g6 ♗g5 19 gxf7+ ♔xf7 20 ♖xg5 ♕xg5 21 ♕xg5 ♖xg5 22 ♖xd6 and Black has good chances to win this ending.

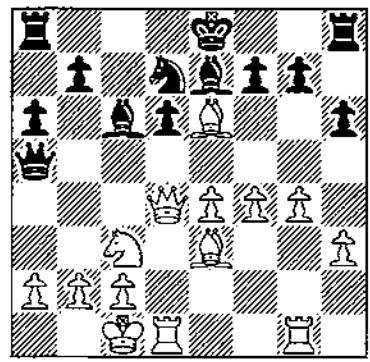
13...♘d7

It's too dangerous for Black to castle kingside, because after 13...0-0 14 g5 hxg5 15 fxg5 ♘d7 16 g6 ♘e5 17 gxf7+ ♖xf7 18 ♗e2 ♖c8 19 ♗h5 White will get a tremendous attack.

14 ♗c4 ♕a5

According to Kasimdzhanov, 14...b5 is losing after 15 ♗xe6 fxe6 16 ♕xg7 ♖f8 (it would not help to try 16...♗f6 17 ♕g6+ ♔e7 18 e5 ♘xe5 19 fxe5 ♗xe5 20 ♗xh6 ♕g8 21 ♕g5+ ♕xg5+ 22 ♗xg5+ ♔d7 23 h4 and one extra pawn with two passed pawns should give White good winning chances) 17 ♕g6+ ♖f7 18 ♕xe6 and Black's various problem pieces give White more than enough compensation for the bishop.

15 ♗xe6!



A piece sacrifice which opens Black's king to a deadly attack. Instead the seemingly aggressive 15 f5 weakens the dark squares and gives Black a chance to get a small initiative, such as with 15...♗f6 16 ♕xd6 0-0-0 17 ♕d2 ♕b4 18 ♗d3 ♘e5 19 a3 ♕a5 20 ♖gf1 ♘c4 21 ♗xc4 ♖xd2 22 ♗xd2 ♕e5.

15...fxe6 16 ♕xg7 ♗f6!

Another possibility with 16...♖f8 17 ♕g6+ ♖f7 18 ♕xe6 ♘f8 would have saved the king, but not for long. Here 19 ♕b3 (best, since 19 ♕xh6? ♖h7 traps the queen) 19...♘d7 20 ♘d5 looks good, but this position is so complicated that even a computer can get lost. We believe, though, that White's activity and pair of passed pawn should be enough for a win: for instance, 20...♖c8 21 g5 ♗a4 22 ♕a3 ♖xc2+ 23 ♔b1 ♖c4 24 ♖c1 ♖xc1+ 25 ♔xc1 ♗d8 26 g6 ♖g7 27 ♕xd6

♕b5 28 ♕e6+ ♔f8 29 ♕f5+ ♔g8 30 b3 ♕c6+ 31 ♔b1 ♗b5 32 ♗d4 ♗d3+ 33 ♔a1 and White's attack should be enough.

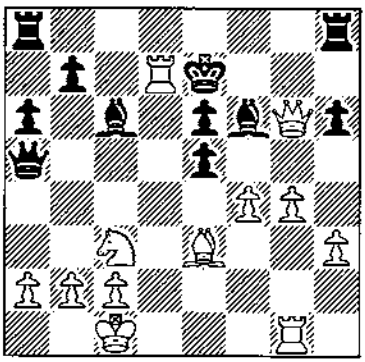
17 ♕g6+ ♔e7 18 e5

This is a decoy sacrifice to open the d-file and prepare the next coup.

18...dxe5?

We agree with Kasimdzhanov that 18...♘xe5 was the only way to save Black's position. He gives the following variations: 19 fxe5 ♕xe5 20 ♗d2 (alternatively, 20 ♖ge1 ♗h4 is equal, while 20 ♕d3 ♕xe3+ 21 ♕xe3 ♗g5 22 ♖ge1 leads to a level endgame) 20...♖ag8 21 ♕d3 ♗b5 22 ♕f3 ♗c6 and now 23 ♕d3 repeats, but in our opinion 23 ♕f2!? could perhaps help to light a fire around the black monarch.

19 ♖xd7+!



And now an elimination sac, with decoy ideas added. Rudolf Spielmann would have loved this game, as he could have displayed his entire sacrificial nomenclature!

19...♔xd7

19...♗xd7 20 ♘e4 ♖af8 21 ♗c5+ ♔d8 22 ♗xf8 ♖xf8 23 ♘xf6 ♕xa2 24 ♕g7 is winning for White.

20 ♖d1+ ♔e7

If 20...♔c7, then 21 ♕f7+ ♔b8 22 ♕xf6 ♖e8 23 fxe5 ♔c7 24 ♕g7+ ♔b8 25 ♖d6 ♕c7 26 ♕xh6 and the active white pieces and two passed pawns are enough for a win.

21 g5 ♖hf8 22 ♕h7+ ♖f7

According to Kasimdzhanov, after 22...♗g7 23 ♕xg7+ ♖f7 24 ♕xh6 exf4 25 g6 fxe3 26 ♕h4+! ♖f6 27 ♕h7+ Black can't stop the passed g-pawn.

23 gxf6+ ♔xf6 24 ♕xh6+ ♔e7 25 f5! 1-0

This diversionary sacrifice crowns a fine effort. White wins in all variations: for instance, 25...♖xf5 (or 25...exf5 26 ♕d6+ ♔e8 27 ♕e6+ ♔f8 28 ♗h6+ ♔g8 29 ♖g1+ ♔h8 30 ♕xf7) 26 ♕g7+ ♔e8 27 ♘e4 ♕b4 28 ♗c5 and it's all over.

Game 43
I.Cervenka-A.Schneider
USSR 1974

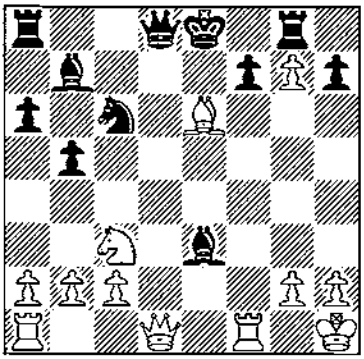
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 0-0 ♗e7 9 f4 ♗b7 10 e5 dxe5 11 fxe5 ♗c5 12 ♗e3 ♘c6

Tony Kosten prefers 12...♗xd4 in his *Easy Guide to the Najdorf*, and this move would avoid the following headaches for Black.

13 exf6 ♗xd4 14 fxg7?!

Better is 14 ♕e2 ♗xe3+ (14...♗xf6 15 ♖ad1 ♕c7 16 ♖xf6 gxf6 17 ♘e4 is too dangerous for Black's king) 15 ♕xe3 ♕d4 16 ♖ae1 gxf6 17 ♘e4 0-0-0 18 ♖xf6 ♕xe3+ 19 ♖xe3, which gave White a slight advantage in the game N.De

Firmian-M.Carlsen, Copenhagen 2004.
14...♗xe3+ 15 ♔h1 ♖g8 16 ♗xe6?



We believe that the simple 16 ♕f3 ♖xg7 17 ♕xe3 gives chances to both sides in this complicated position, which holds perils for both kings.
16...♖xg7

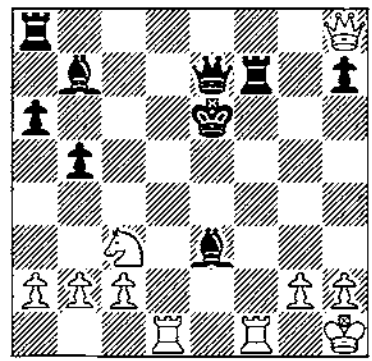
16...fxe6 leads to complicated variations, but should be enough to win: for example, 17 ♕h5+ ♔d7 18 ♖ad1+ ♗d4 19 ♘e2 ♕e8 20 ♖f7+ ♔c8 21 ♘xd4 ♖xg7 22 ♘f5 ♖xf7 23 ♘d6+ ♔d7 24 ♘xe8+ ♔xe8 25 ♖d7 ♔xd7 26 ♕xf7+ ♘e7 and Black's three pieces should win.
17 ♗xf7+

17 ♕h5 looks very aggressive, but Black will keep an extra piece after 17...♘e5! 18 ♗d5 ♖g5 19 ♕d1 ♗xd5 20 ♘xd5 ♘g4 21 ♘xe3 ♘xe3 22 ♖e1 ♕xd1 23 ♖axd1 ♖e5.
17...♖xf7 18 ♕h5 ♘e5

Instead 18...♕d7! 19 ♖ae1 ♔f8 20 ♖xf7+ ♕xf7 21 ♕xf7+ ♔xf7 22 ♖xe3 was an easier way to win.
19 ♕xe5+ ♕e7! 20 ♕h8+?

Better was 20 ♕h5, but the accurate 20...♔f8 21 ♕xh7 ♗d4 22 ♖ae1 ♗g7 still leaves White with almost no chances for survival.
20...♔d7 21 ♖ad1+

According to Florian, 21 ♖xf7 is losing after 21...♕xf7 22 ♕e5 ♗xg2+! 23 ♔xg2 ♖g8+.
21...♔e6! 0-1

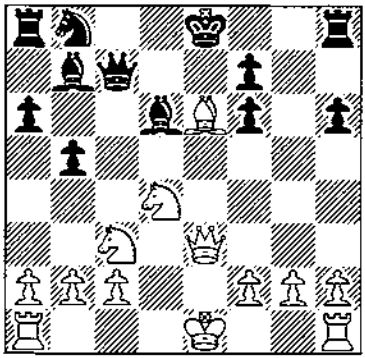


Black's king is safe enough and 22 ♖fe1 ♕g5 leaves White facing a bunch of deadly threats.

Game 44
D.Stellwagen-A.Naiditsch
Wijk aan Zee 2003

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 ♗g5 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♕c7 10 e5 ♗b7 11 exd6 ♗xd6 12 ♕e3 h6?!

The unclear queen sacrifice 12...♗c5 13 0-0-0 ♘c6 14 ♕xe6+!? fxe6 15 ♘xe6 was played in V.Ivanchuk-S.Karjakin, Nice (rapid) 2008. Ivanchuk won this game, but we believe that after 15...♕e7 16 ♖he1 ♕xe6 17 ♖xe6+ ♘e7 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♖xf6 ♖f8 20 ♖xf8+ ♔xf8 21 f3 ♖e8 Black is the one trying to win.
13 ♗xf6 gxf6 14 ♗xe6!

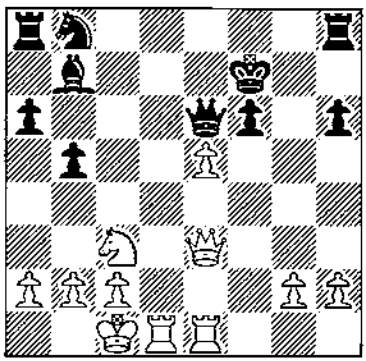


White opens up the black king, placing a bone in the throat on e6 while preparing to destroy Black with two rooks in the centre.

14...fxe6 15 ♘xe6 ♕e7 16 0-0-0 ♔f7 17 ♖he1 ♗e5

It looks like Black has defended himself, but now White throws more wood on to the fire.

18 f4! ♕xe6 19 fxe5



19...♕xe5

According to *Fritz*, after 19...fxe5 Black is better, but 20 ♕g3 ♖g8 21 ♖f1+ ♔e8 22 ♖f6 ♕xf6 23 ♕xg8+ ♔e7 24 ♔b1 b4 25 ♘a4 e4 26 ♘b6 e3 27 ♕h7+ ♕f7 28 ♕xh6 destroys all illusions of survival.

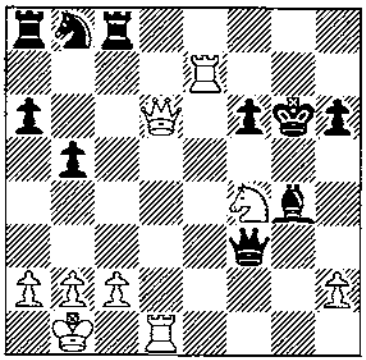
20 ♕b6 ♕f4+ 21 ♔b1 ♗c6 22 g3 ♕f5 23 ♕c7+ ♗d7

The extra piece can't compensate for Black's lack of development. After 23...♔g6 24 ♘e2 h5 25 ♘f4+ ♔h6 26 ♖d6 ♖h7 27 ♖e7 ♖xe7 28 ♕xe7 ♘d7 29 ♖xc6 Black's position is helpless.

24 g4

24 ♖f1 ♕e6 25 ♘d5 ♖c8 26 ♕b7 ♕e2 27 ♘c3 ♕e7 28 ♘e4 ♖c6 29 ♖fe1 ♖e6 30 ♕xa8 was another way to win.

24...♕f3 25 ♘d5 ♖c8 26 ♕d6 ♗xg4 27 ♖e7+ ♔g6 28 ♘f4+



28...♕xf4

Black's king is in a mating net. After 28...♔g5 29 ♖g7+ ♔f5 30 ♕e6+ ♔xf4 31 ♖d4+ the next move will be checkmate.

29 ♕xf4 ♗xd1 30 ♕e4+ 1-0

It's forced mate: 30...f5 31 ♖e6+ ♔g5 32 h4+ ♔h5 33 ♕f4 ♗xc2+ 34 ♔a1 ♖c6 35 ♖xh6+ ♖xh6 36 ♕g5 and mate.

Game 45
A.Fernandez-Y.Quezada
Santa Clara 2006

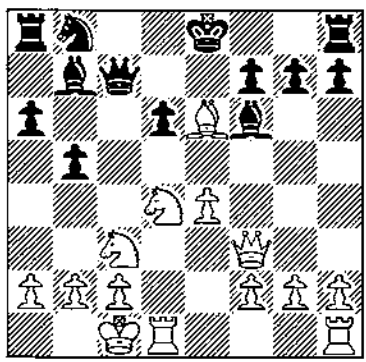
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6

5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 ♗g5 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♕c7 10 ♗xf6!? ♗xf6 11 0-0-0 ♗b7?!

Better was 11...0-0 12 e5 ♗xe5 13 ♕xa8 ♗xd4 14 ♖xd4 ♘c6 15 ♖d2 ♗b7 16 ♘xb5 axb5 17 ♕a3 b4 18 ♕a4 ♕b6 with enough compensation for the exchange in V.Bologan-A.Shomoev, Dresden 2007.

12 ♗xe6!!

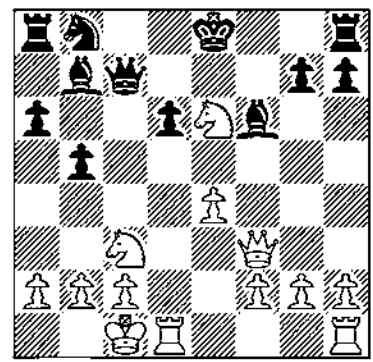
After this move a deluge of white pieces descends on the black king's head. Also very promising was 12 ♘dxb5! axb5 13 ♘xb5 ♕c6 14 ♘xd6+ ♔e7 15 ♕g3 ♘d7 16 f4 ♘c5 (or 16...♔f8 17 e5 ♗e7 18 f5 ♘c5 19 fxe6 ♗xd6 20 exd6 fxe6 21 ♗c4 ♘e4 22 ♖hf1+ ♘f6 23 ♕h4 with a killing attack after 23...♔f7 24 ♕h5+ g6 25 ♕e5) 17 e5 ♘xb3+ 18 ♕xb3 ♖hb8 19 exf6+ gxf6 20 ♕b4 ♗a6 21 ♘f5+ and Black was checkmated in A.Volokitin-P.Harikrishna, Cap d' Agde (rapid) 2006. Which approach is the better of the two, though? I'm afraid that the reader must decide – it's too hard for us!



12...fxe6

12...♗xd4!? would evade the immediate onslaught, but the prospect of defending his weak d-pawn after 13 ♘d5 ♗xd5 14 ♗xd5 ♗xb2+ 15 ♔xb2 ♖a7 16 ♗b3 0-0 17 ♖d5 b4 18 ♖hd1 a5 19 ♗a4 ♖a6 20 ♕g3 would have been quite cheerless for Black. Note the disparity in effectiveness between the minor pieces here.

13 ♘xe6



13...♕c4

The alternatives call forth what Dr. Tartakower would call a 'spectrum analysis':

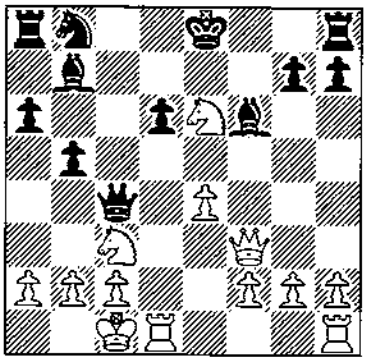
a) 13...♕e7 14 ♘d5 ♗xd5 15 exd5 ♘c6 16 ♕h3 ♘d8 17 ♖he1 ♔f7 18 ♘xg7 ♗xb2+ 19 ♔b1 ♗e5 20 ♘h5 ♔e8 21 f4 ♘f7 22 fxe5 ♘xe5 23 ♘f4 ♖g8 24 ♘d3 is winning for White.

b) 13...♕f7 14 ♖xd6 ♘c6 15 ♘d5 ♖c8 16 ♘xf6+ gxf6 17 ♖hd1 ♖g8 18 ♕h3 ♖b8 19 ♕f5 ♕e7 20 ♖d7 ♕xd7 21 ♖xd7 ♔xd7 22 ♘c5+ ♔c7 23 ♕xh7+ ♔b6 24 ♘d7+ ♔a7 25 ♘xb8 ♖xb8 26 ♕f7 and White's passed pawns will snuff out all resistance.

c) 13...♕d7 14 ♘d5 ♗xd5 15 ♕h5+ g6 16 ♕xd5 ♘c6 17 e5! ♗xe5 18 f4 ♗f6 19 ♖he1 ♗e7 20 f5 gxf5 21 ♕xf5 ♕c8 22

♘g7+ ♔d8 23 ♕c5 h5 24 ♖xe7 ♔xe7 25 ♕xd6+ ♔f7 26 ♖f1+ ♔g8 27 ♕d5+ is mating.

d) 13...♕c6 should be better for White after 14 ♘d5 ♘d7 15 ♘ec7+ ♔f7 16 ♘xa8 ♗xa8 17 ♕h3 ♘b6 18 ♘xf6 gxf6 19 ♕h5+ ♔g7 20 ♖he1.



14 ♖xd6 b4

After 14...♔e7 15 ♕g3 b4 16 ♘xg7 ♗xg7 17 ♖b6 ♗xc3 18 ♕d6+ ♔e8 19 ♖xb7 ♕xe4 20 ♕c7 ♕e6 21 ♖xb8+ ♖xb8 22 ♕xb8+ ♔f7 23 ♕c7+ ♕e7 24 ♕xe7+ ♔xe7 25 bxc3 bxc3 White is winning.

15 ♕g3! g6

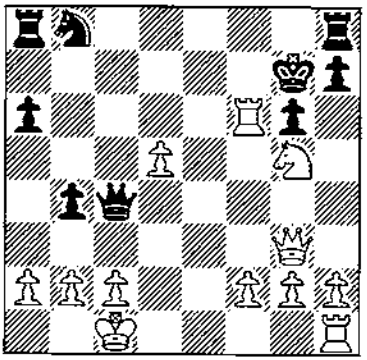
15...bxc3? 16 ♘xg7+ ♔f7 17 ♖xf6+ ♔xf6 18 ♘h5+ ♔e6 19 ♖d1 cxb2+ 20 ♔b1 ♗d5 21 ♖xd5 ♕f1+ 22 ♔xb2 is hopeless for Black.

16 ♘d5 ♗xd5 17 exd5 ♔f7 18 ♘g5+ ♔g7

Or 18...♗xg5+ 19 ♕xg5 ♖c8 20 ♕f6+ ♔g8 21 ♖d8+ ♖xd8 22 ♕xd8+ ♔f7 23 ♖e1 ♕f4+ 24 ♖e3 ♔g7 25 ♕e7+ ♕f7 26 ♕d6 ♕xf2 27 ♕c7+ ♔h6 28 ♖h3+ ♔g5 29 ♕e5+, which also wins for White.

19 ♖xf6!

Luring the enemy king forward into White's clutches.



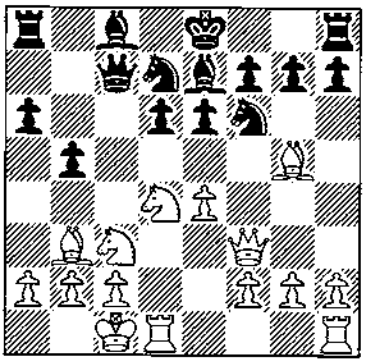
19...♔xf6 20 h4

20 ♖e1 ♕xd5 21 ♕f4+ ♕f5 22 ♖e6+ ♔g7 23 ♖e7+ ♔f8 24 ♖f7+ also won.

20...♕xd5 21 ♖d1 ♕xd1+ 22 ♔xd1 ♖d8+ 23 ♔c1 ♔e7 24 ♕g4 ♖d6 25 ♕e4+ 1-0

Game 46
L.Nisipeanu-R.Ruck
Croatian Team Championship 2006

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 ♗g5 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♕c7 10 0-0-0 ♘bd7



11 ♗xf6

The wild complications after 11 e5 ♗b7 12 ♕g3 ♘xe5 13 ♗xe6 fxe6 14 f4 ♔f7 (14...♘g6 15 ♘xe6 ♕d7 16 ♖he1 ♔f7 17 f5 ♘f8 18 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 19 ♖xd6 ♕c8 20 ♘g5+ ♔g8 21 ♖xf6 gxf6 22 ♘ge4+ ♘g6 23 fxg6 forced Black to resign in L.Christiansen-A.Wojtkiewicz, U.S. Championship, San Diego 2006) 15 fxe5 dxe5 16 ♘xe6 ♔xe6 17 ♕h3+ ♔f7 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♖d7 ♕c6 20 ♖hd1 ♖ad8 21 ♕h5+ ♔e6 22 ♕h3+ ♔f7 23 ♕h5+ ♔e6 led to a draw in the earlier game L.Nisipeanu-S.Karjakin, Foros 2006.

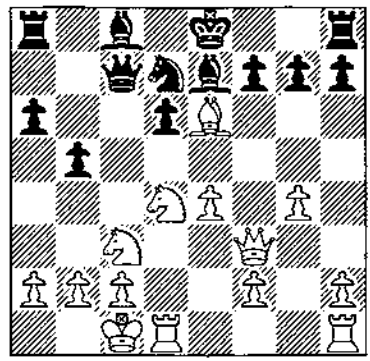
11...♘xf6

According to Nisipeanu, 11...♗xf6 can get Black into big trouble after 12 ♗xe6 fxe6 13 ♘xe6 ♕c6 14 ♘d5 ♔f7 15 ♘g5+ ♔e8 (15...♔f8 doesn't help because 16 ♕h5 g6 17 ♕h6+ ♔g8 18 ♘xh7! ♖xh7 19 ♕xg6+ ♔h8 20 ♘xf6 ♘xf6 21 ♕xf6+ ♖g7 22 ♖xd6 will soon finish off the black king) 16 ♕h5+ g6 17 ♕g4 and White's mating net will soon force resignation.

12 g4 ♘d7

In the later game Y.Vovk-S.Tolontegin, Tashkent 2008, after 12...0-0 13 g5 ♘d7 14 g6 ♘c5 15 gxh7+ ♔h8 16 ♖hg1 ♗b7 17 a3 ♘xb3+ 18 cxb3 b4 19 ♖xg7! ♗xe4 20 ♕xe4 ♔xg7 21 h8♕+ ♔xh8 22 ♖d3 White got a better position, but 22 ♕g4! would have been a more precise way to finish. However, we believe Nisipeanu is right that 12...b4! 13 ♘ce2 ♗b7 14 ♘g3 d5 15 exd5 ♗xd5 16 ♗xd5 ♘xd5 17 ♘df5 0-0 gives Black a slight edge.

13 ♗xe6!



At first glance, this looks like a simple case of 'three pawns and a check', but in fact it is much deeper.

13...♘e5

13...fxe6 is losing after 14 ♘xe6 ♕c4 15 ♘xg7+ ♔d8 16 e5 ♖b8 17 exd6 ♗g5+ 18 ♔b1 ♖g8 19 ♖d4 ♘e5 20 ♕e4 ♕f7 21 d7 ♕xg7 22 dxc8♕+ ♔xc8 23 f4 ♗xf4 24 ♕xf4 and Black is down two pawns.

14 ♘d5 ♕c5 15 ♗xf7+

The best choice, whereas the aggressive 15 ♕f5 leaves White down material after 15...g6 16 b4 ♕a7 17 ♘c6 ♗xe6 18 ♘xa7 gxf5 19 ♘c7+ ♔d7 20 ♘xa8 ♖xa8 21 exf5 ♗c4 22 ♖he1 ♗g5+ 23 ♔b1 ♘f3 24 ♖e4 ♖xa7.

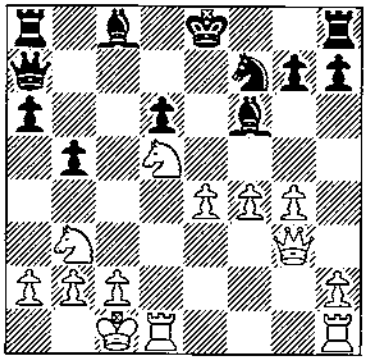
15...♘xf7 16 ♕g3 ♗f6

Another interesting move was 16...♗d8, but it's unclear if Black's extra piece is enough to stem White's activity: for example, 17 f4 ♕c4 18 ♔b1 0-0 19 g5 g6 20 h4 ♖e8 21 h5 ♖xe4 22 hxg6 hxg6 23 ♘f6+ ♗xf6 24 gxf6 g5 25 ♕h2 ♗b7 26 ♕h7+ ♔f8 27 ♘f5 ♕e6 28 ♕g7+ ♔e8 29 ♘xd6+ gives White a win.

17 ♘b3 ♕a7 18 f4

The result of the sacrifice is two pawns, a pawn roller, and the d5-

square in exchange for a piece. This position is unclear and looks very dangerous for both sides. The knight in the middle is key to White's chances, since it will lead his attack.



18...0-0

Probably 18...♗e6 was better, with the idea to eliminate the main white attacker and so help Black to defend his king.

19 ♘xf6+?!

White's willingness to give up his most active piece will give Black better chances to protect the king. The easier way to achieve an advantage was 19 g5! ♗d8 20 g6 hxg6 21 ♕xg6 ♕d7 22 ♖hg1 ♘h8 23 ♕h6 ♖f7 24 ♘d4 ♗b7 25 ♘f5 ♗xd5 26 ♖xd5 ♗b6 27 ♖g2 ♗c5 28 ♘xg7 ♖xg7 29 ♖h5 ♗e3+ 30 ♔b1 ♘g6 31 ♖xg6 ♗d4 32 e5 and White's attack is unstoppable.

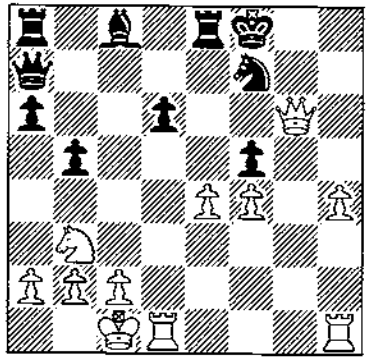
19...gxf6 20 h4 ♖e8

The more natural move 20...♗b7! gives Black a lot of counterplay: for example, 21 ♖he1 ♖ae8 22 ♖d4 ♔h8 23 g5 ♖g8 24 ♕c3 ♗a8 25 gxf6 ♕d7 with chances for both sides.

21 g5 f5 22 g6!

White begins to peel away the black king's guardians.

22...hxg6 23 ♕xg6+ ♔f8



24 exf5

Even more precise was 24 ♘d4! ♖xe4 25 ♖hg1 ♖xd4 26 ♕g7+ ♔e7 27 ♖xd4.

24...♕e3+ 25 ♔b1 ♕xf4 26 ♘d4 ♖e4

The attempt to swap queens by 26...♕h6 doesn't end Black's trouble after 27 h5 ♖e4 28 ♖hf1 ♖a7 29 ♘c6 ♖d7 30 f6 ♖e8 31 ♘e7 ♕h8 32 h6 ♘e5 33 f7 ♖ed8 34 ♕g8+ ♔xe7 35 h7 ♗b7 36 f8♕+ ♖xf8 37 ♖xf8 and White wins.

27 ♖hg1

According to Nisipeanu, 27 ♘e6+! ♗xe6 28 fxe6 ♘e5 29 e7+ ♔xe7 30 ♕xd6+ ♔e8 31 ♕e6+ ♔f8 32 ♖hg1 ♘f7 33 ♕g6 was a another way to finish.

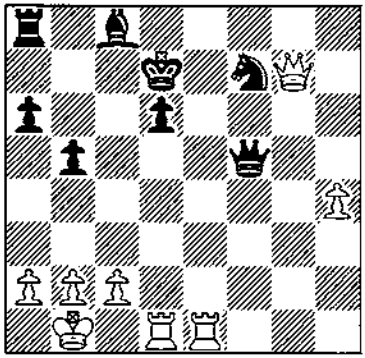
27...♖xd4 28 ♕g7+?

A better way to end the story was 28 ♖xd4! ♕xd4 29 f6 ♔e8 30 ♖e1+ ♗e6 31 ♖xe6+ ♔d7 32 ♕xf7+ ♔c6 33 ♖c1 and White's f-pawn concludes proceedings.

28...♔e7 29 ♖xd4 ♕xf5??

We believe the only attempt to defend was 29...♕e5!.

30 ♖e1+ ♔d7 31 ♖dd1!



This move wins knight or bishop and makes Black's position hopeless.

31...♕h5

Fruitless was 31...♗b7 32 ♖f1 ♗f3 33 ♖d3 ♖e8 34 b3 ♖e2 35 a3 ♕c5 36 ♖c3 ♕h5 37 ♖fxf3, winning a piece.

32 ♖f1 ♔e8 33 ♖de1+ 1-0

The knight is lost.

Game 47
A.Fedorov-M.Kobalija
Russia 1998

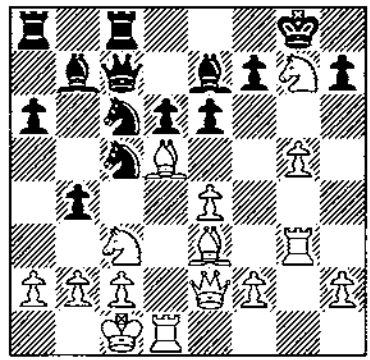
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 ♘c6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 a6 8 ♕e2 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♗e7 10 ♗b3 0-0 11 ♖hg1 ♘d7 12 g4 ♘c5 13 ♘f5 b5

Of course, 13...♘xb3+ 14 axb3 exf5 15 gxf5 gives White a strong attack.

14 ♗d5 ♗b7 15 g5 ♖fc8 16 ♖g3 b4

After 16...♗f8 17 ♕h5 g6 18 ♘h6+ ♔h8 19 ♕h4 b4 20 ♖h3 bxc3 21 ♘g4 f5 22 ♘f6 h6 23 ♕xh6+ the game finished with perpetual check in I.Sofronie-A.Istratescu, Sovata 1998.

17 ♘xg7!?



The aim of this kingside sacrifice is to checkmate Black somewhere along the h-file. White plays like Tal: he brings his forces to the centre to give them away on the flank. Instead after 17 ♖h3 g6 18 ♗xc6 ♗xc6 19 ♘h6+ ♔g7 20 ♕f3 ♗e8 21 ♘g4 bxc3 22 ♘f6 ♗xf6 23 gxf6+ ♔g8 24 b3 ♕a5 25 ♔b1 ♘xb3 26 axb3 ♖ab8 Black could have developed a winning attack in the earlier game M.Kobalija-E.Prokopchuk, Kolontaevo 1997.

A word of warning: if the reader finds the following analysis too hard to follow, the game can still be appreciated for its flamboyance!

17...♔xg7

17...bxc3 could lead to a very complicated game (co-author's note: my partner has a gift for understatement!) with chances for both sides: for example, 18 ♕h5! cxb2+ 19 ♔b1 ♗f8 20 ♘f5 and then:

a) 20...exd5? 21 ♖h3 f6 22 gxf6 ♘e6 23 ♖g1+ ♗g7 24 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 25 fxg7+ and White wins.

b) 20...♗g7 21 ♗xc5 dxc5 (or 21...♘d8 22 ♖h3 exf5 23 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 24

exf5 ♕xc5 25 f6 ♕xc2+ 26 ♕xc2 ♖xc2 27 ♔xc2 with an exchange to the good) 22 ♘xg7 ♔xg7 23 ♕h6+ ♔g8 24 g6 hxg6 25 ♖xg6+ fxg6 26 ♗xe6+ ♕f7 27 ♕xg6+ and mates.

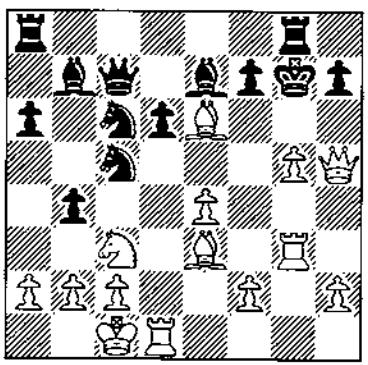
c) 20...♘a4 21 g6 ♘c3+ 22 ♔xb2 ♘xd1+ 23 ♔c1 fxg6 24 ♗xe6+ ♔h8 25 ♖xg6 ♗g7 26 ♖xg7 ♕xg7 27 ♘xg7 ♘xe3 28 fxe3 ♖c7 29 ♘f5 gives White a winning position.

However, in this fascinating variation we can find many other crazy lines; some good for White, others for Black.

18 ♕h5 ♖g8

Fedorov considers that 18...♖h8 loses after 19 ♗xc5 dxc5 20 ♕h6+ ♔g8 21 g6. Meanwhile we believe that 18...bxc3 doesn't stop White's mating attack in view of the line 19 ♕h6+ ♔g8 20 g6 cxb2+ 21 ♔b1 fxg6 22 ♖xg6+ ♔f7 23 ♖g7+ ♔e8 24 ♗xc5.

19 ♗xe6!



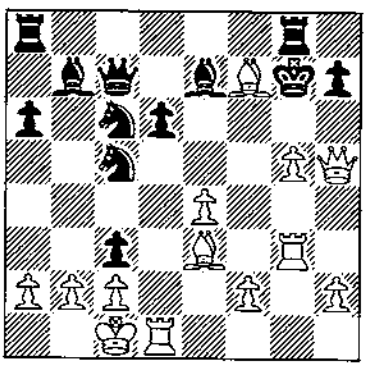
A multi-purpose sacrifice, targeting the squares e6 or g6 according to Black's choice.

19...bxc3?

The superior 19...♘xe6! 20 ♘d5 ♕d8 21 f4 ♔h8 22 ♕xf7 ♗c8 23 f5 ♘xg5 (23...♖g7, *Rybka*'s choice, may cast doubt on the correctness of White's play: 24 ♕h5 ♗xg5 25 fxe6 ♗xe3+ 26 ♘xe3 ♖xg3 27 hxg3 ♗xe6 28 ♕h6 ♕e7 29 ♖xd6 ♘d8 looks better for Black) 24 ♕h5 ♘xe4 25 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 26 ♕g4+ ♗g5 27 ♕xe4 ♔h8 28 f6 creates an unclear position.

However, the weaker 19...fxe6? 20 g6!! peels away the last remnants of resistance.

20 ♗xf7!



20...♕a5

After 20...cxb2+ 21 ♔b1 ♘xe4 22 g6 ♘c3+ 23 ♔xb2 ♘xd1+ 24 ♔c1 Black is cooked.

21 ♖h3 ♔f8 22 ♖f3 ♘e5 23 ♗d5+ ♔g7 24 ♖f7+! 1-0

Fedorov gives 24...♘xf7 25 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 26 ♗d4+ followed by mate.

Game 48
A.Matsukevich-A.Vooremaa
USSR 1968

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6

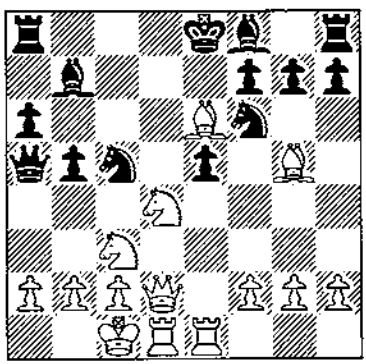
5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 ♘bd7 7 ♗c4 ♕a5 8 ♕d2 e6 9 0-0-0 b5 10 ♗b3 ♗b7 11 ♖he1 ♘c5 12 e5?!

12 ♗xf6!? was a better and safer choice because after 12...gxf6 13 ♕f4 White will be able to probe the weak black pawns.

12...dxe5 13 ♗xe6?

Here White wins an amazing game with this typical ♗xe6 sacrifice. However, we believe that this version is incorrect, even though it gives Black a big headache. Indeed, by the end poor Vooremaa was so bewildered he lost in prosaic fashion.

Instead the better try 13 ♖xe5 gives chances for both sides: for example, 13...♗xg2 14 ♘xe6 fxe6 15 ♗xf6 ♕c7 16 ♗d5 gxf6 17 ♗xg2 ♕xe5 18 ♗xa8 leads to an unclear mess.



13...fxe6?

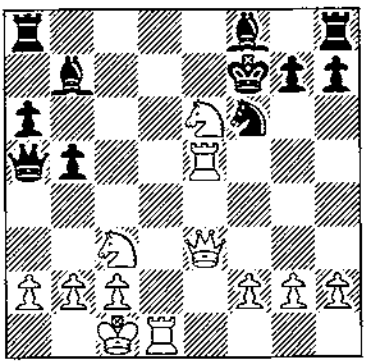
After 13...b4!! White can't defend three pieces at the same time: 14 ♖xe5 fxe6! leads to a complicated win after 15 ♕e3 bxc3 16 ♘xe6 ♔f7 17 ♗xf6 ♕xa2 18 ♘d8+ ♔g8 19 ♕xc3 ♖c8 20 ♖e8 ♘b3+ and White loses too much material. However, here Black must avoid 14...bxc3? 15 ♗c4+ ♗e7 16 ♖xe7+! ♔xe7 17 ♘f5+ ♔e8 18 ♕d6 which led to mate in A.Krzyzanowski-M.Sukiennik, Poland 1993.

14 ♘xe6 ♘cd7

14...♘xe6 would give chances for both sides: for example, 15 ♗xf6 ♗c6 16 ♗xe5 ♔f7 17 ♕d3 ♖e8 18 ♕f5+ ♔g8 19 ♗d6 ♗xd6 20 ♖xd6 ♘f8 21 ♖xe8 when we feel that White has sufficient play for the piece.

15 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 16 ♖xe5 ♔f7 17 ♕e3

17 ♘xf8!? ♖hxf8 18 ♖e7+ ♔xe7 19 ♘d5+ ♘xd5 20 ♕xa5 ♖ad8 should finish as a draw.



17...h6

This looks feeble, but the alternatives may be even worse: for instance, 17...♔g8 18 ♘xg7! (this is even stronger than 18 ♖f5 ♖e8 19 ♖xf6 gxf6 20 ♖d7 ♖c7) 18...♘g4 (or 18...♗xg7 19 ♖e7) 19 ♕g5 ♘xe5 20 ♘h5+ ♘g6 21 ♖d7 and wins.

18 ♘xf8 ♖hxf8

18...♔xf8 19 ♕c5+ ♔g8 20 ♖e7 embarrasses the black bishop, viz. 20...♖b8 21 ♕e5 or 20...♗c8 21 ♘e4!.

19 ♖e7+ ♔g8 20 ♖xb7 b4 21 ♘d5 ♘xd5

22 ♕e5 ♖f6 23 ♖xd5 1-0

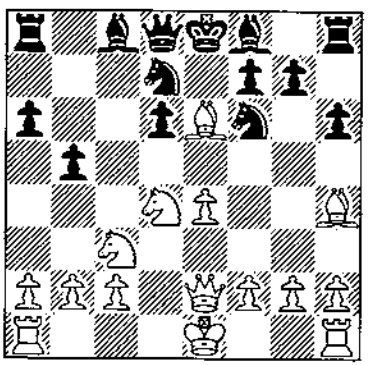
After 23...♕xa2 24 ♖xg7+ ♔xg7 25 ♖d7+ ♔g6 26 ♕e4+ ♖f5 27 ♖d6+ ♔g7 28 ♕xf5 Black cannot escape the mating net.

Game 49
A.Martin Gonzalez-
M.Chiburdanidze
Barcelona 1979

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 ♘bd7 7 ♗c4 e6 8 ♕e2 h6?!

The preferable 8...♕a5!? 9 ♗d2 ♕b6 10 ♘b3 ♕c7 11 0-0 b5 12 ♗d3 ♗b7 13 a4 b4 14 ♘d1 d5 15 exd5 ♘xd5 16 c4 ♘f4 17 ♗xf4 ♕xf4 gave Black a comfortable position in M.Vokac-S.Movsesian, Pribram 1998.

9 ♗h4 b5 10 ♗xe6!?



White will get three pawns and expose the black monarch in exchange for his bishop. The king doesn't get checked, but soon ends up moving of its own accord.

10...fxe6 11 ♘xe6 ♕a5 12 0-0-0 ♔f7 13 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 14 ♖xd6

In this position it seems to us that White has enough compensation for a piece, but he must not tarry. If Black can develop all his pieces, White can get in big trouble. Moreover, a tiny mistake for either side could be fatal.

14...♘e5?!

14...♖e8!? 15 f3 ♘b6 would slow down White's attack.

15 ♖hd1?!

Too slow. Much better was 15 ♗xf6! gxf6 16 ♕h5+: for instance, 16...♔g7 17 f4 ♘f7 18 ♖d3 ♖d8 19 ♖g3+ ♔f8 20 ♕g6 ♗e6 21 ♘d5 ♗xd5 22 exd5 ♖xd5 23 ♕g7+ ♔e7 24 ♖e3+ ♔d6 25 ♕xf6+ ♔c7 26 ♖c3+ is hopeless for Black.

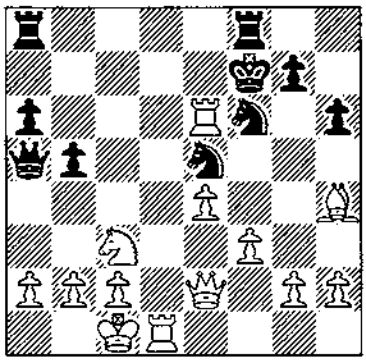
15...♗g4 16 f3 ♗e6?

Instead 16...♘c4 17 ♗xf6 gxf6 18 fxg4 ♕b4 19 ♖xf6+ ♔g8 20 ♖xf8+ ♖xf8 21 ♘a4 bxa4 22 c3 ♕b5 23 h4 leaves matters very unclear; we feel it should finish as a draw.

Possible too is 16...b4 17 ♗xf6 gxf6 18 ♖1d5 ♕c7 19 fxg4 bxc3 20 b3 ♖fd8 21 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 22 ♖xd8 ♕xd8 23 ♕e3 and the strong knight gives Black a slight advantage, but White has good drawing chances. Only a deep analysis beyond the scope of this book can ascertain more.

17 ♖xe6!

Best. Black's extra rook can't stop White's crushing attack in the centre. Instead 17 ♗xf6!? gxf6 18 ♖xe6 ♔xe6 19 f4 ♖ad8 20 fxe5 ♖xd1+ 21 ♕xd1 fxe5 22 ♕d5+ ♔f6 23 ♕d6+ ♔g7 24 ♕xe5+ ♔h7 25 ♕e7+ ♔g8 is better for White, but Black has some hope of saving the game.



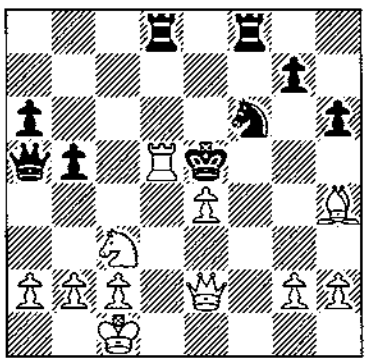
17...♔xe6 18 f4 ♖ad8

According to Chiburdanidze, 18...♘c4 19 e5 ♘e8 20 ♕g4+ ♔f7 21 ♖d7+ ♔g8 22 ♗f6 ♖f7 23 ♕e6 is winning for White.

19 fxe5 ♔xe5

19...♖xd1+ 20 ♕xd1 ♔xe5 21 ♕f3 ♔d6 22 ♕g3+ ♔c6 23 ♕xg7 ♘d7 24 ♕xh6+ wins too much material.

20 ♖d5+!



This further offer cannot be accepted.

20...♔e6

White wins after 20...♖xd5 21 exd5+ ♔d6 22 ♕e6+ ♔c7 23 ♕c6+ ♔d8 24 d6 ♖e8 25 b4 ♕a3+ 26 ♔d2, while 20...♘xd5 21 exd5+ ♔d6 22 ♕e7 is mate.

21 ♖xd8 ♕xd8

The capture 21...♖xd8 is met by 22 e5 winning material.

22 e5 g5 23 exf6+ ♔xf6 24 ♗g3

In this hopeless position, common courtesy demands we remain silent.

24...♖e8 25 ♕f3+ ♔g7 26 ♘e4 ♕d4 27 ♘d6 ♕g1+ 28 ♔d2 ♕d4+ 29 ♕d3 ♕xd3+ 30 cxd3 ♖e6 31 ♘e4 ♔g6 32 ♘c5 ♖c6 33 d4 h5 34 b4 h4 35 ♗e5 ♔f5 36 ♔d3 ♖h6 37 h3 ♖g6 38 ♔e3 g4 39 hxg4+ ♖xg4 40 ♔f3 ♖g6 41 ♗f4 1-0

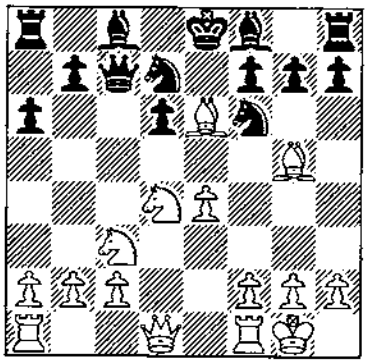
Let us now present a classical brevity played by the great Keres. His ♗xe6 sacrifice has graced a good many books.

Game 50
P.Keres-J.Sajtar
Amsterdam Olympiad 1954

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 ♘bd7 7 ♗c4 e6 8 0-0 ♕c7?!

Two more aggressive choices are 8...♕a5 9 ♕d2 ♗e7 10 ♖ad1 h6 11 ♗e3 ♘c5 12 ♘b3 ♘xb3 13 ♗xb3 b5 14 f3 ♗b7 15 ♕f2 ♕c7 16 ♕g3 ♖g8 and White achieved a slight advantage, V.Ivanchuk-J.Ehlvest, Elista Olympiad 1998; and 8...b5? 9 ♗xe6! fxe6 10 ♘xe6 ♕b6 11 ♘d5 ♘xd5 12 ♕xd5 ♘b8 13 ♘xf8 ♕c6 14 ♘e6 ♕xd5 15 exd5, which left White up two pawns in J.Ehlvest-A.Anastasian, Yerevan 1988.

9 ♗xe6!

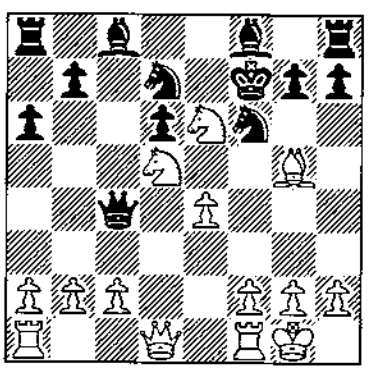


9...fxe6 10 ♘xe6 ♕c4

After 10...♕b6 11 ♘d5 ♘xd5 12 exd5 ♘c5 13 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 14 ♖e1+ ♔f7 15 ♖e7+ ♔g8 16 ♕d4 ♖f7 17 ♖xf7 ♔xf7 18 ♖e1 ♕c7 19 ♕f4+ ♔g6 20 ♖e7 White's attack is decisive.

11 ♘d5 ♔f7

The logical 11...♘xd5 should nonetheless be good for White: 12 exd5 ♖b8 13 ♖e1 ♘e5 14 b3 ♕c3 15 ♗d2 ♕b2 16 ♘xf8 ♔xf8 17 ♗b4 and White should win material.



12 ♗xf6 ♔xe6?

This leaves Black with an exposed king and minimum chances for survival. That said, even after the superior 12...♘xf6 13 b3 ♕xf1+! 14 ♕xf1 ♗xe6 15 ♘c7 ♖c8 16 ♘xe6 ♔xe6 17 ♕d3 ♗e7 18 f4 ♖he8 19 g4 White should be better.

13 ♗c3 ♘f6 14 ♗xf6 gxf6 15 ♘b6 ♕c6 16 ♘xa8 ♗e7 17 a4

The idea is to push a4-a5 and free White's knight.

17...b6 18 ♕d5+ ♔d7 19 ♖a3 ♗d8

Trying to catch the white knight.

20 ♘xb6+! 1-0

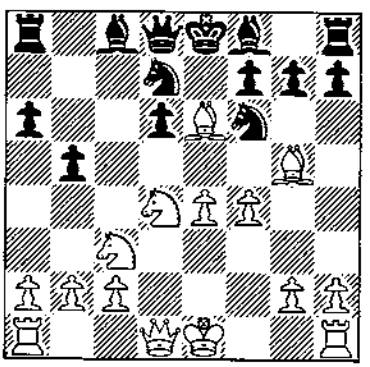
White wins with 20...♗xb6 (or 20...♕xb6 21 ♕f5+ ♔c7 22 ♖c3+) 21 ♕f7+ ♔d8 22 ♕xf6+ ♔c7 23 ♕xh8.

Game 51
A.Matanovic-E.Gufeld
Skopje 1969

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♗c4 b5?!

Another choice is 8...♕b6, which will be covered shortly in Sulskis-Kobalija.

9 ♗xe6!



9...fxe6 10 ♘xe6 ♕b6?!

Not good according to a modern

theory. For 10...♕a5 see the next game.

11 ♘d5! ♘xd5 12 ♕xd5 ♕e3+??

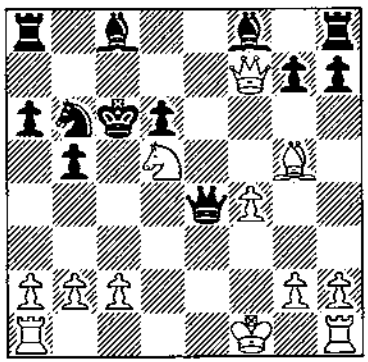
This ill-advised check puts the black queen out of action. Even grandmasters sometimes do crazy things! Instead 12...♘b8!? 13 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 14 ♕xa8 h6 15 0-0-0 hxg5 16 ♕d5 looks better for White, but leaves Black with some counterplay.

13 ♔f1 ♘b6 14 ♘c7+ ♔d7 15 ♕f7+ ♔c6 16 ♘d5

16 ♘xa8 looks like a simple win after 16...♘xa8 17 ♕d5+ ♔c7 18 ♕xa8.

16...♕xe4

Alternatively, 16...♘xd5 17 exd5+ ♔b6 18 ♗h4 ♕e4 19 ♗d8+ ♔c5 20 ♕c7+ ♔xd5 21 ♖d1+ ♔e6 22 ♖e1 and Black loses his queen and the game.



17 ♕c7+ ♔xd5 18 ♖d1+ ♔e6 19 ♖e1 ♕xe1+ 20 ♔xe1 h6

White wins too after both 20...♘d5 21 ♕c6 ♖b8 22 ♕e8+ ♔f5 23 ♕f7+ ♘f6 24 g4+ ♔e4 25 ♗xf6 gxf6 26 ♔f2 ♗xg4 27 ♖e1+, winning material, and 20...♘d7 21 ♕c6 ♖b8 22 ♕e4+ ♔f7 23 ♕d5+ ♔g6 24 f5+ ♔xg5 25 h4+ ♔f4 26 ♖f1+ ♔g3 27 ♕f3+ with a checkmate in couple more moves.

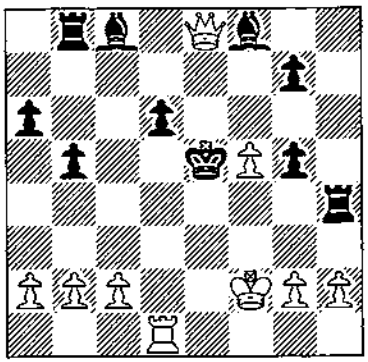
21 f5+ ♔d5

21...♔xf5 22 ♕f7+ ♔e4 23 ♔f2 leads to a forced checkmate: for example, 23...hxg5 24 ♕f3+ ♔d4 25 c3+ ♔c5 26 b4+ ♔c4 27 ♖d1 ♖xh2 28 ♖d4 mate.

22 ♕xb6 hxg5

This is an amazing position where Gufeld's only developed piece is his wandering king. Is this really a 20th Century game?

23 ♔f2 ♖h4 24 ♖d1+ ♔e5 25 ♕c6 ♖b8 26 ♕e8+ 1-0

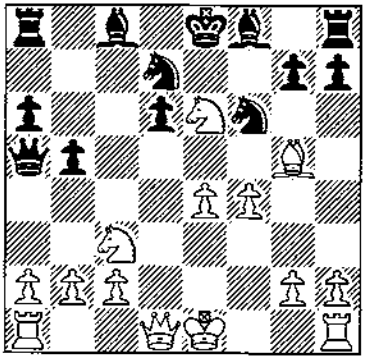


Again it's checkmate: 26...♔xf5 27 ♕f7+ ♔e4 28 ♕d5+ ♔f4 29 ♖d4 mate.

Game 52
A.Zakharov-S.Yuferov
USSR 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♗c4 b5 9 ♗xe6 fxe6 10 ♘xe6 ♕a5

Correct, whereas 10...♕b6? 11 ♘d5 ♘xd5 12 ♕xd5 ♕e3+ 13 ♔f1 ♘b6 14 ♘c7+ ♔d7 15 ♕f7+ ♔c6 16 ♘xa8 ♘xa8 17 ♕d5+ wins for White as in the previous game.



11 0-0

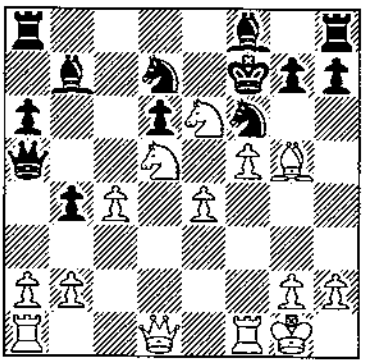
The most popular move is 11 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 12 ♕xd6 ♕b6 13 0-0-0 ♕xd6 14 ♖xd6 b4 15 ♘a4 h6 16 ♗h4 a5 17 ♖hd1 ♖a6. Gipslis assessed this as being slightly better for Black, but in Ma.Tseitlin-L.Polugaevsky, Leningrad 1971, White managed to win.

In a much more recent game White played the novelty 11 ♕d4!? and after 11...♕b6 12 ♗xf6 gxf6 13 ♕d5 ♕e3+ 14 ♔f1 ♘b6 15 ♕h5+ ♔e7 16 ♖e1 ♕xe1+ 17 ♔xe1 ♗xe6 18 ♘d5+ ♘xd5 19 exd5 ♗f7 20 ♕f5 ♗g7 21 ♔d2 ♖hc8 22 ♖e1+ ♔f8 this complicated struggle finished as a draw, A.Shomoev-E.Najer, Moscow 2008. However, we believe that this 11 ♕d4 line will gain many followers in the future.

11...b4

The probably preferable 11...♔f7 12 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 13 ♕xd6 ♕b6+ 14 ♕xb6 ♘xb6 15 ♖ae1 b4 16 ♘d1 ♗b7 17 ♘f2 ♖ac8 18 e5 ♖xc2 19 exf6 gxf6 left Black with tremendous pressure in K.Spraggett-R.Vazquez Igarza, Lorca 2005.

12 ♘d5 ♔f7 13 f5 ♗b7 14 c4

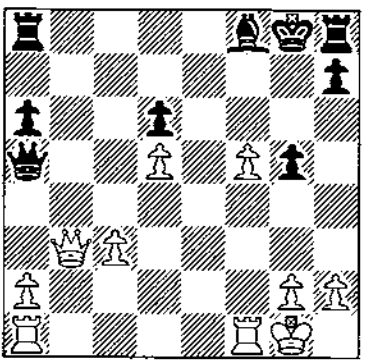


14...bxc3?

14...♗xd5 15 exd5 ♗e7 is given by Gipslis as unclear.

15 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 16 ♘g5+ ♔g8 17 ♘xf6+ gxf6 18 ♕b3+ ♗d5 19 exd5 fxg5 20 bxc3

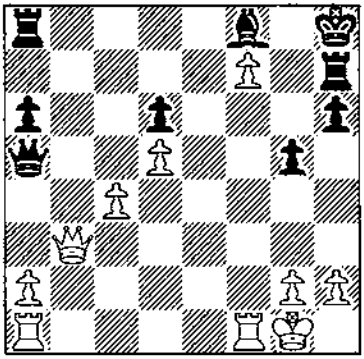
This is much stronger than 20 f6? ♖a7 21 bxc3 ♖f7 22 c4 ♕d8 23 ♕e3 ♖xf6 24 ♕xg5+ ♗g7 25 ♕h5 h6 26 h4 ♔h7, which won shortly for Black in B.Roeschlau-M.Womacka, German League 2004.



20...h6 21 f6 ♖h7 22 f7+ ♔h8

Gipslis points out that 22...♖xf7 23 ♖xf7 ♔xf7 24 ♕b7+ is winning for White.

23 c4



23...♖a7

White wins too after the long line 23...♗g7 24 ♕b7 ♖f8 25 ♕e7 ♕c5+ 26 ♔h1 a5 27 ♖ab1 ♕xc4 28 ♕xd6 a4 29 ♖fe1 ♕c8 30 ♖e8 ♖xe8 31 fxe8♕+ ♕xe8 32 ♖b8.

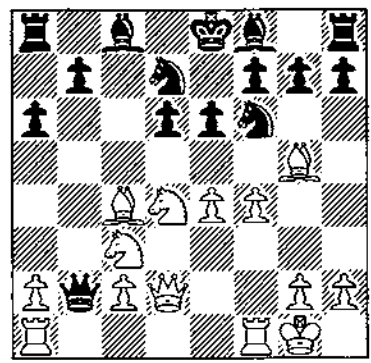
24 ♕b2+ ♖g7 25 ♖f6 ♖axf7 26 ♖xf7 1-0

We end this chapter with another very complicated game, featuring the Russian grandmaster Mikhail Kobalija. He has analysed it very deeply, but we will discuss only his most important notes. Our engine is sure that his opponent's sacrifice was wrong, but Kobalija is no less certain that it was sound. We find this conflict of human and silicon intellect quite enjoyable, and hope you will feel the same.

Game 53
S.Sulskis-M.Kobalija
Moscow 2003

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♗c4 ♕b6 9 ♕d2!? ♕xb2 10 0-0

Practice has seen too 10 ♖b1 ♕a3 11 f5 (after our typical sacrifice 11 ♗xe6 fxe6 12 ♘xe6 ♔f7 13 f5 ♕a5 14 0-0 b5 15 a4 ♗b7 16 axb5 ♖c8 17 bxa6 ♗xa6 Black achieved a better position in T.Radjabov-B.Gelfand, Gothenburg 2005) 11...e5 12 ♘b3 ♗e7 13 0-0 h6 14 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 15 ♖fd1 ♖b8 16 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 17 ♖xd6 b5 18 ♗d5 ♗e7 19 ♖c6 0-0, which gave Black a slight advantage in J.Aldrete Lobo-R.Boger, Switzerland 2002.



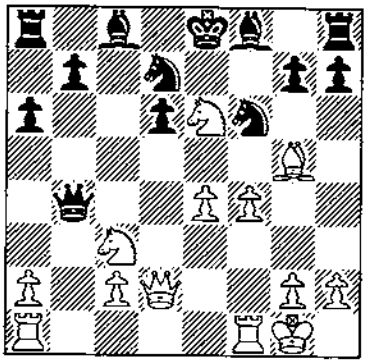
10...♕b4

After 10...♕b6 11 ♔h1 the natural move 11...♕c7 can get Black in trouble after 12 ♗xe6! fxe6 13 ♘xe6 ♕c4 14 e5 dxe5 15 fxe5 ♘xe5 (15...♕xe6 16 exf6 wins for White) 16 ♕d8+ ♔f7 17 ♖xf6+ gxf6 18 ♕xf6+ ♔e8 19 ♘g7+ ♔d7 20 ♖d1+ ♔c7 21 ♕xe5+ and Black gave up in L.Perez-A.Abreu Delgado, Havana 2005.

Another instructive line here runs 11...♗e7 12 ♗xe6! fxe6 13 ♘xe6 ♔f7 14 ♘d5 ♘xd5 15 ♖ab1 ♕e3 16 ♕xd5 ♘f6 17 ♘d8+ ♔e8 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♘xb7 ♖b8 20 ♕h5+ ♔d7 21 ♕f5+ ♔c7 22 ♕a5+ ♔d7 23 ♕xa6, which gives White good

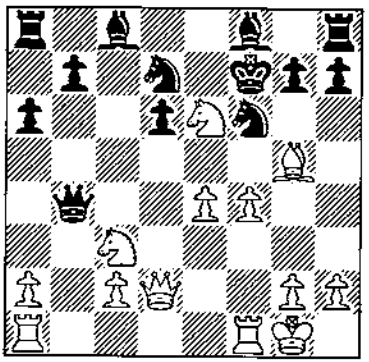
attacking chances according to Kobalija.

11 ♗xe6! fxe6 12 ♘xe6



12...♔f7

According to *Fritz*, 12...♕c4!? gives Black good winning chances, but we believe that after 13 ♘xf8 ♖xf8 14 ♖ae1 ♖f7 15 ♖f3 ♕c5+ 16 ♔h1 ♖e7 17 ♖d3 ♖e6 18 f5 ♖e5 19 ♖xd6 White has more than enough initiative for the piece.



13 e5

We believe that Nataf's 13 f5! gives White enough activity for a piece: for example, 13...♕c4 14 ♖ae1 ♗e7 15 ♘d5 ♘xd5 16 exd5 ♘f6 17 ♘xg7 ♘e4 18 ♖xe4 ♕xe4 19 ♘e6 ♖g8 20 f6 ♗d8 21 ♘xd8+ ♖xd8 22 ♖e1 and White has a winning attack.

13...♔xe6

According to Kobalija, 13...dxe5 14 fxe5 ♘xe5 (after 14...♕b6+ Kobalija shows that 15 ♔h1 ♕xe6 16 exf6 gxf6 17 ♘d5 has to be better for White) 15 ♗xf6 gxf6 16 ♖xf6+ ♔xf6 17 ♘d5+ ♔xe6 18 ♘xb4 gives White good attacking chances.

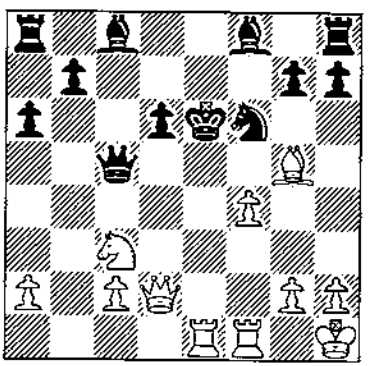
14 exf6 ♕c5+

Kobalija believes that both 14...gxf6 15 ♖ae1+ ♔f7 16 ♕d5+ ♔g7 17 ♘e4! and 14...♘xf6 15 ♗xf6 gxf6 16 ♕d5+ ♔d7 17 ♕f7+ ♔c6 18 ♖f3 ♗g4 19 ♖d3 cause Black too many problems.

15 ♔h1 ♘xf6!

The weaker 15...gxf6? 16 ♘e4 ♕c4 17 ♘xd6! ♗xd6 18 ♖fe1+ ♘e5 (after 18...♗e5 19 fxe5 fxe5 20 ♖ad1 White has more than enough initiative for a piece) 19 fxe5 ♗b4 (or 19...fxe5 20 ♖ad1 ♗c5 21 ♗f6! ♔xf6 22 ♕h6+ ♔f7 23 ♖f1+ and White is winning) 20 c3 ♗c5 21 ♗xf6 ♖g8 22 ♖ad1 gives White a strong attack.

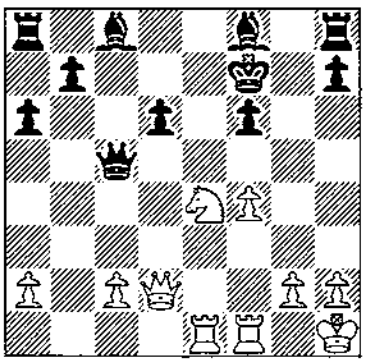
16 ♖ae1+



Thus White is able to give a strong-

looking check, but this is not quite enough for a whole piece. That's partly because White must worry about his knight, and he must trade too many attackers to make it active. Meanwhile Black threatens to run his king to safety and to activate his slumbering army. Those two or three pawns White usually gets are certainly not to be underestimated!

16...♔f7 17 ♗xf6 gxf6 18 ♘e4



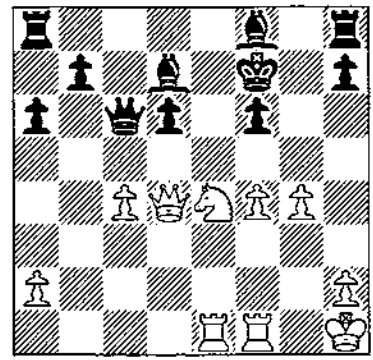
18...♕f5

Both 18...♕c6 and 18...♕c4 are two other possibilities worth considering here.

19 g4! ♕b5 20 ♕d4 ♗d7 21 c4?

Kobalija points out that 21 ♖b1 ♕c6 22 ♖b6 ♕c7 23 ♖xd6 ♗xd6 24 ♕xf6+ ♔g8 25 ♕g5+ ♔f7 26 ♕f6+ ends in perpetual check.

21...♕c6



22 g5?

According to Kobalija, 22 ♕xf6+ ♔g8 23 ♕g5+ ♗g7 24 ♖f3 ♖e8 25 ♘f6+ ♔f7 26 ♕h5+ ♔f8 27 ♘xd7+ ♕xd7 is better for Black, but we feel that Black's development problems gives White chances of survival.

22...♖e8 23 g6+ hxg6 24 ♕xf6+ ♔g8 25 ♖g1 ♖h7 26 ♖xg6+ ♗g7 0-1

Black wins more material after 27 ♕d4 ♗f5.

Chapter Four

The Knight Sacrifice on f5

The sacrifice ♘d4-f5 is a relatively infrequent visitor to the Open Sicilian, at least compared to the knight sacrifice on d5. It commonly occurs these days in two systems: the Velimirovic Attack and the Scheveningen.

For a change, rather than start with a verbal explanation, let's begin by looking back at the game that put the Velimirovic and its creator on the map.

Game 54
D.Velimirovic-J.Sofrevski
Yugoslav Championship, Titograd 1965

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 e6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗e3 ♘c6 7 ♗c4 ♗e7 8 ♕e2 a6 9 0-0-0 ♕c7 10 ♗b3 ♘a5

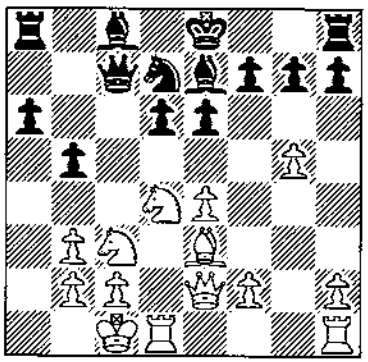
Less accurate is 10...b5? 11 ♘xc6! ♕xc6 12 ♗d4 when 12...0-0 is met by 13 ♘d5!.

11 g4 b5 12 g5 ♘xb3+

Of course, 12...♘d7? 13 ♗xe6! gets three pawns and an attack for the bishop.

13 axb3 ♘d7

Over forty years later, this is still a common position in grandmaster play. The sedate 14 h4 has its followers too, but the more adventurous still play Velimirovic's original idea. To Sofrevski it must have felt like a left hook to the jaw.



14 ♘f5! exf5

Acceptance is pretty much forced. Evans gives 14...♗f8 15 ♗d4 exf5 16 exf5+ ♔d8 17 ♖he1 ♕a5 18 ♘d5 as winning.

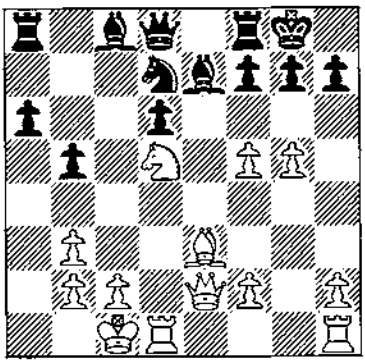
15 ♘d5 ♕d8

Velimirovic dismisses 15...♕b7 with 16 exf5 ♘e5 17 f4 ♗xf5 18 fxe5 ♗e4 19 exd6 ♗xd5 20 ♗c5 ♗xh1 21 d7+ ♕xd7 22 ♖xd7 ♔xd7 23 ♕xe7+ ♔c6 24 ♕d6+ mating.

16 exf5

Here we see the basic idea of White's sacrifice. He has diverted the pawn from e6 to allow ♘c3-d5 with tempo, and he has opened the e-file while the Dark Majesty still resides there. So it's now very tempting for Black to castle...

16...0-0?



Fatal. Praxis has shown the correct defence to be 16...♗b7 17 f6! gxf6 18 ♖he1 ♗xd5 19 ♖xd5 ♖g8! (an idea of Larsen's, first played in F.Gheorghiu-S.Hamann, Vrnjacka Banja 1967) when Yrjola gives 20 gxf6 ♘xf6 21 ♖f5 ♘g4 and now White can force a draw with 22 ♗g5 or play in risky fashion for a win with 22 ♗d4!?. For more details see Finnish GM Jouni Yrjola's fine work *Easy Guide to the Classical Sicilian*.

17 f6! gxf6

The penitent 17...♘xf6 18 gxf6 ♗xf6 fails to gain absolution after 19 ♗b6 ♕d7 20 ♘xf6+ gxf6 21 ♖hg1+.

18 ♗d4

Gaining a necessary tempo to open the g-file and grab the dark squares with killing effect.

18...♘e5 19 gxf6 ♗xf6 20 ♖hg1+ ♗g7 21 ♗xe5 dxe5 22 ♕xe5 f6 23 ♘e7+ ♔f7

23...♔h8 24 ♖xd8 fxe5 25 ♖xf8+ ♗xf8 26 ♖g8 is checkmate.

24 ♕h5+ 1-0

When Black has castled the ♘f5 sacrifice has more limited aims. Generally the big idea is to allow White to follow up with ♘c3-d5, although occasionally the point might simply be to divert the e-pawn or to gain a tempo in some fashion. The main difference is that, with Black having castled, the g7-square tends to be guarded, affording the defender the chance to ignore the knight thrust. Consider the following extract:

Game 55
D.Minic-R. Fischer
Rovinj-Zagreb 1970

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 g4

The main alternative to 10 ♗d3, as we've already seen.

10...b5 11 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 12 g5 ♘d7 13 a3

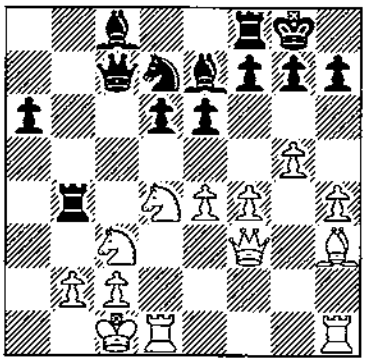
This was in vogue in the 1960s, but has been superseded by 13 f5.

13...♖b8

The older move 13...♗b7 became unpopular after M.Tal-S.Gligoric, Moscow 1963, which saw Tal win a fine game with 14 ♗h3!.

14 h4 b4 15 axb4 ♖xb4 16 ♗h3 0-0!?

A daring idea introduced in this game. 16...♕c5 is considerably safer.



In this position White would like to eliminate the pawn on e6 so as to play ♘c3-d5. There are two ways to do this.

17 ♘f5!?

The knight need not be accepted, so a better approach is the forcing 17 ♘xe6! fxe6 18 ♗xe6+ ♔h8 19 ♘d5 ♕c4 and now 20 ♗f5! with the menace of ♗xh7 is very strong.

17...♘c5!

Fischer continues to play thematically and press against the e-pawn whilst building up against the white king.

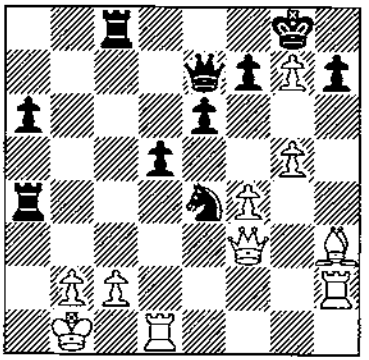
18 ♘xe7+ ♕xe7 19 h5

Gligoric prefers 19 ♕e3.

19...♗b7 20 h6 ♗xe4 21 ♘xe4 ♘xe4 22 hxg7 ♖c8!

Gligoric explains that Minic's likely intention 23 ♗f5 exf5 24 ♕h5 fails to 24...♖xc2+! 25 ♔xc2 ♕c7+ 26 ♔b1 ♘c3+, so he had to slow down.

23 ♖h2 ♖a4 24 ♔b1 d5



And Fischer, whose counterattack was by now in full swing, won in 10 more moves.

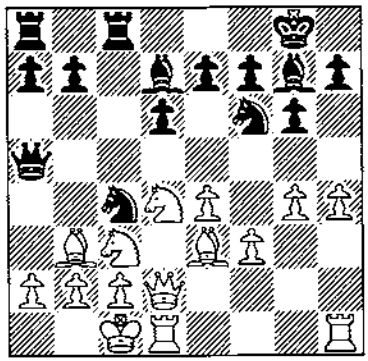
We shall see many successful examples of ♘f5 against a castled king in the body of this chapter, including some fiendishly complex Velimirovic Attacks. I did say in the introduction that this is not intended as a theoretical work, but we will analyse no fewer than six examples of Pereyni's passive ♘f5 sacrifice in the Scheveningen/English Attack.

Over to Yury:

Game 56
L.Barczay-L.Kavalek
Salgotarjan 1967

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 g6 6 ♗e3 ♗g7 7 f3 ♘c6 8 ♕d2

0-0 9 ♗c4 ♗d7 10 ♗b3 ♕a5 11 g4 ♖fc8 12 0-0-0 ♘e5 13 h4 ♘c4



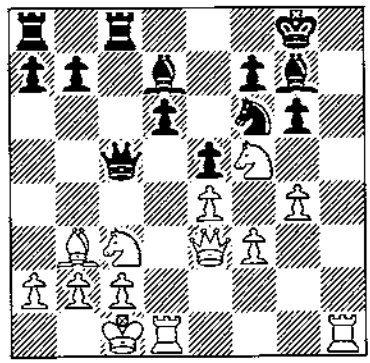
14 ♕d3!?

Fischer's method of attack, introduced in his game with Gligoric from the 1959 Candidates. White feels his light-squared bishop is the more important, so he insists on keeping it. Instead 14 ♗xc4 ♖xc4 15 h5 ♖ac8 16 ♘b3 is more often seen these days, after which 16...♕a6 17 hxg6 fxg6 18 e5 ♘e8 19 ♕h2 h5 20 ♗d4 ♖xd4 21 ♘xd4 ♖xc3 22 bxc3 ♕a3+ 23 ♔b1 ♗xe5 24 f4 ♗e6 25 fxe5 was to finish in perpetual check in J.Moreno Carnero-A.Martin Gonzalez, Barcelona 2000.

14...♘xe3 15 ♕xe3 ♕c5 16 h5! e5?

After 16...a5! 17 hxg6 hxg6 18 a4 b5 19 ♖h6 bxa4 20 ♖xg6 axb3 21 ♖g5 bxc2! (and not 21...e5? 22 ♖xg7+ ♔xg7 23 ♕g5+ ♔f8 24 ♕xf6 ♕xd4 25 ♖xd4 exd4 26 ♕h8+ ♔e7 27 ♘d5+ ♔e6 28 ♕f6 and 1-0 in G.Protze-R.Stach, Germany 1975) 22 ♖h1 ♕xg5 23 ♕xg5 a4 24 ♔xc2 a3 this unclear position ended up as a draw in G.Weinitschke-G.Melzer, Germany 1984.

17 hxg6 hxg6 18 ♘f5!



We already believe that White is better.

18...gxf5

18...♗xf5!? 19 ♕xc5 dxc5 20 exf5! c4 21 ♗a4 gxf5 22 g5 ♘h7 23 ♘d5 gives White some advantage.

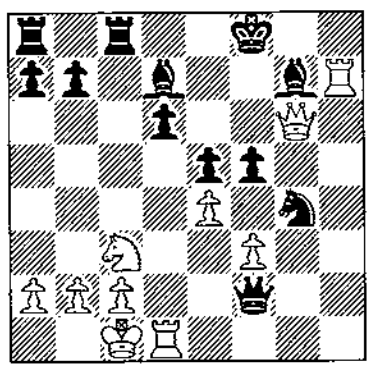
19 ♕g5! ♕f2

Alternatively, 19...f4 20 ♖h6 ♕e3+ 21 ♔b1 ♖xc3 22 ♖dh1 ♔f8 23 bxc3 ♕xf3 24 ♖h8+ ♗xh8 25 ♖xh8+ ♔e7 26 ♖h6 ♕d1+ 27 ♔b2 ♔d8 28 ♕xf6+ ♔c7 29 ♗d5 wins for White.

20 ♖h6! ♘xg4

Or 20...♘h7 21 ♗xf7+! and Black's king is in a mating net, as in the game.

21 ♗xf7+! ♔xf7 22 ♕g6+ ♔f8 23 ♖h7



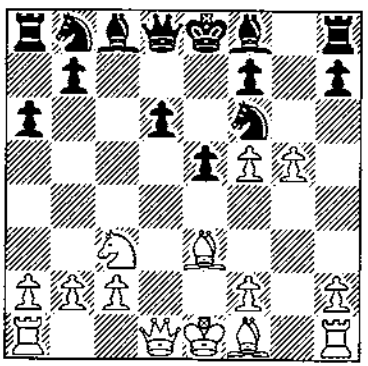
23...♗h6+ 24 ♔b1 ♗e8 25 ♖h8+! ♔e7 26 ♕h7+! ♗f7 27 ♘d5+

This destroys all Black's hopes of survival.

27...♔d7 28 ♕xf7+ ♔c6 29 ♘e7+ ♔b6 30 ♖xc8 ♕xf3 31 ♖xd6+ ♔a5 32 ♕d5+ b5 33 ♘c6+ 1-0

Game 57
A.Shirov-V.Topalov
Wijk aan Zee 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 g4 e5 8 ♘f5!? g6 9 g5 gxf5 10 exf5

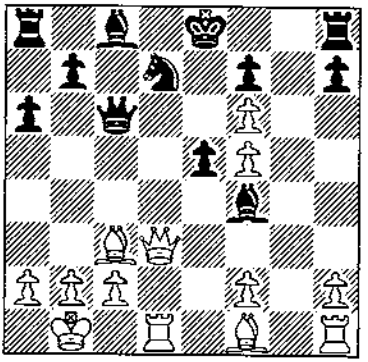


White offers the knight to clear the e4- and d5-squares and the long light-square diagonal, as well as to keep the initiative. Instead recapturing the knight at once allows 10...f4. As usual, the engines tell us that this sacrifice is unsound, but many grandmasters do not agree. We feel, in fact, that Black should be able to unravel and eventually win with the extra piece, but many top grandmasters have lost trying to uphold our point of view, as in this game.

10...d5 11 ♕f3 d4 12 0-0-0 ♘bd7 13 ♗d2 ♕c7 14 gxf6 dxc3 15 ♗xc3 ♕c6 16 ♕g3 ♗h6+ 17 ♔b1 ♗f4

The immediate 17...♕xh1 18 ♗xe5 is fraught with peril for Black, as shown by the possible continuation 18...♕e4 19 ♗c7 ♗d2 20 ♗d3 ♕c6 21 c4.

18 ♕d3



18...♖g8

At present the daring try 18...0-0 is unrefuted. White got a small advantage in the variation 19 ♖g1+ ♔h8 20 ♗b4 ♘c5 21 ♕c3 (after 21 ♗xc5 ♕xc5 22 ♗h3 ♕b6 23 ♕a3 ♖e8 24 ♖d6 ♕xf2 25 ♖gd1 ♗h6 26 ♕d3 ♗f8 27 ♖f1 ♕c5 28 ♖d8 ♗xf5 29 ♗xf5 ♖axd8 30 ♕h3 h6 Black went on to win in P.Smirnov-A.Shomoev, Kazan 2001) 21...♗xf5 22 ♗xc5 ♖fc8 23 ♗d3 ♕xf6 24 ♕b4, but with a big effort Black later drew in D.De Vreugt-O.Korneev, Istanbul 2003.

19 ♗h3 ♔d8 20 ♗b4! ♕xf6 21 ♕c4!

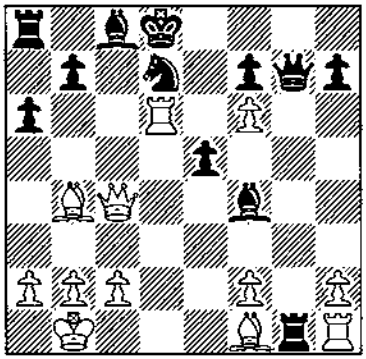
The threat is ♖d6 followed by doubling rooks and/or ♗a5+.

21...♖g5

21...a5 was essential, but after 22 ♖d6 ♕g5 23 ♖hd1! axb4 24 f6 White has a winning attack: for example, 24...♗d2

25 ♗xd7 ♗xd7 26 ♕xf7 and wins.

22 ♖d6 ♕g7 23 f6 ♖g1+ 24 ♗f1 1-0



An amusing final position, with both sides having pieces undeveloped on the first rank so late in the contest. Here 24...♕g8 25 ♗a5+ ♔e8 26 ♕c7 b6 27 ♗xb6 ♖xf1+ 28 ♖xf1 mates.

Next, Shirov, a leading supporter of this variation, easily destroys another strong grandmaster.

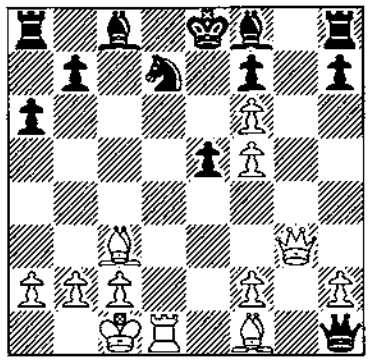
Game 58
A.Shirov-L.Van Wely
Istanbul Olympiad 2000

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 g4 e5 8 ♘f5 g6 9 g5 gxf5 10 exf5 d5 11 ♕f3 d4 12 0-0-0 ♘bd7 13 ♗d2 ♕c7

Black defers the capture on c3 for the moment.

14 gxf6 dxc3 15 ♗xc3 ♕c6 16 ♕g3 ♕xh1?

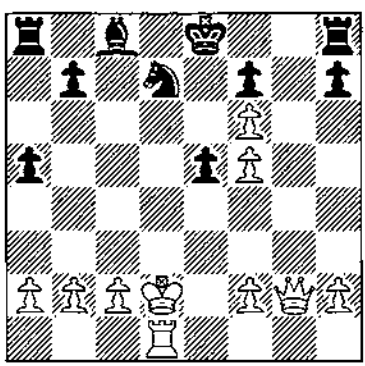
A new idea which unfortunately finishes in tragedy for Black. For 16...♗h6+ see the previous game.



17 ♗g2 ♗h6+ 18 ♗d2 ♗xd2+ 19 ♔xd2 ♕xg2??

19...♕xd1+ is the only way to get counterchances, but Black is in trouble anyway: 20 ♔xd1 ♖f8 21 ♗d5 a5 22 ♗c4 a4 23 ♗b5 ♔d8 24 ♕a3 ♖e8 25 ♕d6 (utter paralysis) 25...h5 26 ♔e2 e4 27 ♔e3 h4 28 a3 h3 29 c4 b6 30 ♕d5 ♖a7 31 ♕xf7 when material might be equal, but White's passed pawns ensure victory. Unless somebody can improve on this line, it seems to us that 16...♕xh1 is refuted.

20 ♕xg2 a5



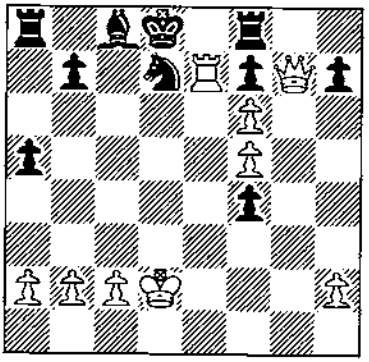
21 f4!

Winning, according to Van Wely.

21...exf4

How else to meet 22 fxe5?

22 ♕g7 ♖f8 23 ♖e1+ ♔d8 24 ♖e7

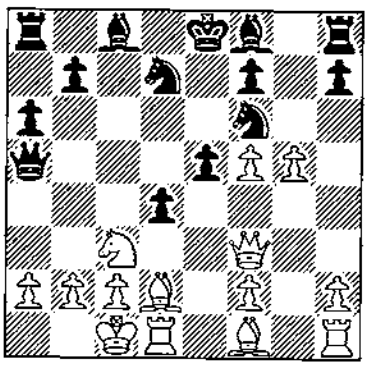


Black is paralysed and helpless. He has to give up material.

24...♔c7 25 ♕xf8 1-0

Game 59
V.Ivanchuk-L.Van Wely
Monaco (rapid) 2005

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 g4 e5 8 ♘f5 g6 9 g5 gxf5 10 exf5 d5 11 ♕f3 d4 12 0-0-0 ♘bd7 13 ♗d2 ♕a5



14 a3!

After 14 gxf6 dxc3 15 ♗xc3 ♗b4 16 ♖d5 my German friend IM Stefan Bromberger (I know him as a master of novelties which he creates with his computer; I remember how in a tournament in Barcelona he destroyed a seemingly stable variation with a new move) played the novelty 16...♕b6!, and after 17 ♗xe5 ♘xe5 18 ♖xe5+ ♔d8 19 ♗g2 ♔c7 20 ♖d1 ♗d7 21 ♕f4 ♗d6 22 ♕c4+ ♔b8 23 ♖e7 ♖c8 24 ♕xf7 ♕c7 25 ♖d2 ♗f4 26 ♕b3 ♗xd2+ 27 ♔xd2 ♕f4+ 28 ♔d1 ♖c7 29 ♕g3 ♕xf5 30 ♗e4 ♕g4+ 31 f3 ♕xg3 32 hxg3 ♔a7 33 g4 ♔b6 34 g5 ♗c6 35 ♖xc7 ♔xc7 36 ♗xh7 ♗xf3+ 37 ♔d2 ♖e8 38 g6 ♗d5 39 f7 ♖d8 Black won with his extra rook, M.Carlsen-S.Bromberger, Gausdal 2004.

14...dxc3 15 ♗xc3 ♕a4 16 gxf6 ♕f4+

16...♗h6+ looks like a good developing move, but after 17 ♔b1 ♗g5 18 ♖d6 ♕f4 19 ♕d5 ♗xf6 20 ♗h3 ♕h4 21 ♖d1 ♔f8 22 ♗b4 ♗e7 23 ♖xd7 (the engines point out that 23 f6! ♘xf6 24 ♕xe5, intending 24...♗xh3 25 ♖6d4, is another winning line) 23...♗xd7 24 ♕xe5 ♖g8 25 ♖d4 ♖g1+ 26 ♔a2 ♕xh3 27 ♗xe7+ ♔g8 28 ♖xd7 White is winning due to his piece activity and the open black king.

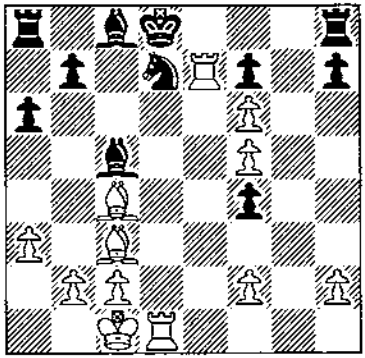
17 ♕xf4 exf4 18 ♗c4!

According to Ivanchuk, 18 ♗g2 ♖b8 19 ♖he1+ ♔d8 20 ♖e7 ♗xe7 21 fxe7+ ♔xe7 22 ♗xh8 f6 23 ♗g7 ♘e5 24 ♗e4 is another way to give White the advantage.

18...♗c5 19 ♖he1+ ♔d8 20 ♖e7!!

The rook on e7 exacerbates all Black's problems: paralysed queenside

pieces, a weak second rank, numerous pawn islands, a weak king, and a soon-to-be-realized passed f-pawn.



20...♖f8

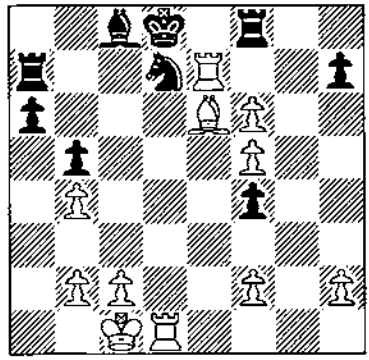
Fritz believes that 20...♗xf2 gives Black a playable game, but our analysis shows that after 21 ♗xf7 ♖a7 22 ♗e6 ♗e3+ 23 ♔b1 b6 24 f7 ♔xe7 25 ♗xh8 ♖a8 26 ♗g7 h5 27 ♗d5 ♖b8 28 f6+ ♔d6 29 f8♕+ ♘xf8 30 ♗xf8+ ♔e5 31 f7 ♗g4 32 ♗g7+ White's f-pawn wins the game. Note too that 20...♗xe7? 21 fxe7+ ♔xe7 22 ♖e1+ ♔d6 23 ♗xh8 is winning for White.

21 ♗b4

This move helps White anchor his rook on e7, but the exchange of pieces weakens his attack. According to Ivanchuk, 21 ♗xf7!? b6 22 ♗e6 ♗xe7 23 ♗xd7 ♗xd7 24 fxe7+ ♔xe7 25 ♗b4+ ♔f6 26 ♗xf8 ♗xf5 27 ♗h6 ♖e8 28 ♗xf4 ♖e2 29 ♖d6+ ♔f7 30 ♖xb6 ♖xc2+ 31 ♔d1 is good for White.

21...♗xb4 22 axb4 b5 23 ♗xf7 ♖a7 24 ♗e6

Black simply can't untie his pieces without losing material, while White can improve his pieces as much as he wants.



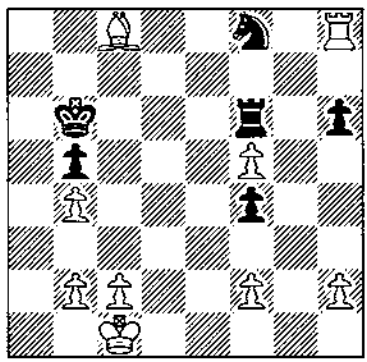
24...h6

24...♖xf6 25 ♖xh7 seems unhelpful, as a healthy black pawn is traded for a rickety white pawn, and White gets a new passer to boot.

25 ♖h7 ♖xf6 26 ♖h8+ ♔c7 27 ♖d3! ♘f8?

Black can't save material. Ivanchuk points out that 27...♘b6! 28 ♗xc8 ♖a8 29 ♖c3+ ♔d6 30 h3 ♘xc8 31 ♖cxc8 ♖xc8 32 ♖xc8 ♔e5 could give Black better chances to survive, but at any rate was good for White.

28 ♖c3+ ♔b6 29 ♗xc8 ♖c7 30 ♖xc7 ♔xc7 31 ♗xa6 ♔b6 32 ♗c8



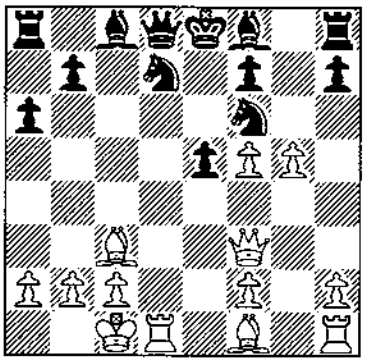
Three extra pawns should be enough material to win.

32...f3 33 b3 ♔c7 34 ♗e6 ♘xe6 35 fxe6 ♖xe6 36 ♖h7+ ♔c6 37 ♖f7 ♖e1+ 38 ♔b2 ♖h1 39 ♖f6+ ♔d5 40 ♖xf3+- ♖xh2 41 ♖f5+ ♔c6 42 c4 h5 43 ♖c5+ ♔d6 44 ♖xb5 h4 45 ♖h5 h3 46 ♔c3 ♖h1 47 b5 h2 48 ♔b4 1-0

Against such an armada there is no recourse.

Game 60
J.Polgar-V.Anand
Dos Hermanas 1999

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 g4 e5 8 ♘f5 g6 9 g5 gxf5 10 exf5 d5 11 ♕f3 d4 12 0-0-0 ♘bd7 13 ♗d2 dxc3 14 ♗xc3



14...♗g7

Instead 14...♘g8! is a computer move if ever we saw one. I was present when it was played and in the post-mortem Novikov told Krush that in his preparations at home he couldn't find a single good variation for White: 15 ♖g1 ♘e7 (according to *Fritz*, 15...♕c7 is another very good option) 16 ♗xe5 ♘xe5 17 ♖xd8+ ♔xd8 18 ♕e4 ♘5c6 19 ♗h3 h6 20 ♖d1+ ♔e8 21 ♗g4 hxg5 22 f6 ♗xg4 23 ♕xg4 ♖d8 24 ♖xd8+ ♔xd8 25 fxe7+ ♗xe7 26 ♕f5 f6 and Black easily won the endgame in I.Krush-I.Novikov, New York 2001.

Another interesting move is 14...♕c7 and after 15 ♗d3 ♕b6 16 ♖he1 ♗b4 17 ♗xb4 ♕xb4 18 gxf6 ♕h4 19 ♗e4 ♕h6+ 20 ♔b1 ♕xf6 21 ♗xb7 ♗xb7 22 ♕xb7 ♖d8 23 f4 ♕xf5 24 fxe5 we see an unclear position with chances for both sides, M.Palac-J.Pinter, Pula 2000.

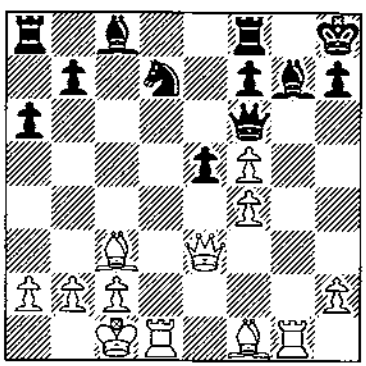
15 ♖g1 0-0?

According to Judit Polgar, 15...♕c7 16 gxf6 ♗xf6 17 ♖g4 gives White good play for the piece. However, according to *Fritz*, the simple 15...♘g8! 16 f6 (what else?) 16...♘gxf6 17 gxf6 ♕xf6 gives Black good winning chances.

16 gxf6 ♕xf6 17 ♕e3

This position does not appear too tricky for Black, but somehow White works up a powerful attack.

17...♔h8 18 f4



18...♕b6?!

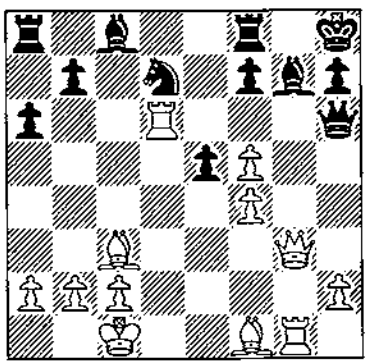
In this position Polgar considered

many defensive tries. We will mention here only the most important:

a) 18...♕h6 19 ♗c4! f6 (or 19...b5 20 ♗d5 ♖b8 21 ♖xg7 ♕xg7 22 ♖g1 ♕h6 23 ♗xe5+ f6 24 ♗xb8 ♘xb8 25 ♕g3, trapping the king) 20 ♗b4! ♖d8 (alternatively, 20...♖e8 21 ♗f7 ♖d8 22 ♗e7 exf4 23 ♕f3 ♖f8 24 ♗xf8 ♘xf8 25 ♖d8 mates or wins material, and 20...exf4 21 ♕e7 is winning for White due to the threat of ♗e6) 21 ♕b6! ♕xf4+ 22 ♔b1 ♖e8 23 ♕c7! ♕xf5 (23...b5 24 ♗f7 ♕xb4 25 ♗xe8 ♕c5 26 ♕xc5 ♘xc5 27 ♗c6 wins material) 24 ♗f7 with a deadly attack.

b) 18...♖e8! 19 ♗c4!? gives White enough compensation for a piece, but *Fritz* believes that Black is winning. However, we feel that Polgar's assessment is most likely the more valid: 19...♗h6 (the most obvious attempt) 20 ♖g4 ♕xf5 21 ♖h4 ♕f6 22 ♖xh6! ♕xh6 23 ♗xf7 ♖e7 24 ♗b3 and despite Black's extra rook, White seems to be doing well: for instance, 24...b6 25 ♕e4 ♖b8 (25...♖a7 26 ♕c4!) 26 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 27 ♗xe5+ ♖g7 28 ♗xb8 ♖g1+ 29 ♔d2 ♕xh2+ 30 ♔c3 ♖g3+ 31 ♔b4 and wins.

19 ♕g3 ♕h6 20 ♖d6



The subtle idea behind this obvious tactic is to induce a fatal weakening of the e6-square.

20...f6

Better than 20...♗f6? 21 ♔b1 ♕h4 22 ♖xf6 ♕xg3 23 ♖xg3 ♘xf6 24 ♗xe5 h6 25 ♗xf6+ ♔h7 26 ♖g7+ ♔h8 27 ♗c4 when the black king is caught in a mating net.

21 ♗d2 e4

According to both Polgar and *Fritz* after 21...♘c5 22 fxe5! ♘e4 23 exf6 ♘xg3 24 fxg7+ ♕xg7 25 ♖xg3 ♕xg3 26 hxg3 ♗xf5 27 ♗c3+ Black can resign.

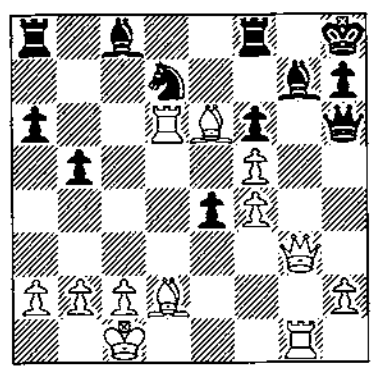
22 ♗c4

Black has problems untying his pieces while White coordinates her army step by step.

22...b5

Polgar mentioned that 22...♘b8 is fruitless due to 23 ♗c3 ♗xf5 24 ♗xf6 ♗g6 25 ♗xg7+ ♕xg7 26 ♕h4, regaining the sacrificed material with interest.

23 ♗e6



23...♖a7

Fritz initially thinks that after 23...♘c5 Black has a playable position, but according to our analysis Black is

losing after 24 ♗e3 ♘xc6 25 fxe6 ♕g6 26 ♕h3 ♕e8 27 f5 ♖g8 28 ♖d4 ♗f8 29 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 30 ♖xe4 h5 31 ♕g2+ ♔h8 32 ♖h4 ♖b8 33 ♕g4 ♗g7 34 ♖xh5+ ♔g8 35 ♖h6.

24 ♖c6! a5 25 ♗e3 ♖b7 26 ♗d5 ♖b8 27 ♖c7 b4 28 b3!

At this point even the computer understands that the extra piece is of no value to Black.

28...♖b5 29 ♗c6 ♖xf5 30 ♖xc8 ♖xc8 31 ♗xd7 ♖cc5 32 ♗xf5 ♖xf5 33 ♖d1!

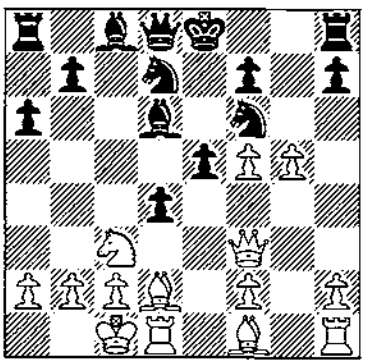
White has achieved material equality. All Black's pieces are in awkward positions and the outcome is clear.

33...♔g8 34 ♕g2 1-0

White wins material and is ready to commence the final assault.

Game 61
A.Onischuk-V.Bologan
Poikovsky 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 g4 e5 8 ♘f5 g6 9 g5 gxf5 10 exf5 d5 11 ♕f3 d4 12 0-0-0 ♘bd7 13 ♗d2 ♗d6!?

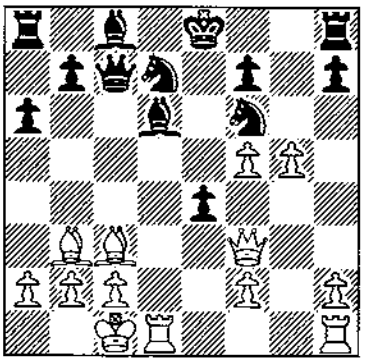


An original idea from Bologan, which in our view casts doubt on White's sacrifice,.

14 ♗c4?

14 gxf6 is the most recent try for White: 14...dxc3 15 ♗xc3 ♕xf6 16 ♖g1 ♖b8 17 ♕d5 ♗e7 (better than 17...♔e7 18 f4 b6 19 fxe5 ♗xe5 20 ♗xe5 ♕xe5 21 ♕d2 ♔d8 22 ♗xa6 ♕c5 23 ♗xc8 ♕xc8 24 ♖g3 with a winning attack) 18 ♖e1 ♕d6 (18...♕xf5 is a possible improvement: 19 ♖xe5 ♕xf2 20 ♗d4 ♕f4+ 21 ♔b1 ♘xe5 22 ♕xe5 ♕xe5 23 ♗xe5 ♗c5 24 ♖g3 ♗h3! 25 ♗d3 ♗f2 26 ♖xh3 ♖g8 27 ♔c1 with some chances for White to hold) 19 ♕e4 b5 20 f4 ♗b7 21 ♕e2 ♖c8 22 fxe5 ♕h6+ 23 ♔b1 ♖xc3 24 bxc3 ♕c6 25 ♖g3 ♘c5 26 ♗g2 ♕b6 27 e6 fxe6 28 fxe6 ♖f8 29 ♖d1 ♘xe6 30 ♗xb7 ♖f5 31 ♗c8 ♘f4 32 ♕e4 ♖f7 33 ♖g8+ and White won in T.Wedberg-R.Astrom, Sweden 2005.

14...♕c7 15 ♗b3 dxc3 16 ♗xc3 e4!



Black clears the e5-square for his bishop, after which he can trade some pieces and castle.

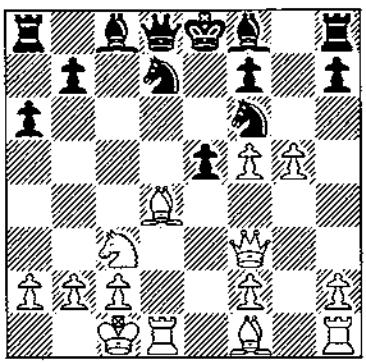
17 ♖he1 ♗e5 18 ♖xe4 ♘xe4 19 ♕xe4 0-0!

Solving the problem of king safety at a stroke. White's next is justifiable desperation.

20 ♖xd7 ♗f4+ 0-1

Game 62
J.Polgar-R.Kasimdzhanov
FIDE World Championship, San Luis 2005

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 g4 e5 8 ♘f5 g6 9 g5 gxf5 10 exf5 d5 11 ♕f3 d4 12 0-0-0 ♘bd7



13 ♗xd4

Fritz's favourite move, which is not popular among grandmasters. 13 ♗d2 was analysed in the last few games.

13...exd4 14 ♖xd4 ♗g7

Probably not the even best try. Judit Polgar mentions 14...♗c5 15 ♖d2 ♕c7 instead and 16 gxf6 ♘xf6 17 ♗c4 ♗e7 18 ♗b3 0-0 19 ♖e1 ♔h8 20 ♕e3 ♗d8 21 ♕d4 ♗xf5 22 ♖e5 ♗g6 23 ♘d5 ♕d6 24 f4 ♖c8 25 f5 ♗h5 26 ♖g2 ♗f3 27 ♖g3 ♗xd5 28 ♗xd5 ♗b6 forced resignation in K.Pulkkinen-L.Oll, Helsinki 1990.

15 ♖g1 ♔f8

We believe that 15...♘g8!? 16 ♕c4+ ♔f8 17 f6 ♘gxf6 18 gxf6 ♕xf6 19 ♘d5 ♕d6 20 ♕h4 ♕h6+ 21 ♕xh6 ♗xh6+ is another way for Black to get the advantage.

16 ♕e3 ♕e7

We think that by stopping ♕e3-h6 with 16...h5!? 17 gxf6 ♗xf6 18 ♖d1 ♕b6 Black obtains the advantage.

17 ♕d2

Fritz thinks that Polgar's variation 17 ♕xe7+ ♔xe7 18 gxf6+ ♗xf6 (18...♔xf6 19 f4!) 19 ♘d5+ ♔e8! 20 ♘c7+ ♔d8 21 ♖xd7+ ♗xd7 22 ♘xa8 ♗d4 gives White the advantage, but our analysis shows equality after 23 ♗g2 ♗xf2 24 ♖d1 ♔c8 25 ♗xb7+ ♔xb7 26 ♖xd7+ ♔c6 27 ♖xf7 ♖xa8 28 ♖xh7.

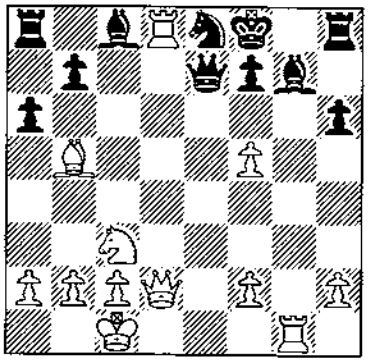
17...h6?

After 17...♖g8! 18 gxf6 ♕xf6 19 ♖d3 ♗h6 20 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 21 f4 ♕xf5 22 ♘d5 ♔h8 23 ♗h3 ♕e4 24 ♖e3 ♕c4 25 ♖e8+ ♘f8 26 ♘e3 ♕c5 27 b4 ♕c6 28 ♕d4+ f6 29 ♕d8 ♗xh3 30 ♕xa8 ♔g8 Black has a huge advantage due to White's weak pawns and king.

18 gxf6 ♘xf6

Instead 18...♗xf6?! 19 ♘d5 ♕e5 20 ♘xf6 ♕xf6 21 ♖g3 ♕e5 22 ♖e3 ♕f6 23 ♕b4+ ♔g8 24 ♖g3+ ♔h7 25 ♖d6 wins material for White, but 18...♕xf6! 19 ♖d6 ♕xf5 20 ♘d5 ♕e5 21 ♕b4 a5 22 ♖xd7+ axb4 23 ♖d8+ ♕e8 24 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 25 ♘c7+ ♔e7 26 ♘xa8 ♗e5 27 ♗c4 ♗xh2 28 ♖e1+ ♔f6 29 ♘b6 ♗f4+ 30 ♔b1 ♗e6 31 ♗xe6 fxe6 32 ♘d7+ ♔f5 33 ♘c5 ♖g8 34 ♘xe6 ♖g2 35 ♘xf4 ♔xf4 36 a4 should be a draw.

19 ♖d8+ ♘e8 20 ♗b5!!



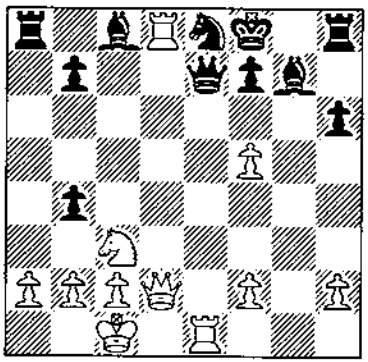
Clearing a path for the rook to visit e1, of course, but this sacrifice is a bit deeper than it looks at first.

20...axb5

Polgar points out 20...♗xf5 21 ♖xa8 axb5 22 ♘d5 ♕d6 23 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 24 ♖xg7 wins for White.

21 ♖e1 b4?

According to Polgar, 21...♗e5 22 f4 ♗f6 23 ♖xe8+! ♕xe8 24 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 25 ♘e4 ♗e7 26 f6 ♖g8 27 ♘d6+! ♔d7 28 ♘xc8+ ♔xc8 29 ♕c3+ ♔d7 30 fxe7 wins for White.



22 ♘b5??

Missing 22 ♖xe8+! ♔xe8 23 ♖xe7+ ♔xe7 24 ♘d5+ ♔d6 25 ♘b6+ ♔c6 26 ♘xa8 ♗xf5 27 ♘c7 ♗g6 28 ♘d5 and wins.

22...♗xb2+?

A slip in return. Polgar mentions that 22...♗e5! 23 ♔b1 ♔g7 24 ♖d5 ♕g5 wins for Black.

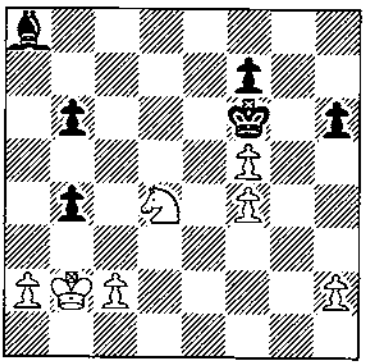
23 ♔xb2

23 ♔b1 was another good approach for White: for example, 23...♗e5 24 f4 f6 25 fxe5 fxe5 26 f6 ♕e6 27 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 28 ♘c7+ ♔f7 29 ♘xe6 ♗xe6 30 ♕xb4 and White is up material.

23...♕f6+ 24 ♕d4 ♔g7 25 ♖exe8 ♖xe8 26 ♖xe8 ♕xd4+ 27 ♘xd4 ♔f6 28 f4

While Black's pieces are paralysed, White is improving her pieces every move.

28...b6 29 ♖d8 ♗b7 30 ♖xa8 ♗xa8



In this unusual position it's easy for White's king to capture the b-pawns and win by creating a passed pawn on the queenside.

31 ♔b3 ♗d5+ 32 ♔xb4 ♗xa2 33 ♔b5 ♗b1 34 c3 ♔e7 35 ♔xb6 ♔d6 36 c4 ♗d3 37 c5+ ♔d5 38 ♘c6 ♔e4 39 ♘e7 ♗c2 40 c6 ♗a4 41 c7 ♗d7 42 ♔c5 1-0

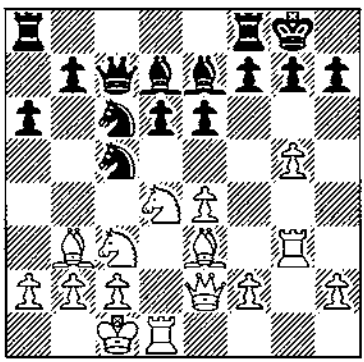
After 42...♔xf4 43 ♔d6 nothing can stop White's passed pawn.

Game 63
N.Davis-G.Wastell
Australia 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 ♘c6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 ♗e7 8 ♗b3 0-0 9 ♕e2

Again we see the Velimirovic Attack.

9...a6 10 0-0-0 ♕c7 11 ♖hg1 ♘d7 12 g4 ♘c5 13 g5 ♗d7 14 ♖g3



14...♖fd8

To us 14...♖fc8!? looks like a good move which helps in the attack on the white king: 15 ♕h5 g6 16 ♕h6 ♗f8 17 ♕h4 ♘xd4 18 ♖xd4 ♘xb3+ 19 axb3 e5? (Black should play 19...♗e7 with the threat of ...h5) 20 ♖d2 ♗e6 21 ♖h3! (it seems Black overlooked this) 21...h5 22 gxh6 ♔h7 23 ♖f3 ♗e7 24 ♗g5 ♗f8 25 ♖f6 b5 26 f4 ♗xb3 27 fxe5 ♗e6 28 ♘d5 ♕a5 29 ♔b1 ♗e7 30 ♕f4 and Black had to resign in G.Binder-A.Lanc, German League 1996.

15 ♕h5 g6 16 ♕h4

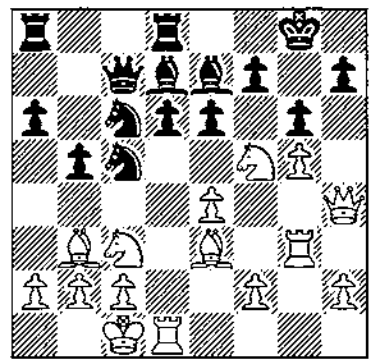
Alternatively, 16 ♕h6!? ♗f8 17 ♕h4 ♗e7 18 f4 b5 (18...h5 19 f5 ♘xd4 20 ♗xd4 ♘xb3+ 21 axb3 ♖ac8 is also possible for those with strong nerves) 19 f5 b4 leads to an unclear position with chances for both sides.

16...b5?

Instead 16...h5!? could delay White's attack down the h-file and give Black valuable time for counter-threats against the white king.

Possible too is 16...♖ac8!? 17 ♘f5 ♘xb3+ (17...gxf5? 18 ♖h3 ♔f8 19 ♕xh7 ♔e8 20 g6 is White's big idea) 18 axb3 h5 (18...exf5? 19 ♘d5 ♕a5 20 ♘xe7+ ♘xe7 21 ♗d4 fxe4 22 ♕h6 ♕a1+ 23 ♔d2 ♕a5+ 24 c3 f6 25 gxf6 e3+ 26 ♖xe3 ♘f5 27 f7+ ♔xf7 28 ♕xh7+ leads to mate) 19 ♘h6+ ♔g7 20 f4 ♕a5 21 ♔b1 ♕b4, which gives chances for both sides.

17 ♘f5!!



It's rare for this knight to impale itself on two pawns, but here it does. If the g-pawn captures, then 18 ♖h3 follows when the counter 18...h5 is no longer available, while the usual drawbacks apply to the e-pawn capture.

17...♘xb3+

Fleshing out the alternatives a little:

a) 17...gxf5 18 ♖h3 ♘xb3+ 19 axb3 ♔f8 20 ♕xh7 ♔e8 21 g6 ♗c8 22 ♘d5! ♕b7 23 ♕xf7+ ♔d7 24 ♗b6 exd5 25 ♕xf5+ wins.

b) 17...h5!? could put up the most resistance, but after 18 ♘h6+ ♔g7 19 f4 ♘xb3+ 20 axb3 b4 21 ♘a4 ♖dc8 22 ♗b6 ♕b8 23 f5 (or 23 ♗f2 ♗d8 24 ♖gd3 ♗c7 25 f5 exf5 26 exf5 ♘e5 27 ♗d4 ♗xf5 28 ♘xf5+ gxf5 29 g6 ♕b5 30 gxf7 ♔xf7 31 ♕xh5+ and White has a crushing attack) 23...exf5 24 exf5 ♔h7 25 ♗e3 ♕c7 26 ♖g2 ♖ab8 27 ♕f2 ♘e5 28 ♘b6 ♖e8 29 ♗d4 White has emerged with some advantage.

18 axb3 exf5??

Even though *Fritz* will initially tell you that White is completely losing, analysis shows that White is winning. Indeed, Mr.Davis finished his attack much better than *Fritz*!

19 ♘d5 ♕a5 20 ♘xe7+ ♘xe7 21 ♗d4!

Nothing can save Black. The obvious threat is, of course, 22 ♕xh7+.

21...fxe4

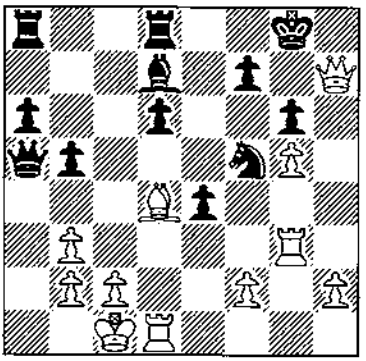
Here Black had a few choices, all of them bad: 21...♔f8 22 ♕xh7 ♗e6 23 ♕h8+ ♘g8 24 exf5 gxf5 25 ♗f6 ♖dc8 26 ♔b1 f4 27 ♖gd3 d5 28 ♖xd5 ♗xd5 29 ♕g7+ ♔e8 30 ♕xg8+ ♔d7 31 ♕xf7+ ♔c6 32 ♕xd5+ ♔b6 33 ♗d4+ ♔c7 34 ♕f7+ is winning for White, as is 21...♕a1+ 22 ♔d2 ♕a5+ 23 ♗c3.

22 ♕h6 ♘f5

Or 22...♕a1+ 23 ♔d2 ♕a5+ 24 ♗c3 ♕xc3+ 25 ♖xc3 ♗g4 26 ♕h4 ♗xd1 27 ♔xd1 d5 28 ♖h3 and wins.

23 ♕xh7+!

By now this type of offer should seem routine to our readers.



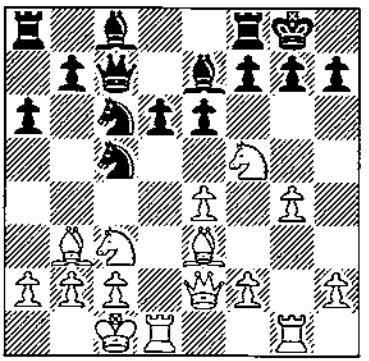
23...♔f8

It's mate after 23...♔xh7 24 ♖h3+ ♔g8 25 ♖h8.

24 ♗f6 ♕a1+ 25 ♔d2 e3+ 26 fxe3 ♕a5+ 27 c3 1-0

Game 64
A.Sokolov-V.Salov
Nikolaev 1983

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 a6 8 ♕e2 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♗e7 10 ♗b3 0-0 11 ♖hg1 ♘d7 12 g4 ♘c5 13 ♘f5



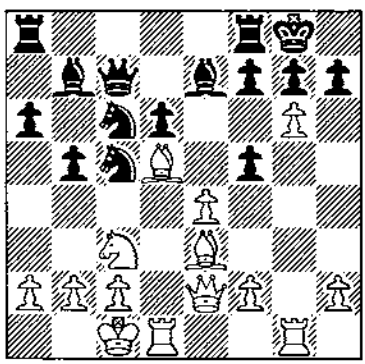
13...b5 14 ♗d5 ♗b7

After 14...exd5 15 ♘xd5 ♕b7 16 e5 the attack is strong: for example, 16...♘e6 17 exd6 ♗d8 18 f4 f6 19 ♕f3 ♖f7 20 d7 ♖xd7 21 ♕e4 ♘f8 22 ♗c5 ♖xd5 23 ♕xd5+ ♗e6 24 ♕d6 ♗c7 25 ♕xc6 ♗xf4+ 26 ♔b1 ♕xc6 27 ♘e7+ ♔f7 28 ♘xc6 ♗xh2 29 ♘d8+ ♔g6 30 ♖ge1 ♗xg4 31 ♖d4 ♘d7 32 ♖xg4+ ♔f5 33 ♖xg7 ♘xc5 34 ♘c6 ♗e5 35 ♘xe5 fxe5 36 ♖xh7 and White is winning, A.Kogan-K.Roser, Port Barcares 2005.

15 g5 exf5

After 15...♖fc8 16 ♕h5 ♘e5 17 f4 ♘g6 18 ♖g3 b4 19 ♖h3 ♘f8 20 ♗d4 exd5 21 ♗xg7 ♗d8 22 ♗d4 f6 23 gxf6 ♘g6 24 f7+ Black gave up in G.Ginsburg-Z.Lanka, Cappelle la Grande 1997.

16 g6!

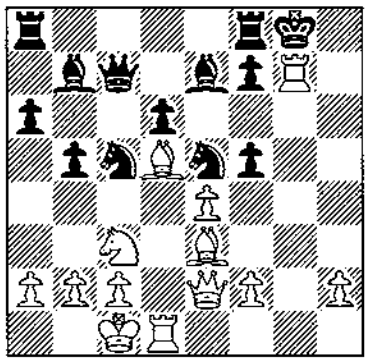


From this moment *Fritz* thinks that Black is absolutely winning. Moreover, Salov defends his position exactly like *Fritz*, but here *Fritz*'s amazing ability to defend is overwhelmed by human attacking skills.

16...hxg6

Another fruitless defence is 16...♘e5 17 exf5 ♗f6 18 ♕h5 hxg6 19 fxg6 ♖fd8 20 ♗g5! ♗xg5+ 21 ♖xg5 ♘cd3+ 22 ♔b1 ♘f4 23 ♕h7+ ♔f8 24 gxf7 ♘fg6 25 f4 b4 26 fxe5 bxc3 27 ♕xg6 and White will checkmate in a couple of moves.

17 ♖xg6 ♘e5 18 ♖xg7+!



Opening the helpless king even further.

18...♔xg7 19 ♖g1+ ♘g6 20 exf5 ♖h8 21 ♗d4+ ♗f6 22 fxg6 fxg6

According to both *Fritz* and Sokolov, after 22...♗xd4 23 gxf7+ ♔f6 24 ♕g4 ♔e7 25 ♕xd4 ♖af8 26 ♖g8 Black is losing.

23 ♕g4 ♖h6 24 ♗xf6+ ♔h7

Unappealing too was 24...♔xf6, since 25 ♕d4+ ♔f5 (25...♔e7 26 ♖e1+ ♔d7 27 ♕g7+ ♔c8 28 ♖e8+ wins) 26 ♕e3 ♗xd5 27 ♖g5+ ♔f6 28 ♘xd5+ wins material.

25 ♖e1 ♗xd5 26 ♘xd5 ♕c8 27 ♖e7+ ♔g8 28 ♖g7+ ♔f8 29 ♖g8+

Another pleasant alternative was 29 ♕d4 ♘d3+ 30 ♔b1 ♘e5 31 ♘c7 ♘f7 32 ♕d5 ♕xc7 33 ♕xa8+

29...♔xg8 30 ♘e7+ 1-0

Black resigned, not a moment too soon because of 30...♔f7 31 ♘xc8 ♔xf6 32 ♕f3+.

Game 65
M.Hansen-G.Fawbush
correspondence 1983

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 ♘c6 7 ♗e3 ♗e7 8 ♕e2 0-0 9 0-0-0 a6 10 ♗b3 ♕c7 11 g4 ♘d7

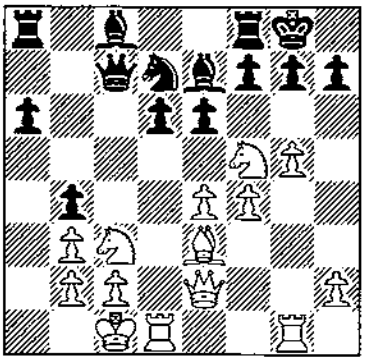
Compared with the Velimirovic game in the introduction to this chapter, Black has castled already and avoided an early ...b5.

Here 11...♘a5!? was good for Black after White attacked with 12 g5 ♘d7 13 h4 b5 14 g6 ♘c5 15 gxf7+ ♖xf7 16 ♔b1 ♘axb3 17 ♘xb3 b4 18 ♘xc5 bxc3 19 ♘b3 a5 20 ♘d4 ♕b7 21 ♗c1 cxb2 22 ♗g5 ♗f8 23 ♖hg1 a4 24 f4 ♖a5 25 h5 a3; Black's extra pawn survived while White's attack soon disappeared in H.Nakamura-L.Van Wely, Bastia (rapid) 2007.

12 ♖hg1 ♘a5 13 g5 ♘xb3+ 14 axb3 b5 15 f4 b4?

Black has to cover the d5-square with 15...♗b7.

16 ♘f5!



White must strike before Black develops all his pieces, in particular the light-squared bishop.

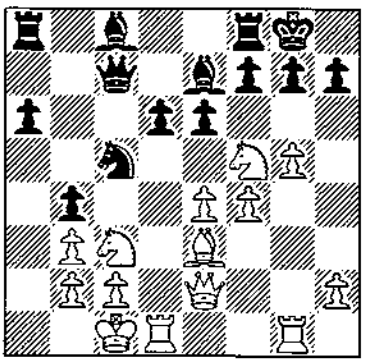
16...exf5

To help us get a better feeling for the Velimirovic, we will also analyse:

a) 16...bxc3!? 17 ♘xe7+ ♔h8 18 f5 cxb2+ 19 ♔xb2 ♗b7 20 f6 g6 21 ♖d4 ♖fd8 22 h4 ♘c5 23 h5 ♗xe4 24 hxg6 ♗xg6 25 ♕h2 e5 26 ♖h4 ♕b7 27 ♖h1 wins for White.

b) According to *Fritz*, 16...♗d8 is winning for Black, but our analysis shows that 17 ♗d4! (threatening 18 ♘h6+) 17...bxc3 (17...exf5? 18 ♘d5 ♕a5 19 ♕h5 ♘c5 20 ♘f6+ ♗xf6 21 gxf6 g6 22 ♕h6 ♘e6 23 ♖d3 with a forced mate) 18 ♘h6+ ♔h8 19 ♕h5 transposes to variation 'c1'.

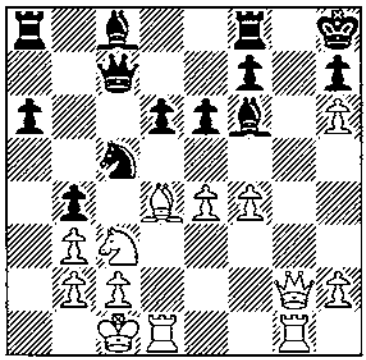
c) 16...♘c5



with a further divide:

c1) 17 ♘h6+ (we spent much time on this line before hitting on the simpler alternative, 'c2'; the complications are hard to fathom) 17...gxh6? (stronger is 17...♔h8! 18 ♗d4 bxc3 19 ♕h5 ♗d8 20 ♔b1 ♖a7 and Black seems to survive, such as in the long line 21 e5 cxb2

22 exd6 ♕a5 23 ♗xb2 ♘e4 24 f5 ♘c3+ 25 ♗xc3 ♕xc3 26 ♖g3 ♕a5 27 d7 ♖xd7 28 ♖xd7 ♗xd7 29 ♘xf7+ ♔g8 30 g6 hxg6 31 ♘h6+ ♔h8 32 ♘f7+ and it's perpetual) 18 gxh6+ ♔h8 19 ♕g2 ♗f6 20 ♗d4

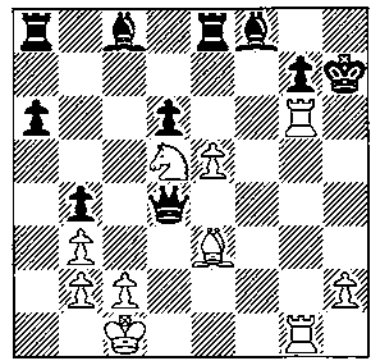


20...♘xb3+ 21 cxb3 e5 22 fxe5 dxe5 23 ♗f2 (White has the nasty threat of ♗h4, conquering the g7-square) 23...♗g4 (or 23...bxc3 24 ♗h4 cxb2+ 25 ♔b1 ♕b6 26 ♗xf6+ ♕xf6 27 ♕g7+ ♕xg7 28 hxg7+ ♔g8 29 gxf8♕+ ♔xf8 30 ♖d8+ ♔e7 31 ♖gg8 and wins) 24 ♕xg4 ♖g8 25 ♕d7 ♕xd7 26 ♖xd7 ♖xg1+ 27 ♗xg1 bxc3 28 bxc3 and White has an extra pawn which helped him to win in P.Anisimov-I.Lutsko, St Petersburg 2006.

c2) The simpler 17 ♘xe7+! ♕xe7 18 e5 d5 19 ♕f2 ♘d7 20 ♘a4 looks like a good French for White, although Black has some counterplay against the king.

17 ♘d5 ♕d8 18 exf5 ♖e8 19 g6 fxg6

Instead 19...hxg6 20 fxg6 fxg6 21 ♖xg6 with the plan of doubling rooks looks promising. Moreover, 21...♗f8 22 ♕c4 ♔h7 23 ♖dg1 ♕h4 24 ♕d4 ♘e5 25 fxe5 ♕xd4



26 ♖h6+! ♔g8 27 ♗xd4 dxe5 28 ♘c7 is an elegant possibility.

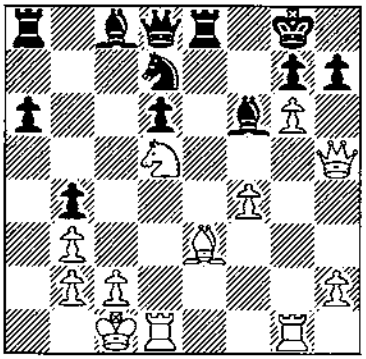
20 fxg6 ♗f6

20...h6!? could give White many problems:

a) 21 ♕c4? ♔h8 22 ♗d4 ♗f8? (better is 22...♘f6 23 ♘c7 ♗f5 24 ♘xe8 ♕xe8 25 ♕xb4 ♖c8 when Black is developing a dangerous initiative which can help him to win) 23 ♘c7 ♘c5 24 ♘xa8 ♗e6 25 ♕e2 ♕xa8 26 ♕h5 ♔g8 27 ♗xc5 dxc5 28 f5 ♗d5 29 f6 ♖d8 30 f7+ ♔h8 31 ♕h4 a5 32 ♖ge1 a4 33 ♕xd8 ♕xd8 34 ♖e8 ♕g5+ 35 ♔b1 ♕xg6 36 ♖xf8+ ♔h7 37 ♖h8+ ♔xh8 38 f8♕+ ♗g8 39 ♖d8 ♕e6 and 1-0 was D.Velimirovic-B.Ivanovic, Niksic 1978.

b) Better is 21 f5!: for instance, 21...♗f6 (or 21...♗g5 22 ♖xg5 ♕xg5 23 ♕c4 ♘e5 24 ♘f6+ ♔h8 25 ♗xg5 ♘xc4 26 ♘xe8 ♗xf5 27 ♘c7 ♖c8 28 bxc4 ♖xc7 29 ♖xd6 ♗xg6 30 ♖xg6 hxg5 31 b3, which leads to a winning endgame) 22 ♕c4 ♔h8 23 ♗xh6 ♘e5 24 ♕f4 ♔g8 25 ♖df1 ♕a5 26 ♕e4 ♗d7 27 ♔b1 ♗d8 28 ♗xg7 ♔xg7 29 f6+ ♗xf6 30 ♘xf6 ♕c5 31 ♘h5+ ♔g8 32 ♕f4 finishes off.

21 ♕h5



21...hxg6

21...h6 locking it up is a stronger defence. Could this be why Patrick Wolff chose 19 ♗d4 in our next game?

22 ♖xg6 ♗b7

After 22...♖xe3 23 ♖dg1 ♖e6 24 ♔d1 ♗b7 25 ♕h6 Black is losing because he can't defend the g7-square.

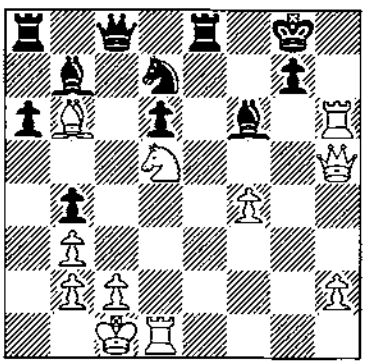
23 ♗b6!

An attempt to divert a defender from f6.

23...♕c8

It's mate after 23...♘xb6 24 ♘xf6+ ♔f7 25 ♖g5+ ♔f8 26 ♕h8+ ♔f7 27 ♕xg7+ ♔e6 28 ♖e1+ ♗e4 29 ♖xe4.

24 ♖h6!!



24...gxh6 25 ♘xf6+ ♔f8

According to Hansen, after 25...♘xf6 26 ♕g6+ ♔h8 27 ♕xh6+ the attack is too strong: 27...♔g8 (or 27...♘h7 28 ♗d4+ ♖e5 29 fxe5 ♕f8 30 e6+ ♔g8 31 ♖g1+ and White will checkmate in couple of moves) 28 ♕g6+ ♔h8 29 ♕xf6+ ♔h7 30 ♕f7+ ♔h6 31 ♖xd6+ and wins.

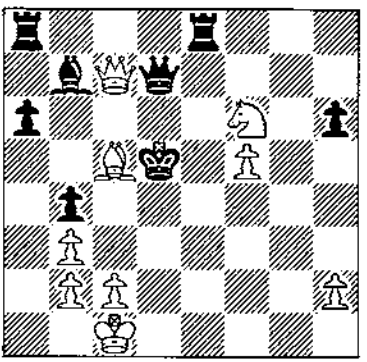
26 ♘h7+ ♔e7

Or 26...♔g7 27 ♖g1+ ♔h8 28 ♕xh6 and it's all over.

27 ♖e1+ ♘e5 28 ♖xe5+ dxe5 29 ♕xe5+ ♕e6

Hansen was ready to meet 29...♔d7 with 30 ♘f6+ ♔c6 31 ♕c5 mate.

30 ♕c7+ ♕d7 31 ♗c5+ ♔e6 32 f5+! ♔d5 33 ♘f6 mate (1-0)



An amazing checkmate which fully deserves a diagram.

Game 66
P.Wolff-I.Sokolov
Baguio City 1987

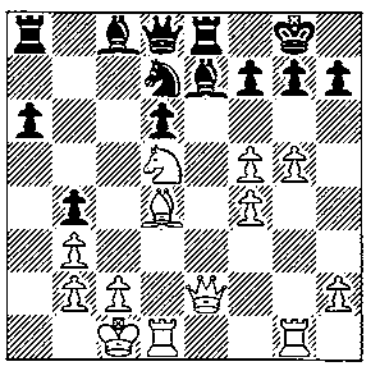
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘c6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗e3 ♘f6 7 ♗c4 ♗e7 8 ♕e2

a6 9 0-0-0 ♕c7 10 ♗b3 0-0

In the early development of this variation 10...♗d7 preparing ...b5 was one of the most popular moves. For example, 11 ♔b1 (11 g4 ♘xd4 12 ♖xd4 ♗c6 13 g5 ♘d7 14 ♖g1 ♘c5 15 h4 offered chances to both sides in D.Janosevic-M.Kapelan, Vrsac, 1977) 11...b5 12 f4 ♘a5 13 ♕f3 ♕b7 14 e5 dxe5 15 fxe5 ♕xf3 16 gxf3 ♘h5 17 ♖hg1 ♘c6 18 a4 ♘xd4 19 ♖xd4 ♗c6 20 axb5 axb5 21 ♘e4 0-0 22 ♗g5 ♖fd8 23 c3 ♖xd4 24 cxd4 ♗xg5 25 ♖xg5 ♘f4 26 ♖g4 was equal, but somehow Black managed to win in M.Damjanovic-V.Simagin, Sochi 1967.

11 ♖hg1 b5 12 g4 ♘a5 13 g5 ♘xb3+ 14 axb3 ♘d7 15 f4 b4? 16 ♘f5 exf5 17 ♘d5 ♕d8 18 exf5 ♖e8 19 ♗d4!

According to Paunovic this is a powerful novelty, improving over our previous game.



19...♗f8

An important alternative is 19...♗b7 20 g6!. Here we believe that in this complicated position, White should win in all variations:

a) 20...hxg6 21 fxg6 ♗xd5 22 ♕h5 ♗f6 23 ♕h7+ ♔f8 24 gxf7 ♔xf7 25 ♖xg7+ ♗xg7 26 ♕xg7+ ♔e6 27 ♕g4+ ♔e7 28 ♕g5+ ♔f7 29 ♕xd5+ ♔f8 30 ♕f5+ ♘f6 31 ♗xf6 ♕c8 32 ♕g6 ♖e7 33 ♖g1 and it's all over.

b) 20...♗f6 21 gxf7+ ♔xf7 22 ♕h5+ ♔f8 (or 22...♔g8 23 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 24 ♖xg7+! ♔xg7 25 ♖g1+ ♔h8 26 ♕xe8+ ♕xe8 27 ♗xf6 mate) 23 ♕xh7 ♘e5 24 fxe5 dxe5 25 ♗c5+ ♔f7 26 ♘xf6 ♕xf6 27 ♖d7+ checkmates in couple of moves.

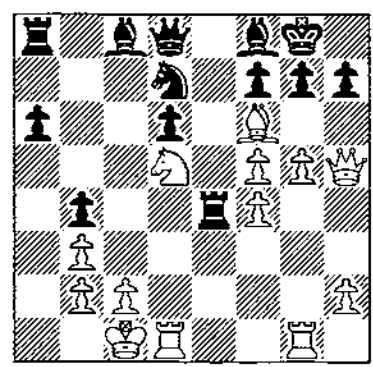
c) 20...♘f6 21 gxf7+ ♔xf7 22 ♕e6+ ♔f8 23 ♖xg7! ♔xg7 24 ♖g1+ ♔h6 25 ♖g5 ♖c8 26 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 27 ♘xf6 ♖xe6 28 ♘g4 mate.

d) 20...fxg6 21 ♕e6+ ♔h8 22 ♗xg7+! ♔xg7 23 fxg6 ♘e5 24 gxh7+ ♗g5 25 ♖xg5+ ♕xg5 26 h8♕+ ♔xh8 27 ♕h3+ wins material.

20 ♕h5 ♖e4

After 20...♗b7 21 ♖d3 ♗xd5 22 ♖h3 h6 23 gxh6 ♘f6 24 ♕h4 ♘h7 25 ♕g4 White has a winning attack.

21 ♗f6!



21...♕e8

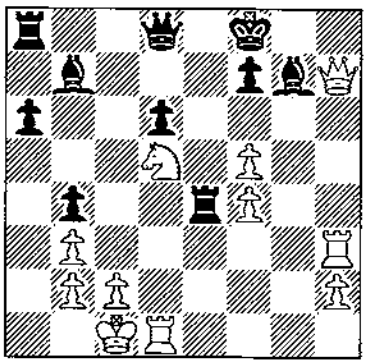
More stubborn was 21...♕a5, although after 22 g6 fxg6 23 fxg6 h6 24 ♗xg7 ♘c5 25 ♗f6 ♗g7 26 ♔b1 ♗b7 27

♗xg7 ♔xg7 28 f5 ♘d7 29 f6+ ♘xf6 30 ♘xf6 ♖e5 31 ♕h4 White is winning. Meanwhile after 21...gxf6? 22 ♘xf6+ ♘xf6 23 gxf6+ ♔h8 24 ♕g5 ♗h6 25 ♕xh6 mate follows.

22 ♘c7 ♘xf6 23 gxf6 ♕d8

According to Paunovic, 23...♕d7 24 ♖xg7+ ♗xg7 25 ♕g5 traps the black king.

24 ♘d5 ♗b7 25 fxg7 ♗e7 26 ♖g3 ♗f6 27 ♖h3 ♗xg7 28 ♕xh7+ ♔f8



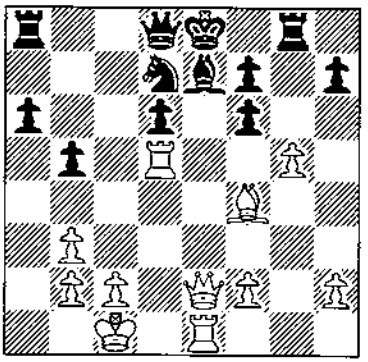
29 f6

Paunovic and *Fritz* point out that White missed the simple 29 ♕xg7+! ♔xg7 30 ♖g1+ ♔f8 31 ♖h8 mate.

29...♗xf6 30 ♕xe4 ♕a5 31 ♕f5 ♗g7 32 ♕d7 1-0

Game 67
S.Martinovic-V.Musil
Yugoslavia 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 e6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗e3 ♘f6 7 ♗c4 ♗e7 8 ♕e2 a6 9 0-0-0 ♕c7 10 ♗b3 ♘a5 11 g4 b5 12 g5 ♘xb3+ 13 axb3 ♘d7 14 ♘f5!? exf5 15 ♘d5 ♕d8 16 exf5 ♗b7 17 f6 gxf6 18 ♖he1!? ♗xd5 19 ♖xd5 ♖g8 20 ♗f4!?



This is assessed by Yrjola as 'a risky attempt to win' in his *Easy Guide to the Classical Sicilian*. The threat to take with the bishop on d6 forces further concessions from Black. Moreover, for his piece, White has one pawn, the safer king, the better structure, the more active pieces and an enduring initiative. Is it enough, though?

The alternative 20 gxf6 will be seen in the next game.

20...♔f8

The weaker 20...♘c5 21 gxf6 ♗xf6 22 ♗xe5 ♗xe5 23 f4 ♔f8 24 fxe5 ♕g5+ 25 ♔b1 dxe5 26 ♖xe5 gives White a safe edge.

21 ♕h5

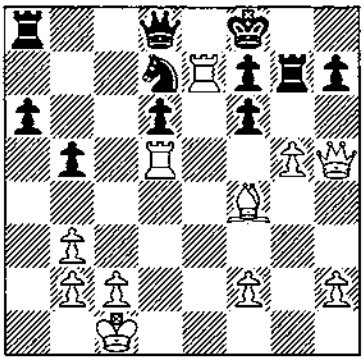
After 21 ♗xd6 ♗xd6 22 ♖xd6 fxg5 23 ♕e4 ♖g6 24 ♕d4 ♖c8 25 ♖xd7 ♕f6 26 ♕d2 ♕f5 27 c3 ♖f6 28 ♖e2 h6 29 ♖d4 ♖cc6 30 h4 ♖ce6 31 ♖xe6 ♖xe6 32 hxg5 ♕xg5 33 ♕xg5 hxg5 34 ♖d5 f6 35 ♔d2 a draw was looking likely in M.Paragua-D.Khismatullin, Oropesa del Mar 2000.

21...♖g7?

According to Vladimir Sokolov, 21...♕a5 is the best try. Indeed, 22 ♕e2

♘e5 23 gxf6 ♗xf6 24 ♖xd6 ♖e8 25 ♗h6+ ♗g7 26 ♔b1 ♗xh6 27 ♖xh6 ♔g7 28 b4 ♕xb4 29 c3 ♕g4 30 ♖xa6 ♘f3 forced White to resign in S.Garber-A.Fishbein, New York 1991.

22 ♖xe7!!



A necessary corollary to the previous play. White exposes the enemy king further and lures it forward.

22...♔xe7 23 ♗xd6+ ♔e6

The fearless king has to attack White's pieces to gain a tempo for developing its army. Worse is 23...♔e8 24 ♕e2+ ♘e5 25 gxf6 ♖g1+ 26 ♔d2 ♕xf6 27 ♖xe5+ ♔d7 28 ♕d3 ♕h6+ 29 ♔e2 ♕xd6 30 ♖d5 ♖e8+ 31 ♔f3 ♖e6 32 ♖xd6+ ♖xd6 33 ♕xh7 and White has good winning chances.

24 c4! bxc4 25 bxc4 ♖xg5 26 ♕h3+ f5 27 f4! ♘f6?

Black should curb his Steinitzian impulse and hide his king with 27...♖g1+ 28 ♔d2 ♔f6 29 ♕xh7 ♖g2+ 30 ♔d3 ♕g8 31 ♕xf5+ ♔g7 32 ♕xd7 ♕h7+ 33 ♔d4 ♖d2+ 34 ♔e3 ♖xd5 35 cxd5 ♕xh2 when a perpetual is likely.

28 ♕e3+ ♘e4 29 fxg5 ♖c8

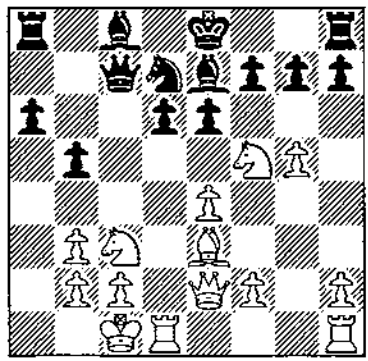
29...♕xg5 30 ♗f4 ♕g6 31 ♕b6+ ♔e7 32 ♕b7+ ♔f6 33 ♕xa8 wins for White.

30 b3 ♖c6 31 ♖e5+! ♔d7 32 ♕a7+ ♔c8 33 ♕a8+ ♔d7 34 ♕b7+ 1-0

White wins material.

Game 68
M.Sion Castro-S.Atalik
Oviedo 1993

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 ♘c6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 ♗e7 8 ♕e2 a6 9 0-0-0 ♕c7 10 ♗b3 ♘a5 11 g4 b5 12 g5 ♘xb3+ 13 axb3 ♘d7 14 ♘f5



14...exf5

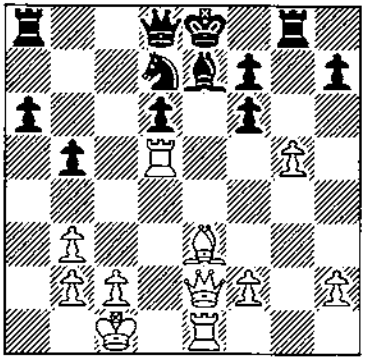
The knight doesn't have to be touched and 14...b4!? 15 ♗d4 bxc3 16 ♘xg7+ ♔d8 17 ♘xe6+ fxe6 18 ♗xh8 e5 19 ♖hg1 ♗b7 20 ♗f6 ♘xf6 21 gxf6 ♗xf6 22 ♖g8+ ♔e7 23 ♖dg1 ♖xg8 24 ♖xg8 ♕a5 25 bxc3 ♕xc3 26 ♕h5 ♕a1+ 27 ♔d2 ♕d4+ 28 ♔c1 ♕a1+ finished as a perpetual check in L.Dominguez-Cu.Hansen, Esbjerg 2003.

15 ♘d5 ♕d8 16 exf5 ♗b7 17 f6 gxf6

After 17...♗xd5 18 fxg7 (18 ♖xd5 gxf6 19 ♗d4 ♔f8 20 ♕h5 h6 21 ♖g1 ♘e5 22 f4 ♘g6 23 gxf6 ♗xf6 24 ♖xg6 ♗xd4

25 ♖gxd6 ♕a5 26 ♖xd4 also gives White an advantage, A.Minasian-T.Thorhallsson, Bled Olympiad 2002) 18...♖g8 19 ♖xd5 ♖xg7 20 f4 ♔f8 21 h4 ♕a5 22 ♖e1 ♖e8 23 ♗d4 ♖g6 24 ♗c3 ♕d8 25 ♕h5 ♔g8 26 ♔b1 ♗f6 27 ♖xe8+ ♕xe8 28 f5 ♗xc3 29 bxc3 ♕e1+ 30 ♔b2 ♖g7 31 ♖xd6 f6 32 ♖e6 ♕g1 33 gxf6 Black resigned in A.Zapata-R.Leitao, Americana 1997.

18 ♖he1 ♗xd5 19 ♖xd5 ♖g8



As mentioned in the introduction to this chapter, this line is still played 40 years after its debut in 1967.

20 gxf6

Theory considers this a safer approach than Martinovic's 20 ♗f4. The only drawback is that a draw is quite likely. Of course, when playing a strong grandmaster that may be a benefit.

20...♘xf6 21 ♖f5 ♖b8

Alternatively:

a) 21...♖g6?! 22 ♗b6 ♕d7 23 ♕f3 ♖c8 24 ♖xf6 d5 25 ♖xg6 hxg6 26 ♕f6 ♕b7 27 b4 ♖c4 28 f3 and Black was overwhelmed in S.Azarov-B.Jobava, Kemer 2007.

b) After the aggressive 21...♘g4!? an unclear position was reached following 22 ♖g5 (22 ♗g5 ♘e5 23 ♗xe7 ♕xe7 24 f4 ♕e6 25 ♕e4 ♘d3+ 26 ♔d2 ♘xe1 27 ♕xa8+ ♔e7 28 ♕b7+ ♔e8 29 ♕a8+ ♔e7 30 ♕b7+ led to a draw in M.Sion Castro-Z.Franco Ocampos, Pamplona 1998) 22...♖xg5 23 ♗xg5 ♘e5 24 ♗xe7 ♕xe7, but this was actually agreed drawn in J.Howell-A.Lisenko, Cappelle la Grande 1995.

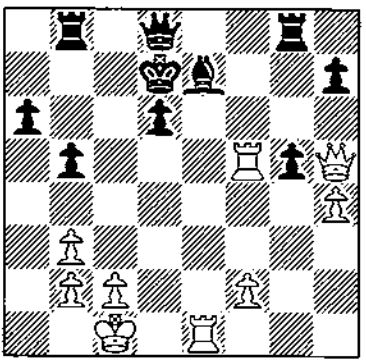
22 h4 ♘g4!

This appears to us to be the best remedy against the threatened ♗g5. Of course, Black would love to snap off that nasty cleric, so...

23 ♗g5

23 ♖g1? ♘h6! achieves a favourable simplification.

23...f6! 24 ♕xg4 fxg5 25 ♕h5+ ♔d7



26 ♖xe7+!

Some folks call this a 'fifty-percenter'. Maybe Black will oblige with 26...♔xe7?? allowing mate in one.

26...♕xe7 27 ♖f7 gxh4 28 ♖xe7+ ♔xe7 29 ♕xh7+ ½-½

We believe that had play continued, a perpetual would have ensued 20 or

so moves down the road. Apparently the opponents shared our forecast and decided to save time.

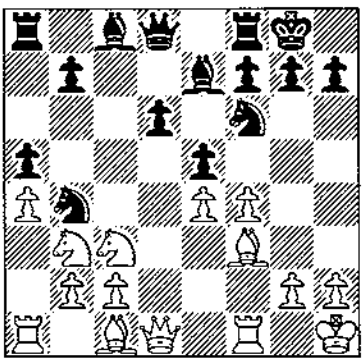
Game 69
G.Kasparov-B.Gelfand
Amsterdam 1996

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e2 e5 7 ♘b3 ♗e7 8 0-0 0-0 9 ♔h1 ♘c6 10 f4 a5

Perhaps better is 10...b5: for example, 11 ♗f3 ♘a5 12 ♘xa5 ♕xa5 13 ♕e1 ♕c7 14 a3 ♗b7 15 ♕g3 ♖fe8 16 ♗e3 ♕c4 17 fxe5 dxe5 18 ♗h6 ♗f8 19 ♖ae1 was roughly even in W.Arencibia Rodriguez-Y.Quezada, Santa Clara 2007.

11 a4 ♘b4 12 ♗f3

According to Kasparov, 12 ♗c3 d5 13 fxe5 ♘xe4 14 ♗f3 ♘xc3 15 bxc3 ♘c6 leads to an unclear position.



12...♕b6

In a more recent game, 12...♗e6 13 ♗e3 ♕c7 14 ♕d2 ♕c4 15 f5 ♘xc2 16 ♘xa5 ♖xa5 17 ♕xc2 ♗d7 18 b3 ♕c7 19 ♖fc1 ♖c8 20 ♕d2 ♕d8 21 b4 ♖aa8 22 a5 h6 23 ♗b6 ♕e8 24 ♕d3 d5 25 ♘xd5 led to a draw in S.Azarov-F.Vallejo Pons, European Championship, Plovdiv 2008.

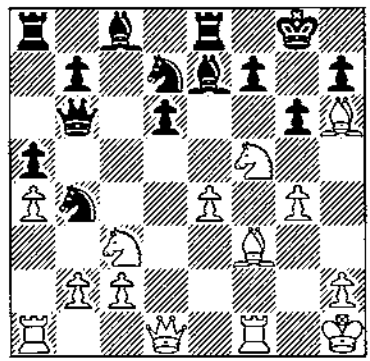
13 g4 exf4

Kasparov points out that 13...♗e6? 14 g5 ♘e8 15 f5 ♘xc2 16 fxe6 ♕xb3 17 ♖a3 ♕c4 18 ♗e2 wins for White.

14 ♗xf4 ♘d7 15 ♘d4 g6

We believe that 15...♘e5 16 ♘f5 ♗xf5 17 exf5 ♘xf3 18 ♕xf3 ♕c6 19 ♖ad1 ♖ac8 20 ♕xc6 bxc6 21 ♖d2 d5 is roughly even.

16 ♗h6 ♖e8 17 ♘f5!?



White sacrifices the knight to open the g-file for his attack. It's not so easy for Black to regroup his pieces for the defence, although he hopes that his knight's access to e5 will help repulse White's invasion. Both 17 ♗e3 and 17 ♗e2 were safer ways to continue the attack.

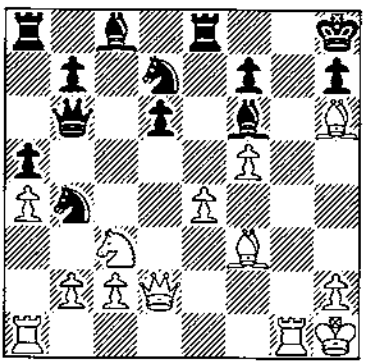
17...gxf5

Kasparov points out that 17...♘e5 18 ♘xe7+ ♖xe7 19 ♗g5 is better for White, but our further analysis show that after 19...♖e8 20 ♗e2 ♗e6 21 ♕d2 ♘xg4 22 ♗xg4 ♗xg4 23 ♗f6 ♖e6 24 ♕h6 ♖xf6 25 ♖xf6 ♗e6 the position is unclear.

18 gxf5 ♗f6?

We believe that 18...♔h8! 19 ♖g1 ♗f8 (according to Kasparov, 19...♖g8? 20 ♖xg8+ ♔xg8 21 ♕g1+ ♕xg1+ 22 ♖xg1+ ♔h8 23 ♗h5 is winning for White) 20 ♕d2 d5 21 ♗xf8 ♖xf8 22 e5 ♘xe5 23 ♕g5 ♘g6 24 ♘xd5 ♘xd5 25 ♗xd5 ♕xb2 26 ♖af1 ♗d7 27 fxg6 fxg6 gives Black good chances to win.

19 ♖g1+ ♔h8 20 ♕d2



20...♘e5

Kasparov's analysis will convince the reader that the other main defences don't help Black:

a) 20...♕d4 21 ♕g2 ♕e5 22 ♖ad1 ♖a6 23 ♘d5 ♘xd5 24 ♖xd5 ♕xb2 25 e5 blocks the diagonal and wins immediately.

b) 20...♕d8 21 ♘b5 ♖a6 (21...♘e5 22 ♘xd6 ♖a6 23 ♘xe8 ♕xd2 24 ♗xd2 ♘xf3 25 ♘xf6 is winning for White) 22 ♘c7 ♕xc7 23 ♕g2 ♕xc2 24 ♗g7+ ♔g8 25 ♕g3 ♘e5 26 ♗xf6+ ♘g6 27 fxg6 fxg6 28 ♖ac1 ♕xa4 29 ♖c7 ♗d7 30 ♗h5! ♖xe4 31 ♗xg6 ♖g4 32 ♕xg4 ♗xg4 33 ♗h5 and to escape checkmate Black is forced to surrender material.

21 ♕g2 ♘g6 22 fxg6 fxg6 23 ♖gf1

White takes back his piece and starts the second wave of the attack.

23...♗g7?!

Black trades his most important defender and gets in trouble. We believe Kasparov is right when he mentioned that 23...♗e5 24 ♖ad1 ♗e6 25 ♘b5 ♗c4 26 ♗e2 gives White only a slight advantage.

24 ♗xg7+ ♔xg7 25 ♖ad1

After Black traded his bishop, the d6-pawn became an excellent target for the attack.

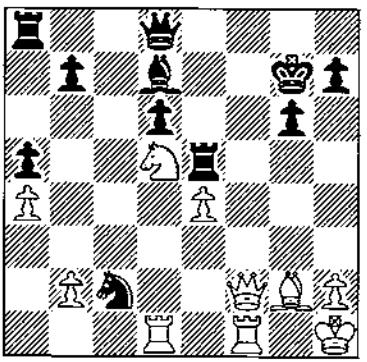
25...♗d7 26 ♕g3 ♖e5 27 ♗g2

Kasparov prefers 27 ♗e2!? ♗c6 (after 27...♖f8? 28 ♕xe5+ White wins material, while 27...♘xc2 28 ♗c4 ♗e6 29 ♗xe6 ♖xe6 30 ♘d5 ♕c6 31 ♕h3 ♖xe4 32 ♖f7+! wins) 28 ♖xd6 ♕c5 29 ♖df6 when White has a clear advantage.

27...♘xc2

Kasparov points out that other tries are fruitless: 27...♖ae8 28 ♕f4! ♗e6 29 ♘b5 is winning for White, and 27...♖f8 28 ♖xf8 ♔xf8 29 ♖f1+ ♔g8 30 ♕h4 ♖e8 31 ♕f6 ♕d8 32 ♕xd6 gives White some advantage.

28 ♘d5 ♕d8 29 ♕f2!



A decisive move which attacks Black's knight and prepares ♕f7 and/or ♘b6.

29...♘b4

According to Kasparov, after 29...♖c8 30 ♘b6 ♗g4 31 ♘xc8 ♗xd1 32 ♘b6 ♖c5 (32...♗g4 33 ♘c4 wins) 33 ♘d5 ♗h5 34 ♕f7+ ♔h8 (34...♔h6 35 ♘f6) 35 ♘e7 White's mating threats will finish the game.

30 ♘b6 ♗g4 31 ♕f7+

Another way to finish the game was 31 ♖c1 ♖b8 32 ♕f7+ ♔h6 33 ♖c7 ♖h5 34 ♕xh7+ ♔g5 35 ♕g7 ♘a6 36 ♖cf7 ♕h8 37 ♖7f5+ ♔h4 38 ♕e7+ g5 39 ♕xd6.

31...♔h8 32 ♘xa8 ♗xd1 33 ♖xd1 ♕xa8 34 ♕f6+ ♔g8 35 ♖xd6 ♖e8 36 ♖d7 ♖e7 1-0

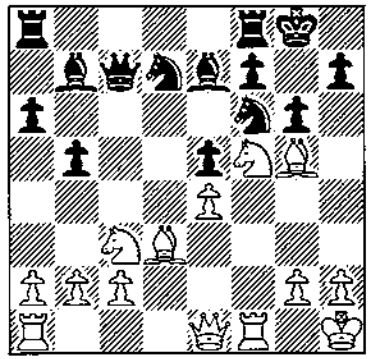
Game 70
D.Ghizdava-A.Munteanu
Romania 1971

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 f4 e5 7 ♘f3 ♕c7 8 ♗d3 b5 9 0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♕e1 ♗e7 11 ♔h1 0-0 12 fxe5 dxe5 13 ♗g5! ♗b7

After 13...b4 14 ♘d1 (or 14 ♘d5 ♘xd5 15 exd5 f6! 16 ♕e4 g6 17 ♗h6 ♗b7!? 18 ♗xf8 ♖xf8 with compensation for the exchange, A.Kapengut-V.Savon, Ashkhabad 1978) 14...♘c5 15 ♘e3 ♗e6 16 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 17 ♗c4 ♗xc4 18 ♘xc4 ♕b7 19 ♕e3 ♘a4 20 ♕b3 ♘c5 21 ♕e3 ♘a4 22 ♕b3 the game was drawn by repetition, D.Bronstein-I.Boleslavsky, Grozny 1969.

14 ♘h4 g6!? 15 ♘f5!? *(see Diagram)*

White is sacrificing his knight to open up Black's king and to put more pressure on the f6-knight, which stands in front of another White target, the pawn on f7.



15 ♗h6 is another try, but we believe that Black can hold the position after 15...♖fe8 16 ♘f5 ♗d8 17 ♘g7 ♖f8 18 ♘f5 ♖e8 when White can either take a draw or try to destroy Black's fortress.

15...gxf5 16 ♖xf5 b4! 17 ♘e2!

White's knight is moving towards its dream squares, f5 and h5. According to Ciocaltea, the inferior 17 ♘d5? ♘xd5 18 exd5 f6! gives Black an advantage.

17...♖fe8

A good try for Black to get counterplay is 17...♔h8: for example, 18 ♕h4 ♖g8 (perhaps Black can defend with 18...♕d6 19 ♖af1 ♘g8 20 ♘g3, but White's attack is still very dangerous: for example, 20...♗d8 21 ♗c4 ♗xg5 22 ♖xg5 ♘df6 23 ♘f5 ♕c6 24 ♗d3 ♖ac8 25 ♖g7 ♖c7 26 ♕g5 ♘h5 27 ♕xh5 ♘h6 28 g4 with a crushing attack) 19 ♖xf6! ♗xf6 (19...♖xg5? 20 ♖xf7 ♖g7 21 ♕xe7 ♖xf7 22 ♕xf7 ♖f8 23 ♕e7 leaves Black

down two pawns) 20 ♗xf6+ ♘xf6 21 ♕xf6+ ♖g7 22 ♘g3 ♕d8 23 ♕xe5 ♕g5 24 ♕d4 a5, but anyway White has a slight advantage.

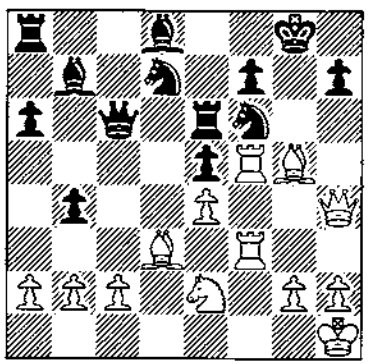
18 ♕h4 ♗d8

Fritz initially believes that 18...♕c6 can give Black an advantage, but our analysis shows that after 19 ♘g3 ♗d8 20 ♖af1 ♖e6 21 ♖5f3 ♗e7 22 ♘f5 ♗f8 23 ♖g3 ♔h8 24 ♖h3 ♔g8 25 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 26 ♘h6+ ♗xh6 27 ♕xh6 ♕d7 28 ♖g3+ ♘g4 29 ♖xg4+ ♖g6 30 ♖xg6+ hxg6 31 ♗c4 ♗xe4 32 ♖xf7 ♕xf7 33 ♗xf7+ ♔xf7 34 ♕h4 ♗f5 35 ♕xb4 White wins.

19 ♖af1 ♖e6 20 ♖1f3!

20 ♗h6!? ♘f8 21 ♗xf8 ♔xf8 22 ♕h6+ ♔e8 23 ♖xf6 ♗xf6 24 ♖xf6 ♖xf6 25 ♕xf6 ♖d8 26 ♕h8+ ♔d7 27 ♕xh7 ♔c8 gives chances to both sides.

20...♕c6



White's attack is nearing its zenith. He should now send in the cavalry.

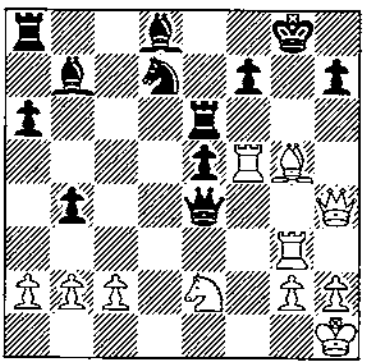
21 ♖g3?

We believe that White needed to include his knight in the attack by means of 21 ♘g3! ♖c8 22 ♘h5 ♘xh5 23 ♕xh5 ♗c7 24 ♕xf7+ ♔h8 25 ♖h3 ♘f8 26 ♗c4 ♕xc4 27 ♗f6+ ♖xf6 28 ♕xf6+ ♔g8 29 ♖g5+ when Black is checkmated in two moves.

21...♘xe4?

It looks like 21...♔f8! 22 ♖gf3 ♔e8 23 ♘g3 ♗e7 24 ♘h5 ♘xh5 25 ♕xh5 ♘f6 26 ♗xf6 ♖xf6 27 ♕xh7 ♕e6 could give Black an advantage.

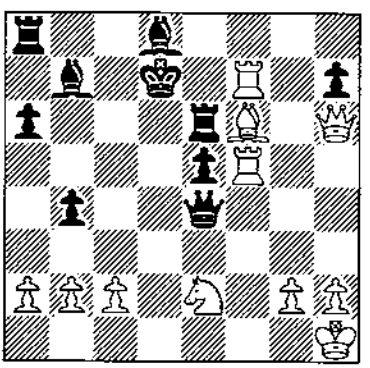
22 ♗xe4 ♕xe4



23 ♗f6+!

This wins material.

23...♔f8 24 ♕h6+ ♔e8 25 ♖g8+ ♘f8 26 ♖xf8+! ♔d7 27 ♖xf7+



27...♗e7

Alternatively, 27...♔c8 28 ♖f2 ♕xc2 29 ♕h3 ♕c6 30 ♗xd8 ♔xd8 31 ♖xb7 wins for White.

28 ♖f2 ♖g8 29 ♖xe7+! ♖xe7 30 ♗xe7 ♖g6

Ciocaltea points out that after 30...♖xg2, 31 ♕d6+ ♔e8 32 ♕d8 is mate; and that 30...♕xg2+ 31 ♖xg2 ♖xg2 32 ♕d6+ ♔e8 33 ♕d8+ ♔f7 34 ♕d7! wins for White.

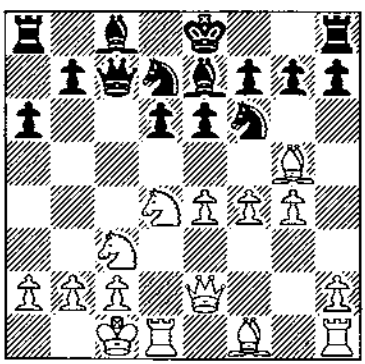
31 ♕f8 ♖xg2

Alternatively, 31...♕xg2+ 32 ♖xg2 ♖xg2 33 ♕d8+ ♔e6 34 ♕b6+ ♔f7 35 ♕xb7 wins.

32 ♕d8+ ♔c6 33 ♖xg2 ♔b5 34 ♕d3+ 1-0

Game 71
R.Calvo Minguez-L.Kavalek
Las Palmas 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♕c7 8 ♕e2 ♘bd7 9 0-0-0 ♗e7 10 g4



10...h6?!

Better is 10...b5!? and then:

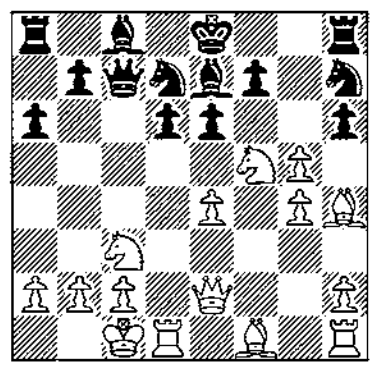
a) According to Velimirovic, 11 ♗g2 ♗b7 (11...b4 12 e5 bxc3 13 exf6 gxf6 14 ♗xa8 fxg5 15 ♕f3 gxf4 16 ♗c6 cxb2+ 17 ♔b1 0-0 18 ♗xd7 ♕xd7 19 ♖he1 ♗g5 20 h4 ♗xh4 21 ♕xf4 was drawn in G.Kuzmin-J.Dorfman, Ordzhonikidze 1978) 12 e5 dxe5 13 fxe5 b4! is unclear.

b) 11 a3 ♗b7 12 ♗g2 0-0-0 13 ♗h4 ♘c5 14 ♗g3 ♖he8? (14...h6 is safer) 15 g5 ♘fd7 16 ♕h5 g6 17 ♕xh7 leaves White with an extra pawn and the better position, E.Najer-M.Kraemer, German League 2007. Black can actually trap White's queen here with 17...♖h8 18 ♕xf7 ♘e5!, but both 19 ♘xe6 ♘xf7 20 ♘xc7 ♔xc7 and 19 ♕xe6+!? ♘xe6 20 ♘xe6 ♕b6 21 fxe5 offer excellent compensation.

11 ♗h4 g5?

11...♘c5!? might still hold the balance.

12 fxg5 ♘h7 13 ♘f5!



White sacrifices his knight to open the e-file for the attack and place his remaining knight on d5.

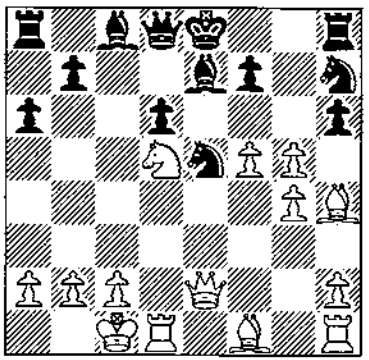
13...exf5

Instructive too is 13...hxg5!? 14 ♗g3 ♘e5 15 ♘xe7 ♔xe7 16 h4 ♗d7 17 ♕d2 ♖hg8 18 ♗e2 b5 19 a3 ♖ab8 20 hxg5 ♘xg5 21 ♖h6 a5 22 ♗h4 f6 23 ♖xf6! ♔xf6 24 ♕f4+ ♔e7 25 ♗xg5+ ♔e8 26 ♕f6 ♖xg5 27 ♕xg5 ♘f7 28 ♕g6 ♕d8 29

♖h1 ♔f8 30 ♖h7 ♕e7 31 ♖g7, which forced Black to resign in J.Howell-G.Timoscenko, Hastings 1991/92.

14 ♘d5 ♕d8 15 exf5 ♘e5

According to Velimirovic, both 15...hxg5 16 ♗g3 and 15...♘xg5 16 ♗g3 are very good for White.



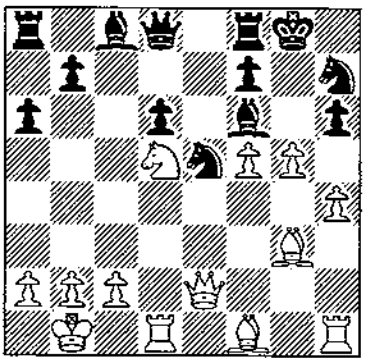
16 ♗g3 ♗xg5+ 17 ♔b1 0-0

Velimirovic points out that other choices are fruitless for Black: 17...f6 18 h4 and White wins back a piece with a big advantage; and 17...♔f8 18 h4 ♗e7 (18...♗f6 19 ♘xf6 ♕xf6 20 ♖xd6! ♕xd6 21 ♗xe5 ♕e7 22 ♗g7+ gives White two extra pawns and winning position) 19 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 20 ♖xd6! ♘c6 21 ♕d2 when the many threats should give an easy win.

18 h4 ♗f6

After 18...♗e7 19 ♗xe5 dxe5 20 g5 ♗d6 21 f6 ♖c8 22 ♕h5 ♗f5 23 ♗c4 ♖c8 24 g6 ♗xc2+ 25 ♔a1 ♖e6 26 gxh7+ ♔h8 27 ♕xf7 ♕f8 28 ♕xe6 ♗xd1 29 ♖xd1 ♖xc4 30 ♖g1 ♔xh7 31 ♕d7+ ♔h8 32 ♕g7+ White wins.

19 g5!



A routine offer to pry open the kingside for further attack.

19...hxg5 20 hxg5 ♗xg5 21 ♗xe5 dxe5 22 ♕g4 ♔g7

After 22...f6, 23 ♖xh7 ♔xh7 24 ♕h5+ ♗h6 25 ♕g6+ ♔h8 26 ♕xh6+ ♔g8 27 ♕g6+ ♔h8 28 ♗g2 checkmates Black's king.

23 f6+! ♔g8

23...♕xf6 24 ♖xh7+ ♔xh7 25 ♘xf6+ ♔g6 26 ♘d7 wins.

24 ♕e4 1-0

After 24...♘xf6 25 ♘xf6+ ♔g7 26 ♖xd8 ♖xd8 27 ♘d5 White wins.

Chapter Five

The Knight Sacrifice on b5

The sacrifice ♘(x)b5 is considerably less common in the Sicilian than its clerical counterpart (♗xb5). One reason for this is that it rarely has any point after Black has castled short, unless Black has been so incautious as to leave a pawn on d6 under-protected, so that a second knight can capture on b5 and then d6 to get a third pawn for the piece. Even then, though, the knight does not give check when it arrives on d6, which certainly affords Black more options for counterplay.

Occasionally a ♘xb5 sacrifice will strip away the pawn cover from a king which has castled long and thus allow a frontal assault by White's heavy pieces. It might also undermine a black knight which has made an unwise sojourn to the square c4. But most often ♘xb5 works when the black king is still in the centre.

Bronstein has pioneered the ♘xb5 attack against the Sveshnikov, but modern theory considers this line more or less harmless for Black. The most useful version of ♘xb5 is that which gets two pawns and gives check to the uncastled enemy king, as in the following example from that self-proclaimed Sicilian beater himself, Dr. John Nunn.

Game 72
J.Nunn-G.Sosonko
Thessaloniki Olympiad 1984

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗e3 a6 8 ♕e2 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘a5

This method of countering the Velimirovic Attack is a bit controversial, as White has the option of retreating his bishop to d3, thus preserving it. However, Black wishes to attend to the development of his queenside at once, reckoning to lessen the impact of White's traditional pawn storm. Prac-

tice has shown this plan to be viable.

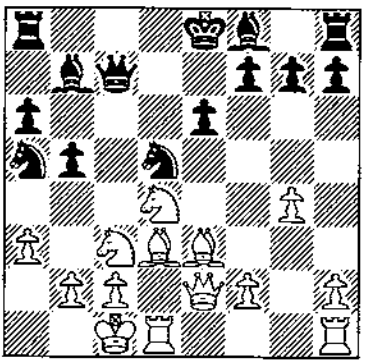
10 ♗d3 b5 11 a3 ♗b7 12 g4!?

Anyway! 12 f4 is an alternative.

12...d5

This break is consistent, but risky. Safer is the anticipatory 12...♘d7, and this looks more logical to us than 12...♖c8 which may commit this rook prematurely.

13 exd5 ♘xd5



14 ♘dxb5! axb5?

As I am fond of telling my students, this is not checkers and captures are not compulsory! Indeed, 14...♕b8! is much more stubborn. Nunn gives 15 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 16 ♘c3 ♗xh1 17 ♖xh1 ♕c7 18 ♗xa6 ♗xa3 as unclear. A couple of years later Hawelka preferred 18 ♘d5!? here against Gaprindashvili, but then 18...♕c6 19 ♗xa6 ♖xa6 20 ♕xa6 ♘b3+! was a clever intermezzo, driving White's king away from the defence of the square d1. The following 21 ♔b1 ♕xd5 22 ♖e1 ♘c5 23 ♗xc5 ♕xc5 24 ♖d1 could have been answered by 24...♕c7, whereas the former Women's World Champion tried 24...♔e7 25. ♕b7+ ♔f6 26 ♖d7 and eventually was checkmated, although she may not have been lost at this stage.

Nunn considers the similar 14...♕e5 15 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 16 f4 ♕b8 17 ♘c3 as unclear, but White is a useful move ahead of Hawelka's line.

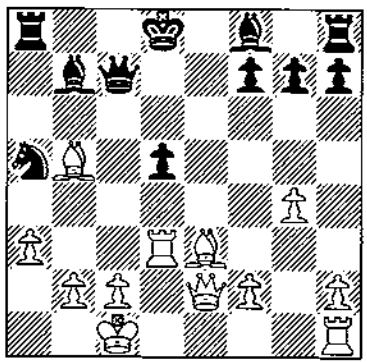
15 ♗xb5+ ♔d8

15...♗c6 16 ♘xd5 exd5 17 ♗b6+ ♕e7 18 ♗xa5 ♕xe2 19 ♗xc6+ ♔e7 20 ♖he1 regains the queen and wins, as analysed by Nunn.

16 ♘xd5 exd5

Or 16...♗xd5 17 ♖xd5+! exd5 18 ♖d1 ♘c6 (best according to Nunn, whose detailed analysis in *Informator 38* gives winning lines against other tries which we have no space to reproduce here) 19 ♖xd5+ ♔c8 20 ♕f3! with a winning attack.

17 ♖d3!



A useful dual-purpose move, clearing a square for the king's rook while activating the queen's rook.

17...♘c4?

A nice line given by the winner is 17...♗e7 18 ♖c3 ♕d6 19 ♖e1! ♗f6 20 ♗b6+! (anyway) 20...♕xb6 21 ♕e8+! and mate next move. The superior

17...♗c5! (Nunn) keeps Black in the game. Then 18 ♖c3 ♗xe3+ 19 ♕xe3 ♕d6 20 ♖e1 ♕e6! looks tenable, so White should continue 18 ♖e1 ♗xe3+ 19 ♖xe3 ♕f4 20 ♔b1 ♔c7 21 ♖f3 ♕d6 22 ♖xf7+ ♔b6 23 ♖e7 with advantage as Nunn prefers.

18 ♖c3 ♗b4

A good last-ditch try.

19 ♖xc4 dxc4 20 ♖d1+ ♔c8 21 ♖d4!

That's all she wrote. The king can't possibly escape the crossfire.

♗d5 22 ♖xd5 ♗d6 23 ♖d4 1-0

Over to Yury for the specifics...

Game 73
T.Horvath-K.Hulak
Virovitica 1980

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 a6 5 ♘c3 ♕c7 6 ♗e2 b5 7 0-0 ♗b7 8 ♖e1 ♘f6

If 8...b4 White may sacrifice with 9 ♘d5! exd5 10 exd5, which deserves further investigation:

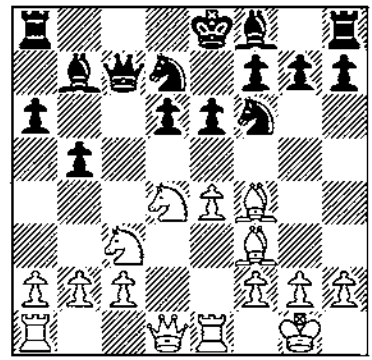
a) After 10...♗c5 11 ♗g5 ♔f8 12 ♗f3 d6 13 ♕e2 ♘d7 14 ♗e7+ ♘xe7 15 ♕xe7+ ♔g8 16 ♘e6 fxe6 the game could finish in perpetual check, but surprisingly after pushing for a win, White lost in L.Fressinet-A.Kogan, Paris 2005.

b) According to Horvath, 10...♘e7 11 ♗h5 g6 12 ♕f3 ♗g7 13 d6! ♗xf3 14 ♖xe7+ ♔d8 15 dxc7+ ♔xe7 16 ♗xf3 ♘c6 17 ♘xc6+ dxc6 18 ♗xc6 ♖ac8 19 ♗f4 ♗xb2 20 ♖e1+ ♔f6 21 ♗d7! gives White an advantage. We believe this analysis needs to be tested in practice.

9 ♗f3 d6 10 ♗f4!

Also possible is 10 a4 when the following entertainment may ensue: 10...bxa4 11 ♘d5 exd5 12 exd5+ ♔d8 13 ♖xa4 ♘xd5 14 ♗g5+ ♗e7 15 ♗xd5 ♗xg5 16 ♖c4 ♕b6 17 ♗xf7 ♗f6 18 ♘e6+ ♔e7 19 ♘xg7+ ♔f8 20 ♖e8+ ♔xg7 21 ♕g4+ and Black resigned, not waiting to be mated in several moves, B.Jobava-H.Steingrimsson, European Team Championship, Crete 2007.

10...♘bd7



After 10...e5? White has several continuations, including all of 11 ♘d5, 11 ♘f5 exf4? 12 e5! when White should have a crushing attack, and 11 ♗g3 exd4? 12 e5! which should also give Black many problems. Likewise, 10...b4 11 e5 bxc3 12 exf6 ♕d7 13 fxg7 ♗xg7 14 ♘f5 ♗f8 15 ♗xb7 ♕xb7 16 ♕h5 cxb2 17 ♖ad1 won for White in V.Nevednichy-P.Deneufeglise, St. Affrique 2004.

11 ♘dxb5!

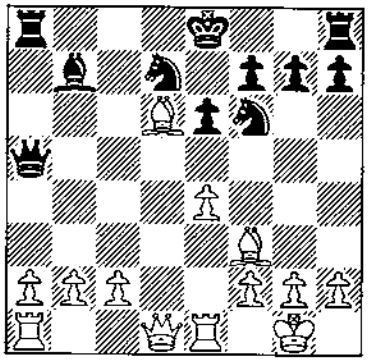
For his knight White will get three passed pawns and an attack.

11...axb5 12 ♘xb5 ♕a5

Instead 12...♕c4!? 13 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 14 b3 ♕c3 15 ♗xd6 ♘e5 16 ♖e3 ♕b2!?

leads to an unclear position, and for 12...♕b6 see the next game.

13 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 14 ♗xd6



Black can't castle to the kingside, but it is dangerous to castle queenside. Now the faster White pushes his three passed pawns, the more problems Black has to face.

14...♘e5 15 ♕d4 ♘c6

15...♘xf3+ 16 gxf3 ♕g5+ 17 ♔h1 ♕h5 18 ♖e3 ♖d8 19 ♖g1 looks good for White.

16 ♕e3 e5

After 16...♘e5 17 ♗e2 ♘ed7 18 ♗d3 White is slightly better.

17 b4 ♕a4 18 c3 0-0-0 19 ♗d1!

Improving the position of his bishop, while preparing a pawn storm on the queenside.

19...♕a3 20 ♕h3+ ♖d7 21 ♗b3 ♔d8

Black tries to unpin his rook, but White has consolidated all his pieces for a devastating attack.

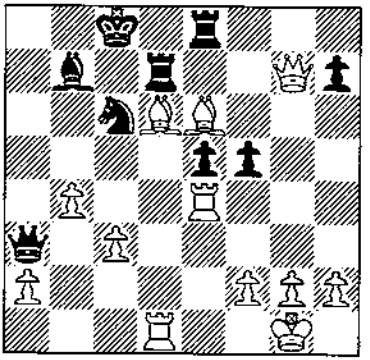
22 ♖ad1 ♖e8 23 ♕g3! ♔c8

Or 23...♖g8 24 b5 ♖xd6 25 bxc6 ♗xc6 26 ♖xd6+ ♕xd6 27 ♖d1 with a decisive gain of material.

24 ♕xg7

The white queen shatters Black's kingside. In this ruined position Black resorts to tactics but to no avail.

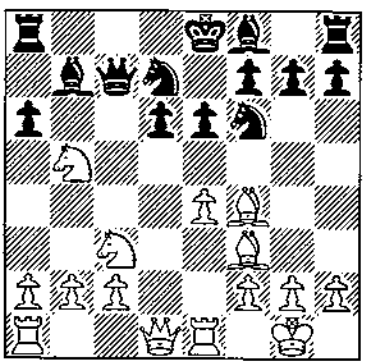
24...♘xe4?! 25 ♖xe4 f5 26 ♗e6! 1-0



Horvath points out that 26...♖xe6 27 ♕g8+ ♘d8 28 ♖c4+ ♗c6 29 ♖xc6+ ♔b7 30 ♖c7+ finishes the story.

Game 74
L.Nisipeanu-D.Solak
Bucharest 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 ♘c3 a6 4 d4 cxd4 5 ♘xd4 ♕c7 6 ♗e2 b5 7 0-0 ♗b7 8 ♖e1 ♘f6 9 ♗f3 d6 10 ♗f4 ♘bd7 11 ♘dxb5!



11...axb5 12 ♘xb5 ♕b6 13 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 14 ♗xd6 ♖d8

Nisipeanu believes that 14...e5 15 c4 ♖a6 16 c5 ♘xc5 17 ♗xe5 0-0 18 ♗d4 gives White good attacking chances.

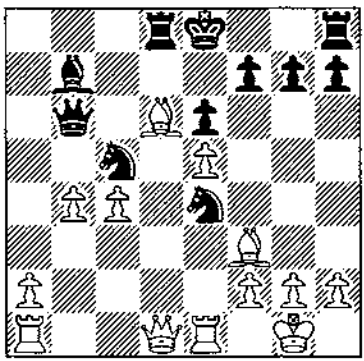
15 c4 ♘c5

After 15...♘e5 the game could continue 16 c5 ♘xf3+ 17 ♕xf3 ♕c6 18 ♕g3 ♖g8 19 f3 g5 20 ♕e5 ♖g6 21 ♖ad1 when *Fritz* prefers White; White's three passed pawns and strong bishop outweigh the extra piece.

16 e5 ♘fe4

According to *Fritz*, 16...♘fd7 is the best try, but after 17 b4! ♕xb4 18 ♗xb7 ♕xb7 19 ♕g4 g6 20 ♕g5 f6 21 exf6 ♖c8 22 ♕h6 ♘xf6 23 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 24 ♖xe6+ ♔f7 25 ♖xf6+! ♔xf6 26 ♕f4+ ♖f5 27 ♕d4+ ♖e5 28 ♖e1 ♖he8 29 f4 White is winning.

17 b4!



In this complicated position nothing can save Black.

17...♘xd6

17...♕xb4 18 ♗xe4 ♗xe4 19 ♖xe4 ♘xe4 20 ♗xb4 ♖xd1+ 21 ♖xd1 leaves Black down two pawns.

18 bxc5 ♗xf3

18...♕xc5!? 19 exd6 ♖xd6 20 ♕a4+ ♗c6 21 ♗xc6+ ♖xc6 22 ♖ab1 0-0 23 ♖ec1 ♖fc8 could offer more resistance.

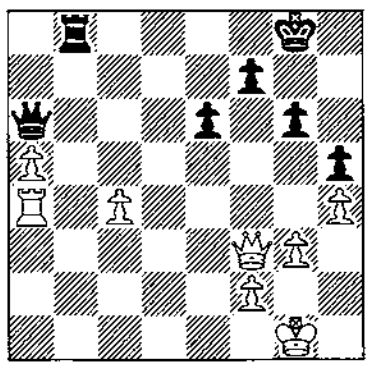
19 ♕xf3 ♕xc5 20 exd6 0-0 21 ♖ed1 ♖xd6 22 ♖xd6 ♕xd6 23 a4

White is up one pawn, but the rest of the game shows how difficult it is to win with two disconnected passed pawns. White's plan is to push his a- and c-pawns and when Black stops them, to switch to an attack on the black king.

23...♖c8 24 a5 ♕a6 25 ♖a4 g6 26 g3 h5

Nisipeanu points out that 26...♖xc4? 27 ♖xc4 ♕xc4 28 ♕a8+ ♔g7 29 a6 is winning for White.

27 h4 ♖b8



28 ♕e4?!

Following 28 ♕d3!? ♕c6 (after the more active 28...♖b2 29 ♕d8+ ♔h7 30 ♕d7 ♖b7 31 ♕d3 ♕c6 32 a6 ♖a7 33 ♖a5 ♖xa6 34 ♖xh5+ ♔g7 35 ♕d4+ f6 36 ♖c5 White is up one pawn and with the better position) 29 ♕c2 ♕a6 30 ♔h2 ♕c6 31 a6 ♖a8 32 ♕a2 ♖b8 33 ♖a5 ♖d8 34 ♕b3 ♖d2 35 ♖a2 ♖d8 36 a7 ♔h7 37 ♕a4 ♕a8 38 c5 e5 39 c6 ♖c8 40 ♕b5 White wins.

28...♖b2 29 ♔g2 ♕a7 30 ♕f3 ♕a6

Now it might look like White is tied up and can't improve his position, whereas our analysis shows that after the inferior 30...♕c5? 31 ♖a1 ♕a7 32 a6 ♔h7 33 ♖a5 ♔g8 34 ♖b5 White is winning.

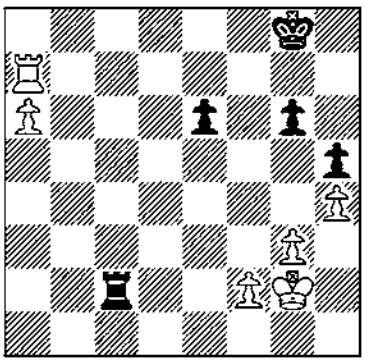
31 ♖a1 ♖c2 32 ♖d1

It's time to take care of the black king.

32...♖xc4?

Absolutely losing. According to Nisipeanu, after 32...♕xa5! 33 ♕f6 ♖d2 34 ♖xd2 ♕xd2 35 ♕e5 White is only slightly better.

33 ♖d8+ ♔g7 34 ♖d7 ♕c6 35 ♖xf7+ ♔g8 36 ♕xc6 ♖xc6 37 ♖a7 ♖c2 38 a6



With an extra passed pawn and an active rook, White can easily win with a king trip to the centre.

38...♖a2 39 ♔f3 ♖a4 40 ♔e3 ♖a2 41 ♔d4 ♖a5 42 ♔c4 e5 43 ♔b4 ♖a2 44 f3 1-0

After 44...♔f8 45 ♖a8+ ♔g7 46 a7 ♖a1 47 ♔c5 ♔h7 48 ♔d5 ♖a5+ 49 ♔d6 ♔g7 50 ♔e6 ♖a6+ 51 ♔xe5 White easily wins with two extra pawns.

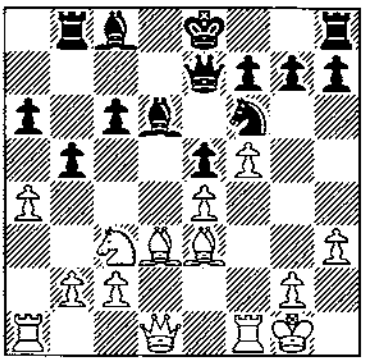
Game 75
J.Becerra Rivero-A.Zapata
San Juan 2006

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 a6 5 ♗d3 ♘f6 6 ♘c3 ♕c7 7 0-0 ♘c6 8 ♗e3 b5 9 ♘xc6 dxc6 10 a4 ♗b7

Black has some alternatives:

a) After 10...b4 11 ♘b1 ♗e7 12 ♘d2 0-0 13 ♘c4 c5 14 ♕f3 e5 15 ♕g3 ♘g4 16 ♗c1 h5 17 f3 h4 18 ♕e1 ♘h6 19 ♘e3 ♗e6 20 ♗c4 ♔h7 21 a5 ♗xc4 22 ♘xc4 ♖ad8 23 ♗xh6 ♔xh6 24 ♘e3 g6 25 ♕e2 White got a positional advantage which he converted to a win in P.Zarnicki-E.Peralta, Cascavel 1996.

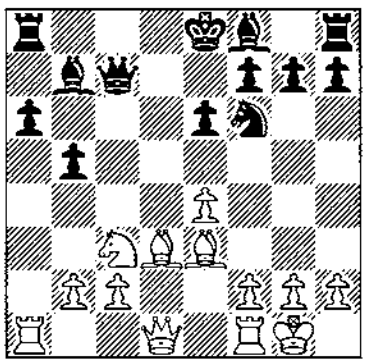
b) 10...♖b8 11 f4 (11 e5!? is an interesting speculation; then 11...♕xe5 12 axb5 cxb5 13 ♗a7 ♖a8 14 ♗d4 ♕b8 15 ♗xf6 gxf6 16 ♕f3 is one intriguing possibility) 11...e5 12 h3 ♗d6 13 f5 ♕e7



14 ♔h1?! (hereabouts White loses a lot of his advantage; we are not sure, but this move might be the culprit and 14 axb5 followed by ♕f3 might be better) 14...♗c5 15 ♕f3 ♗b7 16 ♘e2 0-0 17

♗g5 ♕c7 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♘g3 ♔h8 20 ♘h5 ♗e7 21 ♕e3 ♖g8 22 ♖fd1 c5 23 axb5 c4 24 ♗e2 axb5 25 ♗f3 ♕c6 26 ♖d5 ♕e8 27 ♖d2 ♖g5 28 h4 ♖g8 29 ♕h6 ♕f8 30 ♕xf8 ♖gxf8 31 ♖d7 ♗c5 32 ♘xf6 is better for White, but Black escaped with a draw in S.Haslinger-N.Miezis, Liverpool 2006.

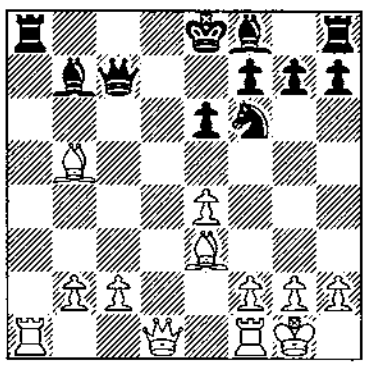
11 axb5 cxb5



12 ♘xb5!!

For the knight White will get two pawns and an attack on the uncastled black king.

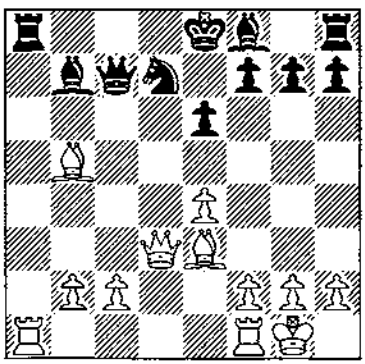
12...axb5 13 ♗xb5+



13...♘d7

According to Becerra and Moreno, after 13...♔e7 14 ♕e2! ♗xe4 (or 14...♘xe4 15 ♖xa8 ♗xa8 16 ♖a1 ♗b7 17 ♖a7 ♘d6 18 b4! ♘c8 19 ♗c5+ ♔f6 20 ♗d4+ ♔e7 21 ♗e5 ♕b6 22 ♕d3! and White's mating threats should win the game) 15 ♗d4 ♖xa1 (or 15...♕b7 16 ♗c5+ ♔d8 17 ♖xa8+ ♕xa8 18 ♗b6+ ♔e7 19 ♖d1 ♗d5 20 ♕e5 ♕c8 21 ♗a5 ♕b7 22 ♗b4+ ♔d8 23 ♗xf8 ♕xb5 24 ♗xg7 ♖g8 25 ♗xf6+ ♔c8 26 g3 and White wins) 16 ♖xa1 ♕xc2 17 ♕e3 e5 (the best way to try to free Black's pieces and escape checkmate) 18 ♗xe5 ♘d5 19 ♕a7+ ♔e6 20 ♗c3! ♘xc3 21 ♖a6+ White's crushing attack will shortly decide proceedings.

14 ♕d3!



Preparing to seize the a-file and put more even more pressure on the pinned knight.

14...♗e7?

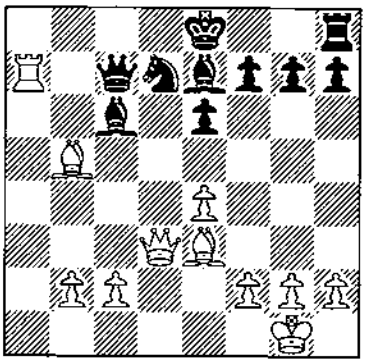
Becerra and Moreno point out that Black can survive White's attack after 14...0-0-0! 15 ♗a6 ♘b8! (15...♗c5? 16 ♗xb7+ ♕xb7 17 ♕c4 ♕b4 18 ♖a4! ♕xc4 19 ♖xc4 wins two pawns) 16 ♗xb7+ ♕xb7 17 ♕c4+ ♕c6 18 ♕b3 ♖d7 19 ♗f4! ♗d6 (or 19...♖b7 20 ♕g3 and we believe that both sides have chances to

win) 20 ♗xd6 ♖xd6 21 ♖a4 when White has enough compensation for the material deficit and either side could win the game.

15 ♖xa8+

15 ♗f4! ♕c8 16 ♖fd1 0-0 17 ♗xd7 should be winning for White.

15...♗xa8 16 ♖a1 ♗c6 17 ♖a7



17...♕c8?

Better was 17...♗xb5 18 ♕xb5 ♕d6 19 g3 as given by Becerra and Moreno, and now Yury's suggestion of 19...♖f8!, defending the rook and preparing a counterblow on the kingside, looks good to us.

18 ♕c3 ♘b8

18...♗b7 19 ♕xg7 ♖f8 20 ♕d4 ♗c6 21 ♕c4 ♗b7 22 ♕a4, as analysed by the winner, leaves Black in a pickle.

19 ♕xg7 ♗xb5

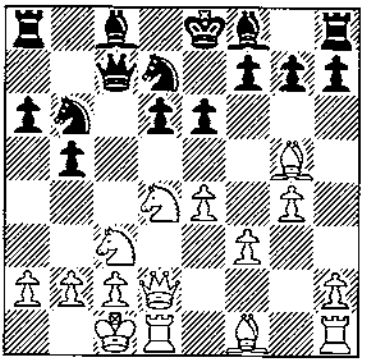
Instead 19...♖f8 20 ♖xe7+ ♔xe7 21 ♗c5+ ♔d7 22 ♕xf8 ♕xf8 (or 22...♗xb5 23 ♕d6+ ♔e8 24 ♕e7 mate) 23 ♗xc6+ ♘xc6 24 ♗xf8 is given by the winner as a trivial win.

20 ♕xh8+ ♗f8 21 ♗h6 1-0

There follows 21...♘d7 22 ♕g8! with a deadly 'tickle' on f7.

Game 76
P.Smirnov-S.Shipov
Russian Championship, Elista 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 f3 e6 7 ♗e3 b5 8 g4 ♘fd7 9 ♕d2 ♘b6 10 0-0-0 ♘8d7 11 ♗g5 ♕c7



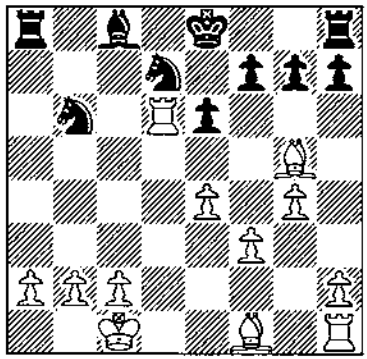
12 ♘dxb5!?

An interesting alternative is 12 ♔b1!? ♗b7 13 ♘dxb5 axb5 14 ♘xb5 ♕c5 15 b4 ♕c6 16 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 17 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 18 ♖xd6 ♘a4 19 ♔c1 ♗c8, as in P.Svidler-K.Georgiev, Istanbul Olympiad 2000, and now 20 c4!? h5 (20...♘c3 21 a3 h5 22 ♔c2 is better for White) 21 c5 f6 22 ♗d2 hxg4 23 fxg4 ♔e7 24 h4 e5 25 ♗c4 ♘axc5 26 bxc5 ♘xc5 27 ♖c6 ♘xe4 28 ♗b4+ ♔d8 29 ♖d1+ gives White the advantage.

12...axb5 13 ♘xb5 ♕c6 14 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 15 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 16 ♖xd6

Giving up a piece for three passed pawns looks wrong, especially as White has no knight on c3 and might get hit by a timely ...h5. However, mat-

ters are still by no means easy for Black.



16...♗a6!

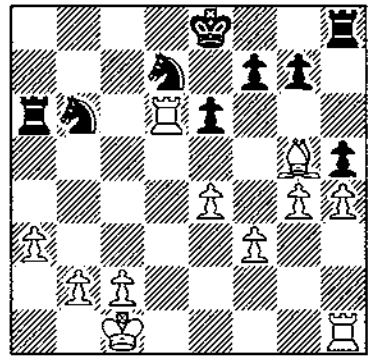
According to Shipov, 16...♖xa2 17 ♔b1 ♖a5 18 ♗d2! ♖a8 19 ♗b5 0-0 (after 19...♔d8 20 ♖d1 ♔c7 21 ♗e3 ♖a5 22 c4 White is better) 20 ♖d1 gives White the advantage. Meanwhile after 16...0-0 White has a simple plan to get the better position: 17 ♗e3 ♘a4 18 b3 ♘ac5 19 a4 ♘a6 20 ♗e2 ♘e5 21 ♖hd1 ♘b8 22 ♗c5 ♗a6 23 c4 with a huge advantage, S.Karjakin-H.Nakamura, Cuernavaca 2004.

17 ♗xa6 ♖xa6 18 a3 h5!

Black is trying to create a weakness in the white camp.

19 h4!

White has to take care of his weak pawns. After 19 gxh5 ♖a5 20 h4 ♘c4 21 ♖c6 ♖c5 22 ♖xc5 ♘xc5 23 b3 ♘xa3 24 h6 gxh6 25 ♗e3 ♘b7 26 ♔b2 ♘b5 27 e5 ♖g8 28 ♗xh6 ♘d4 29 h5 ♖g2 30 ♔c3 ♘xf3 31 ♗f4 this complicated, roughly equal position ended as a draw in R.Ponomariov-P.Svidler, FIDE World Championship, Moscow 2001.



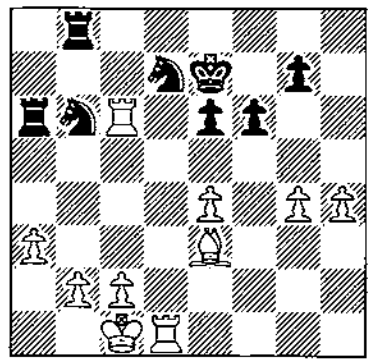
19...hxg4 20 fxg4 f6

According to Shipov, 20...♖a4 21 ♖hd1 0-0 22 ♖xd7 ♘xd7 23 ♖xd7 ♖xe4 24 b4 ♖xg4 25 b5 is better for Black, but this is not so clear to us.

21 ♗e3 ♔e7 22 ♖hd1! ♖b8?

Shipov points out that 22...♖xh4 23 ♗xb6 ♘xb6 24 c4 ♖a4 25 ♖xb6 ♖xc4+ 26 ♔b1 ♖xe4 27 ♖b7+ ♔e8 28 g5! gives White an advantage. However, with 22...♘d5! 23 ♖xd7+ (or 23 ♖xa6 ♘xe3 24 ♖d3 ♘xg4 and the coming ...♘ge5 will make matters far from clear) 23...♔xd7 24 ♗f2 ♖a4 25 exd5 ♖xg4 26 dxe6+ ♔xe6 Black should hold.

23 ♖c6!



Intending 24 ♖c7.

23...♖a7

Shipov mentions 23...♘e5 24 ♗c5+ ♔f7 25 ♖c7+ ♔g6 26 ♖d6 ♘xg4 27 ♖xe6 when the pin on the knight will be painful.

24 ♖dd6 ♖ab7 25 ♖xe6+ ♔f7 26 g5 ♘c8 27 ♗f4

Possible too was 27 gxf6!? ♘xf6 28 b4 and the mass of passed pawns gives White an advantage.

27...♖a8 28 h5?!

28 ♖a6!? fxg5 29 hxg5 ♘cb6 30 ♖xa8 ♔xe6 31 ♖a5 ♘c4 32 ♖a6+ keeps White on top.

28...fxg5 29 ♗xg5 ♖a5?!

Again not best: 29...♘b8! 30 ♖xc8 ♔xe6 31 ♗f4 ♔d7 32 ♖g8 ♔e6 offers better prospects of a successful defence.

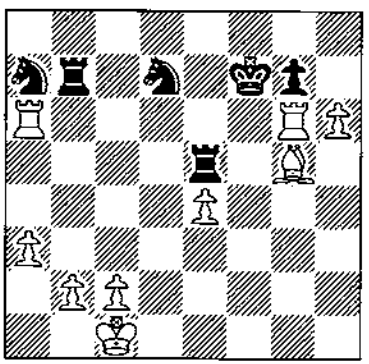
30 ♖g6?

30 h6! ♖xg5 31 h7 ♖h5 32 ♖h6! is a direct win according to Shipov.

30...♘a7 31 ♖a6 ♖e5?

The errors flow on: 31...♖xa6 32 ♖xa6 ♘c5 33 ♖a5 ♘xe4 would have kept Black in the game.

32 h6!



After all that, White will win with a direct attack on the king.

32...gxh6 33 ♗xh6 ♖xe4 34 ♖g7+ ♔e8 35 ♗g5! ♔f8 36 ♖ag6 ♘c6! 37 ♖h7!

37 ♗h6 ♘e7! is less clear.

37...♘e7 38 ♖gg7 ♘b6 39 ♗f6! 1-0

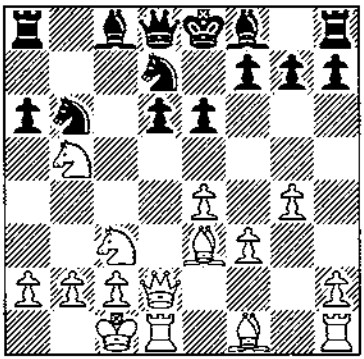
We now come to a game played in the last round of the U.S. Championship. The two grandmasters involved were competing for a high place and big money. I was playing in the same tournament near their table and tried to beat GM Larry Christiansen for a top-10 finish. However, with an extra pawn and a winning position, I couldn't find the right plan and only drew the game. Let's see if those involved in this sharp Sicilian struggle handled the pressure any better.

Game 77
J.Becerra Rivero-I.Novikov
U.S. Championship, San Diego 2004

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 f3 b5 8 g4 ♘fd7 9 ♕d2 ♘b6 10 0-0-0 ♘8d7 11 ♘dxb5!?

I am sure this sacrifice was Becerra's opening preparation. In this tournament everyone played one game per day and Becerra had a whole day to prepare for Novikov's Najdorf (which he has played all his life). Many strong players have spent many hours trying to surprise him, but he has always been ready for almost everything. Indeed, this game is another example

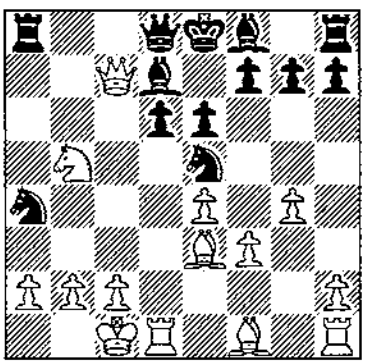
of Novikov's knowledge of the variation.



11...axb5 12 ♘xb5 ♘e5

After 12...♗a6 13 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 14 ♕xd6 ♘c4 15 ♗xc4 ♗xc4 16 a3 ♕c8 17 ♖d2 ♖a6 18 ♕b4 e5 19 ♖hd1 ♗e6 20 g5 ♖c6 21 ♔b1 ♖c4 22 ♕d6 ♖c6 23 ♕b4 ♖c4 24 ♕d6 the game was drawn, S.Karjakin-V.Anand, Benidorm (rapid) 2003.

13 ♕c3 ♘a4 14 ♕c7 ♗d7!

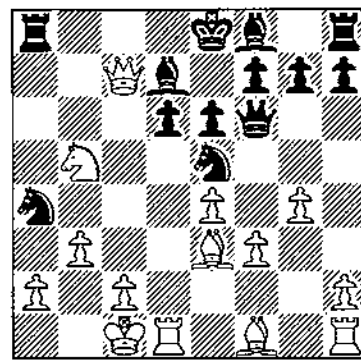


Several years ago Nick witnessed a game where Black couldn't even find his mistake in the post-mortem: 14...♕f6?! 15 f4 ♘d7 16 e5 ♕d8 17 ♕c6 ♕a5 18 ♗d2 ♘c3 19 ♗xc3 and Black resigned because he was losing more material, M.Thaler-M.Arnold, New York 2005.

15 b3

Instead 15 ♘xd6+!? ♗xd6 16 ♕xd6 f6 17 g5 ♘f7 18 ♕d3 ♖b8 gives chances to both sides. Here too, though, Black has 18...fxg5 19 b3 ♘e5 20 ♕d6 ♘f7 (after 20...♘c3?! 21 ♕xe5 ♘xd1 22 ♕xg7 ♘xe3 23 ♕xh8+ ♔f7 24 ♕xh7+ ♔f8 25 ♕h8+ ♔f7 26 ♕xd8 ♖xd8 27 ♗d3 we believe White has more chances to win this ending because of his three connected passed pawns) 21 ♕d3 ♘e5 with a repetition.

15...♕f6!



Black returns the extra piece, but gets a couple of pawns, ruins White's structure and opens up the white king. Not a bad bargain.

16 bxa4

Maybe White should consider 16 f4 ♘xg4 17 e5, but Black has good chances after 17...♕d8 or 17...♕h4.

16...♕xf3 17 ♗d4 ♕xe4

Our analysis shows that after 17...♕xh1 18 ♗xe5 ♕xe4 19 ♖xd6 ♖d8 20 ♖d4 ♕e3+ 21 ♔b2 f6 22 ♗d6 ♖c8 23

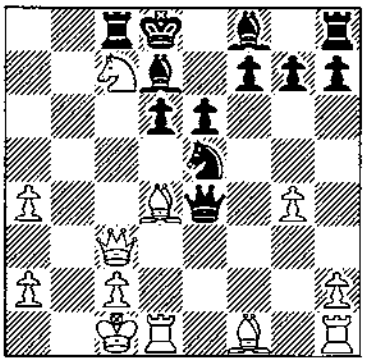
♕b7 ♖d8 24 ♗xf8 ♖xf8 25 ♕a7 ♕e5 26 ♘d6+ ♔e7 27 ♗b5 ♕xd4+ 28 ♕xd4 ♗xb5 29 axb5 ♖xd6 30 ♕a7+ White is winning, although this line really requires further investigation.

18 ♕c3?

This is no time to go backwards. After the aggressive 18 ♕b6! ♖d8 19 ♘c7+ ♔e7 20 ♗b5 (threatening ♖he1) 20...♘f3 21 ♖hf1 ♘xd4 22 ♖xd4 ♕e5 23 ♖f5 exf5 24 ♘d5+ ♔e8 25 ♘c7+ ♔e7 26 ♘d5+ we found a draw, but we suspect that further analysis by others may uncover more ideas for White.

18...♖c8 19 ♘c7+ ♔d8!

This winning move, attacking the white knight, required serious confidence, as Black will come under a dangerous attack which must slowly be beaten off. Instead after 19...♔e7 20 ♗a6 ♕f4+ 21 ♖d2 ♘f3 22 ♗xc8 ♘xd2 23 ♕xd2 ♕xd2+ 24 ♔xd2 ♗xc8 25 a5 e5 26 ♗b6 ♗xg4 27 a6 g6 28 a7 ♗f3 29 ♖b1 ♗h6+ 30 ♔e1 ♔d7 31 ♗a5 ♖c8 32 ♖b8 ♖xc7 (32...♗g5 33 c4 ♗c6 34 ♘d5 is even worse) 33 ♗xc7 ♔xc7 34 a8♕ ♗xa8 35 ♖xa8 White is better.



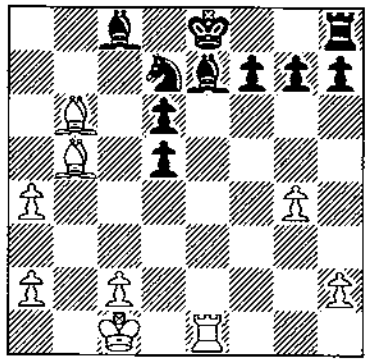
20 ♗b6 ♕xh1 21 ♘d5+ ♔e8 22 ♕xc8+

According to Bruzon and Ibarra, 22 ♘c7+ ♔e7 23 ♗a6 ♕f3 is winning for Black.

22...♗xc8 23 ♗b5+ ♘d7! 24 ♖xh1 exd5 25 ♖e1+

Bruzon and Ibarra point out that 25 a5 ♗e7 26 ♗d4 ♔d8 wins for Black.

25...♗e7



Down one piece, White is simply losing.

26 ♗c7 ♔f8 27 a5

White's passed pawn is his hope for survival, but Novikov is a master of the art of eliminating threats.

27...♘c5 28 a6 ♘e6 29 ♗b8 ♗g5+ 30 ♔d1 ♔e7 31 a7 ♗b7 32 ♔e2 d4 33 ♖b1 ♖c8 34 ♗a6 ♗xa6+ 35 ♔d1 ♗e2+ 36 ♔xe2 ♖xc2+ 37 ♔d3 ♖xa2 38 ♖b7+ ♔f6 39 ♗xd6 ♖a4 40 ♗b4 ♗e3 41 h4 h6 42 h5 g6 43 ♔e4 ♗f4 44 ♗e7+ ♔g7 45 ♔d3 ♗c7 46 ♔c2 d3+ 47 ♔xd3 ♗e5 0-1

Game 78
C.Lutz-B.Gelfand
Budapest 2003

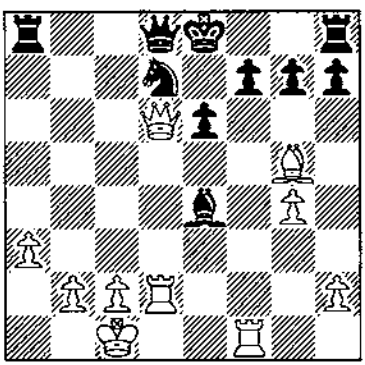
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6

5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗e3 e6 7 f3 b5 8 g4 ♘fd7 9 ♕d2 ♘b6 10 0-0-0 ♘8d7 11 ♘dxb5 axb5 12 ♘xb5 ♗a6 13 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 14 ♕xd6 ♘c4 15 ♗xc4 ♗xc4 16 a3

A year later Browne tried the natural queen fork 16 ♕d4 against the well-prepared Wojtkiewicz: 16...♖xa2 17 ♔b1 ♕c8 18 ♕xg7 ♖f8 19 ♖xd7! ♔xd7 20 ♖d1+ ♔c6 21 b3 ♕a6 22 ♕e5 ♕a3 23 ♕d4 ♖a1+ 24 ♕xa1 ♕xa1+ 25 ♔xa1 ♗e2 26 ♖d4 e5 27 ♖a4 f6 28 f4 exf4 29 ♗xf4 ♗xg4 30 ♔b2 and White's two extra pawns were decisive in W.Browne-A.Wojtkiewicz, Fort Lauderdale 2004.

16...♗e2 17 ♖d2 ♗xf3 18 ♖f1 ♗xe4 19 ♗g5

A new idea at the time. 19 ♖fd1 had occurred previously.



19...f6 20 ♕xe6+!

Lutz considered the alternatives 20 ♖e1 ♕e7 21 ♖xe4 ♕xd6 22 ♖xd6 fxg5 and 20 ♖fd1 fxg5 21 ♕xe6+ ♕e7 22 ♕xe7+ ♔xe7 23 ♖xd7+ ♔e6 24 ♖xg7 ♖hc8, which are both good for Black.

20...♕e7 21 ♕xe7+ ♔xe7 22 ♖e2!?

22 ♖e1 fxg5 23 ♖xe4+ ♔d8 is unclear according to Goloshchapov.

22...♘c5

Instead 22...fxg5 23 ♖xe4+ ♔d8 24 ♖f7 keeps an edge, according to Lutz.

23 ♗d2

Not the only try: 23 ♗e3 ♘e6 24 ♗h6 gxh6 25 ♖xe4 ♖he8 gives chances to both sides, while 23 ♖f5!? fxg5 24 ♖xc5 ♔d6 25 ♖xg5 ♗g6 is unclear.

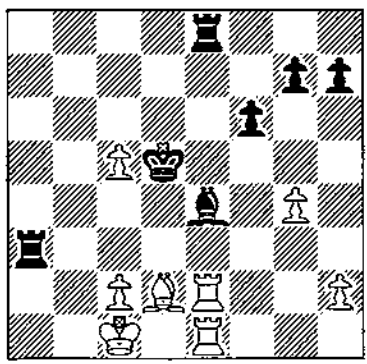
23...♖he8?

Black can't save the piece, but he can sell it for a good price. However, this is the wrong way, whereas the superior 23...♔d6 24 b4 ♖xa3 25 bxc5+ ♔d5 should hold in Lutz's view.

24 ♖fe1 ♔d6 25 b4 ♖xa3

25...♘b3+ 26 cxb3 ♖ec8+ 27 ♗c3 ♖xc3+ 28 ♔b2 is good for White.

26 bxc5+ ♔d5



27 ♗b4?

A mistake in time trouble. Lutz claims a win with 27 c4+! ♔d4 28 ♔b2! ♖d3 (28...♖h3 29 ♖xe4+ ♖xe4 30 ♖xe4+ ♔xe4 31 c6 wins; 28...♖a6 29 ♗c3+ ♔d3 30 ♖e3+ wins a piece) 29 ♗c3+ ♔xc4 30 ♖xe4+ ♖xe4 31 ♖xe4+ ♔xc5 32 ♖e7 ♖h3 33 ♖xg7 h5 34 ♖h7 ♔c4 35 ♗xf6 ♖xh2+ 36 ♔c1 and it's all over.

27...♖a1+ 28 ♔b2 ½-½

Actually White might still be better.

Game 79
J.Rigo-C.Busu
Romania 1978

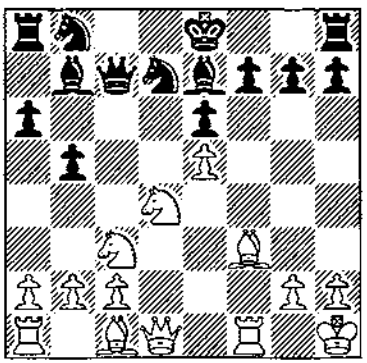
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 a6 5 ♗e2!? ♘f6 6 ♘c3 d6 7 0-0 ♗e7 8 ♔h1 ♕c7 9 f4 b5?!

This move will lead to problems on the a8-h1 diagonal. All of 9...0-0, 9...♘c6 and 9...♘bd7 are safer choices in this position.

10 ♗f3 ♗b7 11 e5! dxe5

Even worse is 11...♘fd7? 12 exd6 ♗xd6 13 ♘dxb5 axb5 14 ♘xb5 ♕b6 15 ♘xd6+ ♔e7 16 ♗xb7 ♖a7 17 ♘c8+, which was catastrophic for Black who resigned here in O.Gutdeutsch-A.Palas, Decin 1997.

12 fxe5 ♘fd7

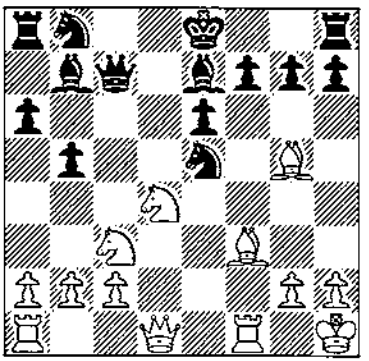


13 ♗g5!?

Possibly more promising is the routine 13 ♗xb7 ♕xb7 14 ♕g4 ♘c6 (14...g6 is safer) 15 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 16 a4 ♕c4? (16...b4 was necessary) 17 ♖f4 ♕c5 18 ♕xg7 0-0-0 19 ♕xf7 ♕xe5 20 ♗d2 ♗g5 21 ♖e4 ♕f6 22 ♕xf6 ♗xf6 23 ♖xe6 b4 24 ♘e4 ♗xb2 25 ♖b1 ♖hf8 26 ♗xb4 and Black gave up in A.Sokolov-R.Jacques, St. Martin 1992.

13...♘xe5

It seems that Black may be able to survive 13...♗xg5! 14 ♘dxb5: for example, 14...axb5 15 ♘xb5 ♕xe5 16 ♘d6+ ♔e7 17 ♘xf7 ♔xf7 18 ♗xb7+ ♗f6 19 ♗xa8 ♕xb2 is certainly far from clear.



14 ♘dxb5!?

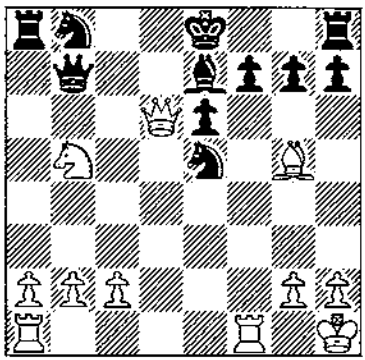
The idea this time is to occupy d6 with the white queen, as will shortly become evident.

14...axb5 15 ♘xb5 ♕b6?

The correct 15...♕d7! contains a lovely defensive idea, to wit 16 ♗xb7 ♖a5!, attacking a substantial portion of the white army: 17 ♕xd7+ (White avoids both 17 a4 ♕xb7 18 ♕d2 ♘bc6 and 17 c4 ♕xd1 18 ♖fxd1 ♗xg5) 17...♘bxd7 18 ♘c7+ ♔d8 and now the best choice for White in this uncomfortable situation is perhaps the striking 19 ♖xf7!? ♘xf7 20 ♘xe6+ ♔e8 21 ♘xg7+ ♔f8 22 ♘e6+. Then if Black declines the repetition with 22...♔g8, there is 23 ♗xe7 ♖e5 24 ♗h4 ♖xe6 25

♖f1 when we feel that in this position White's four pawns and bishop-pair offer good compensation for his missing rook.

16 ♗xb7 ♕xb7 17 ♕d6!!



A nasty shock for Black. The queen attacks the crucial squares e7, c7 and e5 all at once.

17...0-0?

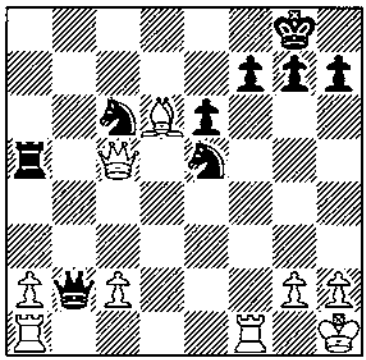
17...♘bc6! looks to us the best chance, as 18 ♘c7+ ♕xc7! 19 ♕xc7 ♗xg5 avoids immediate doom, but in the long term after something like 20 ♖fe1 ♗d8 21 ♕d6 ♗e7 22 ♕d2 0-0 23 a4 White's passed pawns should roll and collect at least a piece.

Instead 17...♘a6 18 ♕xe5! f6 19 ♘d6+ ♗xd6 (or 19...♔d7 20 ♘xb7 fxe5 21 ♖f7 ♖he8 22 ♖d1+) 20 ♕xd6 fxg5 21 ♕xe6+ is winning for White, as pointed out by the winner.

18 ♗xe7 ♕xb5

18...♖c8 19 ♕xe5 ♖xc2 20 ♕g5 h6 21 ♘d6 hxg5 22 ♘xb7 ♖c7 23 ♗xg5 ♖xb7 24 ♖f2 leaves Black with minimal drawing chances.

19 ♗xf8 ♘bc6 20 ♕c5! ♕xb2 21 ♗d6 ♖a5



22 ♕xa5!

White uses tactics to liquidate to a won ending.

22...♘xa5 23 ♖ab1 ♘ec4 24 ♖xb2 ♘xb2 25 ♖b1 ♘ac4 26 a4! 1-0

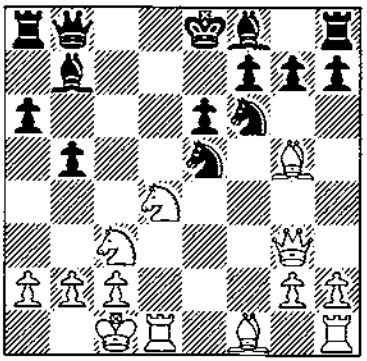
Game 80
A.Martin Gonzalez-
J.Magem Badals
Spanish Championship 1986

Notes are based heavily on the winner's in *Informator 42*.

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 ♕d3 ♘bd7 8 0-0-0 b5 9 f4 ♗b7 10 e5 dxe5 11 fxe5 ♘xe5 12 ♕g3 ♕b8?!

A new idea, but probably not a good one. Critical is 12...♘ed7 13 ♘dxb5 axb5 14 ♗xb5 ♗c8, although after 15 ♗xf6 gxf6 16 ♖d4 ♗c5 17 ♖c4 ♕b6 18 ♖d1 ♔e7 19 ♖e4 ♔d8 20 ♕g7 ♖e8 21 ♕xf7 ♖e7 22 ♕xf6 ♖xa2 23 ♘xa2 ♕xb5 24 ♖xe6 ♕a4 25 ♕f8+ ♔c7 26 ♖xe7 ♗xe7 27 ♕xe7 ♕xa2 28 ♕d6+ ♔d8 29 ♕b6+ ♔e7 30 ♕d6+ ♔d8 31 ♕b6+ ♔e7 32 ♕b4+ ♔d8 33 ♖d3 Black had to

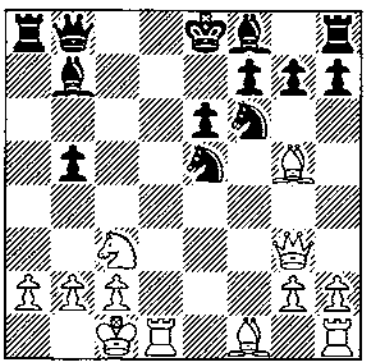
resign in V.Kupreichik-V.Dydyshko, Minsk 2000.



13 ♘dxb5!

Much stronger than 13 ♗f4? ♘h5.

13...axb5



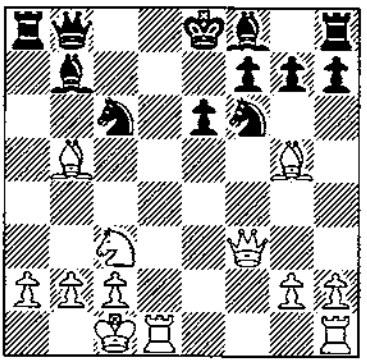
14 ♗xb5+?!

More promising is 14 ♗f4! pinning the black knight. The winner believed that 14...♗c6 (14...♘h5? 15 ♗xe5 ♘xg3 16 ♗xb5+ wins) was a good response, but after 15 ♗xe5 ♕b7 White has the trick 16 ♘xb5! ♗xb5 (or 16...♘e4 17 ♕e3! ♗xb5 18 ♕xe4 ♗c6 19 ♕d4 f6 20 ♗xf6 ♖xa2 21 ♔b1 ♕a8 22 ♕d8+ ♔f7 23 ♕xa8 ♖xa8 24 ♗c3 and the extra pawn is not as significant as the two white passers; White has a big plus) 17 ♕b3 ♗c6 18 ♕xb7 ♗xb7 19 ♗b5+ ♔e7 20 ♗d6+ ♔d8 21 ♗xf8+, winning.

14...♘c6

A weaker defence was 14...♗c6 15 ♕xe5! ♕xe5 16 ♗xc6+ ♔e7 17 ♖d7+ ♔e8 18 ♖d5+ and White wins.

15 ♕f3



15...♕c7?

Missing 15...♕c8 16 ♗xf6 gxf6 17 ♘e4 (17 ♕xf6? ♖g8 18 ♘d5 ♖xa2) and then our discovery of 17...f5!, which we believe demonstrates equality: 18 ♘f6+ ♔e7 19 ♕f4 ♔xf6! (19...h5? 20 ♕g5 ♗h6 21 ♘g8+ ♔f8 22 ♘xh6 ♖xa2 23 ♗xc6 ♖a1+ 24 ♔d2 ♖xd1+ 25 ♖xd1 ♗xc6 26 ♕f6 ♖h7 27 ♘xf7 wins for White) 20 ♕h4+ and it's perpetual check.

16 ♗xf6 gxf6 17 ♕xf6 ♖g8 18 ♘d5!

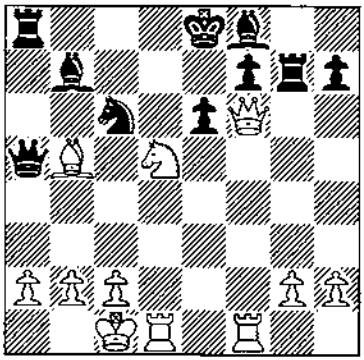
The tempo this move gains makes all the difference.

18...♕a5!?

Alternatively, 18...exd5 19 ♗xc6+! (19 ♖he1+ ♗e7 20 ♗xc6+ ♔f8! is a mess) 19...♗xc6 20 ♖he1+ ♗e7 21 ♖xe7+ is conclusive. The best try was 18...♕d6! 19 ♖hf1 ♖g7 20 ♘b6 ♕e7, although after 21 ♘xa8 (21 ♕f4!? ♖d8! resists)

21...♕xf6 (21...♗xa8 22 ♕d4 keeps a pull) 22 ♘c7+ ♔e7 23 ♖xf6 ♔xf6 24 ♘e8+ ♔e7 25 ♘xg7 ♗xg7 26 a4 White is better.

19 ♖hf1 ♖g7

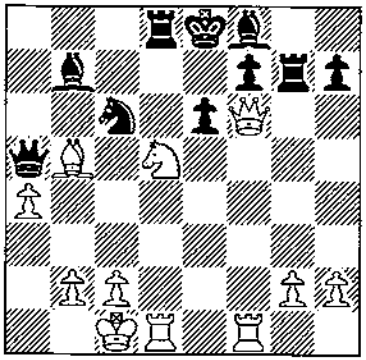


20 a4!

This looks like the best.

20...♖d8

Otherwise, 20...♖c8 21 ♕e5 ♖g6 22 ♗xc6+ and the queen will drop off.



21 b4 ♗xb4 22 ♘xb4 ♖xd1+ 23 ♖xd1 ♖g6

Time trouble. Resigning was equally good.

24 ♗xc6+ ♗xc6 25 ♕h8+ 1-0

A fiendishly difficult game to analyse!

Game 81
B.Rogulj-Kr.Georgiev
Varna 1977

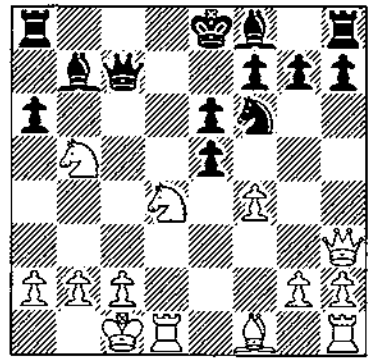
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♕c7 8 ♕f3 ♘bd7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 ♗xf6!? ♘xf6

Minev prefers 10...gxf6 to the text.

11 e5 ♗b7 12 ♕h3 dxe5

12...♘e4!? 13 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 14 ♕e3 d5 looks equal to us.

13 ♘cxb5!



13...axb5

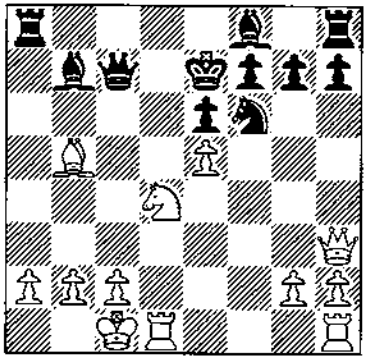
The knight can be ignored:

a) 13...♕b8 14 ♘xe6! axb5 15 ♗xb5+ ♔e7 16 ♘g5 with the threat of ♖d7+, and if, say, 16...♕c8, then 17 ♕b3 ♘d5 18 ♖xd5 ♗xd5 19 ♕xd5 with numerous crushing threats.

b) 13...♕b6!? 14 fxe5 ♘e4 15 ♗c4 (15 ♕b3 ♘c5! 16 ♘d6+ ♕xd6 17 ♕xb7!? ♘xb7 18 exd6 ♘xd6 19 ♗d3 looks like an edge for White) 15...♘f2 16 ♕b3 0-0-0 17 ♘d6+ ♖xd6 18 exd6 ♕xb3 19 ♘xb3 ♘xh1 20 ♘c5 ♗xg2 21 ♗xe6+

♔d8! 22 ♗xf7 g6 23 ♔b1 ♗c6 24 ♘e6+ ♔d7 25 ♘c5+ ♔d8 26 ♘e6+ was drawn in M.Carlsen-B.Gelfand, Biel 2005.

14 ♗xb5+ ♔e7 15 fxe5



15...♕xe5

Again Black has alternatives:

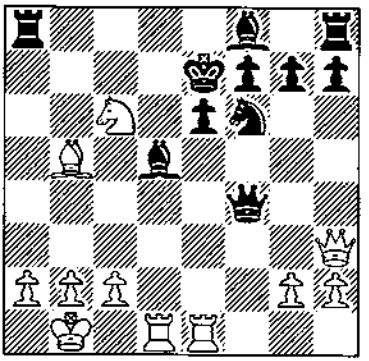
a) 15...♘d5 16 ♔b1 g5 17 ♖hf1 ♕xe5 18 ♖fe1 ♕f6 19 ♗c6 ♕xd4? (a bit optimistic, but Black did not like 19...♗xc6 20 ♘xc6+ ♔d6 21 ♘e5 ♗g7 22 c4) 20 ♖xd4 ♗xc6 21 ♕d3 ♗g7 22 ♖xd5 ♖hb8 23 ♖d4 ♗xg2 24 ♖d7+ ♔f8 25 c3 ♔g8 26 ♖g1 ♗c6 27 ♖c7 ♗d5 28 b3 h6 29 ♖f1 ♖a4 30 c4 f5 31 ♖xf5 and Black at last gave up in K.Haznedaroglu-Kr.Georgiev, Antalya 2001.

b) 15...♘e4 16 ♖hf1 ♕xe5 17 ♘f5+ exf5 18 ♖xf5 ♕e6 19 ♖d7+ ♕xd7 20 ♗xd7 ♘d6 was seen in E.Fernandez Romero-Wei Chenpeng, Moscow 2005, and now best is 21 ♖xf7+! ♘xf7 22 ♕e6+ ♔d8 23 ♕b6+ ♔xd7 24 ♕xb7+ ♔e6 25 ♕xa8 when White's pawns should carry the day.

16 ♖he1 ♕f4+

Black hasn't anything better: 16...♕g5+ 17 ♔b1 ♘g4 (17...♗d5 18 ♘c6+ ♔e8 19 ♘b4+ ♔e7 20 ♗c6 wins) 18 ♘xe6! fxe6 19 ♖d7+ ♔f6 20 ♖f1+ is winning, according to Minev, and 16...♘e4 17 ♗c6 ♕f4+ 18 ♔b1 ♗xc6 19 ♘xc6+ ♔e8 20 ♕b3 ♕c7 21 ♘d4 ♘d6 22 ♘xe6! fxe6 23 ♕xe6+ ♗e7 24 ♖xd6 was rather strong too in J.De Toledo-D.Di Berardino, Guarulhos 2006.

17 ♔b1 ♗d5 18 ♘c6+



18...♗xc6

Or 18...♔d6 19 c4 ♕f5+ 20 ♕xf5 exf5 21 ♘b4 and wins, according to Minev.

19 ♗xc6 ♖b8

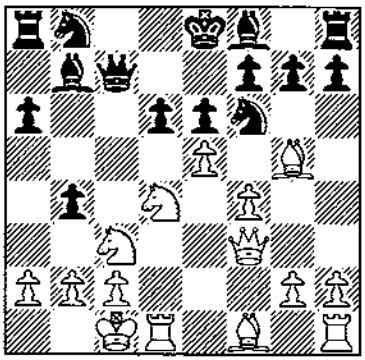
After 19...♖a7 20 ♕b3 (but not Minev's 20 ♕c3 ♘d7 21 ♖d4 ♕b8 22 ♖ed1 which he considered to be winning, but after 22...♘e5 23 ♖b4 ♕c7 24 ♕c5+ ♔f6 25 ♕f2+ ♔g6 26 ♕g3+ ♔f6 we see only a draw) 20...♘d7 21 ♕b5 White wins material.

20 ♕a3+ ♕b4 21 ♕a7+ 1-0

Game 82
L.Psakhis-V.Tukmakov
USSR Championship, Frunze 1979

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6

5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♕c7 8 ♕f3 b5 9 0-0-0 b4 10 e5 ♗b7



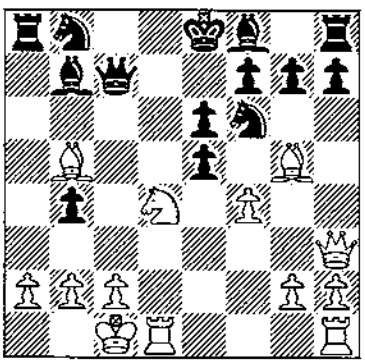
11 ♕h3?!

After the complicated 11 ♘cb5! axb5 12 ♗xb5+ we saw in Chapter Two that Kasparov once erred with 12...♘fd7?. As we indicated there, theory prefers 12...♘bd7.

11...dxe5 12 ♘cb5

According to Tukmakov, 12 fxe5 ♕xe5 13 ♗xf6 gxf6 is better for Black, but 13...♕xf6 14 ♘cb5! has long been known to be one to avoid since the game M.Chiburdanidze-V.Tukmakov, Tashkent 1980.

12...axb5 13 ♗xb5+



13...♗c6!

This looks like the winning move and is obviously much stronger than 13...♘fd7? 14 ♘xe6 ♕b6 15 ♗xd7+ ♘xd7 16 ♘xg7+ ♗xg7 17 ♕xd7+ ♔f8 18 ♕e7+ ♔g8 19 ♖d7, which gives White an advantage as indicated by Tukmakov.

14 fxe5 ♗xb5 15 exf6 ♗d7!

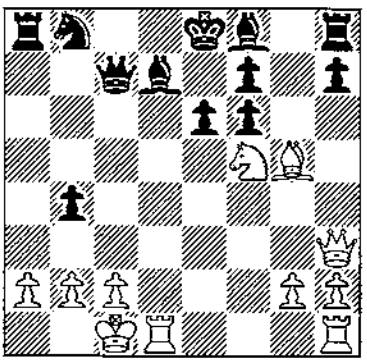
White is ahead in development, but it's not enough for a piece: Black's e6-pawn is a bulwark which can resist the enemy assault.

16 ♘f5

White desperately tries to crash through the black wall, but it's all to no avail. Alternatively, after 16 ♖he1 ♖xa2 17 ♕g4 h5 18 ♕e4 ♘c6 White's attack is finished.

16...gxf6!

The inconsistent 16...exf5?? is punished by 17 ♖he1+ ♗e6 18 ♕xf5 ♗e7 19 fxg7 ♖g8 20 ♕xh7 ♗xg5+ 21 ♔b1 ♖xg7 22 ♕xg7 ♕a5 23 ♖xe6+ fxe6 24 ♕g8+ ♔e7 25 ♕g7+ with a draw.



17 ♗xf6 ♖g8 18 ♕xh7 b3!

A neat stiletto thrust which will penetrate the enemy defence.

19 ♘d6+

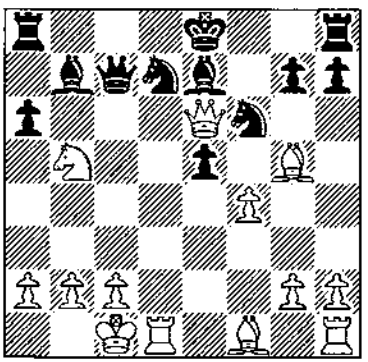
Or 19 axb3 ♖a1+ 20 ♔d2 ♖xg2+ and Black is winning.

19...♗xd6 20 ♖xd6 ♖f8! 0-1

Black's numerous threats forced White to resign.

Game 83
A.Chudinovskih-V.Kuporosov
USSR 1980

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 e5 ♗b7 11 ♕h3 dxe5 12 ♘xe6 fxe6 13 ♕xe6+ ♗e7 14 ♘xb5



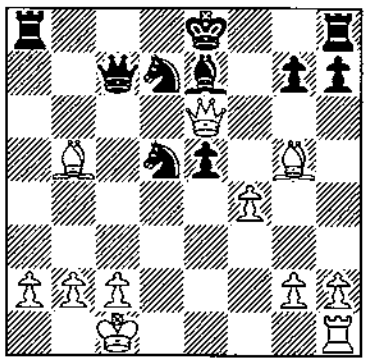
The alternative sacrifice of the bishop on b5 will be discussed in the next chapter.

14...axb5 15 ♗xb5 ♗d5

There's also 15...♗e4, an idea of Lev Gutman's. Play might then continue 16 ♖d2 ♔f8! (Boris Spassky gave this as good for Black back in 1976) 17 ♗c4 ♗g6 18 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 19 fxe5 ♗b4 20 ♖f2 ♗f7 21 ♕xf7+ ♕xf7 22 ♗xf7 ♔xf7, which looks roughly equal to us, although Black has scored well from here in practice.

However, 15...♖d8 appears inferior: 16 ♖he1 e4 17 ♖d4 ♗d5 (or 17...♖f8 18 ♖dxe4! ♖f7 19 ♗c4 ♗d5 20 ♗xd5 ♘xd5 21 ♕xd5 ♘f6 22 ♕b5+ ♔f8 23 ♗xf6 gxf6 24 ♕f5 with the better chances for White) 18 ♖xd5 ♘xd5 19 ♖xe4 ♕c5 20 ♗xe7 ♕g1+ 21 ♖e1 ♕xe1+ 22 ♕xe1 ♘xe7 23 ♕e5 ♖f8 24 ♕xg7 ♖g8 25 ♕xh7 ♖xg2 26 b3 and White went on to win in M.Oleksienko-Y.Kuzubov, I.vov 2005.

16 ♖xd5! ♘xd5



17 ♖d1!

The winner claimed this as a new move, but it had been given by Spassky in 1976! Instead 17 ♕xd5? ♖c8 18 c3 ♗xg5 19 fxg5 ♔e7 20 ♖e1 ♖hd8 21 ♖f1 ♖f8 22 ♖e1 ♖f7 23 a4 ♕d6 24 ♕e4 ♘c5 25 ♕xe5+ ♕xe5 26 ♖xe5+ ♔d6 27 ♖e2 ♖f1+ saw Black win in H.Suradiradja-A.Bachtiar, Surakarta 1982.

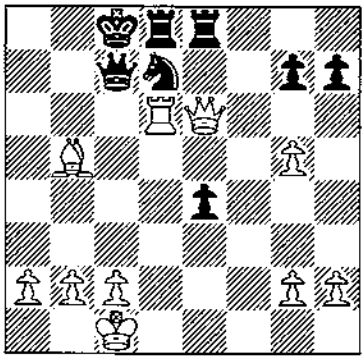
17...0-0-0

17...♖c8 18 c4! ♕d6 19 ♕xd6 ♗xd6 20 ♖xd5 is very strong too, as given by the winner.

18 ♖xd5 ♗xg5 19 fxg5 e4 20 ♖d6! ♖he8

Chudinovskih also analyses

20...♕a7 21 b3! e3 22 ♖c6+ ♔b7 23 ♕d5 ♔b8 24 ♕d6+ ♔a8 25 ♖c7 ♕b6 26 ♗c6+ ♔b8 27 ♖b7+ as winning.



21 ♗xd7+ ♕xd7 22 ♕c4+ ♕c7 23 ♖c6 ♖d7 24 ♕a6+ ♔d8 25 ♖xc7 ♔xc7

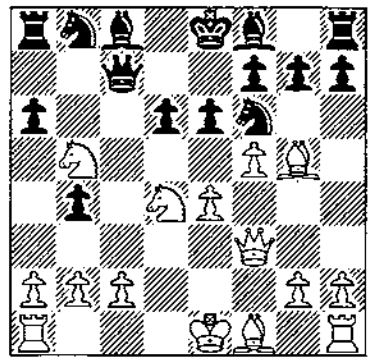
Or 25...♖xc7 26 ♕a8+ ♔d7 27 ♕a4+ ♔d8 28 ♕d4+ and White will blockade the e-pawn with his queen and win easily.

26 ♕a7+ ♔c6 27 ♕e3 ♖d5 28 b4 ♖ee5 29 a4 1-0

Game 84
A.Perez-P.McIntoch
Camaguey 1997

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♕c7 8 ♕f3 b5 9 f5 b4 10 ♘cb5!?

The author of this sacrifice was that master of Sicilian sacrifices, Dragoljub Velimirovic. For a piece, White is getting couple of pawns and an attack. Instead after the more logical 10 ♘d1 ♘c6 11 ♘xc6 ♕xc6 12 fxe6 fxe6 13 ♗d3 ♗e7 14 0-0 0-0 the position is roughly equal and the two legends took a draw in a couple more moves, D.Bronstein-M.Tal, Tbilisi 1982.

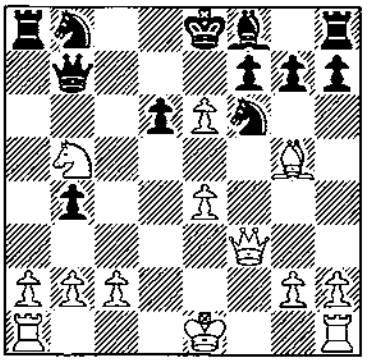


10...axb5 11 ♗xb5+ ♗d7 12 fxe6 ♗xb5 13 ♘xb5 ♕b7

Not forced:

a) After the aggressive 13...♕c4 14 ♗xf6 gxf6 15 ♕xf6 ♕xe4+ 16 ♔d1 ♕d5+ 17 ♔c1 ♕xb5 18 exf7+ ♔d7 19 ♕xh8 ♕g5+ 20 ♔b1 ♕xg2 21 ♖c1 ♘c6 22 a3 ♘e5 23 ♕xh7 ♕d5 24 ♕f5+ ♔c7 25 axb4 ♖xa1+ 26 ♔xa1 White won in V.Maki-J.Arnason, Helsinki 1991.

b) Theory has often preferred 13...♕c5, but after 14 ♗xf6 fxe6 15 ♕h3 gxf6 16 ♕xe6+ ♗e7 17 0-0-0 ♕xb5 18 ♕c8+ ♗d8 19 ♖xd6 ♔f7 (risky; 19...♕g5+ 20 ♔b1 ♕a5 21 ♖hd1 ♕xa2+ 22 ♔c1 ♔f7 23 ♖1d5 h5 24 ♖xd8 ♕a7 25 ♕f5 ♖xd8 26 ♕h7+ finished as a draw in O.Milani-E.Dibley, correspondence 2004) 20 ♕e6+!? ♔g7 21 ♖xd8 ♕e5 22 ♕xe5 fxe5 23 ♖hd1 ♖xa2 24 ♔b1 ♖xd8 25 ♖xd8 ♖a8 26 g4 ♔f7 27 h4 ♔g7 28 b3 ♔f7 29 ♔b2 ♔g7 30 c3 bxc3+ 31 ♔xc3 ♔f7 32 ♖h8 ♔g7 33 ♖c8 ♔f6 34 ♔c4 h6 35 b4 Black gave up in the game M.Manduch-W.Casier, correspondence 2005.



14 ♗xf6 ♕xb5

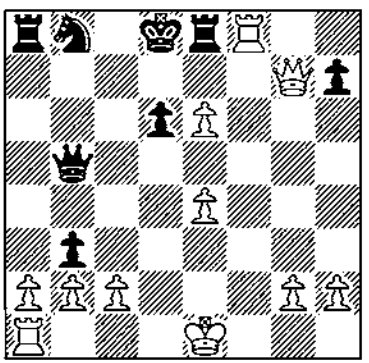
And not 14...gxf6? 15 ♕xf6 ♕xe4+ 16 ♔d1 ♕d5+ 17 ♔c1 ♗h6+ 18 ♕xh6 ♕xb5 19 ♕g7 when White wins.

15 ♗xg7 ♗xg7 16 ♕xf7+ ♔d8 17 ♕xg7 ♖e8 18 ♖f1 b3

Black prepares an assault with ...♕b4+.

19 ♖f8!?

A forgotten move which may be a refutation of Black's strategy. 19 cxb3 is the main theoretical try.

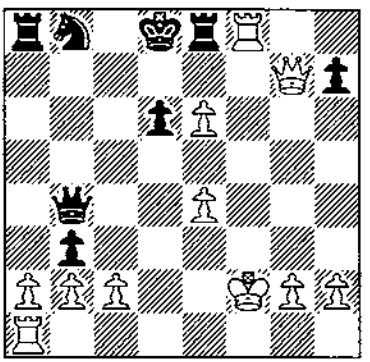


19...♕b4+

According to Pavlovic, 19...♖xa2 20 ♖d1 bxc2 (after 20...♕b4+ 21 ♔f2 ♖xf8+ 22 ♕xf8+ ♔c7 23 ♕f7+ ♔b6 24 e7 bxc2 25 e8♕ cxd1♘+ 26 ♔g3 ♘c6 27 ♕xa2 ♕e1+ 28 ♔g4 ♘f2+ 29 ♔f5 ♕d1 30 h3 the two queens were too much in W.Knebel-J.Exposito Cabrera, correspondence 2001) 21 ♖xd6+ ♔c8 22 ♖xe8+ ♕xe8 23 ♕c3+ is winning for White with his attack.

Instead in his analysis Pavlovic tried to prove that 19...bxc2 is the best way for Black to get a playable position. It took us many hours to find a win for White after 20 ♕f6+ ♔c8 21 ♖c1 ♕b4+ (21...♕a5+ 22 ♔e2 ♕h5+ 23 ♔d2 ♔b7 24 ♖f7+ ♔a6 25 ♖xc2 ♕e5 26 ♕f3 ♕a5+ 27 ♖c3 ♘c6 28 ♕d3+ ♔b6 29 ♔c1 wins for White) 22 ♔f1 ♕c4+ 23 ♔g1 ♖xf8 24 ♕xf8+ ♔b7 25 ♕f7+ ♔c8 26 h3 ♘c6 27 ♕d7+ ♔b8 28 e7 ♕d4+ (28...♘xe7 29 ♕xe7 concedes a win to White; the text explores an attempt to keep fighting) 29 ♔h2 ♕e5+ 30 g3 ♘xe7 31 ♖xc2 ♖a7 32 ♕d8+ ♔b7 33 ♖c7+ ♔a6 34 ♖c3 d5 35 ♖a3+ ♔b5 36 ♖b3+ ♔c4 37 ♕b6 and White's various threats will finish the game. However, all this analysis needs testing and possibly the reader will find an improvement somewhere.

20 ♔f2



Now look how White's king masterfully escapes from the black queen.

20...♕c5+ 21 ♔f3 ♕h5+ 22 g4 ♕h3+ 23 ♔e2 ♕xh2+

Or 23...♕g2+ 24 ♔e3 ♕h3+ 25 ♖f3 ♕h4 26 ♕b7 ♕g5+ 27 ♔e2 and White wins material.

24 ♔d3 ♕xc2+ 25 ♔e3 ♕c5+

According to Pavlovic, 25...♕c6 26 ♖xe8+ ♕xe8 27 ♖f1 bxa2 28 ♖f8 a1♕ 29 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 30 ♕f7+ ♔d8 31 e7+ is winning for White.

26 ♔f3 ♕b5

26...♖xa2 27 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 28 ♕f7+ ♔d8 29 e7+ ♔c7 30 e8♕+ wins.

27 ♖c1! 1-0

Presumably Black gave up. We couldn't find the rest of the game, but we believe it's a very important one for this variation. After 27...♕d3+ 28 ♔f4 ♕d2+ 29 ♔g3 ♕e3+ 30 ♔h4 ♕xc1 31 ♖xe8+ ♔xe8 32 ♕f7+ ♔d8 33 e7+ ♔c7 34 e8♕+ Black's king can't escape the attention of the two ladies.

Chapter Six

The Bishop Sacrifice on b5

The sacrifice ♗xb5 is after ♘c3-d5 the most common sacrificial theme in the Open Sicilian, since in many variations Black plays ...a6 and ...b5 at an early stage when White's lead in development is best exploited by this direct assault. In almost all cases Black is uncastled or has castled long, and the considerations outlined next apply in either case.

After playing ♗xb5 axb5, White will normally recapture with his knight from d4, especially in the typical case of the black queen being posted on c7. White thus gains a second pawn and a tempo straightaway. In certain cases, when the pawn on d6 is insufficiently guarded, White will gain a third pawn with check, disturbing the enemy king and, if Black has castled long, achieving a decisive fork on the weakened point f7. Other times, White may follow up ♘dxb5 with the thrust e4-e5 which often ensures a trade of dark-squared bishops to enable a big check on d6. (See Velimirovic-Al Kazzaz below for an illustration of these latter ideas.)

We haven't examined many endings in this book (nor will we), but the following is a well-known classic which illuminates some considerations in the 'three-pawns-for-a-piece' structure which can arise if White is fortunate.

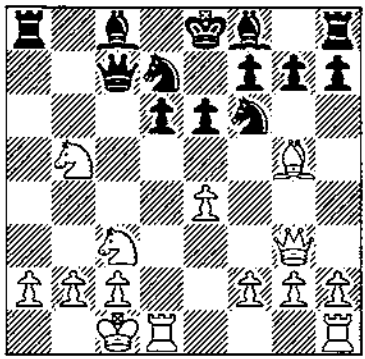
Game 85
D.Bronstein-M. Najdorf
Buenos Aires 1954

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 ♕f3 ♘bd7

Nunn prefers 7...h6 here, continuing 8 ♗h4 ♘bd7 9 0-0-0 ♕c7. Then White might try 10 ♗e2 which conceals a nifty trap, viz. 10...b5? 11 e5 ♗b7 12 ♘xe6! fxe6 13 ♕h5+!. Also losing here

is 12...♕c8 13 ♘xg7+ ♗xg7 14 ♕g3 dxe5 15 ♕xg7.

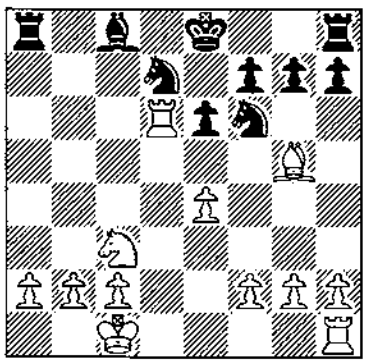
8 0-0-0 ♕c7 9 ♕g3 b5 10 ♗xb5!? axb5 11 ♘dxb5



11...♕b8

I'm not aware that anybody has tried Pachman's suggestion of 11...♕a5 yet.

12 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 13 ♕xd6 ♕xd6 14 ♖xd6



White has acquired three connected passed pawns for his piece. The question is: can he advance them without jeopardizing his king and without permitting a blockade?

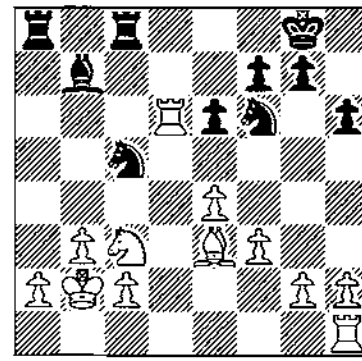
14...h6 15 ♗d2

Pachman in his *Modern Chess Strategy* prefers 15 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 16 ♖hd1 ♗b7 17 f3 ♔e7 18 ♖b6.

15...♗b7 16 f3 0-0?

I must agree with Pachman that it is much more sensible to play 16...0-0-0 here. The black king would be well placed on the queenside to assist the blockade of White's pawns, and just as important, it would be out of the way for Black to seek counterplay with ...g5-g4.

17 b3 ♖fc8 18 ♔b2 ♘c5 19 ♗e3



19...e5?!

In a few moves this will look like hara-kiri, but it is hard to suggest a spirited alternative. At present I think the following is a good try: 19...♔f8 20 ♖hd1 ♔e7 21 e5 ♘d5 22 ♘xd5+ exd5 23 c4 when Black should return the piece with 23...dxc4! 24 ♗xc5 ♖xc5 25 ♖d7+ ♔e6 26 ♖xb7 c3+ 27 ♔a1 ♖xe5 and this double rook ending offers some counterplay for Black. Also possible in this line is to put the king on e8 instead of e7; at least the computer does not show a forced win in that case.

20 ♖hd1 ♘e6 21 ♖b6 ♗c6 22 ♘d5

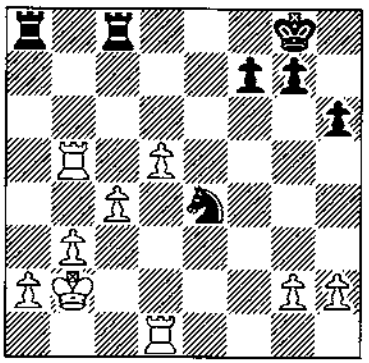
♗xd5

After this virtually forced capture, White has four connected passers and the rest, as they used to say, is a mere bagatelle.

23 exd5 ♘c5 24 ♖b5

This is an ideal square for the rook. It is a perfectly safe perch from which to fight for the key blockade square c5.

24...♘fd7 25 c4 e4 26 ♗xc5 ♘xc5 27 fxe4 ♘xe4



28 d6!

Establishing a pawn pair on the sixth rank is much more to be valued than hoarding all the booty.

28...♖xa2+ 29 ♔xa2 ♘c3+ 30 ♔a3 ♘xd1 31 c5 ♘c3 32 ♖a5 ♘d5 33 c6 ♘f6 34 ♖a6 ♔f8 35 b4 ♔e8 36 b5 ♘d7 37 ♖a7 ♖b8 38 ♖xd7 ♖xb5 39 ♖a7 ♖b8 40 d7+ ♔e7 41 d8♕+ ♔xd8 42 c7+ 1-0

Game 86
D.Velimirovic-R.Al-Kazzaz
Nice Olympiad 1974

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♗d3 b5 11 ♖he1 ♗b7 12 ♕g3

Spassky's idea, introduced in his 1972 match against Fischer.

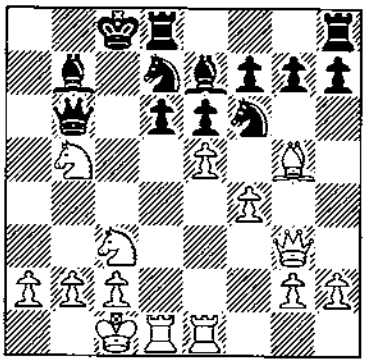
12...0-0-0?!

12...b4 was considered in Conticello-Paolozzi, at the beginning of Chapter One.

13 ♗xb5!

This assault has pretty much put Black's 12th move out of business, whereas Spassky preferred 13 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 14 ♕xg7 which won a pawn but Fischer scrounged up enough play to draw.

13...axb5 14 ♘xb5 ♕b6 15 e5



15...d5

Moving the knight at once or swapping pawns on e5 will inevitably lead to a fatal knight check on d6. Thus Black offers to return a piece, hoping to recapture with tempo with his pawn and at least secure a bit of play. However, Velimirovic will not be mollified.

16 f5!

With this intermezzo, White opens both the e-file and the diagonal leading to c7. Moreover, he threatens 17 fxe6

fxe6 18 exf6 gxf6 19 ♖xe6! ♕xe6 20 ♕c7 mate and, of course, 16...exf5 17 exf6 forces the bishop to recapture and so allows the knight into d6.

16...♘h5 17 ♕h4 ♗xg5+ 18 ♕xg5 ♘xe5 19 ♕xh5 d4 20 ♖xe5 dxc3 21 ♘xc3 ♖xd1+ 22 ♕xd1 ♖d8 23 ♕e1

The rest is perfunctory.

23...exf5 24 ♖xf5 ♕h6+ 25 ♔b1 ♕xh2 26 ♖xf7 ♕xg2 27 ♕e6+ ♔b8 28 ♕e5+ 1-0

As a matter of fact, it's mate in ten from here, but taking Black's rook with check would be enough to finish matters among the civilized.

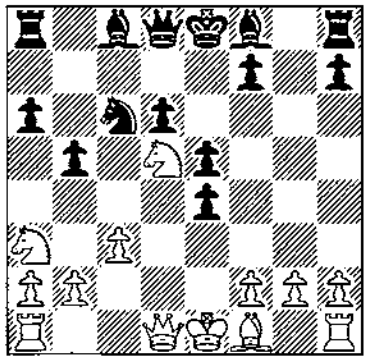
In the Sveshnikov too the ♗xb5 sacrifice is a recurring theme, here to retake with the d4-knight and threaten ♘c7+ aided by the other knight that has already reached d5. Yury will analyse several attempts along these lines in the body of this chapter, but for now I wish to display a trap with which every Sveshnikov fan should be familiar. The following is an example of what I like to term 'one-time cons', a name appropriated from the American poker writer John Fox. Should you happen to catch an unprepared opponent in this line, it is highly probable your victim will walk right into the trap and so you will garner an easy point.

Game 87
L.Shamkovich-R.Wachtel
Columbus 1977

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘4b5 d 6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gxf6 10 ♘d5 f5 11 c3

We reach a crossroads. Best now is 11...♗g7! when White can exchange on f5, but the unwary might snatch the bait...

11...fxe4?



12 ♗xb5! axb5 13 ♘xb5

Now Black faces a conundrum: 13...♖a7 loses after 14 ♘xa7 ♘xa7 15 ♕a4+ ♕d7?? 16 ♘f6+ and 13...♖a4?? just hangs a rook. So Wachtel tried...

13...♕g5 14 ♘dc7+ ♔d7 15 ♕d5! ♗b7 16 ♕xf7 ♕e7 17 ♕f5 ♕d7? 18 ♕f6+ 1-0

Over to Yury:

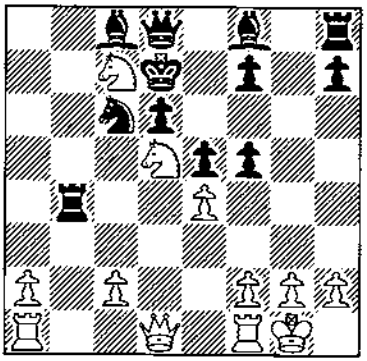
Game 88
A.Shirov-V.Topalov
Leon (rapid) 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gxf6 10 ♘d5 f5 11 ♗xb5 axb5 12 ♘xb5

This game made the chess world pay more attention to White's 11 ♗xb5

sacrifice, at least for a while.

12...♖a4 13 b4 ♖xb4 14 ♘bc7+ ♔d7 15 0-0



15...♕xc7

Topalov and *Fritz* believe that three pieces are much better than one queen. In this game Shirov shows his disagreement.

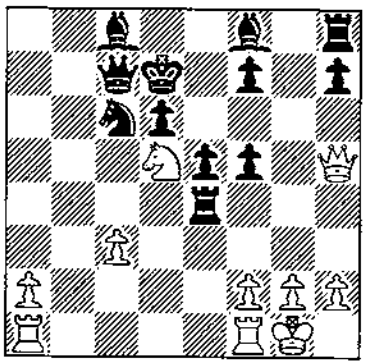
16 c3!

Revealing excellent home preparation. Shirov doesn't need to snap up the queen. For him a rook, the c-file, two connected passed pawns and an attack on the uncastled king are worth more. Instead after the logical 16 ♘xc7 ♔xc7 17 ♕h5 ♖xe4 18 ♕xf7+ ♗e7 19 a4 (19 ♖fb1 ♖f8 20 ♕b3 ♖b4 21 ♕d5 ♖xb1+ 22 ♖xb1 ♗d7 23 a4 ♖a8 24 ♕c4 h5 25 g3 ♖a5 26 ♖b5 d5 27 ♖xd5 ♗e6 28 ♕xc6+ ♔xc6 29 ♖xa5 ♗c5 is roughly equal, M.Rytshagov-M.Ripari, Saint Vincent 2001) 19...♖f8 20 ♕b3 ♖b4 21 ♕d5 ♗a6 22 c3 ♖e4 23 ♖fb1 ♗c4 24 ♕d1 ♖e2 25 a5 d5 26 ♖a4 ♗c5 27 ♖xc4 ♗xf2+ 28 ♔f1 ♖e1+ 29 ♕xe1 ♗xe1 30 ♖xc6+ ♔xc6 31 ♔xe1 the game was soon drawn in C.Baljon-S.Dolmatov, Amsterdam 1979.

16...♖xe4

According to Shirov, 16...♕b7 17 cxb4 fxe4 18 ♖c1 gives White a dangerous attack.

17 ♕h5!



17...♔d8?!

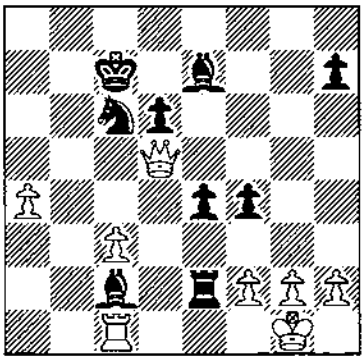
Shirov thinks that 17...♕a5 18 ♕xf5+ ♔d8 19 ♕xe4 gives White a slight advantage, but we believe that in this unclear position both sides have chances to win.

18 ♘xc7 ♔xc7 19 ♕xf7+ ♗e7 20 ♖ab1 ♗a6! 21 ♖fd1 ♖f8 22 ♕b3 ♖b8 23 ♕e6 ♖xb1

After 23...♗c4 24 ♕xf5 ♖xb1 25 ♖xb1 ♗d3 26 ♖f1 d5 27 ♕e6 ♗xf1 28 ♔xf1 d4 29 cxd4 ♖xd4 30 g3 the position was roughly equal in A.Naiditsch-A.Jakubiec, Griesheim 2002.

24 ♖xb1 ♗d3 25 ♖d1 f4 26 ♕d5 ♗c2 27 ♖c1 ♖e2 28 a4 e4

Shirov thinks that 28...♗e4 29 ♕b5 ♖d2 30 a5 wins for White. Our analysis shows that he is right: for example, after 30...d5 31 f3 ♗a3 32 fxe4 ♗xc1 33 exd5 ♖d1+ 34 ♔f2 ♗e3+ 35 ♔f3 ♘e7 36 c4 the three passed pawns should be enough to win.



29 a5 ♗d3 30 ♖a1!

Preparing to push the passed pawn, which is very difficult to stop.

30...♖b2

After 30...♗a6? 31 ♕b3 ♔d7 32 ♕b6 the a-pawn can't be stopped.

31 c4 ♖b7

Shirov points out that 31...♖b4 32 a6 ♗xc4 33 ♕xc6+ ♔xc6 34 a7 wins for White.

32 a6 ♖a7 33 f3

Now that the black rook has become a spectator, it's time to destroy the fortress in the centre. In the rest of the game Shirov finishes clinically:

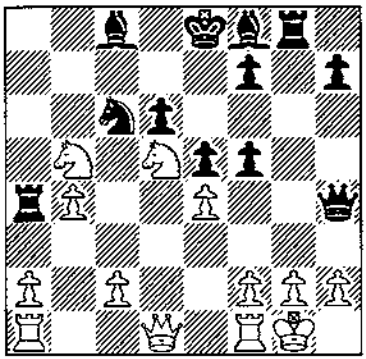
33...♘e5 34 fxe4 ♗xc4 35 ♖c1 ♖xa6 36 ♖xc4+ ♘xc4 37 ♕xc4+ ♖c6 38 ♕f7 ♔d8 39 ♕g8+ ♔d7 40 ♕xh7 ♖c5 41 ♕f7 ♖c1+ 42 ♔f2 ♖c8 43 ♕f5+ ♔c7 44 ♕e6 1-0

Game 89
A.Shirov-G.Kasparov
Linares 2002

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gxf6 10 ♘d5 f5 11 ♗xb5 axb5 12 ♘xb5 ♖a4 13 b4 ♕h4!?

Kasparov varies from Topalov's play.

14 0-0 ♖g8



15 f4

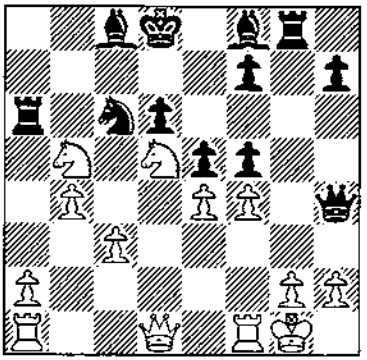
Shirov's home preparation, trying to open the centre immediately. A popular draw here is 15 c3 f4 16 ♕xa4 ♖xg2+ 17 ♔xg2 ♕g4+, as in T.Luther-L.McShane, Lippstadt 2000.

15...♔d8! 16 c3?!

According to Kasparov, after 16 ♘xd6? ♗xd6 17 ♘b6 ♘d4 18 ♘xa4 fxe4 Black wins with a crushing attack. Better too for Black is 16 fxe5? ♘xe5! 17 ♕d4 (after 17 ♘bc3? ♖xb4! 18 ♘xb4 ♘g4 Black is winning) 17...♖a6.

Perhaps White should try 16 c4!? or 16 ♘b6!?. Indeed, after the latter, 16...♖xb4 17 ♘xc8 ♔xc8 18 ♕d5 ♘d4 19 ♕a8+ ♔d7 20 ♕b7+ ♔e8 21 ♕c8+ ♔e7 22 ♘c3 f6? (22...♖b5 23 ♘xb5 ♘e2+ 24 ♔h1 ♘g3+ 25 ♔g1 ♘e2+ is a draw) 23 ♖f2 ♔f7 24 ♘d5 ♖b2 25 ♕d7+ ♔g6 26 exf5+ ♔h6 27 ♕f7 saw White win in Li Shilong-Zhao Jun,Wuxi 2006.

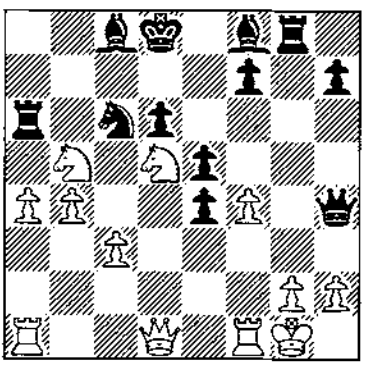
16...♖a6



17 a4?

In our view White underestimated Black's attack and lost an important tempo with this move. This became the reason for his defeat. Kasparov points out 17 ♘dc7? fxe4 18 ♘xa6 ♗h3! 19 ♕e1 ♖xg2+ 20 ♔h1 ♕g4 21 ♖f2 exf4 and Black is winning. However, we believe that White could get a playable position with 17 exf5!? ♗b7 18 f6 ♘a7 19 ♘xa7 ♖xa7 20 ♖f2.

17...fxe4



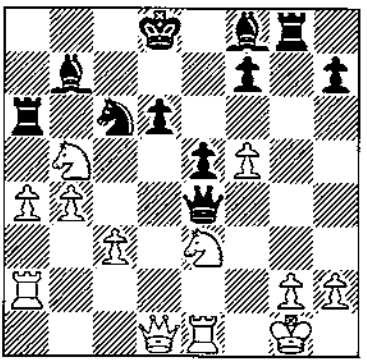
18 f5

After 18 ♘dc7 ♖b6 19 ♕d5 ♕g4 20 ♕xe4 ♗b7 21 ♖f2 ♘d4 22 ♘d5 ♘xb5 23 axb5 ♖xb5 24 c4 ♖xb4 25 ♕d3 exf4 Black is winning.

18...♗b7 19 ♖a2

Alternatively, 19 ♘bc7 ♘e7 20 ♘xe7 ♗xe7 21 ♘d5 e3 22 ♕d3 e2 23 ♖f2 ♖xa4 wins for Black, and after 19 ♘dc7 e3 20 ♖a2 ♘b8 21 ♘xa6 ♕h3 22 ♕c2 ♘xa6 Black has a crushing attack.

19...e3 20 ♘xe3 ♕e4 21 ♖e1



21...♘xb4!

A tactical blow which wins a pawn and the game.

22 cxb4 ♗h6 23 ♔h1 ♗xe3 24 ♕e2 ♖c6

24...♖xa4 25 ♘xd6 ♖xa2 26 ♘xb7+ ♕xb7 27 ♕xa2 ♗d4 wins for Black according to the victor.

25 a5 ♕xb4 26 ♘xd6 ♖xd6 27 ♕xe3 ♕d4 28 ♕c1 ♕d5 0-1

With 29 ♕c2 ♖xg2 30 ♕xg2 ♕b5 Black wins material.

Game 90
M.Yeo-M.Chandler
British League 1996

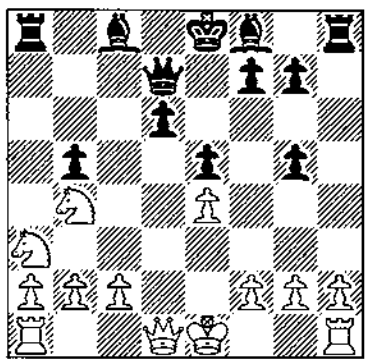
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 e5 5 ♘b5 d6 6 ♘1c3 a6 7 ♘a3 b5 8 ♘d5 ♘ge7 9 ♗g5 h6 10 ♗xb5!?

It's amazing how calmly White puts a second bishop in danger and yet Black will have problems to win material. The safer 10 ♕h5 ♗e6 11 ♖d1 ♗xd5 12 exd5 ♘d4 13 c3 b4 14 cxd4 bxa3 15 ♗c4 ♕c7 16 b3 g6 17 ♕h3 ♗g7 18 ♗c1 ♕a5+ 19 ♗d2 ♕b6 20 dxe5 ♗xe5 21 0-0 ♔f8 22 ♕d7 gave White a slight advantage in the game A.Fier-L.Liascovich, Villa Martelli 2006.

10...hxg5

The inferior 10...axb5 11 ♘xb5 ♖a7 12 ♘xa7 ♘xa7 13 ♗e3 ♘xd5 14 ♕xd5 ♕c7 15 0-0 ♗e7 16 b4 0-0 17 a4 ♗b7 18 ♕d3 ♘c6 19 c3 gave White two passed pawns and a clear advantage in T.Abrahamyan-M.Sarquis, Cuenca 2006.

11 ♘xe7 axb5 12 ♘xc6 ♕d7 13 ♘b4

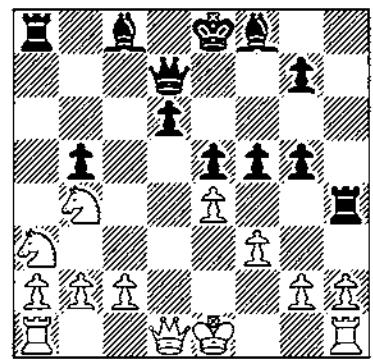


Black is down one pawn, d5 is a weak square, the pawn on b5 is weak, his king is in the middle and his pieces are not developed, but anyway two active rooks and the bishop-pair give him enough compensation for the pawn!

13...♖h4?!

In our opinion, better is 13...♖a4!? 14 c3 d5 (also possible is 14...♗b7!? when 15 f3 d5 16 ♘xd5 ♗xa3 17 bxa3 ♗xd5 18 exd5 g4 19 0-0 gxf3 20 ♕xf3 0-0 leaves Black down two pawns, but with good drawing chances) 15 ♕xd5 ♕xd5 16 exd5 ♗xb4 17 cxb4 ♖xb4 18 0-0-0 ♔d7 19 h3 ♔d6 20 b3 ♗d7 (we prefer 20...♗f5 21 ♔b2 ♖c8 22 ♖d2 ♖c5 23 ♖hd1 f6 and it should be drawn) 21 ♔b2 ♖bh4, which was roughly equal in the game A.Shlakich-O.Girya, St Petersburg 2008.

14 f3 f5



15 g3?!

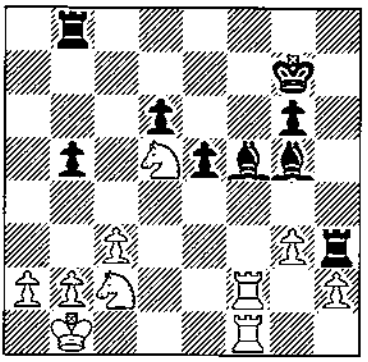
This creates more weaknesses in White's camp. Better is 15 ♘d5!? ♖b8 16 ♕d2 g4 (16...f4 17 ♕b4) 17 ♕g5 ♖h8 18 fxg4 fxe4 19 ♖f1 ♖b7 20 ♕g6+ ♔d8 21 h3 and White is better.

15...♖h6 16 ♘d5 ♖b8 17 ♕d3 ♔f7 18 exf5 ♕xf5 19 ♕xf5+ ♗xf5 20 0-0-0 ♖h3 21 c3

Now it looks like White is better, but after Black improves his passive pieces, White will feel the bishops' heat...

21...g6 22 ♘c2 g4 23 fxg4 ♗h6+ 24 ♔b1 ♗xg4 25 ♖df1+ ♔g7 26 ♖f2 ♗f5

27 ♖hf1 ♗g5



White has an extra pawn, but his advantage has gone with the wind. Black's bishops are too active and his rooks have found h2 to be a juicy target.

28 g4 ♗e6 29 ♘cb4 ♖bh8 30 b3 ♖c8 31 ♘f6??

Losing the exchange and the game. 31 ♖g2 would have continued to resist.

31...♗h4 32 ♘bd5 ♗xf2 33 ♖xf2 ♗xd5 34 ♘xd5 ♖d3 35 ♘f6 ♖dxc3 36 g5 ♖d3 37 ♔b2 ♖d4 38 h3 b4 39 a4 ♖d3 40 a5 ♖xh3 41 ♘d5 ♖c5 42 ♖c2 ♖xd5 43 ♖c7+ ♔f8 44 a6 ♖h2+ 0-1

Game 91
M.Tal-M.Stean
Hastings 1973/74

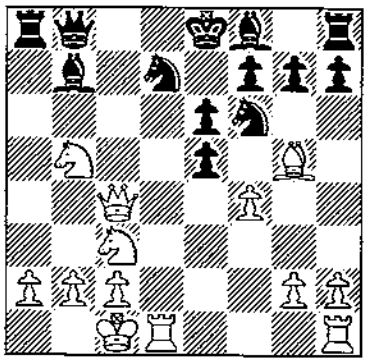
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 ♗xb5!?

We believe this is not a winning move, but it is good enough for a draw. (Take it from us, there are people who play such lines without knowing all, or even most, of the theory.)

10...axb5 11 ♘dxb5 ♕b8 12 e5 ♗b7

12...♖a5!? is another line which theory considers satisfactory.

13 ♕e2 dxe5 14 ♕c4

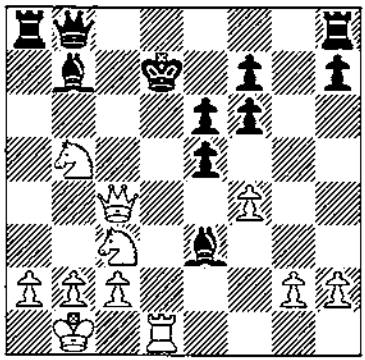


14...♗c5

Another interesting try is 14...♗e7 15 ♘c7+ ♔f8 16 ♖xd7 ♘xd7 17 ♖d1 ♗d5 (after 17...♘f6 18 fxe5 ♘d5 19 ♗xe7+ ♔xe7 20 ♕c5+ ♔d7 21 ♘3xd5 ♗xd5 22 ♘xa8 ♕xa8 23 ♕d6+ ♔c8 24 ♖d3 ♕a5 25 ♖c3+ ♔b7 it was perpetual check in M.Perunovic-D.Doric, Vogosca 2007) 18 ♘3xd5? (better is 18 ♖xd5! exd5 19 ♗xe7+ when 19...♔g8 20 ♘3xd5 ♘b6 21 ♗d6 ♘xc4 22 ♘e7+ ♔f8 23 ♘g6+ ♔g8 24 ♘e7+ is perpetual check and 19...♔xe7 20 ♘3xd5+ ♔d8 21 ♘xa8 ♕a7!? 22 fxe5 ♘xe5 23 ♕h4+ f6 24 ♘ab6 is rather unclear) 18...exd5 19 ♕xd5 ♗xg5 20 fxg5 ♖xa2 21 ♕xa2 ♕xc7 22 ♕a3+ ♔e8 23 ♖d3 ♔d8 24 ♕a8+ ♕c8 25 ♕a5+ ♕c7 26 ♕a8+ ♕c8 27 ♕a5+ and the opponents took a draw in A.Naiditsch-B.Gelfand, Dortmund 2006, but we believe that after 27...♔e7 28 ♕b4+ ♔e8 29 ♕d6 ♕b7 30 h4 h6 31 g6 ♖f8 32 ♖d1 ♕b5 33 b3 fxg6 34 c4

♕b7 35 ♕e6+ ♔d8 36 ♕xe5 ♖f6 Black is actually winning.

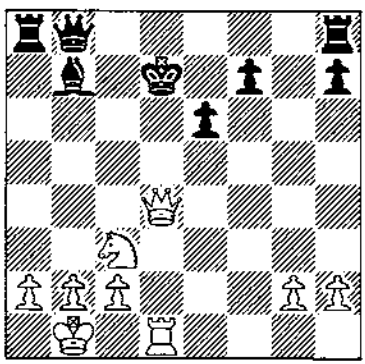
15 ♗xf6 gxf6 16 ♖xd7! ♗e3+ 17 ♔b1 ♔xd7 18 ♖d1+



18...♗d4

Another option was 18...♔e8 19 ♘c7+ ♔f8 20 ♕b4+? (better is 20 fxe5!?, breaking Black's shield) 20...♔g8? (after 20...♔g7 21 ♕e7 exf4 22 ♖d7 ♕g8 White is in trouble) 21 ♘xa8 ♕xa8 22 ♕e7 with an unclear game which ended as a draw in P.Bobras-J.Czakon, Lublin 2008.

19 fxe5 fxe5 20 ♘xd4 exd4 21 ♕xd4+



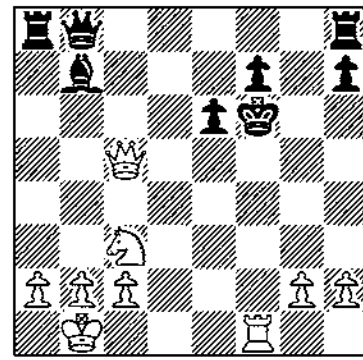
21...♔e7??

'The losing moment', as the late GM Edmar Mednis used to say. Instead 21...♗d5! 22 ♘xd5 exd5 23 ♕xd5+ ♔e7 24 ♖e1+ ♔f8 25 ♕c5+ ♔g7 26 ♕g5+ is a draw.

22 ♕c5+ ♔f6

After 22...♔e8!? 23 ♘b5 f5 24 ♘d6+ ♔e7 25 ♘xb7+ White is better.

23 ♖f1+



Now nothing can save Black's king.

23...♔g6

23...♔g7 24 ♕g5+ ♔f8 25 ♕f6 wins.

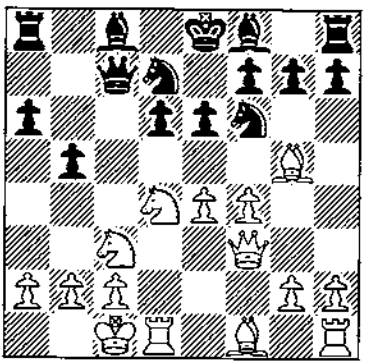
24 ♕e7 f5 25 ♕xe6+ ♔g7 26 ♕e7+ ♔g6 27 h4 ♖a5

Here Tal spotted a checkmate in 7 moves which not everyone would find.

28 h5+ ♔xh5 29 ♕f7+ ♔h4 30 ♕f6+ ♔g3 31 ♕g5+ ♔h2 32 ♕h4+ ♔xg2 33 ♖f2+ ♔g1 34 ♘e2mate (1-0)

Game 92
L.Psakhis-Y.Anikaev
USSR Championship, Frunze 1979

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5



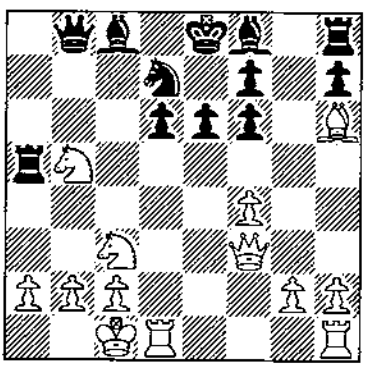
10 ♗xb5

10 e5 ♗b7 11 ♕h3 will be seen in Vitolinsh-Yuferov later in this chapter. The text has been considered weaker.

10...axb5 11 ♘dxb5 ♕b8

Maybe 11...♕b6!? is better: 12 e5 ♗b7 13 ♕e2 dxe5 (13...♘e4 14 ♘xe4 ♗xe4 15 exd6 ♖c8 16 ♘c7+ ♖xc7 17 dxc7 ♗b7 18 f5 e5 19 ♕xe5+ forced Black to resign in J.De Wit-L.Gutman, Wijk aan Zee 1984) 14 fxe5 ♘d5 15 ♘xd5 ♗xd5 16 ♖xd5 exd5 17 ♘d6+ ♗xd6 18 exd6+ ♔f8 19 ♕e7+ ♔g8 20 ♕xd7 h6 21 ♗e7! and Psakhis thinks this is unclear.

12 e5 ♖a5 13 exf6 gxf6 14 ♗h6!



An idea introduced by Yuri Balashov three years earlier.

14...♗xh6 15 ♘xd6+ ♔e7 16 ♔b1 ♘b6

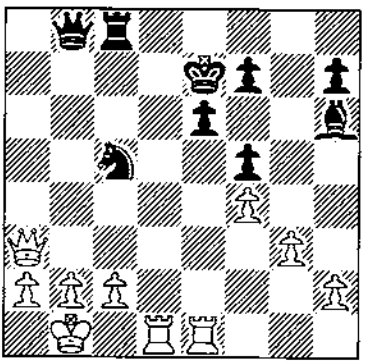
Nobody seems to play this way anymore. 16...♖d8 is now popular: for example, 17 ♖hc1 ♘b6 18 ♘cb5 ♗a6 19 ♘f5+ ♔f8 20 ♕c3 ♖xb5 21 ♕xf6 ♖xb2+ 22 ♕xb2 ♘d5 23 ♖xd5 ♕xb2+ 24 ♔xb2 ♗g7+ 25 ♘xg7 ♖xd5 26 ♘xe6+ fxe6 27 ♖xe6 was agreed drawn in C.Lutz-B.Gelfand, Dortmund 2002.

17 ♘ce4!?

Trying to improve over the stem game, which continued 17 ♕e4 ♖d8 18 ♘db5 ♖xb5 19 ♘xb5 ♘d5 20 c4 ♗a6 21 cxd5 ♕xb5 22 ♖he1 ♗b7 23 ♕xh7 ♗xd5 24 ♕xh6 ♖b8 25 ♖d2 ♗xa2+ 26 ♔c1 ♖c8+ 27 ♖c2 ♖xc2+ 28 ♔xc2 ♕c4+ 29 ♔d2 ♕b4+ 30 ♔e2 ♗c4+ 31 ♔d1 ♕xb2 32 ♖e5 fxe5 33 ♕g5+ ♔d7 and White resigned in Y.Balashov-L.Polugaevsky, Manila 1976.

17...♘a4! 18 ♘xc8+ ♖xc8 19 ♕a3+ ♘c5 20 ♕xa5 ♘xe4 21 ♕a3+! ♘c5 22 g3 f5 23 ♖he1!

23 ♖d4 ♗g7 24 ♖c4 ♕d6 should be okay for Black.



23...♕b6

We prefer 23...♗g7 24 ♖d5 (24 ♖c3 is possible) 24...♕b6 25 ♖xf5 ♗d4! when White is in trouble: for instance, 26 c3 (or 26 ♖h5 ♖a8!) 26...♗f2 27 ♖e2 ♕d6 28 ♕a7+ ♔d8 29 ♕a5+ ♔e8 30 ♕b5+ ♔f8 and Black wins.

24 ♖d4 ♗g7 25 ♖c4 ♕d6 26 ♕a5

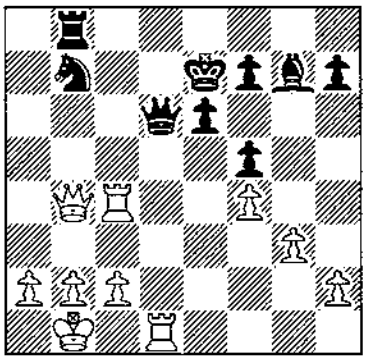
Instead 26 ♔c1 ♖b8! 27 ♖d1 ♗xb2+ 28 ♕xb2 ♕xd1+ 29 ♔xd1 ♖xb2 30 ♖xc5 ♖xa2 is equal.

26...♘b7 27 ♕b4 ♖b8?

Psakhis prefers 27...♖xc4 28 ♕xc4 ♕b6!.

28 ♖d1!

Stronger than 28 ♖c7+ ♔e8!.



28...♘c5

White wins too after 28...♕xb4 29 ♖xb4; he will play a3 and ♖d3-b3.

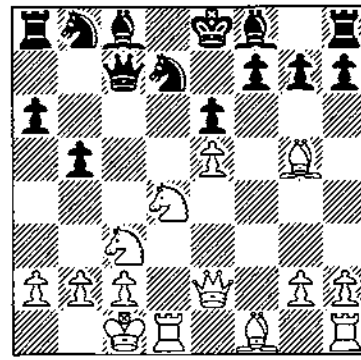
29 ♕xc5 ♕xc5 30 ♖xc5 ♗xb2 31 c4! ♗a3+ 32 ♖b5 ♖c8 33 ♔c2 ♔f6 34 ♔b3 ♗f8 35 ♖d7 1-0

Game 93
Ljiljak-A.Goddard
correspondence 1968

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 b5 8 e5 dxe5 9 fxe5 ♕c7 10 ♕e2

The alternative is 10 exf6 ♕e5+ 11 ♗e2 ♕xg5 12 0-0.

10...♘fd7 11 0-0-0



11...♗b7

According to Trajkovic, 11...♕xe5?? 12 ♕xe5 ♘xe5 13 ♘dxb5 is winning for White.

12 ♕g4 ♕xe5

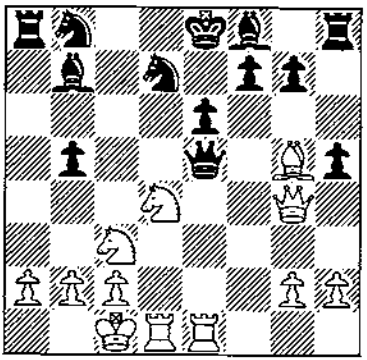
After 12...♘xe5?? 13 ♘xe6!! fxe6 14 ♕xe6+ ♗e7 15 ♗xb5+ axb5 16 ♘xb5 ♕c5 17 ♘d6+ Black gave up in Tietze-O.Amigo, Argentina 1990. However, 12...♕b6!? is possible: for example, 13 ♗f4 ♘c5 14 ♗e2 b4 15 ♘b1 ♘bd7 16 ♘d2 ♗d5 17 ♘c4 ♗xc4 18 ♗xc4 g6 19 h4 ♗g7 20 ♖he1 h5 21 ♕e2 ♕c7 22 ♘f3 ♘b6 23 ♖d4 0-0 24 ♖ed1 a5 25 g4 hxg4 26 ♘h2 ♖fd8 27 ♘xg4 ♖xd4 28 ♖xd4 ♖d8 29 ♘f6+ ♔f8 30 ♘h7+ ♔g8 31 ♘f6+ ♔f8 32 ♘h7+ ♔g8 and it was a draw in V.Liberzon-S.Tatai, Beersheba 1978.

13 ♗xb5??

Trajkovic thought this was a winning move and put '!!' after it, but with the hindsight of many years of theory we can say it's actually losing. Better is

13 ♗e2 ♗c5 14 ♗f4 ♕f6 15 ♗g5 and White continued his attack in V.Kotronias-E.Hermansson, Malmö 2007.

13...axb5 14 ♖he1 h5!!



The only way to stop the attack.

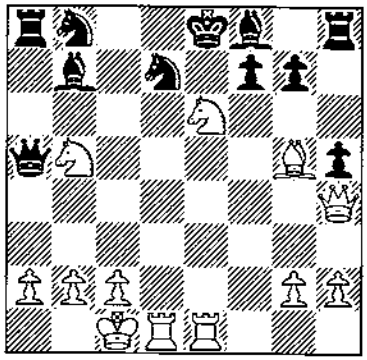
15 ♕h4 ♕c7??

Black misses a strong resource: 15...♕c5!! 16 ♘cxb5 (White isn't helped by 16 ♘xe6 fxe6 17 ♖xe6+ ♔f7 18 ♖de1 ♕f5 19 g4 ♕xg4 20 ♕f2+ ♔g8 21 ♗e7 ♘c6 0-1 A.Zaitsev-L.Belov, Saratov 1966) 16...♖xa2 17 ♔b1 ♗d5 18 ♖d3 (or 18 ♖e3 ♕b6 19 ♘xe6 ♗xe6 20 ♕c4 ♗c5!, which improves over 20...♗e7 21 ♕c8+ ♕d8 22 ♘c7+ with equality, as given by Nunn) 18...f6 19 ♖c3 ♕b6 20 ♘c7+ ♔f7 21 ♗c1 ♕a5 22 ♘b3 ♖a1+ 23 ♘xa1 ♕a2 and mate in C.Dieta-A.Dearnley, correspondence 1999.

16 ♘cxb5 ♕a5

Black is toast in any case: 16...♕b6 17 ♕f4 ♗e7 18 ♘xe6 f6 19 ♘d6+ ♗xd6 20 ♖xd6 ♕a5 21 ♘xg7+ ♔d8 22 ♗xf6+ ♔c8 23 ♗c3 forced Black to resign in Przybiski-S.Mierzejewski, correspondence 1974, and after 16...♕c5 17 ♕f4 ♗e7 18 ♘xe6! fxe6 19 ♖xe6 ♘f6 20 ♘d6+ ♔f8 21 ♗xf6 White has a crushing attack.

17 ♘xe6!!



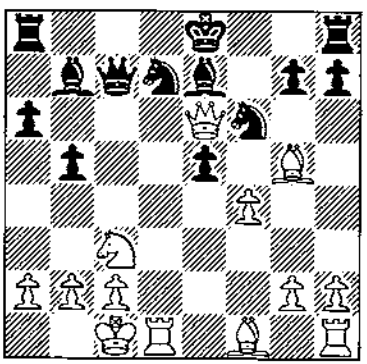
Destroying the king's shelter.

17...fxe6 18 ♖xe6+ ♔f7 19 ♕c4! 1-0

It's mate after 19...♕a4 20 ♖f6+ ♔e8 21 ♘c7+ ♔d8 22 ♖xf8.

Game 94
A.Vitolinsh-S.Yuferov
Moscow 1972

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 e5 ♗b7 11 ♕h3 dxe5 12 ♘xe6!? fxe6 13 ♕xe6+ ♗e7



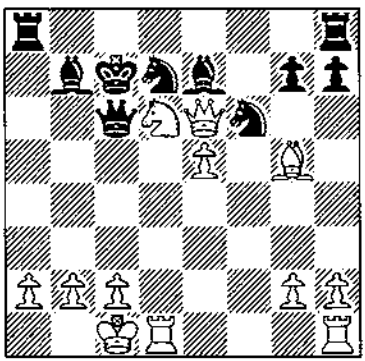
14 ♗xb5!?

Another try is 14 ♘xb5, as we saw in the previous chapter.

14...axb5 15 ♘xb5 ♕c6

15...♕b6 is another defensive attempt: 16 ♘d6+ ♔d8 17 fxe5 ♔c7 18 exf6 (we believe 18 ♗xf6!? gxf6, as played in V.Berlinsky-L.Dominguez, Turin Olympiad 2006, and then 19 ♕xe7 ♖xa2 20 b3 is promising: for example, 20...♗c6 21 ♘c4 ♕f2 22 ♖d2 ♕f5 23 ♖hd1 ♖ha8 24 ♕d6+ ♔d8 25 exf6 ♖a1+ 26 ♔b2 ♖8a2+ 27 ♔c3 ♕b5 28 f7 is winning for White) 18...♗xd6 19 ♖xd6 ♕xd6 20 ♕c4+ ♗c6 21 ♖d1 ♖a4?? (21...♘e5 is good for Black) 22 fxg7 ♖xc4 23 gxh8♕ is good for White, who went on to win in S.Brenjo-V.Jakovljevic, Teslic 2006.

16 ♘d6+ ♔d8 17 fxe5 ♔c7



18 ♕xe7

Instead 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 ♕xe7 ♖xa2 20 ♘xb7 ♖a1+ (20...fxe5!? 21 ♖d3 ♖a1+ 22 ♔d2 ♖xh1 23 ♘c5 is a risky attempt by Black to win, D.Boros-E.Najer, Las Vegas 2003) 21 ♔d2 ♕d5+ is a draw.

18...♖xa2

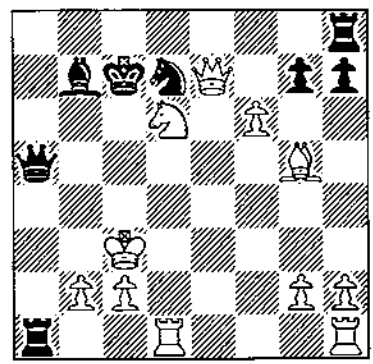
18...♘d5 19 ♖xd5 ♕xd5 20 ♖d1 ♕xe5 21 ♘xb7 ♕xe7 22 ♗xe7 ♖xa2 is also fine for Black, even though White later won in F.Boettcher-A.Parrilla, correspondence 2003.

19 exf6 ♖a1+ 20 ♔d2 ♕d5+

And not 20...♕xg2+? when 21 ♔c3 ♕f3+ 22 ♖d3 ♕xh1 23 ♘e8+ ♔b8 24 ♕d8+ ♔a7 25 ♗e3+ ♔a6 26 ♖d6+ ♗c6 27 ♕a8+ ♔b5 28 ♘c7 is mate.

21 ♔c3 ♕a5+!

Black must take the draw: 21...♖xd1? 22 ♖xd1 ♕xd1 23 fxg7 ♖g8 24 ♘e8+ ♔c6 25 ♕e6+ again leaves him facing mate.



22 ♔d3 ♕d5+

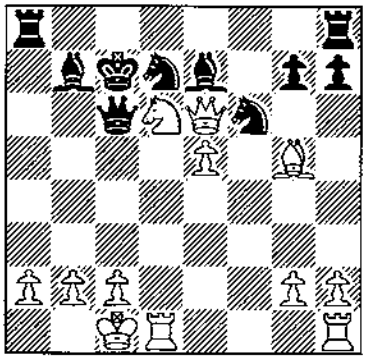
Accurate again, whereas 22...♖xd1+ 23 ♖xd1 ♕xg5 24 ♘xb7 leaves White with some chances.

23 ♔c3 ½-½

Game 95
V.Rajlich-D.Sahovic
Belgrade 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♘bd7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5 10 e5 ♗b7 11 ♕h3 dxe5

12 ♘xe6 fxe6 13 ♕xe6+ ♗e7 14 ♗xb5 axb5 15 ♘xb5 ♕c6 16 ♘d6+ ♔d8 17 fxe5 ♔c7



So far, all as in the previous game.

18 ♔b1?

Levy, back in the 1970s, thought this move was 'interesting'. At first we believed that it offered White a substantial advantage and, indeed, *Rybka's* inventor, Vasik Rajlich, has successfully used it at a high level.

18...♘d5?

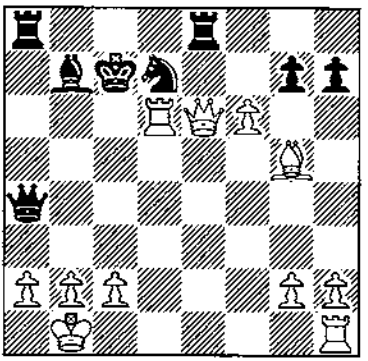
Just look at our following analysis. How can this be bad for White? Consider lines like:

a) 18...♗f8 19 ♕f7 ♗xd6 20 ♖xd6 ♕a4 21 exf6 ♔xd6 22 ♖d1+ ♔c7 23 fxg7 ♖hc8 24 g8♕ ♖xg8 25 ♗f4+ ♔b6 26 ♖xd7 ♕xa2+ 27 ♕xa2 ♖xa2 28 ♔xa2 ♗e4 29 c4 ♖xg2 30 ♔a3 and wins.

b) 18...♗xd6 19 ♖xd6 ♕xg2 20 ♖hd1 ♕xg5 (20...♖ae8 21 ♖xd7+ ♘xd7 22 ♕xd7+ ♔b8 23 ♕d6+ and ♖d3 to come will win quickly) 21 ♖xd7+ and mate follows.

c) 18...♖he8 19 ♘xe8+ ♖xe8 20 ♕xc6+ ♗xc6 21 exf6 ♗xf6 22 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 23 ♖he1 ♗xg2 24 ♖xe8 ♘xe8 25 a4 ♗c6 26 a5 ♘f6 27 c4 g5 28 b4 and the three passed pawns should win.

d) Unfortunately I came crashing back to earth when I analysed this variation with chess expert Joel Yoffie. He has played only in about five tournaments in his life, but it took him all of 10 minutes to prove that all my work with *Fritz* was wrong! When I came home and started to analyse Yoffie's idea I understood that White is in big trouble. For example, 18...♗xd6! 19 ♖xd6 ♕a4! 20 exf6 ♖he8!



forces White to give up more material: 21 ♖xd7+ ♕xd7 22 ♕c4+ ♗c6 23 ♗f4+ ♔b7 24 f7 ♖e4 25 ♕b3+ ♗b5 26 ♗d6 ♕xd6 27 ♕xb5+ ♔c7 and White's four pawns don't compensate for the rook, so Black has a winning position.

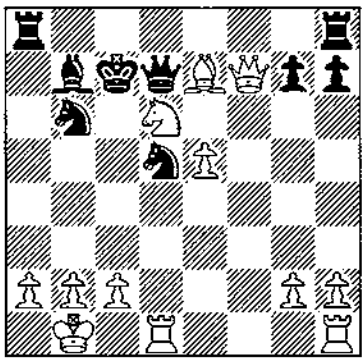
Returning to 18...♘d5:

19 ♗xe7 ♘7b6

19...♖xa2 is perhaps the best try, but then comes 20 ♘b5+! ♕xb5 21 ♕d6+ ♔c8 22 ♔xa2 ♖e8 (or 22...♘e3 23 ♖d3! ♘c4 24 ♕b4 ♕xb4 25 ♗xb4 ♘dxe5 26 ♖g3 and the pawn on g7 is a goner, because 26...g6 runs into 27 b3 ♘b6 28 ♗c3 ♖e8 29 ♖e1 ♘bd7 30 ♖ge3) 23 e6

♖xe7 24 exd7+ ♖xd7 25 ♕f8+ ♔c7 26 ♖he1 and White's attack is the stronger.

20 ♕f7 ♕d7



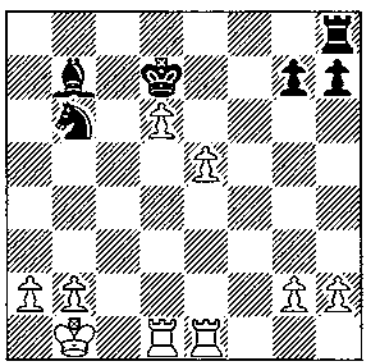
21 c4?

21 ♘f5 ♖he8 22 ♖hf1 ♖xe7 23 ♘xe7 ♕xe7 24 c4 ♘xc4 25 ♖xd5 ♕xf7 26 ♖xf7+ ♔b6 27 ♖d4 ♗e4+ 28 ♔a1 ♘xe5 29 ♖xg7 with a winning ending was the right way.

21...♕xe7 22 cxd5 ♕xf7 23 ♘xf7 ♖af8?

We don't understand why Black rejected the natural 23...♖he8, which should not lose.

24 d6+ ♔d7 25 ♘xh8 ♖xh8 26 ♖he1



Now a favourable outcome for White is no longer in doubt.

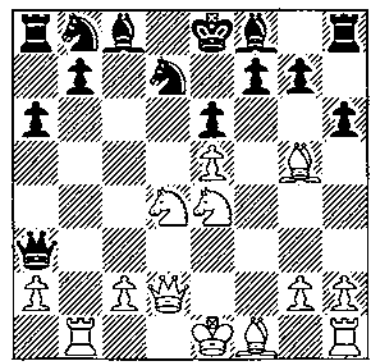
26...♔e6 27 ♖d4 ♘d7 28 g3 ♖a8 29 ♖g4 g6 30 ♖h4 h5 31 g4 ♗f3 32 gxh5 ♗xh5 33 b4 ♖h8 34 ♔b2 ♖f8 35 a4 ♖f2+ 36 ♔a1 ♗f3 37 ♖h7 ♗g4 38 ♖e7+ ♔d5 39 e6 ♘b6 40 d7 1-0

Game 96
N.Martinez-R.Vera
Cuba 1984

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♕b6 8 ♕d2 ♕xb2 9 ♖b1 ♕a3 10 e5

10 f5 ♘c6 became the main line of the Poisoned Pawn. The text goes back to 1948!

10...dxe5 11 fxe5 ♘fd7 12 ♘e4 h6



13 ♗b5!?

Tal introduced this sacrificial idea in a game against Tolush in 1956, although not in this exact position. Instead 13 ♗h4 is virtually the only move played today when this variation (10 e5) is tried: 13...♕a4 14 ♗e2 ♘c6?? (14...♕xa2 is essential and leads to highly unclear play) 15 ♘xe6! g5 16

♘f6+ and 1-0 was T.Radjabov-V.Anand, Rishon Le Zion (blitz) 2006. A bad day for a world champion.

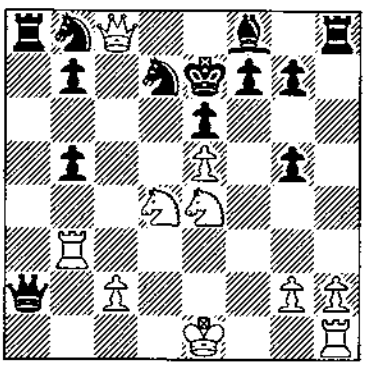
13...hxg5

Here is an example of accepting the other bishop: 13...axb5 14 ♘xb5 hxg5 15 ♘xa3 ♗xa3 (Black obtains enough for the queen) 16 ♕xg5 ♖a4 17 ♕f4 ♖a5 18 0-0 ♘xe5 19 ♖b3 ♗c5+ 20 ♘xc5 ♖xc5 21 ♖c3 ♖xc3 22 ♕xe5 ♖xc2 23 ♕xb8 0-0 24 ♖f2 ♖c1+ 25 ♖f1 ♖c2 26 ♖f2 and ½-½, R.Garbarino-H.Saldano Dayer, Buenos Aires 1995.

14 ♖b3 ♕xa2 15 ♕c3 axb5

Perhaps better is 15...♘c6!? 16 ♗xc6 bxc6 17 0-0 ♘xe5 18 ♘e2 ♕a4 19 ♕xe5 ♕c4 20 ♖d3 f5?? (20...♕b5 21 ♘d6+ ♗xd6 22 ♕xd6 ♕b6+ 23 ♔h1 ♖a7 should win) 21 ♖xf5 ♖a7?? (21...♗e7) 22 ♖xf8+, but by this point White was winning in M.Quinteros-J.Sunye Neto,J San Pedro de Jujuy 1981.

16 ♕xc8+ ♔e7



17 ♘d6??

A rare modern reference saw White prefer 17 0-0! and after 17...♕a7 18 ♖d3 ♘xe5 (18...f5? 19 ♖xf5 exf5 20 ♘d6 ♕xd4+ 21 ♖xd4 ♖a1+ 22 ♔f2 ♘xe5 23 ♕xb8 ♘g4+ 24 ♔e2 is good for White) 19 ♘c5 ♘bd7 20 ♘f5+ exf5 21 ♖xd7+ ♔f6 22 ♖xf7+ ♔g6 23 ♕xf5+ ♔h6 Black had successfully defended and White had to take the draw in A.Shabalov-A.Areshchenko, Port Erin 2006.

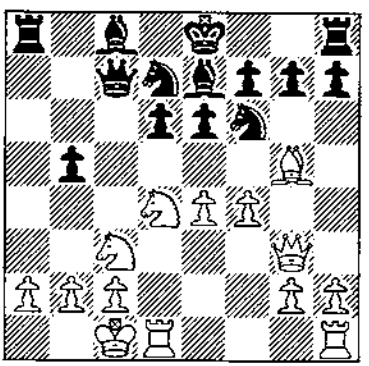
17...♘c6! 18 0-0 ♘cxe5! 19 ♘4f5+ exf5 20 ♘xf5+ ♔f6 21 ♕c7 ♔g6 0-1

Game 97
A.Vitolinsh-B.Anetbayev
Riga 1975

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♕g3 b5

Better than 10...0-0 11 ♗d3 b5 12 ♖he1 b4 13 ♘d5! exd5 14 ♘f5 ♗d8 15 ♘xg7 ♔h8 16 exd5 ♖g8 17 ♘f5 ♘c5 18 ♗xf6+ and the checkmate in two moves forced Black to give up in V.Koziak-V.Buturin, Lvov 1997. However, 10...h6 11 ♗h4 g5!? is playable.

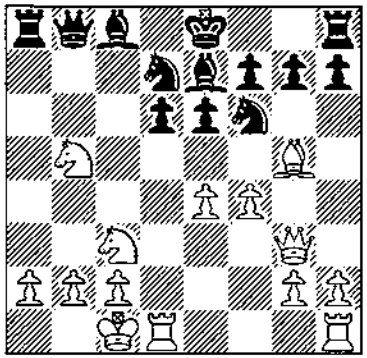
11 ♗xb5! axb5



12 ♘dxb5

Not the only try; Konstantinopolsky's bold 12 ♖he1!? is the alternative.

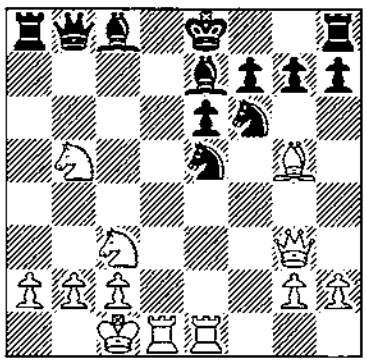
12...♕b8



13 e5 dxe5

Black correctly avoids 13...♘d5 14 ♖xd5 exd5 15 ♗xe7 ♔xe7 16 ♕xg7 when White is winning, according to Gipslis.

14 fxe5 ♘xe5 15 ♖he1



15...♘c4?

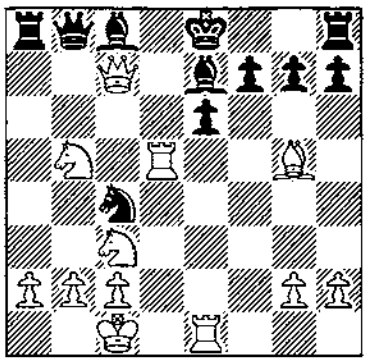
Much better is 15...♘g6! 16 ♘c7+ (or 16 ♗xf6 ♗xf6 17 ♘c7+ ♔f8 18 ♘xa8 e5! 19 ♘d5 ♕xa8 20 ♘xf6 gxf6 21 ♖d8+ ♔g7 22 ♖xh8 ♔xh8 with good winning chances in the ending) 16...♔f8 17 ♘xa8 ♕xa8 18 ♕c7 h6 19 ♗e3 ♘e8 20 ♕b6 ♕xg2 21 ♔b1 and now 21...♕xh2 looks good for Black, although after 21...♕b7 Black won anyway in K.Shirazi-W.Browne, Greenville 1983.

16 ♕c7! ♘d5?

We believe that after 16...♗a6 17 ♕c6+ ♔f8 18 ♕xc4 ♗xb5 19 ♘xb5 ♕xh2 Black has chances to survive.

17 ♖xd5!

17 ♘xd5? ♗xg5+ 18 ♔b1 ♕xb5 is winning for Black.



17...0-0

White wins too after 17...♗xg5+ 18 ♖xg5 0-0 19 ♕xc4.

18 ♗xe7! 1-0

Game 98
V.Tsaturian-A.Bangiev
USSR 1988

Notes to this game are based heavily on those of Kasparov and Tsaturian in *Informator 46*.

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 g4 b5 11 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 12 g5 ♘d7 13 f5

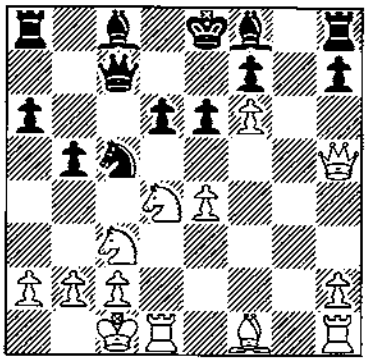
For 13 a3 ♖b8! see Minic-Fischer in the introduction to Chapter Four.

13...♘c5

The solid 13...♗xg5+ is the other main approach for Black.

14 f6 gxf6 15 gxf6 ♗f8 16 ♕h5

16 ♖g1!? is Bela Perenyi's highly interesting idea (see Game 21).



16...♖g8?!

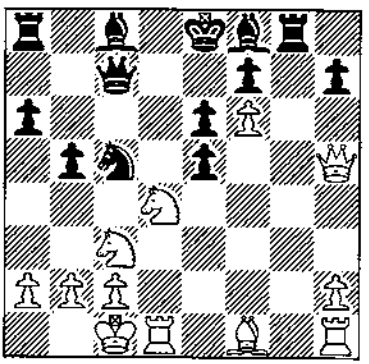
An attempt to innovate; the old reliable way is 16...♗d7. Here is one relatively recent example: 17 ♗h3 b4 18 ♘d5 exd5 19 exd5 0-0-0 20 ♘c6 ♖e8 21 ♖he1 ♔b7 22 ♗xd7 ♖xe1 23 ♖xe1 ♘xd7 24 ♖e4 a5 25 ♕xf7 ♔b6 26 ♔d1 ♘c5 27 ♕xc7+ ♔xc7 28 ♖e8 ♘d7 29 f7 ♔b6 30 ♖d8 ♔c7 31 ♖e8 ♔b6 32 ♖d8 ♔c7 33 ♖e8 and ½-½, P.Spitz-V.Hefka, correspondence 2003.

17 e5!

This is Tsaturian's improvement over 17 ♗h3. Also possible is 17 ♖e1!? ♕a5 18 ♗h3 ♖g6 19 ♔b1 ♗d7 20 ♘d5 b4? (20...♖h6 21 ♕f3 exd5 22 exd5+ ♔d8 23 ♗xd7 ♔xd7 looks better to us) 21 e5 with an attack, although the game eventually ended in a draw, P.Carlsson-V.Babula, European Team Championship, Crete 2007.

17...dxe5?

Not good. Instead 17...d5 18 ♗d3 ♘xd3+ 19 ♖xd3 gives White a positional advantage, but even 17...b4 18 ♕xh7 doesn't help Black: 18...♖g6 (or 18...bxc3 19 ♕xg8 cxb2+ 20 ♔b1 dxe5 21 ♗b5+! axb5 22 ♘xb5 ♕c6 23 ♘d6+ ♔d7 24 ♕xf8 and White wins) 19 ♘cb5!! (in our opinion, this is the strongest move, improving over Kasparov and Tsaturian's 19 ♗b5+) 19...axb5 20 ♘xb5 ♘b3+ 21 ♔b1 ♕a5 22 ♘xd6+ ♗xd6 23 ♗b5+! (the main idea of this is to divert the queen from the a-file when ♖xd6 will mate Black) 23...♔d8 24 ♖xd6+ ♔c7 25 ♕xf7+ ♔b8 26 a4! (forced but sufficient) 26...bxa3 (26...♕xb5 27 cxb3) 27 cxb3 axb2 28 ♗a4 ♖g2 29 ♖hd1 ♕c5 30 ♕h7 ♖a6 31 ♖d8 and a careful advance of the f-pawn will finish matters easily enough.



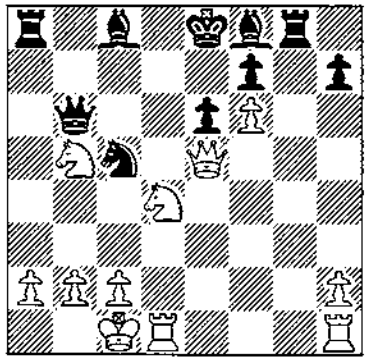
18 ♗xb5+!

Now this looks like the best try for an advantage.

18...axb5 19 ♘cxb5! ♕b6

Black avoids both the pitfalls: 19...♕a5? 20 ♘c6 and 19...♘d3+ 20 ♖xd3 ♕b7 21 ♖hd1!.

20 ♕xe5



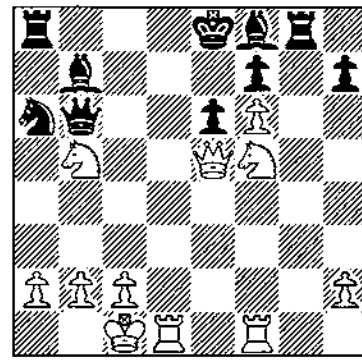
20...♘a6?

Instead both 20...♖a7? 21 ♘xa7 ♕xa7 22 ♘c6 and 20...♗h6+ 21 ♔b1 ♖g5 22 ♘c7+ ♔f8 23 ♘xa8 are also winning, but the amazing move 20...♖xa2!!, found by *Fritz*, seems to hold: 21 ♔b1! (21 ♘c7+ ♔d7 22 ♘dxe6+ ♗d6 23 ♔b1 ♖a5 looks hopeless for White) 21...♖a5 22 ♘c7+ ♔d7 (only a computer could possibly defend like this!) 23 ♘cb5 ♖xb5 24 ♘xb5+ ♔c6 25 c4 ♗a6 26 ♖d4 with a complete mess. We invite our readers to draw their own conclusions, but we are stopping here to preserve our sanity.

21 ♘f5 ♗b7

21...♕c5 22 ♘g7+! ♖xg7 23 ♕xc5 wins material or mates, as does 21...♗d7 22 ♘bd6+ ♗xd6 23 ♘xd6+ ♔f8 24 ♘c4 ♕c6 25 ♖hg1! ♖g6 26 ♖xg6 hxg6 27 ♕g5 ♔e8 28 ♕h6 ♕c5 29 ♕h8+.

22 ♖hf1!



22...♗c6

Alternatively, 22...♖d8 23 ♘bd6+ ♗xd6 24 ♖xd6 ♕c5 25 ♘g7+ ♖xg7 26 ♖xd8+ ♔xd8 27 ♕xc5 ♘xc5 28 fxg7 wins, as does 22...♕c5 23 ♘g7+ ♖xg7 24 fxg7! ♕xe5 25 g8♕ ♕e3+ 26 ♔b1 ♗f3 27 ♘d6+.

23 ♘bd6+ ♗xd6 24 ♕xd6 1-0

Chapter Seven

Miscellaneous Sacrifices

This chapter does not really need an introduction, since a brief note before each game or set of related games can do the task. So let's pitch right in. I promised to discuss the following game in the notes to Stean-Browne, so I'll take care of it now. Indeed, it's no hardship, because this is one of the most beautiful games ever played in a World Championship match.

Game 99
B.Spassky-T.Petrosian
World Championship (Game 19), Moscow 1969

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 ♘bd7 7 ♗c4

It's worth pausing a moment here to point out that White's sixth and seventh moves can be inverted. I believe in that case that 7 ♗g5 is undoubtedly White's most testing move.

7...♕a5

After 7...e6 8 0-0, the reply 8...h6 was seen in Stean-Browne, whereas the move 8...♕c7? allows 9 ♗xe6!, as in Keres-Sajtar. Both these games have been discussed earlier in this book. Otherwise, 7...h6 8 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 9 ♕e2 is pleasant for White, while Gligoric considers 7...♕c7 and 7...g6 as playable, but dismisses 7...b5? 8 ♗d5 ♘xd5 9 ♘xd5 as inferior.

8 ♕d2 h6?! 9 ♗xf6 ♘xf6 10 0-0-0 e6 11 ♖he1

Spassky's idea is simple. He will wait until Black castles short, then blast him with g2-g4. In the meantime he prepares a central advance to rush Black along.

11...♗e7? 12 f4 0-0 13 ♗b3 ♖e8 14 ♔b1 ♗f8 15 g4!

Routine but effective. This kind of line-opening sacrifice is more often played in the Open Sicilian by Black: for example, a ...b5 sacrifice in the

Dragon. By now Petrosian was probably regretting his eighth move.

15...♘xg4

Gligoric mentions 15...♘d7 16 h4 with g4-g5 to come.

16 ♕g2 ♘f6 17 ♖g1 ♗d7 18 f5

This thrust, stock in the Sozin, here has the added bonus of threatening to blow open the doors to Black's home. Maybe Black should submit to passivity with 18...e5. The Armenian's choice was unsuccessful, to put it mildly.

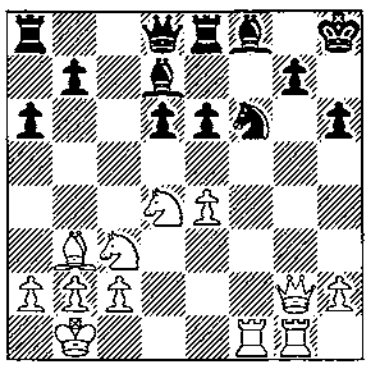
18...♔h8 19 ♖df1

Threatening 20 fxe6 and 21 ♖xf6.

19...♕d8 20 fxe6

If 20...♗xe6 White can lop off the bishop then continue as he does in the game.

20...fxe6



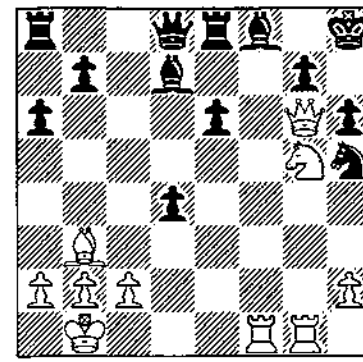
21 e5! dxe5 22 ♘e4

A lovely breakthrough: f6 is crumbling, while 22...♘xe4? 23 ♖xf8+ mates.

22...♘h5 23 ♕g6! exd4

Robbing the fans of an even nicer finish. Gligoric gives 23...♘f4 24 ♖xf4 exf4 25 ♘f3 ♕b6 26 ♖g5! ♗c6 27 ♘f6!, which is certainly strong.

24 ♘g5 1-0



This final position deserves a diagram. The end now would be 24...hxg5 25 ♕xh5+ ♔g8 26 ♕f7+ ♔h8 27 ♖f3, so Petrosian resigned. Not even Fischer ever made such short shrift of 'El Tigre' as did Spassky here.

Game 100
R.Fischer-J. Rubinetti
Palma de Mallorca
Interzonal 1970

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗c4

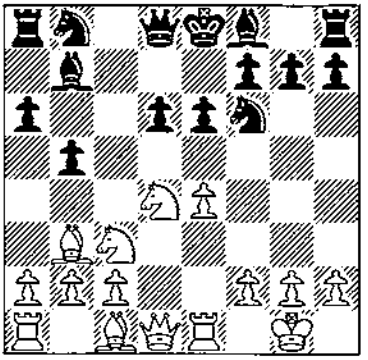
Fischer's pet line which now bears his name.

6...e6 7 ♗b3 b5 8 0-0 ♗b7?!

Chiefly as a result of this game, 8...♗e7! is now generally accepted as the best defence. You can find discussion of that move elsewhere in this text, including in Nikolenko-Nagy in Chapter Two.

9 ♖e1!

Fischer was not the first to play this move, but he was the first to demonstrate its full power.



9...♘bd7 10 ♗g5

Now Black is in a quandary. He cannot play 10...♗e7 because of 11 ♗xe6!. Instead in an earlier game K.Honfi-S.Tatai, Monaco 1968, cited by Wade and Blackstock in the English tournament book, Black chose 10...♘c5 and was hit with 11 ♗d5!. The Italian master calmly replied 11...h6, and eventually won the game! However, after 12 ♗xf6! (rather than Honfi's 12 ♗xb7, but White might transpose to Fischer-Rubinetti with 12 ♗h4) 12...♕xf6 13 b4! exd5 14 exd5+! White should be doing pretty well.

10...h6 11 ♗h4

Fischer is content to lie in wait, but objectively 11 ♗xf6 is probably stronger. King gives 11...♘xf6 12 ♕f3 as promising for White, while Ivkov in *Informator* suggests 12 a4 b4 13 ♘a2 ♘xe4 14 ♘xb4.

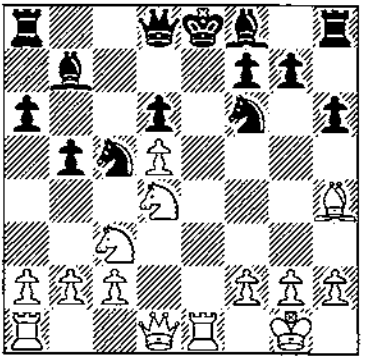
11...♘c5?

Walking right into the trap. Kavalek gives 11...g5! 12 ♗g3 ♘e5 as playable. King continues here with 13 ♗xe6!? fxe6 14 ♘xe6 ♕d7 15 ♘d5 which he likes for White.

12 ♗d5! exd5

Instead 12...b4 is Tal-Mukhin from Chapter One.

13 exd5+



13...♔d7

White wins after 13...♗e7? 14 ♘f5.

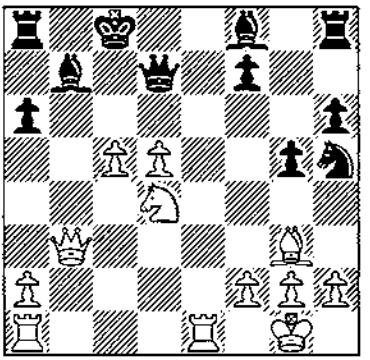
14 b4! ♘a4 15 ♘xa4 bxa4 16 c4

Fischer is following earlier analysis by Maric. White has two pawns and a massive initiative for his piece.

16...♔c8 17 ♕xa4 ♕d7 18 ♕b3 g5 19 ♗g3 ♘h5 20 c5!

Here they come!

20...dxc5 21 bxc5



21...♕xd5?

I find it amazing that the final

moves of this game are glossed over in every published commentary I have yet read. No one has yet asked the obvious question: 'Why not 21...♗xd5?' Clearly the answer is not 22 c6? ♗xb3 23 cxd7+ ♔xd7 24 ♘xb3 ♘xg3 which trades too many pieces. Surely Mikhail Tal would not have repeated this line if that was all he could achieve! I believe Fischer would have played 22 ♕c2! when I don't see a good defence for Black. The main line runs 22...♘xg3 23 hxg3 ♗g7 24 c6 ♕g4 25 ♘f5! ♗xa1 26 ♘e7+ ♔c7 27 ♘xd5+ ♔d6 28 ♘e3! ♕b4 29 ♖d1+ ♗d4 30 ♕e4! ♔c5 31 ♕d5+ ♔b6 32 ♘c4+ and wins.

22 ♖e8+ ♔d7 23 ♕a4+ ♗c6 24 ♘xc6 1-0

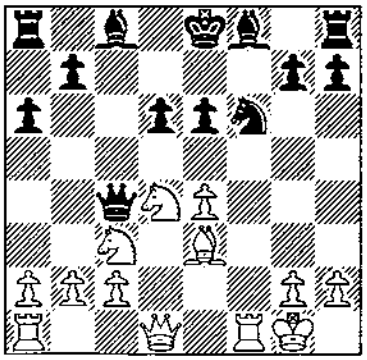
The analogue for White of the standard ...♖xc3 sacrifice by Black is a relatively rare bird in the Open Sicilian, and even rarer when it scores a victory; many prominent examples end in a draw. Rarest of all is an effective ♖xf6 when the black king's address is still e8. The following is that most rara avis:

Game 101
E.Lasker-V.Pirc
Moscow 1935

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 d6 6 ♗e2 e6 7 0-0 a6 8 ♗e3 ♕c7 9 f4 ♘a5

Not a good idea. The Scheveningen was still an adolescent in 1935, but even so Pirc should have stayed on safer paths with 9...♗e7.

10 f5 ♘c4 11 ♗xc4 ♕xc4 12 fxe6 fxe6



13 ♖xf6! gxf6 14 ♕h5+ ♔d8

Or 14...♔e7 15 ♘f5+! exf5 16 ♘d5+ with a mating attack.

15 ♕f7 ♗d7

White wins too after 15...♗e7 16 ♘f5! ♖e8 17 ♘xd6! ♗xd6 18 ♗b6+ ♗c7 19 ♖d1+.

16 ♕xf6+ ♔c7 17 ♕xh8 ♗h6 18 ♘xe6+ ♕xe6 19 ♕xa8 ♗xe3+ 20 ♔h1 1-0

A Hobbesian game: nasty, brutish, and short.

More typical is the struggle in the following encounter. The sacrifice shatters Black's kingside, but he has enough resources to scrape through.

Game 102
L.Yudasin-Van Wely
Philadelphia 1994

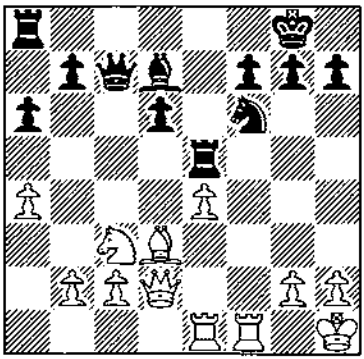
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 a4 e6 7 ♗e2 ♘c6 8 0-0 ♗e7 9 ♗e3 0-0 10 ♔h1 ♕c7 11 ♕d2

Yudasin frequently avoids standard paths. This game is no exception.

11...♗d7 12 f4 ♖fe8 13 ♗d3 ♘g4 14 ♗g1 ♘xd4 15 ♗xd4 ♗f6 16 ♗xf6 ♘xf6

The simplifications have been beneficial to Black. White faces the prospect of an inferior middlegame and ending due to his bad bishop. Thus he must act quickly.

17 ♖ae1 e5 18 fxe5 ♖xe5



19 ♖xf6 gxf6 20 ♘d5 ♕d8 21 ♕h6

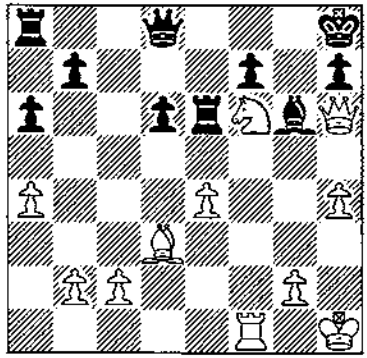
Now if 21...♖e6 there follows 22 e5 with a mating attack. Van Wely finds the only way out.

21...♗f5 22 ♘xf6+ ♔h8 23 ♖f1 ♗g6 24 h4

It's very natural to make luft with such a frail back rank, but we think Yudasin missed a stronger plan here. 24 ♗c4! does many good things: it stops ...♖e6, it threatens ♗xf7, and it prepares ♗d5 followed by a queenside pawn roller. Indeed, 24...♕f8 (24...♖c8 25 ♗d5! ♖xc2?? 26 ♗xf7 works this time) 25 ♕d2! (25 ♕xf8+? ♖xf8 26 ♘d7 ♖xe4 dissipates all the pressure) 25...♕e7 26 ♗d5 leaves Black with many problems to solve.

24...♖e6

Intending to repulse the invading queen with ...♕f8.



25 ♕g5

Yudasin analyses 25 ♕e3 ♖xf6 26 ♕d4 ♔g7 27 g4 d5! (once more the old saw about meeting a flank attack with action in the centre is affirmed) 28 exd5 (28 g5? dxe4 29 gxf6+ ♔g8 is very good for Black) 28...♕b6 29 ♕c3 ♗xd3 30 cxd3 ♖c8 31 ♖xf6 ♕xf6 32 ♕xc8 ♕f1+ with perpetual.

25...♔g7

Allowing a repetition. McDonald in *Modern Chess Miniatures* considers some alternatives: 25...♖c8 26 g4 ♖c5 27 ♕h6! or, better, 25...♕e7 26 g4 when Black should again submit to a repetition as in the game.

26 ♘h5+ ♔h8 27 ♘f6 ♔g7 ½-½

Our next example illustrates a rare tactical theme I choose to call Paulsen's Coffin, having in mind the unfortunate predicament Louis Paulsen found himself in against Paul Morphy in their famous encounter at New York, 1857. One of the joys in writing a book like this is the unearthing of a treasure buried in some forgotten tome. The game

which follows is one such. It's so obscure that I don't know the full name of the winner! There were two players with the surname 'Gusev' playing in 1951. Nikolay Gusev has no games in my database which start 1 e4, so I assume the white player is Yury Gusev. (Yury and Nikolay? Coincidence or kismet?)

At any rate, this unknown masterpiece is most likely the greatest achievement in the career of a modest Soviet Master, squashing one of the three survivors (at the time of writing) of the great Candidates Tournament at Zurich in 1953. I found this game in Rolf Schwarz's 1966 compendium *Die Sizilianische Verteidigung* and have based my notes upon his. Any translations from the German are my own.

Game 103
Y.Gusev-Y.Averbakh
Moscow 1951

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 g6 6 ♗e2 ♗g7 7 ♘b3

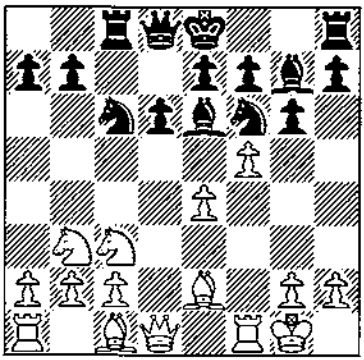
A bit early for this. More frequently seen in this position are the moves 7 ♗e3 and 7 0-0.

7...♘c6 8 0-0 ♗e6 9 f4 ♖c8?

White's unusual move order has caught his eminent adversary napping. The superior 9...♕c8! will probably transpose to standard lines.

10 f5!

Instead 10 ♗e3 0-0 would transpose to a main line. In that case 11 f5 ♗d7 12 g4?! ♘e5 13 g5? ♖xc3! is a favourable exchange sacrifice for Black, but this doesn't work in the game.



10...♗d7 11 g4 ♘e5

With the white pawn storm already under way, Black was reluctant to 'castle into it', but castling was probably a better try.

12 g5 ♘g8

Here 12...♖xc3? is, of course, well met by 13 gxf6!.

13 ♘d5!

White plans 14 f6! exf6 15 gxf6 ♘xf6 16 ♗g5!.

13...f6

Hideous, but 13...gxf5 14 exf5 h6 15 h4, leaving the horse on g8 'zugtot' (literally, move-dead), was also not appetizing.

14 ♗e3 b6 15 ♘d4

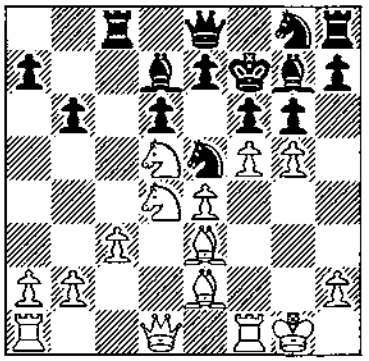
White at once sets off to exploit the weakness on e6.

15...♔f7 16 c3

Preparing ♕b3.

16...♕e8

To answer 17 ♕b3 with 17...♗a4. Now it was already possible to play technically with 17 a4, but this was Mr. Gusev's day!



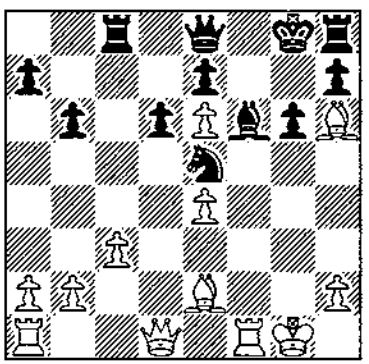
17 ♘e6! ♗xe6 18 fxe6+ ♔f8

Here 18...♔xe6 19 ♕b3 ♔d7 20 ♕a4+ ♘c6 21 ♗g4+ e6 22 gxf6 and wins is given by Schwarz. After the text, again White could switch fronts with 19 a4, as perhaps Averbakh might have preferred if he had been White, but Gusev would not be distracted.

19 ♘xf6! ♘xf6

Instead 19...exf6 20 ♕xd6+ and 21 ♕xe5 is killing.

20 gxf6 ♗xf6 21 ♗h6+ ♔g8

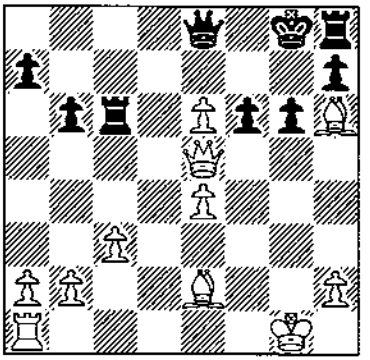


22 ♖xf6! exf6 23 ♕xd6 ♖c6

Now what?

24 ♕xe5!!

This position, diagrammed by Schwarz, caught my eye.



24...fxe5 25 ♖f1

By now poor Averbakh was probably sorry he showed up for this contest.

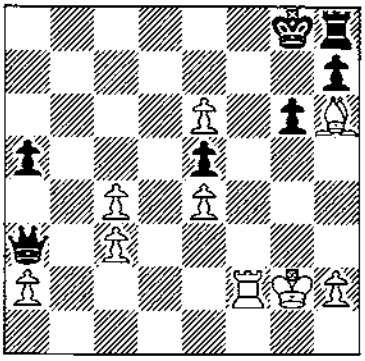
25...♖c8

The other try is to put this rook on c7, aiming to blockade the e-pawn on e7. However, after 25...♖c7 26 ♗d1! ♖e7 27 ♗b3 White has a clear winning plan: put the bishop on d5, the king on g2, leave the rook on the f-file to answer ...g5 with ♖f5, tying down the black queen, and make a passed c-pawn whose advance will finish matters. (The advance h4 if permitted will do no harm.) We won't deprive you of the pleasure you will get playing out this position against your computer by analysing any further.

26 ♗d1 ♖c4 27 ♗b3 b5 28 ♗xc4 bxc4 29 b3 a5 30 bxc4 ♕e7 31 ♔g2 ♕a3 32 ♖f2

Schwarz criticizes this move, calling it 'an aesthetic flaw which prolongs the game.' He prefers the direct 32 ♖f7 ♕b2+ 33 ♔g3 ♕xc3+ 34 ♔g4 ♕a3 35 c5! ♕xc5 36 ♖g7+, winning. I must disagree. Herr. Schwarz was a correspon-

dence player for whom shortening the game and saving postage was a serious consideration. Any OTB player will gladly milk this position for all its worth by repeating moves once or twice.



32...♕e7 33 ♖f1 g5

Of course, 33 ....♕a3 34 ♖f7 is quite hopeless, but nothing helps.

34 ♖f5

'A cold-blooded winning move', according to Schwarz. Now the black queen can only oscillate between d8 and e7 to keep guard of the mating squares f8 and g5.

34...g4

Schwarz refutes 34...♕d8 with 35 c5 ♕d2+ 36 ♖f2 ♕d8 37 c6.

35 c5 ♕d8 36 c6 ♕e7 37 c7 1-0

'And Black strikes his colours. A demonic combination!' On that matter Herr. Schwarz and I are in complete accord.

There are not many variations in any opening in which a queen sacrifice is thematic, and in most lines in which the queen is offered, it's Black who does the offering; think of the Open Ruy Lopez with ♕e2 or Bronstein's sacrifice in the Sämisch King's Indian. Nonetheless, the Najdorf features a couple of lines in which the white queen can surrender herself for a few bits of enemy pieces. But before we examine those, let's inspect a few odds and ends from the Dragon. First up is a rare positional sacrifice of the queen for a couple of minor pieces including the Dragon bishop:

Game 104
R.Nezhmetdinov-L.Chernikov
Rostov on Don 1962

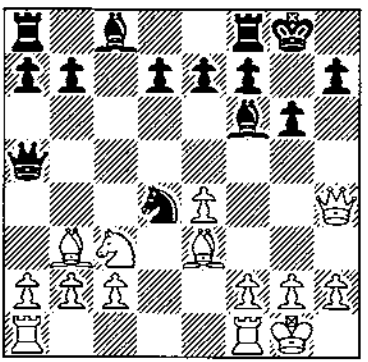
1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 ♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 g6 5 ♘c3 ♗g7 6 ♗e3 ♘f6 7 ♗c4 0-0 8 ♗b3 ♘g4

Suetin considers this dubious.

9 ♕xg4 ♘xd4 10 ♕h4

The idea. 10 ♕d1 is more natural.

10...♕a5 11 0-0 ♗f6



It seems White must resign himself to a draw by repetition after 12 ♕h6 ♗g7 13 ♕h4 ♗f6, etc, but now

Nezhmetdinov reveals his plan:

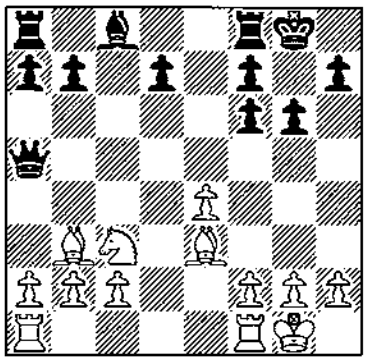
12 ♕xf6!!

White will get only two minor pieces for the queen, but he gains the bishop-pair and inflicts severe damage to the enemy pawn structure. Moreover, his minor pieces will have safe and aggressive squares from which to ply their trade; in particular the dark-squared bishop becomes a monster in the absence of its rival.

12...♘e2+!

A finesse which gains time. After 12...exf6? 13 ♗xd4 the combined attack of this bishop and the knight about to land on d5 will lead to a rout, and 12...♘xb3 13 axb3 ♕xa1 14 ♕xe7 is also quite hopeless.

13 ♘xe2 exf6 14 ♘c3



14...♖e8?

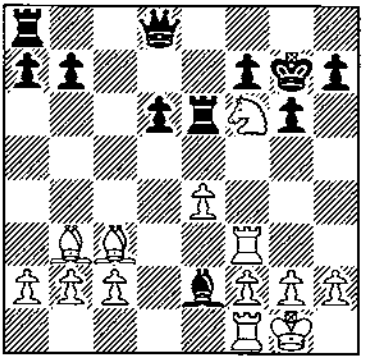
Black omits the essential counter-blow 14...d5!, which would permit him to develop and perhaps trade off one of White's more dangerous men.

15 ♘d5 ♖e6 16 ♗d4 ♔g7 17 ♖ad1

The calm manner in which White masses his forces is most instructive.

17...d6 18 ♖d3 ♗d7 19 ♖f3 ♗b5 20 ♗c3 ♕d8 21 ♘xf6! ♗e2

21...♗xf1 22 ♘g4+ is even stronger here than 22 ♘xh7+, which is also good.



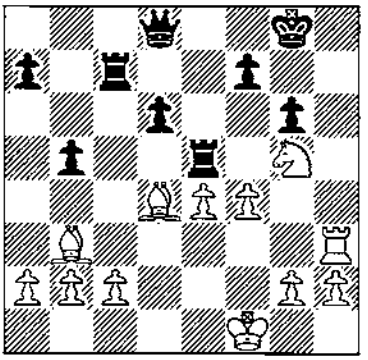
22 ♘xh7+! ♔g8

Suetin gives 22...♔xh7 23 ♖xf7+ ♔h6 24 ♗xe6 ♗xf1 25 ♗d2+ g5 26 ♗f5 ♕h8 (or 26...♕g8 27 ♖f6+ ♔h5 28 g4+) 27 h4 with a winning attack.

23 ♖h3 ♖e5 24 f4 ♗xf1 25 ♔xf1! ♖c8 26 ♗d4!

Nezhmetdinov will not allow his valuable bishop to be traded for a mere rook.

26...b5 27 ♘g5 ♖c7



28 ♗xf7+!

One last combination finishes things.

28...♖xf7 29 ♖h8+ ♔xh8 30 ♘xf7+ ♔h7 31 ♘xd8 ♖xe4 32 ♘c6 ♖xf4+ 33 ♔e2 1-0

Enough was enough. A beautiful example of sustained attack.

Theory has grouped all those 6 ♗g5 Najdorf lines in which Black plays an early ...h6 under the convenient heading 'the Browne Variation', in honour of the six-time United States Champion who assumed the mantle of America's Najdorf guru upon the retirement of Bobby Fischer. Browne tried ...h6 in many different positions, but probably his greatest success was in the position arising after 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♗d3 h6 11 ♕h3 ♘b6!, as he established in several encounters with the Dutch GM Jan Timman in the 1970s.

The Browne Variation has a sound positional basis, the idea being to gain control of the e5-square with a well-timed ...g5, but when things go wrong, look out! Indeed, White is often able to offer his queen for a devastating attack, as in the following game played when Browne was just a schoolboy.

Game 105
S.Gligoric-M.Bobotsov
Hastings 1959/60

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 h6

It later became the norm to play first 7...♗e7 8 ♕f3 and only then 8...h6.

8 ♗h4 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♕c7

9...g5 is the Gothenburg Variation, which we discussed in Chapter Two.

10 0-0-0 ♘bd7 11 ♗d3

So we have transposed to Browne's line should White retreat his bishop to h4 in lieu of Timman's 11 ♕h3. In this move order the text has, though, been superseded by 11 ♗e2!, which we'll see in our next game.

11...b5?

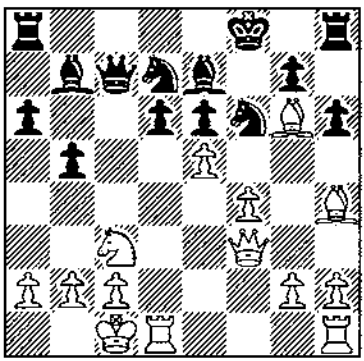
Without the insertion of ...h6 and ♗h4 this is a perfectly good move, but here it is fatal! Correct is 11...g5!.

12 e5 ♗b7 13 ♘xe6!

Yet another example of the weakening ...h6 provoking a lethal strike on e6.

13...fxe6 14 ♗g6+ ♔f8

On 14...♔d8, Rolf Schwarz gives 15 ♕h3 dxe5 16 ♕xe6 ♕c6 17 ♖xd7+ ♘xd7 18 ♕xe7+ ♔c7 19 ♖d1, etc.



15 exf6! ♗xf3 16 fxe7+ ♔g8 17 gxf3 ♘f6 18 ♗xf6 gxf6 19 e8♕+ ♖xe8 20 ♗xe8 d5 21 ♖d4

Gligoric later claimed a quicker win with 21 f5! ♕f4+ 22 ♔b1 ♕xf5 23 ♖hg1+ ♔f8 24 ♗g6!. At any rate, the rest of

this game is purely a technical exercise and requires no further commentary.

21...♔h7 22 ♗h5 ♕c5 23 ♖hd1 ♖c8 24 ♖1d2 f5 25 ♘e2 ♔g7 26 ♔b1 ♔f6 27 a3 a5 28 ♘g3 b4 29 a4 ♕c6 30 b3 ♕c3 31 ♖4d3 ♕c5 32 ♖e2 ♕g1+ 33 ♔b2 ♖c3 34 ♖dd2 d4 35 ♖g2 ♕e3 36 ♗e8 d3 37 cxd3 ♕e1 38 ♖c2 ♖xd3 39 ♗b5 ♖c3 40 ♗c4 ♖xc2+ 41 ♖xc2 e5 42 fxe5+ ♕xe5+ 43 ♔a2 f4 44 ♘e4+ ♔g6 45 ♖g2+ ♔h5 46 ♘f2 ♕e8 47 ♗d3 ♔h4 48 ♖g4+ ♔h5 49 ♗g6+ 1-0

Game 106
J.Grefe-W.Browne
U.S. Championship, El Paso 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 h6 8 ♗h4 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♘bd7 10 0-0-0 ♕c7 11 ♗e2!

For one thing, this covers the g4-square, which could be significant after ...g5. For another, it discourages 11...b5? because of 12 e5 ♗b7 13 exf6! ♗xf3 14 ♗xf3 ♗xf6 15 ♗xf6 ♖c8 16 ♗h4!, according to Geller. Note too that Schwarz points out an interesting idea here: 16 ♗xg7 ♖h7 17 ♗h5!, which might be worth looking into. Importantly too the logical 11...g5 can be met by 12 fxg5 ♘e5 13 ♕g3 ♖g8 14 ♘f3 when Black cannot maintain his outpost on e5. So Black has to turn to other approaches:

11...♖b8 12 ♕g3!

Now if Black castles, both 13 ♘d5 and 13 ♗f3 are good for White, according to Geller, while 12...g5 13 fxg5 ♖g8 14 ♘xe6! fxe6 15 gxf6! ♖xg3 16 ♗h5+ is a disaster. So Browne played the popular...

12...♖g8 13 ♖hf1!

In an earlier round Tarjan had played 13 ♖he1 against Browne but only drew. The text is stronger.

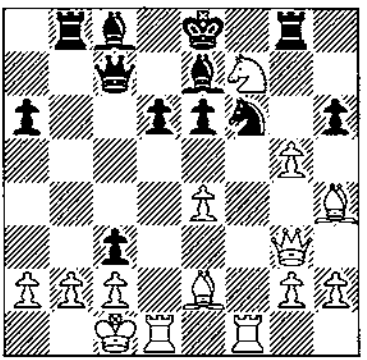
13...g5 14 fxg5 ♘e5 15 ♘f3! b5

Can Black play better? A wiser choice is 15...hxg5! when White has two choices: 16 ♘xg5 ♖g6 17 ♕h3 was agreed drawn in A.Soltis-B.Zuckerman, Birmingham 1973, but my preference is 16 ♗xg5!? ♘h5 17 ♕h3 ♗xg5+ 18 ♘xg5 ♖xg5 19 ♗xh5, which is untested, but I would prefer to be White.

16 ♘xe5 b4

On 16...dxe5 Geller shows 17 gxf6! ♖xg3 18 fxe7 ♖g5 19 ♗xg5 hxg5 20 ♗h5 to be winning.

17 ♘xf7! bxc3



18 gxf6!

By now this should come as no surprise.

18...♖xg3 19 fxe7 ♖g5 20 ♗xg5 hxg5 21 ♘xd6+ 1-0

This game was instrumental to Grefe's sharing of the Championship

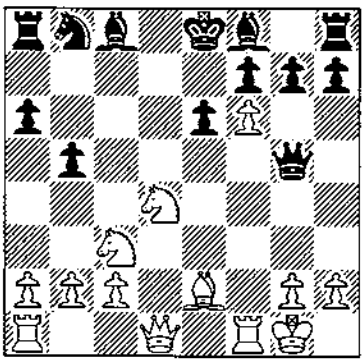
with Lubomir Kavalek that year.

Game 107
Pedersen-Hallmeyer
Denmark 1973

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 b5

Polugaevsky's move. White's response is probably the simplest in this hellishly complex opening.

8 e5 dxe5 9 fxe5 ♕c7 10 exf6 ♕e5+ 11 ♗e2 ♕xg5 12 0-0



12...♕e5

The immediate 12...♖a7 is also possible. The last word on this move seems to be Leko-Ghaem Maghami, Yerevan 2001. See the next game.

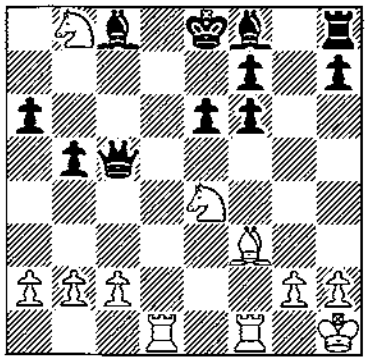
13 ♗f3 ♖a7 14 ♘c6 ♕c5+?!

14...♘xc6 15 ♗xc6+ ♗d7 16 ♗xd7+ ♖xd7 17 ♕f3 ♗d6! is the right way, as pointed out by Geller. He considers 18 ♕h3 best, but then 18...b4! 19 fxg7 (19 ♘d5? ♕xd5 20 fxg7 ♕d4+) 19...♖g8 20 ♕xh7 ♕xh2+ 21 ♕xh2 ♗xh2+ 22 ♔xh2 bxc3 is assessed by him as 'no worse' for Black.

15 ♔h1 ♖d7

Or 15...♘xc6 16 ♘e4 and the threats of fxg7 and ♘d6+ leave Black in a mess, such as after 16...♕d4 17 ♘d6+! ♕xd6 18 fxg7.

16 ♘xb8! ♖xd1 17 ♖axd1 gxf6 18 ♘e4



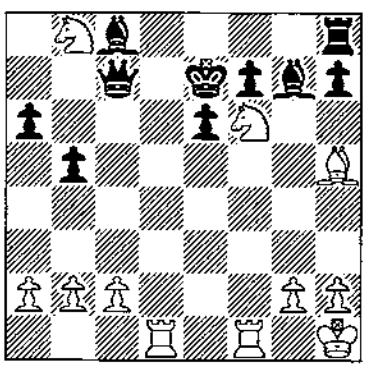
Black has but one saving move...

18...♕c7?

But this is not it. Correct is 18...♕f5! 19 ♘xf6+ ♕xf6 20 ♗c6+ ♔e7 21 ♖xf6 ♔xf6 22 ♘d7+ ♗xd7 23 ♖xd7 ♗e7 24 ♗e4 h6 25 ♗d3 ♖d8 with a virtually certain draw (analysis by Geller).

19 ♘xf6+ ♔e7 20 ♗h5! ♗g7

Black avoids mate by 20...♕xb8 21 ♘g8+ ♖xg8 22 ♖xf7+ ♔e8 23 ♖g7.



21 ♘c6+! ♕xc6 22 ♘g8+! ♔e8 23 ♗xf7+ ♔f8 24 ♖d8+ 1-0

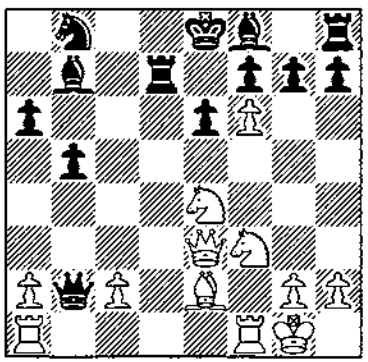
This beautiful game, commended by the editors of *Informator*, is almost forgotten today. Sic transit gloria mundi!

Game 108
P.Leko-E.Ghaem Maghami
World Team Championship, Yerevan 2001

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 b5 8 e5 dxe5 9 fxe5 ♕c7 10 exf6 ♕e5+ 11 ♗e2 ♕xg5 12 0-0 ♖a7

12...♕e5 was, of course, Pedersen-Hallmeyer, our previous game.

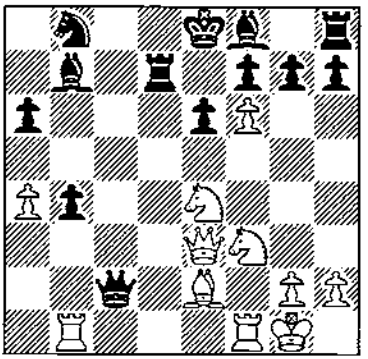
13 ♕d3 ♖d7 14 ♘e4 ♕e5 15 ♘f3 ♕xb2 16 ♕e3 ♗b7



17 a4

So far, all this had been given by Geller in 1976. But in a game from Malmo 2007, 14-year-old Indian GM Parimarjan Negi played 17 ♖ab1! against Swedish IM Emil Hermansson. That game continued 17...♕xc2 18 ♘fg5 g6? 19 ♖bc1 ♕a4 20 ♘xe6! fxe6 21 f7+ ♔d8 22 ♕g5+ ♖e7 23 ♕e5 when Black resigned due to the impending mate.

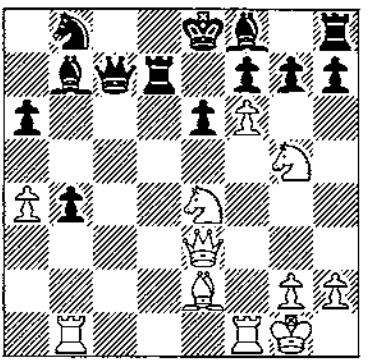
17...b4 18 ♖ab1 ♕xc2



19 ♘fg5

Geller gave 19 ♖xb4 ♗xb4 20 fxg7 ♖g8 21 ♘f6+ ♔d8 22 ♕b6+ as winning, but any analysis engine will disagree, and obviously so did Leko. Yury did his best to uphold Geller's point of view, but 22...♔c8 23 ♕xb4 ♖xg7 24 ♕f8+ ♖d8 25 ♕xg7 ♕xe2 26 ♖e1 ♖d1 looks drawish to us.

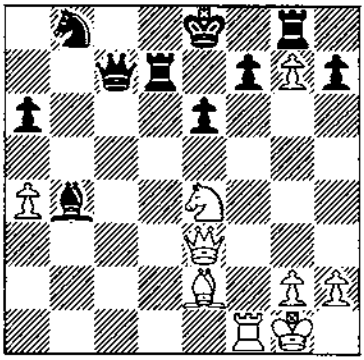
19...♕c7



20 ♖xb4!

This is only the beginning!

20...♗xe4 21 ♘xe4 ♗xb4 22 fxg7 ♖g8



23 ♘f6+! ♔d8 24 ♘xg8! ♗c5 25 ♘f6! ♗xe3+ 26 ♔h1 ♔c8 27 ♘xd7! 1-0

The most ruthless, and sufficient to induce resignation.

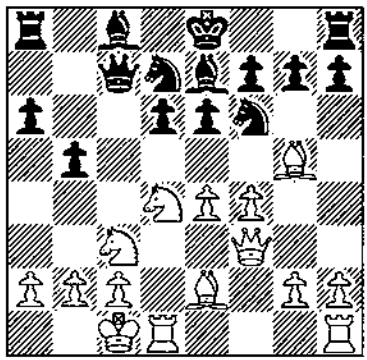
In chess, as in life, first impressions last. Paul Keres introduced a fascinating queen sacrifice against Fischer in Zurich 1959, but unfortunately he lost the game. Indeed, Fischer's improvised defence was so effective that all but a few hardy souls were deterred from exploring the line. One such intrepid individual was the Colombian GM Gildardo Garcia, who dared to test his ideas against Fischer's successor as the American Najdorf guru, the redoubtable Walter Browne.

Game 109
G.Garcia-W.Browne
U.S. Open 1990

1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘bd7 10 ♗e2

The introduction to Keres' line, all the more appropriate as it inhibits Browne's favourite retort to 10 ♗d3, namely 10...h6.

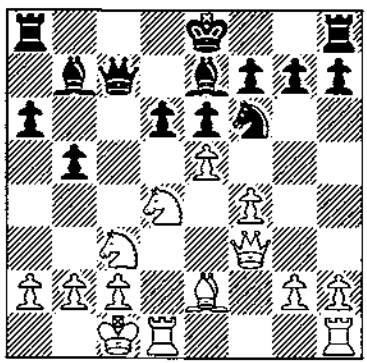
10...b5



11 ♗xf6 ♘xf6

Of course, not 11...♗xf6? 12 ♗xb5! axb5 13 ♘xb5 with 14 ♘xd6+ to follow, leaving Black's king a sitting duck in the centre.

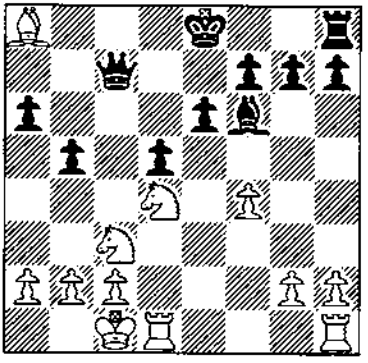
12 e5 ♗b7



13 exf6!? ♗xf3 14 ♗xf3 ♗xf6 15 ♗xa8 d5

At present White has a rook and two light pieces for the lady, but the king's bishop is awaiting execution

behind enemy lines.



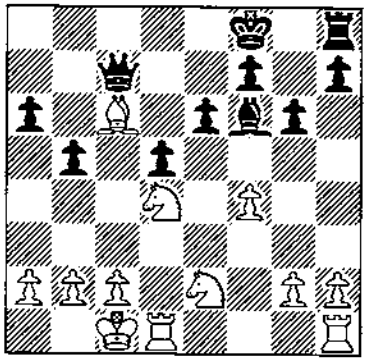
16 ♗c6+!

This was Garcia's new idea. Keres played 16 ♗xd5 straightaway, but Garcia uses his bishop's dying breath to sabotage Black's harmony.

16...♔e7?!

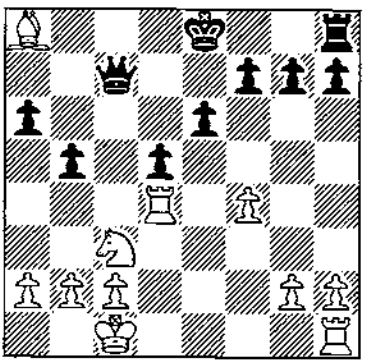
Browne's punctuation in *Informator*. In hindsight he preferred 16...♔f8 17 ♘ce2 ♗xd4 18 ♘xd4 ♕xf4+ 19 ♔b1 ♕d6 20 ♖hf1 g6 intending ...e5 with, he claimed, a slight plus for Black. The problem with this is the killing shot 21 ♘xe6+! ♕xe6 22 ♗xd5. Now if Black doesn't want to give back the queen and defend a lost rook and pawn ending, he must play something like 22...♕e5 23 ♖xf7+ ♔e8 24 ♖a7 ♕f6 when he is holding on by his fingernails. Many moves look good, for instance 25 c4 or even 25 a3. I don't see a forced win for White, but I would not mind taking over his chair.

Flash forward 17 years to Las Vegas 2007, another big Swiss, the National Open, and Gildardo Garcia repeats the variation and gets the same position after 16 ♗c6+. His young opponent, N.Yap, played 16...♔f8 17 ♘ce2 g6!,



although after 18 a4 b4 19 ♖hf1 ♔g7 20 g4 ♖c8 21 g5 ♗e7 22 h4 ♕b6 23 a5 ♕xa5 24 ♔b1 ♕b6 25 ♗a4 White had rescued the bishop with continuing pressure. Indeed, White later won, although Black may have missed a draw.

So what should Black do? Nunn and King both mention that Black can transpose to Keres-Fischer with the move order 15...♗xd4! 16 ♖xd4 d5.

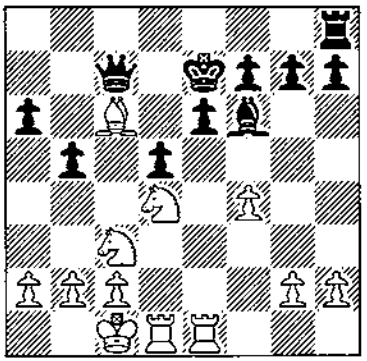


Nunn follows with 17 ♗xd5 exd5 18 ♖e1+ ♔f8 19 ♖e5 (instead of Keres' 19 ♘xd5 which is playable, though) 19...g6 20 ♘xd5 which he implies is about equal. The whole thing is food

for thought, and inspiration to investigators everywhere.

We now return to Browne's 16...♔e7:

17 ♖he1!

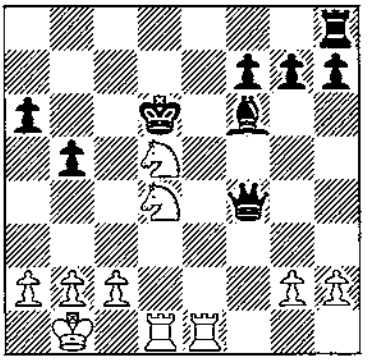


Nunn gives only 17 ♘ce2 ♖c8 as good for Black.

17...♕xf4+ 18 ♔b1 ♔d6?!

Instead 18...♔d8 19 ♖xe6! ♗xd4 20 ♘xd5 is dangerous, but Browne points out the better 18...♖d8! 19 ♘xe6! fxe6 20 ♘xd5+ ♖xd5 21 ♗xd5 e5 22 h3, although White is clearly better.

19 ♗xd5 exd5 20 ♘xd5!



Now an avalanche descends upon Black's head.

20...♕g5 21 ♘xf6 ♕xf6 22 ♘xb5+ ♔c5 23 ♖d6 ♕f5

Or 23...♕f2 24 ♖e5+ ♔b4 25 a3+ and mate in two.

24 g4 ♕f4 25 ♖ed1 ♕e4 26 ♘c3 ♕f4 27 ♖1d5+ ♔c4 28 ♖c6+ 1-0

Just in time to avoid the picturesque 28...♔b4 29 a3 mate.

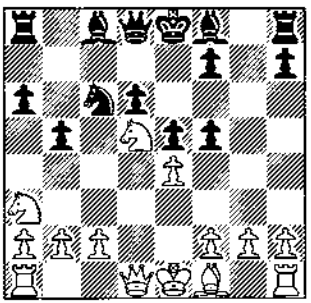
Index of Variations

1 e4

1 d4 – *68*

1...c5 2 ♘f3 d6

2...♘c6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 (4...e5 – *149*; 4...g6 – *170*) 5 ♘c3 e5 6 ♘db5 d6 7 ♗g5 a6 8 ♘a3 b5 9 ♗xf6 gxf6 10 ♘d5 f5



11 ♗xb5 (11 c3 – *146*) 11...axb5

12 ♘xb5 ♖a4 13 b4

13...♖xb4 – *147*

13...♕h4 – *148*

2...e6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 a6 (4...♘c6 5 ♘c3 ♕c7 – *47*; 5...d6 – *71*) 5 ♘c3 (5 ♗d3 – *125*) 5...♕c7 (5...b5 – *19*) 6 ♗e2 (6 g3 – *8*, *17*) 6...b5 7 0-0 ♗b7 8 ♖e1 ♘f6 9 ♗f3 d6 10 ♗f4 ♘bd7 11 ♘dxb5 axb5 12 ♘xb5

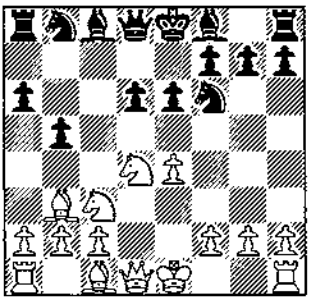
12...♕a5 – *122*

12...♕b6 – *124*

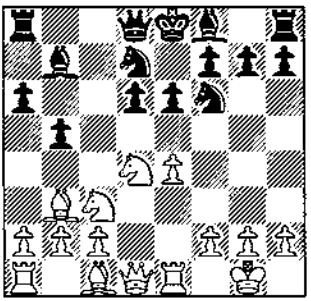
3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 and now:

A: 5...a6
B: 5...♘c6
C: Others

A) 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5
6 ♗e2 e5 (6...♕c7 – *57*) 7 ♘b3 – *114*
6 f4 – *116*
6 ♗c4 e6 7 ♗b3 b5



8 ♗g5 ♗e7 9 ♕f3 ♕c7 (9...♕b6 – *54*)
10 e5 – *74*
10 ♗xf6 – *76*
10 0-0-0 – *77*
8 0-0 ♗b7 (8...♗e7 9 ♕f3 – *46*; 9 f4 – *73*) 9 ♖e1 ♘bd7



10 ♗g5 h6
(10...♘c5 – *26*) 11 ♗h4 ♘c5 12 ♗d5
12...b4 – *27*
12...exd5 – *165*

6...e6

6...♘bd7 7 ♗c4 e6 (7...♕a5 8 ♕d2 e6 – *82*; 8...h6 – *163*) 8 0-0 (8 ♕e2 – *83*)
8...h6 – *44*
8...♕c7 – *84*

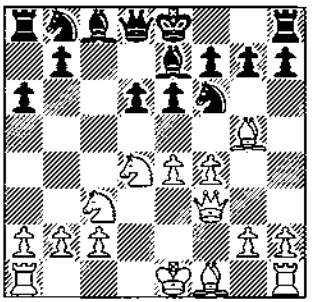
7 f4

7 ♕d3 – *134*
7 ♕f3 – *143*

and now:

A1: 7...♗e7
A2: Others

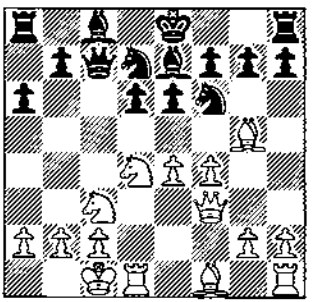
A1) 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4 ♗e7 8 ♕f3



8...♕c7

8...h6 9 ♗h4 ♗e7 (9...g5 – *64*) 10 ♕f3 ♕c7 11 ♗e2 (11 ♗d3 – *172*)
11...b5 – *66*
11...♖b8 – *66*, *173*

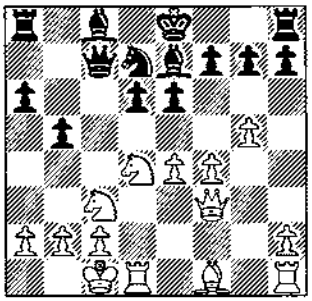
9 0-0-0 ♘bd7



10 ♗d3

10 f5 – *10*
10 ♗e2 – *176*

10 ♕g3 – *159*
10 g4 b5 11 ♗xf6 (11 ♗g2 – *39*) 11...♘xf6 12 g5 ♘d7



13 f5 (13 a3 – *92*) 13...♘c5
14 f6 gxf6 15 gxf6 ♗f8
16 ♖g1 – *40*
16 ♕h5 – *161*

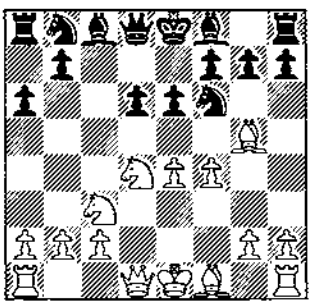
10...b5 11 ♖he1 ♗b7 12 ♕g3

12 ♘d5 exd5 (12...♘xd5 – *37*, *38*) 13 ♘f5 – *37*

12...b4 – *15*

12...0-0-0 – *145*

A2) 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 a6 6 ♗g5 e6 7 f4



7...♘bd7

7...♕b6 – *158*
7...♕c7 8 ♕f3 (8 ♗d3 – *58*) 8...b5 9 0-0-0 (9 f5 – *140*) 9...b4 10 e5 ♗b7
11 ♘cb5 – *60*
11 ♕h3 – *138*, *139*
7...b5 8 e5 dxe5 9 fxe5 ♕c7 10 exf6 (10 ♕e2 ♘fd7 11 0-0-0 ♗b7 12 ♘xe6 – *62*; 12 ♕g4 – *62*, *154*) 10...♕e5+ 11 ♗e2 ♕xg5 12 0-0
12...♕e5 – *174*

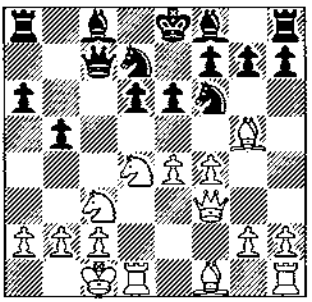
12...♖a7 – *175*

8 ♕f3

8 ♗c4 b5 (8...♕b6 – *88*) 9 ♗xe6 fxe6 10 ♘xe6 ♕b6 (10...♕a5 – *86*) 11 ♘d5 – *86*

8 ♕e2 ♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♗e7 (9...b5 – *35*) 10 g4 – *118*

8...♕c7 9 0-0-0 b5



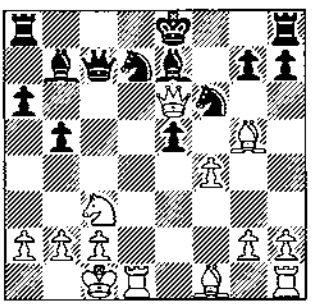
10 e5

10 ♗d3 b4 11 ♘d5 exd5 12 ♖he1 (12 exd5 – *33*) 12...♗e7 13 exd5 – *31*

10 ♗xb5 axb5 11 ♘dxb5 ♕b8 12 e5 ♗b7 (12...♖a5 – *153*) 13 ♕e2 – *151*

10 ♗xf6 – *136*

10...♗b7 11 ♕h3 dxe5 12 ♘xe6 fxe6 13 ♕xe6+ ♗e7



14 ♗xb5

14 ♘xb5 – *139*

14...axb5 15 ♘xb5 ♕c6 16 ♘d6+ ♔d8 17 fxe5 ♔c7

18 ♕xe7 – *156*

18 ♔b1 – *157*

B) 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 ♘c6 6 ♗c4

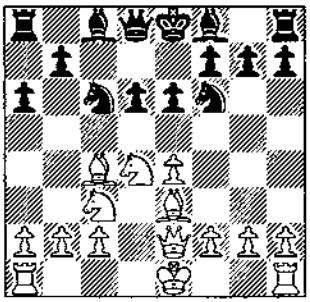
6 ♗g5 ♗d7 7 ♕d2 ♖c8 8 f4 ♘xd4 9 ♕xd4 ♕a5 10 c5 dxe5 11 fxe5 e6

12 0-0-0 ♗c6 13 ♘b5 ♗xb5 14 exf6 ♗c6 15 h4

15...♖g8 – *69*

15...g6 – *70*

6...e6 7 ♗e3 a6 8 ♕e2



8...♗e7

8...♕c7 9 0-0-0 ♘a5 10 ♗d3 b5

11 f4 – *30*

11 a3 – *121*

9 ♗b3 0-0

9...♕c7 10 0-0-0 ♘a5 11 g4 b5 12 g5 ♘xb3+ 13 axb3 ♘d7 14 ♘f5 exf5

15 ♘d5 ♕d8 16 exf5 ♗b7 (16...0-0 – *92*) 17 f6 gxf6 18 ♖he1 ♗xd5 19 ♖xd5 ♖g8

20 ♗f4 – *111*

20 gxf6 – *113*

10 0-0-0 ♕c7

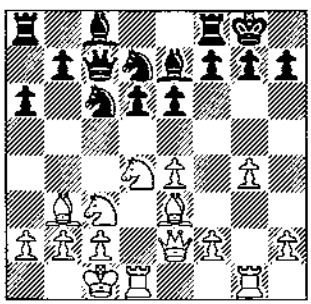
10...♕e8 – *28*

11 ♖hg1 ♘d7

11...b5 – *16*, *28*, *56*

11...♘a5 – *56*

12 g4



12...♘c5

12...♘a5 13 g5 ♘xb3+ 14 axb3 b5 15 f4 b4 16 ♘f5 exf5 17 ♘d5 ♕d8 18 exf5 ♖e8

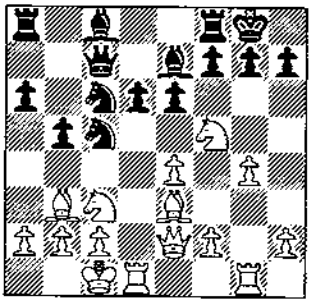
19 g6 – *108*

19 ♗d4 – *110*

13 ♘f5

13 g5 – *104*

13...b5



14 ♗d5 ♗b7 15 g5

15...♖fc8 – *80*

15...exf5 – *106*

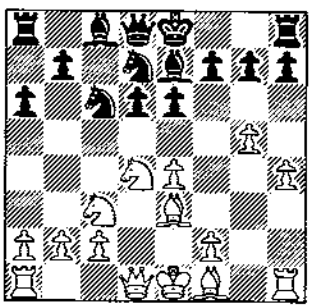
C) 1 e4 c5 2 ♘f3 d6 3 d4 cxd4 4 ♘xd4 ♘f6 5 ♘c3 e6

5...g6 6 ♗e3 (6 ♗e2 – *168*) 6...♗g7 7 f3 – *94*

6 ♗e3

6 f4 – *51*

6 g4 ♘c6 (6...a6 7 g5 ♘fd7 8 ♗e3 b5 9 a3 ♘b6 10 ♖g1 ♘8d7 – *49*; 10...♗b7 – *51*) 7 g5 ♘d7 8 h4 ♗e7 9 ♗e3 a6



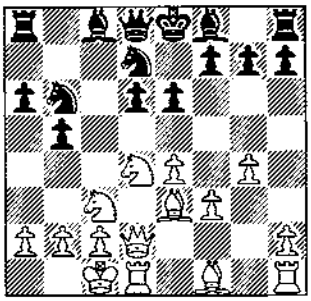
10 ♕h5 (10 ♕e2 – *21*; 10 f4 – *23*) 10...0-0 11 0-0-0 ♕c7 (11...♘xd4 – *25*) 12 f4 – *24*

6 ♗e2 a6 7 ♗e3 (7 0-0 ♗e7 8 ♔h1 – *133*) 7...♘c6 (7...♘bd7 – *52*) 8 0-0 ♗e7 (8...♕c7 – *166*) 9 a4 – *166*

6...a6 7 g4

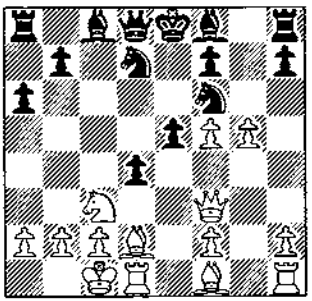
7 f4 – *41*

7 f3 b5 8 g4 ♘fd7 (8...h6 – *48*) 9 ♕d2 ♘b6 10 0-0-0 ♘8d7



11 ♘dxb5 (11 ♗g5 – *127*)
11...axb5 12 ♘xb5
12...♘e5 – *130*
12...♗a6 – *132*

7...e5 8 ♘f5 g6 9 g5 gxf5 10 exf5 d5 11 ♕f3 d4 12 0-0-0 ♘bd7 13 ♗d2
13 ♗xd4 – *102*



13...♕c7
13...♕a5 – *97*
13...dxc3 – *99*
13...♗d6 – *101*

14 gxf6 dxc3 15 ♗xc3 ♕c6 16 ♕g3
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